

RECORDS OF THE GRAND HISTORIAN

BY SIMA QIAN
TRANSLATED BY BURTON WATSON

QIN DYNASTY



A Renditions – Columbia University Press Book

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INTRODUCTION

The Chinese, with their veneration of ancestors and reverence for the rites and practices of the past, have from early times been indefatigable keepers of historical records. It is not surprising, therefore, that works of history should occupy a place of particular importance in their literature. The text from which the chapters translated here are drawn, the *Shi ji, Records of the Grand Historian* — or *Historical Records*, as the title is sometimes translated — is in fact one of the most widely read and influential of all works of early Chinese literature, and its author, Sima Qian (145?-89? BC), commands among readers of Chinese a respect and admiration comparable to that accorded Herodotus or Thucydides in the Western tradition.

The *Shi Ji* was planned, and perhaps written in part, by Sima Qian's father, Sima Tan (d. 110 BC), an official who held the title of *Taishi*, or Grand Historian, at the court of Emperor Wu of the Han dynasty but whose actual duties pertained more to astronomy and the regulation of the calendar. Sima Qian succeeded to his father's post and title and, obedient to his father's dying request, set about bringing the proposed work of history to completion. After some seven years of labor, however, his efforts were unexpectedly interrupted by a tragic turn of events.

China at this time was frequently troubled by raids from the Xiongnu, a nomadic people living in the desert north of China. Emperor Wu, determined to put an end to the incursions, repeatedly dispatched large military forces to the desert region in an attempt to capture the Xiongnu ruler, known by the title of *Shanyu*, or at least force him to acknowledge fealty to the Han. During one such expedition in 99 BC, a young military commander named Li Ling led a force of several thousand men in a daring raid deep into enemy territory, but after desperate fighting he was finally forced to surrender. Emperor Wu, who expected his military leaders to die in battle, was enraged when he learned of the surrender, and the other court officials united in condemnation of Li's action. Only Sima Qian, who had known and admired Li Ling in the past, spoke out in his defense. For such temerity he was charged with attempting to deceive the ruler and handed over to the law officials for investigation, a process that involved imprisonment and torture. Eventually he was sentenced to undergo the penalty of castration. Customarily, a man of honor would commit suicide before submitting to such disgrace. But, as Qian explains in a letter to a friend translated in appendix 2 of this volume, he chose to suffer the shame of mutilation in order that he might finish the writing of his history. This price of completion, ghastly as it was, has assured him a place of honor among the world's great historians.

The *Shi ji* is monumental in scope and aim, running to 130 chapters and covering the entire known history of the Chinese people from its beginnings

down to the time of the historian, a period of well over two thousand years. In addition, it includes chapters describing the lands and peoples of the areas of central Asia, Korea, and Vietnam that border China. It is thus in effect a history of the entire world as known to the Chinese of this early period.

To impose order on this vast array of material, Sima Qian devised an entirely new historiographical form. He divided his history into five large sections, arranging his material by subject and suggesting by the section in which he placed it something of its importance and relative reliability. His work opens with twelve chapters entitled *benji*, or "Basic Annals," which deal with the early dynasties of Chinese history or, in the case of the Han dynasty, with the reigns of individual rulers. Next come ten "Chronological Tables" that list in graph form the important events of the past with their dates. These are followed by eight "Treatises" on such subjects as rites, music, astronomy, religious affairs, water control, and economics. Thirty chapters entitled "Hereditary Houses" come next, dealing for the most part with the histories of the various feudal states of ancient China. The work concludes with seventy chapters entitled *liezhuan*, "Biographies" or "Accounts" devoted to the lives of famous personages or to the foreign lands with which China had contact.

These five large divisions of the history support and supplement one another in various ways, the different chapters pertaining to a single event or personage often varying subtly in treatment and angle of approach. Thus, although there is a certain degree of cross-referencing, one must take care to read all pertinent sections of the work in order to gain a full picture of any given subject. This type of formal arrangement, known as the "annal and biography form," was adopted in later dynastic histories compiled under official auspices, and it exercised a great influence on the development of Korean and Japanese historiography.

In two earlier volumes of translations from the *Shi ji* published in 1961 and reissued in slightly revised form in 1993, I presented material dealing with the founding and early years of the Han, the dynasty under which the historian lived and worked. In the present volume I have moved backward in time somewhat to focus on the chapters of Sima Qian's work that relate to the preceding Qin, or Ch'in, dynasty, founded in 221 BC when the king of the state of Qin brought all of China under his rule and assumed the title of First Emperor of the Qin. The First Emperor, long regarded as one of the most influential and noteworthy of all Chinese rulers, has in recent years become the center of particular interest because of the spectacular life-size terracotta figures of Qin period warriors that were discovered in excavations near his mausoleum in 1974.

Sima Qian began his history with a chapter entitled "Basic Annals of the Five Emperors," which describes five legendary sages who were said to have ruled the nation in the dawn of Chinese history. He followed this with three chapters dealing respectively with the Xia, Shang (or Yin), and Zhou

dynasties, the Three Dynasties of antiquity that ruled China in succession in the early historical period. Sima Qian's account of the Xia and Shang dynasties need not concern us here, but it should be noted that much of what he tells us about the early centuries of the Zhou dynasty has been confirmed or supplemented in recent years through the results of archaeological research. Thus from the late years of the Shang, and certainly from the Zhou on, we are on firm historical ground, though dates in this early period are uncertain.

The Zhou, which was probably founded around 1045 BC, appears to have exercised fairly effective control over a wide area of northern China during the early years of its rule. But later, particularly after its capital was moved east to Luoyang in 770 BC, its power rapidly waned, and China was thereafter ruled by a number of feudal states that acknowledged nominal fealty to the Zhou king but in fact behaved as virtually independent political units.

The Zhou royal house, despite its political weakness, continued in existence until its overthrow by the state of Qin in 256 BC. Sima Qian might therefore have begun his account of the Qin dynasty at that point and still preserved chronological continuity in his narrative. But, as he makes clear in his remarks on Qin history, he was intensely interested in origins, in the history of a state or ruling family not only in its period of greatest glory but in the long centuries that preceded that era of flowering, for in the actions of those earlier years, he believed, lay the key to an understanding of its later successes or failures. He therefore began his account of the Qin dynasty with a "Basic Annals of Qin" chapter that in chronological terms runs parallel to his account of the Zhou dynasty and traces the beginnings of the Qin ruling family back to the age of the mythic Five Emperors. The chapter then describes the history of the state of Qin from its start as a tiny feudal domain on the far northwestern border of the Chinese cultural sphere, down through its subsequent stages of growth until the moment when, having gradually amassed power over the centuries, it was able to swallow up its rivals and unite China under a single rule.

Sima Qian then added a second chapter in annals form in order to present a greatly expanded account of the momentous reign of the First Emperor, and that of his successor, the Second Emperor, when the dynasty was swiftly toppled by the rebellion that brought the Han dynasty to power. The events in the close of this chapter, therefore, dovetail with those described in the opening pages of my earlier volumes on the Han.

Sima Qian's dramatic portrait of the First Emperor in this chapter is one of the highlights of his history, skillfully juxtaposing examples of the grandiose rhetoric employed by the monarch to celebrate his achievements with grim accounts of the cruelty, folly, and oppression of the populace for which he has been remembered in later ages. But Sima Qian's preceding chapter, in part because of the scanty sources available to him, is less colorful and at times consists of little more than a dry recital of military

actions and steps in the slow process of territorial expansion.

To better understand the events briefly referred to in the annals section of the *Shi ji*, one must always turn to the relevant chapters of the *liezhuan* section of Sima Qian's history, which contains biographies of the prominent statesmen, military leaders, and thinkers of the period. I have accordingly followed my translations of the two annals pertaining to the Qin with ten chapters or excerpts from chapters dealing with the lives of men who played an important role in Qin history.

In all these chapters on Qin history, and in particular in the often seemingly disconnected welter of entries in "The Basic Annals of Qin" chapter, there are three overall processes that the reader will want to keep close watch on. First, of course, is Qin's slow but virtually unceasing territorial expansion, a process often described in traditional Chinese histories as *canshi*, or "eating away in silkworm fashion." Qin, beginning as a tiny feudal domain situated on the Wei River in present day Gansu Province, bit by bit expanded to the east and south, gradually moving its capital eastward until it had established it at Xianyang near the modern city of Xi'an in Shaanxi. This is the heart of the so-called "land within the passes," a rich agricultural area protected on the north and south by mountain barriers and on the east by the Yellow River, where it flows south from the Ordos region and then turns abruptly east toward the sea.

At first Qin's ambition seemed to be merely to expand eastward as far as the Yellow River, thus fulfilling an ancient prophecy that the descendants of its ruling family would one day "water their horses at the Yellow River." In time, however, Qin crossed the Yellow River to attack the states to the east, continuing its seemingly inevitable expansion in that direction, as well as southwest into the area of present-day Sichuan and southward into the Yangtze valley.

A second and closely related process is that by which Qin incorporated newly acquired territory into its administrative system in the form of *xian*, or districts, and later in larger administrative units known as *jun*, provinces or commanderies. The *junxian*, or province and district system, as it came to be known, apparently did not originate in Qin and was employed in other feudal states of the period as well. But Qin was noteworthy for the rapidity and thoroughness with which it adopted the system.

The founders of the Zhou dynasty, when they had overthrown the preceding Shang, parceled out fiefs to the members of their family and to the distinguished men of other families who had assisted them to power. The rulers of the individual feudal states in turn bestowed grants of land within their domains on members of their own families or meritorious officials, until China became a veritable patchwork of tiny political entities. Over the centuries, however, the better governed of these small feudal domains absorbed their weaker neighbors, until at times they came to pose a serious threat to the ruling family of the state in which they were situated, or to the Zhou kings themselves. This happened notably in the states of Jin

and Qi, where ministerial families in time actually deposed and replaced the ruling family of the state.

Qin, which had a later start than the states of eastern China — the traditional date for its founding is 897 BC — at first followed the practice of the other states, handing out fiefs to its prominent statesmen and military leaders and honoring them with the title of marquis. But, perhaps because it could observe what was happening in the older states, Qin seems to have been highly wary of the dangers involved in such granting of territorial domains, and it seized on every excuse to take back the land that had already been handed out. Clearly it preferred to exercise direct jurisdictional control over its territory through the province and district system described above. Often, as will be seen, when it acquired new territories, particularly if they were in outlying regions, it forcibly transported large numbers of its population to the area in order to insure more effective control and quicker assimilation of the local populace.

In view of this background, it is not surprising that in 221 BC, when the Qin ruler united all of China under a single authority, he firmly rejected any suggestion that he dole out land in fiefs to his brothers or sons, as had the founders of previous dynasties. Instead he extended the provincial system to embrace the entire empire, creating an administration that consisted of thirty-six provinces and an unknown number of districts. While undergoing innumerable modifications over the centuries, this is essentially the administrative system that has remained in effect in China down to the present time.

A third process characteristic of the Qin, which began at the urging of the Legalist statesman Wei Yang, or Lord Shang, and is described in his biography below, was the promulgation of a code of laws to replace the largely unwritten complex of customs and rites that had governed the people in the past and continued to do so in the other feudal states. Qin's laws are noted for their harsh penalties and detailed regulations, and for the equality with which they were applied to high and low alike, regardless of social rank. Qin's legal system, and the philosophy of government underlying it, was one of the aspects of Qin government most vocally criticized by the founders of the succeeding Han dynasty, who had been commoners under Qin rule and had experienced in person its more oppressive aspects. They therefore made a show of simplifying the legal system in order to win popular support, though in practice they took over and carried on many features of the Qin code.¹

In selecting chapters from the *liezhuan*, or biography, section of the *Shi ji* for translation, I have tried to include all those that describe figures of major importance in Qin history, though since so many of the bureaucrats and political advisors of the period moved about from one feudal state to another, and since the histories of the various feudal states are so closely interwoven with one another, it is difficult to present all the material that

relates to the Qin. These chapters, beginning with the biography of Lord Shang and covering such famous statesmen as Shuli Zi, Gan Mou, Wei Ran, Fan Ju, and Cai Ze, along with the military leaders Bai Qi and Wang Jian, draw heavily for their material from an early text known as the *Zhanguo ce*, or *Intrigues of the Warring States*. This work, though cast in the form of historical narratives, contains a large element of fiction, its principal aim being to demonstrate how to present one's ideas cogently and effectively and to persuade a ruler or superior to adopt a particular course of action. These persuasions, as the episodes have been called, are of considerable literary interest, though at times the arguments are so tortuous the reader may well lose his way in their complexities.

One may ask why Sima Qian should have incorporated material of such questionable nature into his history. It is well to keep in mind, however, that the First Emperor of the Qin, in his infamous Burning of the Books, deliberately destroyed the historical records of all the feudal states other than Qin, and Sima Qian hence had very few sources to draw on for the period. Had he not borrowed from the *Intrigues*, he would have had virtually no account of the men and events of the time at all. Since his purpose in writing his history was above all didactic: to preserve for posterity the moral and political lessons of the past even when he could not always be certain of the facts, he understandably elected to utilize the *Intrigues* despite its inconsistencies and dubious elements. As a result, he was able to fashion biographies that, while closer to historical fiction than true history, are highly effective as literature and among the most memorable in his entire 130-chapter work.

My selection concludes with biographies of persons associated with the First Emperor, which also draw at times upon the *Intrigues*. These include accounts of Lü Buwei, the rich merchant who may have been the real father of the First Emperor; the hero Jing Ke, whose desperate attempt to assassinate the First Emperor, had it succeeded, might have changed the whole course of Chinese history; Li Si, chancellor under the First and Second emperors; and General Meng Tian, builder of the Great Wall.

Conspicuously absent from this roster of famous figures of the period of the First and Second emperors is the eunuch official Zhao Gao, who played a crucial role in the closing years of the Qin. Eunuchs, because they waited on the ruler in his inner apartments, where none of the regular officials were permitted access, could exercise enormous influence over him, particularly if he was a minor, at times completely controlling his avenues of information and isolating him from his ministers and kin. There is no question that eunuchs exerted a sinister and inimical influence in some periods of Chinese political history. But because they were the natural enemies of the court bureaucrats, and because in most cases it was the latter who compiled the official histories, any accounts of the eunuchs therein are likely to be strongly colored by prejudice and animosity.

At this late date we have no way to determine whether this is true of Sima

Qian's portrait of Zhao Gao. I would simply note here that, leaving aside a few stereotyped villains of high antiquity such as the "bad last" rulers of the Xia and Shang dynasties, Zhao Gao is without doubt the most unmitigatedly evil figure to appear in the pages of the *Shi ji*. And his evilness is all the more chilling because it finds expression not in acts of passion or violence but in the deliberate and cunningly planned corruption of men such as Huhai and Li Si who otherwise, one feels, might have acquitted themselves in a passable manner.

One should also note that, important a figure as he was, there is no chapter devoted to Zhao Gao. Sima Qian is obliged to record Zhao Gao's words and actions in great detail in the chapters devoted to the men whose downfall he engineered, but the historian refused to dignify him with a biography of his own. In terms of the formal structure of the *Shi ji*, Zhao Gao has been condemned to oblivion.

At the very end of my selection I have added two appendixes. The first contains a translation of "The Hereditary House of Chen She," Sima Qian's account of the rebellion that led in time to the downfall of the Qin. Chen She, the principal leader of the revolt in its initial stages, a farm laborer and self-styled king who was murdered by his own carriage driver after only six months of rule, was hardly a commanding personality, and one would expect to find his story related in the biography section of the *Shi ji* rather than in the more prestigious section labeled "Hereditary Houses." But perhaps because his daring act of defiance showed how widespread was the hatred of Qin rule and how vulnerable it was to attack, thus opening the way for the founding of the Han, Sima Qian has chosen to honor his memory in this fashion.

The second appendix contains a translation of Sima Qian's letter to his friend Ren An, already mentioned above, in which he describes the circumstances that led to his castration. A gem of the prose literature of the period, its outpourings afford us a rare insight into the character and motivations of the historian. Following his punishment, it may be noted, Qian was promoted to the post of Palace Secretary and continued in the service of Emperor Wu. After his death, the date of which is uncertain, a grandson by his only child, a daughter, worked to circulate the text of the *Shi ji* and insure its wide recognition.

Except for a brief moment of levity in the excerpt from "The Biographies of Wits and Humorists," the material from the *Shi ji* on the state of Qin and the Qin dynasty that I have presented here is almost unrelievedly dolorous in tone. Sterner laws, harsher penalties! is the cry that rings throughout it, and many of the biographies, after describing some brilliant career in statecraft or military activity, end with the forced suicide of the protagonists or the thump of the executioner's axe. Readers may be tempted to ask: were things under the Qin really that bad?

There is no question that they *could* have been that bad: the history of our present century, with its mass murders, concentration camps, and other unspeakable horrors, is proof enough of that. But one may still wonder if Sima Qian's picture of Qin history is not perhaps rather grimmer and more dismal than the facts would justify. Let us consider here, therefore, what can be known about his attitude toward the Qin and what reasons he might have had for distortion in his portrayal of it.

First of all, one should keep always in mind that Sima Qian was a man of the Han, and it was the Han that overthrew and replaced the Qin. The rebel leader known as the governor of Pei who marches onto the scene in the very closing pages of my narrative on the Qin is none other than Liu Ji [Liu Bang], or Han Gaozu, the founder and first emperor of the Han dynasty. And as I have mentioned earlier, it was in his interests and the interests of his supporters to stress as much as possible the cruel and tyrannous nature of Qin rule in order to contrast it with their own lighter yoke and more enlightened methods of government. This attitude no doubt quickly became established as the official Han view of Qin history. We see it reflected, for example, in the famous essay entitled "The Faults of Qin" by the early Han poet and statesman Jia Yi (201-169 BC), which is praised by Sima Qian and quoted at length at two points in the *Shi ji*.

Sima Qian's own comments at the end of his chapters on Qin history, and in the introduction to "The Chronological Table of the Six States," evince a like attitude. Again and again, when we might expect him to express sympathy, or at least pity, for his subject, we find him sharply condemning the statesmen or military leaders who shaped Qin history for bowing too readily to the will of the ruler, for accommodating themselves too willingly to the trend of the times instead of endeavoring to reform it.

One should keep in mind too that Sima Qian spent most of his life as a court official in the service of a ruler, Emperor Wu of the Han (r. 140-87 BC), who in many ways disturbingly resembled the First Emperor of the Qin. True, Emperor Wu officially sanctioned Confucianism as the state creed, whereas the First Emperor had embraced the tenets of Legalism. But like the First Emperor, Emperor Wu worked to expand the territorial limits of the nation and to strengthen the power of the central government, and he attempted to gain tighter control over the population through strict and detailed laws in a way that hardly differed from the methods of the Qin — see, for example, Sima Qian's chapter on the law officials of Emperor Wu's time, "The Biographies of the Harsh Officials," in *Han Dynasty*, volume II. Like the First Emperor, Emperor Wu launched military campaigns and vast construction projects that put a heavy strain on the population and the nation's finances. He even imitated the First Emperor in his dogged efforts to establish contact with the spirit world and to attain immortal life — so much so that later ages would habitually link their names as fellow believers

in superstitious folly. Because of these points of resemblance between the two sovereigns, it is clear that when Sima Qian condemns the failings and abuses of the Qin, he is at the same time indirectly attacking what he viewed as similar trends in his own age.

Finally, one should recall that, because Sima Qian spoke out in defence of an army leader who had surrendered to the enemy, he roused the ire of Emperor Wu and was handed over to the law officials for criminal investigation. Thus when he describes the harsh legal procedures of the Qin, when he tells of men being beaten so mercilessly that in desperation they confess to crimes they never committed, he may well be drawing on his own experiences in the palace prison. He was in time condemned to death and, lacking the money to buy commutation of the sentence, underwent castration rather than take his own life so that he could complete the writing of his history. The trauma of this event no doubt influenced his whole outlook and inspired in him a loathing for the type of legal processes used by the Qin, and in many instances by the Han as well, and for the whole Legalist philosophy that attempted to justify them.

We know so little about the sources used by Sima Qian in putting together his portraits of the First and Second emperors, Li Si, and Zhao Gao that it is impossible to say just how and to what extent his own prejudices may have affected his view of the Qin. But, as I have pointed out, there is every reason to expect that he would have judged the Qin with severity. Attempts have been made to argue that Sima Qian's original description of the Qin may not have been so unfavourable, and that some of the more damning passages in his narrative are in fact later interpolations in the *Shi ji* text, but I find such arguments unconvincing.² No one, it seems to me, would have had greater reason than Sima Qian himself to paint a grim picture of the reigns of the First and Second emperors, and almost no one in succeeding centuries to my knowledge ever accused Sima Qian of being unfair in his treatment of the Qin or attempted to correct the record.³

Until archaeological excavations in some way produce data that appreciably alter that record, therefore, we must continue to view the Qin through the eyes of Sima Qian. If he portrayed it in particularly sombre colors, it was doubtless because he wanted, with these "portions and parcels of the dreadful past," to warn future ages away from its errors and atrocities. He knew that tendencies toward megalomania and tyranny, and the temptation to try to manipulate human beings like so many puppets through the twin levers of punishment and reward, are present in all governments and that one must be constantly on guard against them. That no doubt was the lesson he wished to convey in his depiction of the Qin.

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE ON THE TEXT

As in my earlier volumes of translations from the *Shi ji*, I have on the whole followed the text of the *Shi ji* as it appears in the edition entitled *Shiki kaichū kōshō* (Tokyo, 1934; reprinted in China and Japan), though I have not always followed the punctuation in this edition. Below are listed works that contain earlier translations of the chapters I have translated here *Shi ji* chapters translated both in these works and in my selection are listed in brackets), or works that were particularly helpful to me in preparing my selection. I am much indebted to the Research Centre for Translation of the Chinese University of Hong Kong, and to its director, Dr Eva Hung, for a *Renditions* Fellowship that allowed me to spend six months at the Centre in the spring of 1990 revising my earlier translations and preparing the new translations in this volume.

Derk Bodde. *China's First Unifier: A Study of the Ch'in Dynasty as Seen in the Life of Li Ssu* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1939; rpt. Hong Kong: Hong Kong University Press, 1967). [*Shi ji* 88]

Derk Bodde. *Statesman, Patriot and General in Ancient China: Three Shih-chi Biographies of the Ch'in Dynasty* (New Haven, Conn.: American Oriental Society, 1940; rpt. New York: Kraus Reprint, 1967). [*Shi ji* 85, 86 (*Jing Ke*), 88]

Édouard Chavannes. *Les Mémoires Historiques de Se-Ma Ts'ien*, Vol. I-V (Paris: Ernest Laroux, 1895-1905; rpt. Paris: Adrien Maisonneuve, 1969). [*Shi ji* 5, 6, 15]

J. I. Crump, Jr. *Chan-kuo ts'ue* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1970).

J. J. L. Duyvendak. *The Book of Lord Shang* (London: A. Probsthain, 1928). [*Shi ji* 68]

Denis Twitchett & Michael Loewe. *The Cambridge History of China*, vol. 1 (Cambridge University Press, 1986).

Burton Watson. *Records of the Historian: Chapters from the Shih chi of Ssu-ma Ch'ien* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1969). [*Shi ji* 85, 86]

Gladys & Hsien-yi Yang. *Records of the Historian* (Hong Kong: Commercial Press, 1974). [*Shi ji* 6, 68, 79, 85, 126]

SHI JI 5: THE BASIC ANNALS OF QIN

Boyi, the ancestor of Qin, assisted Emperor Yu. Duke Mu, mindful of righteousness, mourned for those who fought at Yao; but when they used men to accompany him in death, the poem on the “Yellow Birds” was sung. King Xiaoxiang opened the way for an emperor. Thus I made “The Basic Annals of Qin”.⁴

The forbears of the Qin were descendants of Emperor Zhuan Xu.⁵ Zhuan Xu's granddaughter was named Nüxiu. When Nüxiu was weaving, a swallow happened to drop an egg. Nüxiu swallowed the egg and gave birth to a son, Daye. Daye took as his wife a daughter of Shao Dian named Nühua, and Nühua gave birth to Dafei.⁶

Dafei joined the sage ruler Yu in pacifying the waters and the land, and when the work had been completed, Emperor Shun presented Yu with a black jade baton. When Yu accepted it, he said, “I could not have done this if Dafei had not acted as my helper.”

Emperor Shun said, “Ah, Fei! You assisted Yu in his task. You shall be given a black banner. Your descendants will hereafter prosper greatly.” He also gave him as a wife a beautiful daughter of the Yao clan.

Dafei, bowing and accepting these gifts, aided Shun in subduing and training the birds and beasts, and many of the birds and beasts became submissive. This was the man known as Boyi. Shun bestowed on him the surname Ying.⁷

Dafei had two sons. One was called Dalian and was the founder of the Bird-custom family. The other was called Ruomu and was the founder of the Fei family. His great-great-grandson was Fei Chang. Some of Fei Chang's descendants lived in China and some lived among the Yi and Di tribes.

In the time of Jie, the last ruler of the Xia dynasty, Fei Chang deserted the Xia dynasty and went over to the side of the Shang. King Tang, founder of the Shang, made him his carriage driver when he defeated Jie at Mingtiao.

Dalian's great-great-grandsons were Mengxi and Zhongyan. Zhongyan had the body of a bird but spoke like a human being. Emperor Taiwu, hearing of him, divined to see if he should employ him as his carriage driver. The response being favourable, he employed him as such, and also gave him a wife. From the time of Emperor Taiwu on, the heirs of Zhongyan won merit generation after generation by assisting the state of Shang. Hence many members of the Ying family gained prominence and in time became feudal lords.

Zhongyan's great-great-grandson was Zhongjue. He lived among the Western Rong people and guarded the western border. Zhongjue sired

Feilian, and Feilian sired Elai. Elai was very strong and Feilian was skilled at running; both father and son offered their strength and ability in the service of Zhou, the last ruler of the Shang or Yin dynasty. When King Wu of the Zhou dynasty attacked and killed Zhou of the Yin, Elai was killed at the same time.

Feilian at this time had been sent by Zhou on a mission to the northern region. When he returned, he had no one to report to, so he built an altar on Mt. Huotai and there made his report. He found a stone coffin with an inscription that read: "The emperor orders you, Chufu, not to take part in Yin's disorders, but presents you with a stone coffin to bring glory to your family."⁸ When Feilian died, he was accordingly buried on Mt. Huotai.

Feilian had another son named Jisheng, and Jisheng had a son named Mengzeng. Mengzeng enjoyed favour with King Cheng of the Zhou dynasty and is known as Zhai Black Wolf. Zhai Black Wolf sired Hengfu and Hengfu sired Zaofu. Zaofu won favour with King Mu of the Zhou dynasty because of his skill as a carriage driver. King Mu acquired a team of four, made up of a chestnut, a light grey, a dappled red, and a green ear, and embarked on a hunting tour to the west, enjoying himself so much he forgot to return. When the rebellion of King Yan of Xu broke out, Zaofu was acting as carriage driver for King Mu and he raced over the long road back to the Zhou capital, covering 1,000 *li* in one day, in order to put down the rebellion.⁹

King Mu enfeoffed Zaofu in the city of Zhao, and Zaofu's kin from this time on were known by the surname Zhao. It was five generations from Feilian and his son Jisheng down to Zaofu. Zaofu lived away from the court in Zhao; Zhao Cui was his descendant.¹⁰

Feilian's son Elai or Ge died at an early age. He had a son named Nüfang, who sired Panggao. Panggao sired Taiji, Taiji sired Daluo, and Daluo sired Feizi. Because of the favour enjoyed by Zaofu, all these persons were permitted to be counted as members of the Zhao family of the city of Zhao.

Feizi lived at Quanqiu or Dog Hill. He loved horses and domestic animals and was skilled at raising and breeding them. The people of Dog Hill mentioned him to King Xiao of the Zhou dynasty, and King Xiao summoned him and ordered him to pasture the royal horses in the area between the Qian and Wei rivers. The horses increased greatly in number.

King Xiao wanted to see Feizi designated as the heir of Daluo. But Marquis Shen had given his daughter to Daluo as a wife and she had borne him a son named Cheng who had been designated as heir. Marquis Shen said to King Xiao, "Long ago an ancestor of mine, a woman of Mt. Li, married a man of the Rong people named Xuxuan and bore a son named Zhongjue. Because of his parentage Zhongjue paid allegiance to the Zhou dynasty and guarded the western border for it. As a result, there was peace and harmony on the western border. Now I have given my daughter to Daluo as a wife and she has borne him a son, Cheng, who has been

designated heir. The Shen and Daluo families are thus doubly related, and all the Western Rong people have submitted to you. That is why you are able to reign as king. Your Majesty would do well to consider this."

King Xiao replied, "Long ago Boyi supervised the raising of animals for Emperor Shun, and the animals multiplied greatly. Therefore he was assigned a domain and presented with the surname Ying. Now his descendant in later ages is raising horses for me. I therefore propose to set aside land for him so he may become a dependant domain, assigning him the town of Qin and instructing him to carry on sacrifices to the Ying family." He gave Feizi the title Qin Ying and refrained from removing Daluo's son by the daughter of Marquis Shen from the position of heir in order to remain at peace with the Western Rong.

Qin Ying sired Qin Hou, who died after ten years of rule. Qin Hou sired Gongbo, who died after three years of rule. Gongbo sired Qin Zhong. Three years after Qin Zhong assumed power, King Li of the Zhou dynasty acted in an unprincipled manner and many of the feudal lords turned against him.¹¹ The Western Rong also revolted against the royal house and wiped out the descendants of Daluo in Dog Hill.

When King Xuan came to the throne of Zhou, he made Qin Zhong a grandee and sent him to punish the Western Rong, but they killed him. Qin Zhong thus died among the Rong after holding his position for twenty-three years.

Qin Zhong had five sons, the eldest of whom became Duke Zhuang. King Xuan summoned Duke Zhuang and his four brothers, gave them a force of 7,000 men, and sent them to attack the Western Rong, whom they defeated. The king then once more presented to Duke Zhuang the domain that had belonged to Qin Zhong, as well as the area of Dog Hill that had belonged to his ancestor Daluo, decreeing that he hold possession of both regions and act as grandee of the western border. Duke Zhuang resided in the west, in the old region of Dog Hill.

Duke Zhuang had three sons, of whom the eldest was named Shifu. Shifu said, "The Rong killed our grandfather Qin Zhong. Until I have killed the ruler of the Rong, I will not venture to enter my domain." He accordingly led his forces in a surprise attack on the Rong, turning over his domain to his younger brother, Duke Xiang. Duke Xiang thus became the heir apparent.

After Duke Zhuang had ruled for forty-four years he died and the heir apparent, Duke Xiang, succeeded him as ruler.

In the first year of his rule, Duke Xiang gave his younger sister, Muying, to be the wife of King Feng.¹²

In the second year of Duke Xiang's reign the Rong besieged Shifu at Dog Hill. Shifu attacked them but was taken prisoner. A year or so later Shifu was returned to his domain.

In the spring of Duke Xiang's seventh year, King You of the Zhou dynasty,

heeding the wishes of his favourite, Baosi, removed the heir apparent and set up Baosi's son in his place, and several times deceived the feudal lords. The feudal lords revolted against him, and the Western Rong and Dog Rong peoples, joining forces with Marquis Shen, attacked the Zhou capital and killed King You at the foot of Mt. Li. Duke Xiang of Qin led his forces to the rescue of the Zhou, fighting bravely in battle and winning merit. In order to avoid harassment from the Dog Rong, the Zhou dynasty moved its capital east to the city of Luoyang.¹³

Duke Xiang led his troops to escort King Ping to the new capital. King Ping enfeoffed Duke Xiang as one of the feudal lords, bestowing on him the land from Mt. Qi on west. "The Rong have behaved in an unprincipled manner, invading and seizing our lands of Qi and Feng," he said. "But Qin has succeeded in attacking and driving out the Rong, and therefore he shall possess these lands." Thus the king swore an oath with Duke Xiang, bestowing a fief and title on him.

Duke Xiang thus for the first time became the possessor of a feudal state and observed the rites appropriate to the exchange of embassies and official visits and banquets. He used a set of three sacrificial animals, a red colt with a black mane, a yellow ox, and a ram, to sacrifice to the Lord on High at the Altar of the West. In the twelfth year of his rule, he attacked the Rong and advanced as far as Mt. Qi, where he died. He was succeeded by his son, Duke Wen.

In the first year of his rule, Duke Wen resided in the Western Border Palace. In his third year he took a force of 700 armed men and went east to hunt. In his fourth year he arrived at the confluence of the Qian and Wei rivers. "In ancient times," he said, "the Zhou dynasty gave my ancestor Qin Ying this land to dwell in, and his descendants have at last succeeded in becoming feudal lords." He carried out divination by the tortoise shell to see if he should settle there. The answer being favourable, he proceeded to build a town in which he took up residence.

In his tenth year he established the Altar of Fu, using a set of three sacrificial animals in the rites there.¹⁴ In his thirteenth year the historians for the first time began to keep a record of events, and many of the inhabitants changed their ways.¹⁵ In his sixteenth year Duke Wen led his forces in an attack on the Rong, who fled in defeat. Duke Wen thereupon gained possession of the land as far as Mt. Qi, where the remnants of the Zhou people lived. He presented the area east of Mt. Qi to the Zhou dynasty.¹⁶ In his nineteenth year he gained possession of the Treasures of Chen.¹⁷

In his twentieth year the law stipulating that a criminal's three sets of relatives should be put to death along with the criminal himself was first promulgated.¹⁸ In his twenty-seventh year he attacked Daxin, Feng, and Date in the Southern Mountains. In his forty-eighth year Duke Wen's heir

apparent died and was given the posthumous title of Duke Jing. Duke Jing's eldest son, the grandson of Duke Wen, was designated heir apparent.

In his fiftieth year of rule Duke Wen died and was buried on the Western Mountain. Duke Jing's son was set up as ruler and is known as Duke Ning.

In his second year of rule Duke Ning moved his residence to Pingyang. He dispatched troops to attack Dangshe. In his third year he fought with Hao, the ruler of Dangshe, and Hao fled to the Rong people. Thus the settlement at Dangshe was wiped out. In his fourth year Hui, a ducal son of the state of Lu, assassinated his lord, Duke Yin.¹⁹ In his twelfth year Duke Ning attacked the Dang family and took them prisoner.²⁰ Duke Ning became ruler in his tenth year and died in his twelfth year of rule, being buried on the Western Mountain.

Duke Ning had three sons, of whom the eldest, who became Duke Wu, had been designated heir apparent. The second son, who had the same mother as the first, became Duke De. The third, Chuzi, was the son of a woman from the ruling family of the state of Lu.

When Duke Ning died, the militia leaders Fuji, Weilei, and Sanfu deposed the heir apparent and set up Chuzi as ruler. In the sixth year of Chuzi's rule, Sanfu and the others joined in arranging to have someone attack and kill Chuzi. Thus Chuzi became ruler at the age of five and died in the sixth year of his rule. Sanfu and the others then set up the former heir apparent as ruler, who became Duke Wu.

In the first year of his rule Duke Wu attacked Pengxi, advancing as far as Mt. Hua. He took up residence in the Feng Palace in Pingyang. In his third year he punished Sanfu and the others, wiping them out along with their three sets of relatives. This was because they had killed Chuzi. Gao Qumi of the state of Zheng killed his lord, Duke Zhao (695 BC). In his tenth year Duke Wu attacked the Rong people of Gui and Ji and for the first time established a district (*xian*) in the area. In his eleventh year he set up the districts of Du and Zheng and wiped out the settlement of Xiaoguo.

In Duke Wu's thirteenth year Guan Zhifu, Lian Cheng and other men of Qi killed their lord, Duke Xiang, and set up the ducal grandson Wuzhi as ruler.²¹ The state of Jin wiped out the states of Huo, Wei, and Geng. Yong Lin of Qi killed Wuzhi, Guan Zhifu, and the others and set up Duke Huan of Qi. Jin and Qi thus became powerful states. In Duke Wu's nineteenth year the ruler of Quwo in Jin for the first time assumed the title of marquis of Jin. Duke Huan of Qi became an overlord (*ba*) at Juan. Duke Wu of Qin died in his twentieth year of rule and was buried at Pingyang in Yong. For the first time there were persons to accompany him in death, in this case sixty-six persons.²²

Duke Wu had only one son, named Bai. Bai was not set up as ruler but was enfeoffed in Pingyang. Instead, Duke Wu's younger brother became ruler and is known as Duke De.

In the first year of his rule Duke De took up residence in the Dazheng Palace in the city of Yong. He used 300 sets of sacrificial animals to sacrifice at the Altar of Fu. Divining by the tortoise shell to see if he should reside at Yong, he was told that his sons and grandsons in ages to come would water their horses at the Yellow River. The earls of Liang and Rui came to pay their respects at the Qin court.

In the second year of Duke De's rule the *fu* was observed for the first time, dogs being used to suppress evil influences.²³

Duke De became ruler at the age of thirty-three and died after two years of rule. He had three sons; the eldest became Duke Xuan, the second became Duke Cheng, and the youngest became Duke Mu.

After the death of Duke Wu, his eldest son became ruler and is known as Duke Xuan. In the first year of Duke Xuan's rule the states of Wey²⁴ and Yan attacked the Zhou court, drove out King Hui, and set up Prince Tui as ruler. In Duke Xuan's third year the earl of Zheng and Shu of Guo killed Prince Tui and put King Hui back on the throne.

In the fourth year of his rule Duke Xuan set up the Mi Altar. He fought with the state of Jin at Heyang and was victorious. In his twelfth year Duke Xuan died. He had nine sons but none of them became ruler. Instead Duke Xuan's younger brother was set up and is known as Duke Cheng.

In the first year of Duke Cheng's rule the earls of Liang and Rui came to the Qin Court. Duke Huan of Qi attacked the Mountain Rong and encamped at Guzhu. Duke Cheng died in the fourth year of his rule. He had seven sons but none of these became ruler, the rule passing to Duke Cheng's younger brother, who became Duke Mu.

In the first year of Duke Mu (659 BC), whose personal name was Renhao, the duke led an attack on Maojin and defeated it. In his fourth year he took a bride from the state of Jin; she was an elder sister of Shensheng, the heir apparent of Jin. This year Duke Huan of Qi attacked the state of Chu, advancing as far as Shaoling.

In Duke Mu's fifth year, Duke Xian of Jin wiped out the states of Yu and Guo and took prisoner the ruler of Yu and the grandee Baili Xi. He did this by bribing the men of Yu with jade disks and horses. After taking Baili Xi prisoner, he sent him to Qin to act as an attendant to Duke Mu's bride. Baili Xi escaped from Qin and fled to Wan, where he was seized by villagers of the state of Chu. Duke Mu had heard that Baili Xi was a man of worth and was anxious to buy him back from his captors, but he was afraid that the people of Chu would not hand him over. He therefore sent a messenger to say to Chu, "Baili Xi, one of the attendants to my bride, is there with you. I am prepared to offer five black ram skins as ransom for him." The people of Chu agreed to this and handed him over. At this time Baili Xi was over seventy years old.

Duke Mu untied his bonds and began questioning him on affairs of state. But Baili Xi declined to answer, saying, "I am an official from a state that

has perished — how could I be worth consulting?”

Duke Mu said, “The ruler of Yu failed to make use of you and so he perished. That is no fault of yours.” He persisted in his questioning, and they talked for three days. Duke Mu was overjoyed and wanted to hand over the governing of the state to him, entitling him Lord Five Ram Skins. But Baili Xi declined, saying, “I cannot compare to my friend Jian Shu. But no one in the world recognizes Jian Shu’s worth. Once, when I was travelling and found myself in difficulty in the state of Qi, I had to beg food from the people of Zhi, and Jian Shu took me in. I wanted to use the opportunity to enter the service of Wuzhi, who was the ruler of Qi at that time, but Jian Shu dissuaded me, and so I was able to escape the difficulties that attended Wuzhi’s downfall.

“Later I went to the Zhou capital. Prince Tui of Zhou liked cattle, and so I tried to gain his attention by my skill in raising cattle. But when Prince Tui tried to employ me, Jian Shu stopped me from accepting. So I left, and was thus able to avoid being wiped out along with Prince Tui’s other supporters.

“When I took service under the ruler of Yu, Jian Shu once more tried to stop me. I knew that the ruler of Yu would never heed me, but to tell the truth, I was hoping to profit from the salary and rank and so I stayed on. If I had once more listened to Jian Shu’s advice, I would have escaped, but because I failed to do so, I was involved in the ruler’s downfall. Because of this I have come to understand his worth.”

Duke Mu thereupon dispatched an envoy with generous gifts to invite Jian Shu to take office, making him a grandee of the upper rank.

In the autumn of this year Duke Mu led his troops in an attack on Jin, fighting with the Jin forces at Hequ. Lady Li fomented trouble in Jin, and as a result the heir apparent Shensheng killed himself at New City and Chonger and Yiwu fled to Ben.²⁵

In the ninth year of Duke Mu’s rule, Duke Huan of Qi called the other feudal lords together for a meeting at Sunflower Hill. Duke Xian of Jin died, whereupon Lady Li set up her son Xiqi as ruler of Jin. Li Ke, a Jin official, killed Xiqi, and when Xun Xi set up another of the duke’s sons, Zhuozhi, as ruler, Li Ke killed him too, along with Xun Xi. Yiwu then sent an envoy to Qin asking if Qin would help him to become ruler of Jin. Duke Mu agreed to this and ordered Baili Xi to lead a force of troops and escort Yiwu to Jin.

Yiwu said, “If I succeed in becoming ruler, I would like to take eight of Jin’s cities lying west of the Yellow River and present them to Qin.” Once he had reached Jin and become ruler, however, he sent Pi Zheng to Qin with excuses, reneging on his promise and failing to hand over the cities west of the Yellow River. Moreover, he put Li Ke to death.

When Pi Zheng received word of this, he was frightened and began scheming with Duke Mu, saying, “The people of Jin do not want Yiwu as their ruler. The one they really want is Chonger. This going against the promise to Qin and putting Li Ke to death is all a plot by Lü Sheng and Xi

Rui.²⁶ I advise you to offer some inducement and send an urgent summons to Lü and Xi. Once they are here, it will be easy to have Chonger made ruler of Jin."

Duke Mu agreed to this and sent someone to return with Pi Zheng to Jin and invite Lü Sheng and Xi Rui to come to Qin. These two men, suspecting that Pi Zheng was acting in collusion with Qin, advised Yiwu to have Pi Zheng put to death. Pi Zheng's son Pi Bao fled to Qin, where he advised Duke Mu, saying, "The ruler of Jin is unprincipled and his people do not support him. He is ripe for attack!"

But Duke Mu said, "If the people do not support him, then how is he able to put to death a chief minister such as Pi Zheng? The fact that he can do so shows that he and his people are in accord." So he refused to heed Pi Bao's advice, though he secretly made use of him.

In Duke Mu's twelfth year, Guan Zhong and Xi Peng of Qi died.²⁷ The state of Jin, being afflicted with drought, came to Qin to request grain. Pi Bao advised Duke Mu not to give Jin any grain but instead to take advantage of the famine to launch an attack on it. Duke Mu asked Gongsun Zhi for his opinion. He replied, "Years of dearth and plenty simply go in a cycle. You cannot refuse the request." And when the duke questioned Baili Xi, he said, "Yiwu has acted wrongly toward you, but what wrong have his people done?" So in the end the duke heeded the advice of Gongsun Zhi and Baili Xi and sent grain to Jin, transporting it in boats and carts that stretched in a continuous line all the way from the Qin capital at Yong to the Jin capital at Jiang.

In Duke Mu's fourteenth year there was a famine in Qin and the duke sent a request to Jin for grain. The ruler of Jin consulted his chief ministers. Guo Shi said, "Take advantage of the famine and attack Qin. You can win great merit!" The Jin ruler decided to follow this advice.

In Duke Mu's fourteenth year the ruler of Jin called out his troops and led them in an attack on Qin. Duke Mu dispatched his own troops, appointing Pi Bao to lead them, and he himself took part in the attack. On the day *renxu* of the ninth month, he joined in battle with Yiwu, Duke Hui of Jin, in the region of Han.

The Jin ruler, abandoning the main body of his troops, fought for the advantage with the Qin forces, but as he turned his carriage around, his horses became bogged down. Duke Mu and the men under him chased after in pursuit, but they were unable to capture the Jin ruler and instead found themselves surrounded by the Jin army. The Jin forces attacked Duke Mu and had wounded him when 300 men who had earlier eaten horse flesh at Mt. Qi raced to his rescue, braving the Jin forces. The Jin forces broke their encirclement, so that Duke Mu was able to escape and return to his own forces, and in addition the Jin ruler was taken prisoner.

Sometime earlier, Duke Mu lost one of his prize horses. It was discovered that a group of 300 or more rustics in the region of Mt. Qi had captured the

horse and eaten it. The Qin officials in time apprehended the men and were about to punish them, but Duke Mu said, "A gentleman does not allow his domestic animals to injure people. I have heard that if one eats good horseflesh but fails to drink wine, it will lead to illness." He therefore had wine passed out to all the men and pardoned their offence. Later, when the 300 men heard that Qin was about to attack Jin, they all asked to join in the attack. They were thus among the troops accompanying the duke, and when they saw him hard pressed, they all brandished their spears and fought to the death in order to repay the kindness he had shown them with regard to the horseflesh. Thus Duke Mu was able to take the ruler of Jin prisoner and return with him to Qin.

He circulated an order throughout the state, saying, "Fast until tomorrow. I am going to offer the Jin ruler as a sacrifice to the Lord on High." When the Zhou Son of Heaven heard of this, he exclaimed, "Jin belongs to the same clan as myself!" and begged Duke Mu to spare the Jin ruler.²⁸

Duke Mu's wife was an older sister of Yiwu, the Jin ruler, and when she heard of the proposed sacrifice, she donned mourning garments and appeared barefoot before the duke, saying, "I was unable to instruct my younger brother properly and so have occasioned you this inconvenience."

Duke Mu said, "I supposed it was an illustrious feat to have captured the Jin ruler. But now the Son of Heaven speaks on his behalf, and my wife is grieved." He therefore swore an oath of alliance with the Jin ruler and gave him permission to return to his own state, shifting him to better quarters and feasting him with seven sets of sacrificial animals.

In the eleventh month the Jin ruler Yiwu returned to his state. He presented Qin with the territory west of the Yellow River and sent the heir apparent Yu to be a hostage in Qin. Duke Mu gave the heir apparent Yu one of his daughters for a wife. At this time, therefore, the Qin territory extended all the way east to the Yellow River.

In Duke Mu's eighteenth year, Duke Huan of Qi died. In his twentieth year Qin wiped out the states of Liang and Rui.

In Duke Mu's twenty-second year the heir apparent Yu, hearing that the Jin ruler was ill, said to himself, "Liang was my mother's state, and now Qin has destroyed it. I have many brothers, and if my father, the ruler of Jin, should pass away, Qin is certain to detain me here. Then Jin will ignore my claim to the throne and set up one of my brothers instead!" He therefore escaped from Qin and made his way back to Jin.

In Duke Mu's twenty-third year Duke Hui of Jin died and his son Yu was set up as ruler. Duke Mu of Qin, angry at Yu for having escaped, thereupon invited the ducal son Chonger to come to Qin from the state of Chu, and offered him as a wife his daughter who had previously been married to Yu. Chonger at first declined the offer but later accepted her as his wife. Duke Mu treated him with increasing respect and generosity.

In Duke Mu's twenty-fourth year he sent an envoy to inform the high

ministers of Jin that he wished to place Chonger on the throne of Jin; the ministers of Jin gave their consent. Duke Mu accordingly sent men to escort Chonger to Jin, and in the second month he was set up as ruler of Jin. He is known as Duke Wen. Duke Wen then dispatched men to kill Yu. Yu is known posthumously as Duke Huai of Jin.

In the autumn of this year Dai, the younger brother of King Xiang of the Zhou dynasty, led the Di people in an attack on the king. The king fled from the capital and took up residence in the state of Zheng. In the twenty-fifth year of Duke Mu the Zhou king sent envoys to Jin and Qin to inform them of his difficulties. Duke Mu of Qin led his troops and assisted Duke Wen of Jin in restoring the Zhou king to his throne and killing his younger brother Dai.

In Duke Mu's twenty-eighth year Duke Wen of Jin defeated the state of Chu at Chengpu.

In his thirtieth year Duke Mu aided Duke Wen of Jin in besieging the state of Zheng. Zheng sent an envoy to say to Duke Mu, "Destroying Zheng and increasing the power of Jin will benefit Jin, but hardly be to the profit of Qin. The stronger Jin becomes the greater the worry for Qin!" Duke Mu thereupon called off his troops and returned to Qin, and Jin likewise abandoned the siege.

In Duke Mu's thirty-second year Duke Wen of Jin died (628 BC). Some men of Zheng offered to betray Zheng to Jin, saying, "We have charge of the city gate — Zheng can be taken by surprise attack."

Duke Mu consulted Jian Shu and Baili Xi, but they replied, "No one who has to pass through numerous states and journey 1,000 *li* to carry out a surprise attack is likely to have much success. Moreover, if these men betray Zheng's secrets to us, how do we know that people of our own state are not secretly informing Zheng of our plans? The idea is impossible!"

But Duke Mu replied, "You understand nothing of this. I have already made my decision!" Then he called out his forces, appointing Baili Xi's son Mengming Shi, Jian Shu's son Xiqi Shu, and Bai Yibing to lead the troops. The day the troops set out, Baili Xi and Jian Shu both wept over the departure. Duke Mu accosted them angrily, saying, "Now that my troops are setting out, what do you mean by weeping and trying to detain the army?"

The two old men replied, "It is not that we would dare to detain your army. But when the army goes, our sons go with it. We are old, and if the army is long in returning, we fear we will never see them again. That is the only reason we weep."

When the old men had withdrawn from the duke's presence, they said to their sons, "If the army you are with is defeated, it will surely be at the narrow defile of Yao."

In the spring of Duke Mu's thirty-third year Qin's forces set out for the east. As they passed the northern gate of the Zhou capital on their way through Jin, the royal grandson Man said, "The Qin army has no sense of propriety. How could it help but suffer defeat?"[29](#)

The Qin troops had advanced as far as Hua when they encountered Xian Gao, a travelling merchant of Zheng who was taking twelve oxen to the Zhou capital to sell. Seeing the Qin troops, he became fearful that he would be put to death or taken captive, and so he presented his oxen, saying, "The ruler of Zheng, hearing that your great state was coming to punish him, has respectfully taken measures for his defence, and at the same time has sent me with these twelve oxen for the provisioning of your officers."

The three Qin generals conferred together, saying, "We had intended to make a surprise attack on Zheng, but now Zheng already knows about it. Better to abandon the mission than to go any farther." They proceeded to wipe out Hua, a city on the Jin border.

At this time the burial of Duke Wen of Jin had not yet been carried out. His heir, Duke Xiang, was enraged. "Qin thinks nothing of the fact that I am newly bereaved and takes advantage of our mourning to wipe out our city of Hua!" he said. Then he dyed his white mourning garments black and called out his troops to cut off the Qin forces at Yao. He inflicted a crushing defeat on the Qin army, not allowing a single man to escape. He took the three Qin commanders prisoner and returned with them to Jin.

The widow of Duke Wen of Jin was a daughter of the Qin ruling house, and she spoke to her son regarding the three captive Qin generals, saying, "The hatred Duke Mu bears these men eats into his very bones and marrow! I beg you to send them back to Qin so that my lord of Qin may have the pleasure of boiling them alive!"

The Jin ruler consented to this and sent the three generals back to Qin. When they arrived, Duke Mu donned white mourning garments and went out to the suburbs to greet them. Addressing them, he wept and said, "I failed to heed the advice of Baili Xi and Jian Shu and so brought shame on you three. What fault have you committed? I ask only that you give all your thought to how we may wipe out this disgrace, never slacking your efforts!" He then restored the three men to their posts and ranks and treated them with even greater favour.

In Duke Mu's thirty-fourth year Shangchen, the heir apparent of the state of Chu, murdered his father, King Cheng, and became ruler in his place. Duke Mu once more ordered Mengming Shi and the other commanders to lead the Qin forces in an attack on Jin. They engaged in battle at Pengya but, failing to win the advantage, withdrew their troops and returned home.

The ruler of the Rong people sent You Yu to Qin. You Yu's forbears were people of Jin who had fled from Jin and gone to live among the Rong. You Yu could therefore speak the language of Jin. The Rong ruler, having heard that Duke Mu was a worthy man, dispatched You Yu to observe the situation in Qin.

Duke Mu showed You Yu the goods and possessions heaped up in his palace, but You Yu said, "If these were made by ghosts, it must have exhausted the spirit world, and if they were made by human beings, it must have been bitter for the people!"

Duke Mu, puzzled, questioned him, saying, "China employs the Odes and Documents, its rites and music, its laws and regulations to govern the land, but even so there are times of chaos. Now the Rong and Yi people have none of these, so how can they bring about order? It must be very difficult, is it not?"

You Yu laughed and replied, "It is precisely because of these that China is in chaos! In ancient times when the sage rulers such as the Yellow Emperor created rites and music, laws and regulations, they took the lead in observing and carrying them out, and a small measure of order was achieved. But the rulers of later ages grow daily more arrogant and licentious, scrutinizing and berating their subjects in the name of the law, while their subjects, utterly exhausted, angrily reproach their superiors in the name of benevolence and righteousness. So superior and inferior wrangle and revile one another, usurping and murdering until whole clans are wiped out. And all because of such things as rites and music, laws and regulations!

"The Rong and Yi people are not like this. Superiors treat their inferiors with simplicity and thoughtfulness, while inferiors serve their superiors with loyalty and good faith, and the governing of the whole state is like the ordering of a single individual. No one knows why order comes about — such is the ordering of a true sage."

When Duke Mu retired from the interview, he questioned his internal secretary Liao, saying, "I have heard that a sage in a neighbouring state can be a source of worry to that state's rivals. Now this worthy man You Yu could be a threat to me. What should I do?"

The internal secretary Liao replied, "This Rong ruler lives hidden away in the borderlands and has never heard the music of China. You could try sending him some women musicians to distract his attention. Meanwhile you could make various requests of You Yu in order to cause dissension between him and his ruler, detaining him here and failing to send him back when the date for his return comes. The Rong ruler will wonder at this and will surely begin to suspect You Yu. Once dissension is sown between ruler and subject, we can make You Yu our captive. And if the Rong ruler likes our music, he is bound to neglect affairs of government."

Duke Mu approved this plan and accordingly seated You Yu on a mat close by his side, pressed one dish after another on him, and questioned him about the topography of the Rong territory and the strength of its armed forces, till he had learned all about them. Then he ordered the internal secretary to send two sets of eight women musicians each to the Rong ruler. The Rong ruler accepted the musicians, found them to his liking, and by year-end had still not sent them back. Qin then sent You Yu back to his own country.

You Yu repeatedly admonished the Rong ruler, but his advice went unheeded. Meanwhile, Duke Mu several times sent persons to speak to You Yu in secret and invite him to come to Qin. In the end You Yu left the Rong

ruler and came over to the side of Qin. Duke Mu treated him with the courtesy due a guest and questioned him on how to go about attacking the Rong.

In his thirty-sixth year Duke Mu once more bestowed favours on Mengming and the other commanders and sent them to lead troops in an attack on Jin, burning their boats behind them when they crossed the Yellow River. They inflicted a crushing defeat on the men of Jin, seizing the cities of Wangguan and Jiao and thus repaying Jin for the battle of Yao. The people of Jin all kept to their cities and did not venture forth.

Then Duke Mu in person crossed the Yellow River at Reed Ford and raised a grave mound for the dead who had fallen in the battle of Yao, proclaiming mourning and carrying out lamentations for three days.

He then swore this oath with his army: "You, my officers and men, hearken and cease your clamour! I declare this oath to you. The men of old consulted with their grey-haired ones, the hoary-headed, and thus they were without error. But I keep recalling how I failed to heed the counsels of Jian Shu and Baili Xi. Therefore I take this oath, so that ages hereafter may remember my error."³⁰

When gentlemen heard of this, they all wept tears of admiration, saying, "Ah, Duke Mu of Qin did right by others. So in the end he achieved a felicitous outcome through Mengming."

In his thirty-seventh year Duke Mu employed You Yu's advice to carry out an attack on the Rong ruler, acquiring twelve new states, extending his territory 1,000 *li*, and making himself overlord of the Western Rong. The Son of Heaven dispatched Guo, the Duke of Shao, to congratulate Duke Mu and present him with a golden drum.

In his thirty-ninth year (621 BC) Duke Mu died and was buried at Yong. He was accompanied in death by 177 persons. Three good ministers of the Ziyu family, Yanxi, Zhonghang and Zhenhu, were among those who followed him in death. The people of Qin, grieved at this, composed for them the song in the *Book of Odes* known as "Yellow Birds".³¹

The gentleman remarks: Duke Mu of Qin broadened his territory and increased his state, in the east humbling the powerful Jin, in the west making himself overlord of the Rong barbarians. But he never became a leader of the alliance, which is only right.³² For when he died, he cast aside his people and instead enlisted his good ministers to accompany him in death. When the kings of antiquity passed away, they left virtue behind them and laws to be handed down. How could they ever snatch away their best men and good ministers, causing their people to grieve? So we know that Qin will never again be able to march east in conquest.³³

Duke Mu had forty sons. The heir apparent Ying succeeded him as ruler and is known as Duke Kang.

Duke Kang first year: in the previous year, when Duke Mu died, Duke

Xiang of Jin also died. Duke Xiang's younger brother was named Yong and, his mother being of the state of Qin, he was living in Qin. Zhao Dun, a high official of Jin, wanted to make him ruler of Jin and therefore dispatched Sui Hui³⁴ to go to Qin to fetch him. The Qin armed forces had escorted Yong as far as Linghu when the people of Jin, having meanwhile set up Duke Xiang's son as their new ruler, instead sent a force to attack the Qin army. The Qin army was defeated and Sui Hui fled back to Qin.

In Duke Kang's second year Qin attacked Jin and seized the city of Wu to retaliate for its defeat at Linghu.

In Duke Kang's fourth year Jin attacked Qin and seized Shaoliang. In his sixth year Qin attacked Jin and seized Jima, fighting at Hequ and inflicting a great defeat on the Jin army. The men of Jin, worried that Sui Hui, having gone over to Qin, would make trouble for Jin, sent Wei Shouyu to go to Qin and, pretending that he had turned against Jin, to plot with Sui Hui. By this ruse he was able to capture Sui Hui and take him back to Jin.

Duke Kang died twelve years after assuming the throne and was succeeded by his son, Duke Gong. In Duke Gong's second year, Zhao Chuan of Jin murdered his ruler, Duke Ling. In Duke Gong's third year, King Zhuang of Chu, being very powerful at this time, marched north with his troops as far as Luoyang and asked about the cauldrons of Zhou.³⁵

Duke Gong died after five years of rule and was succeeded by his son, known as Duke Huan. In Duke Huan's third year Jin defeated one of Qin's generals. In Duke Huan's tenth year King Zhuang of Chu conquered Zheng and advanced north to defeat the Jin forces at the Yellow River. At this time Chu, acting as overlord, called the other feudal rulers together to a conference to conclude an alliance.

In Duke Huan's twenty-fourth year, Duke Li became ruler of Jin. He concluded an alliance with Duke Huan of Qin, the two states occupying opposite sides of the Yellow River, but once the Qin ruler had returned to his capital, he violated the alliance and joined with the Di people in plotting and carrying out a surprise attack on Jin. In Duke Huan's twenty-sixth year Jin led the other feudal lords in an attack on Qin. The Qin army fled in defeat, its enemies pursuing it as far as the Jing River before turning back. Duke Huan died in his twenty-seventh year of rule and was succeeded by his son, Duke Jing.

In Duke Jing's fourth year (573 BC) Luan Shu of Jin murdered his ruler, Duke Li. In Duke Jing's fifteenth year Qin went to the rescue of Zheng, defeating the Jin troops at Li. At this time Duke Dao of Jin was acting as the leader of the alliance.

In Duke Jing's eighteenth year Duke Dao of Jin, being very powerful at this time, several times called the other feudal leaders together and led them in an attack on Qin, defeating the Qin army. When the Qin army fled, the Jin forces pursued them, eventually crossing the Jing River and advancing as far as Yulin before turning back.

In his twenty-seventh year of rule Duke Jing went to Jin and concluded an alliance with Duke Ping, but having done so, he proceeded to violate it.

In Duke Jing's thirty-sixth year (541 BC) the ducal son Wei of Chu murdered his ruler and set himself on the throne. He is known as King Ling. Duke Jing of Qin had a younger brother by the same mother as himself named Houzi or Qian. He enjoyed favour with Duke Jing and was very rich, but when someone slandered him to the duke, he fled to the state of Jin, fearing punishment. He was accompanied by an entourage of 1,000 carriages. Duke Ping of Jin said, "If you are this rich, why do you run away?" Houzi replied, "The ruler of Qin is unprincipled and I am afraid of being put to death. I would like to wait till there has been a change of ruler before going home."

In Duke Jing's thirty-ninth year King Ling of Chu, who was powerful at this time, summoned the other feudal leaders to a meeting at Shen, where he acted as leader of the alliance and put Qing Feng of Qi to death. Duke Jing of Qin died in his fortieth year of rule and was succeeded by his son, who became Duke Ai. At this time Houzi returned to Qin.

In Duke Ai's eighth year (529 BC) the ducal son Qiji of Chu murdered his lord, King Ling, and set himself up as ruler. He is known as King Ping. In Duke Ai's eleventh year King Ping of Chu asked the ruler of Qin for one of his daughters as a bride for his son, the heir apparent Jian. But when the woman arrived in Chu and he saw how beautiful she was, he took her for himself.

In Duke Ai's fifteenth year King Ping of Chu was about to put to death his heir apparent Jian, but Jian escaped, and the Chu minister Wu Zixu fled to the state of Wu. The ducal house of the state of Jin had sunk very low at this time, power being in the hands of the six great ministerial families who struggled for supremacy within the state.³⁶ For this reason Qin and Jin for a long time refrained from attacking each other.

In Duke Ai's thirty-first year King Helü of Wu and Wu Zixu attacked Chu. King Zhao of Chu fled to the state of Sui and the Wu forces eventually entered the Chu capital of Ying. The Chu grandee Shen Baoxu went to Qin to report the emergency, refusing to eat for seven days and for seven days and nights wailing and lamenting. Finally Qin agreed to dispatch a force of 500 war chariots to rescue Chu. They defeated the Wu army, which returned to Wu, and King Zhao was at last able to re-enter the capital city of Ying (505 BC).

After thirty-six years as ruler, Duke Ai died. The heir apparent, Duke Yi, had died previously and never actually became ruler. Duke Yi's son was set up as the new ruler and is known as Duke Hui (I). In the first year of Duke Hui's rule Confucius carried out the duties of the prime minister of Lu.³⁷

In Duke Hui's fifth year the Jin ministerial families Zhonghang and Fan revolted against Jin. Jin ordered the Zhi family and viscount Jian of Zhao to attack them, whereupon the Fan and Zhonghang families fled to Qi. Duke

Hui died in his tenth year and was succeeded by his son, Duke Dao.

In Duke Dao's second year the Qi minister Tian Qi murdered his sovereign, Ruzi, and set up Ruzi's elder brother, Yangsheng, as ruler of Qi; he is known as Duke Dao of Qi.

In the sixth year of Duke Dao of Qin the state of Wu defeated the Qi army. The people of Qi murdered Duke Dao and set up his son as Duke Jian. In Duke Dao's ninth year Duke Ding of Jin and King Fuchai of Wu swore an alliance at Huangchi. They quarrelled as to which should take precedence, but in the end Wu went first since its power exceeded that of the central states of China.

In Duke Dao's twelfth year Tian Chang of Qi murdered Duke Jian and set up Duke Jian's younger brother as Duke Ping, with Tian Chang as prime minister. In Duke Dao's thirteenth year Chu wiped out the state of Chen. Duke Dao of Qin died in the fourteenth year of his rule and was succeeded by his son, who became Duke Ligong. Confucius died in the twelfth year of Duke Dao's rule (479 BC).

In the second year of Duke Ligong's rule the people of Shu came to Qin with gifts.³⁸ In Duke Ligong's sixteenth year a canal was dug that ran parallel to the Yellow River and 20,000 troops were dispatched to attack the area of Dali and seize the city of Wangcheng. In Duke Ligong's twenty-first year Pinyang was made into a district. Jin seized the region of Wucheng.

In Duke Ligong's twenty-fourth year rebellion broke out in Jin, Zhi Bo was killed, and his lands were divided up among the Zhao, Hann, and Wei families. In Duke Ligong's twenty-fifth year Zhi Bo's son Zhi Kai fled with the people of his city to Qin. In Duke Ligong's thirty-third year Qin attacked the Yiqu people and captured their ruler. In Duke Ligong's thirty-fourth year there was an eclipse of the sun. Duke Ligong died and was succeeded by his son, Duke Zao.

In Duke Zao's second year the region of Nanzheng revolted. In his thirteenth year the Yiqu people came to attack Qin, advancing as far as the area south of the Wei River. In the fourteenth year Duke Zao died and was succeeded by his younger brother, known as Duke Huai.

In Duke Huai's fourth year the militia leader Chao joined with the chief ministers of Qin in besieging Duke Huai, whereupon the duke committed suicide. Duke Huai's heir apparent was named Zhaozi, but as he had died at an early age, the chief ministers set up his son as ruler. He is known as Duke Ling and was the grandson of Duke Huai.

In Duke Ling's sixth year Jin walled the city of Shaoliang, whereupon Qin attacked the city. In Duke Ling's thirteenth year Qin walled Jigu. Duke Ling died, but his son, Duke Xuan, did not succeed him. Instead he was succeeded by his paternal uncle Daozi, who became Duke Jian. Duke Jian was a son of Duke Huai and younger brother of Zhaozi.

In Duke Jian's sixth year officials were for the first time ordered to wear swords. The Luo canal was dug and the city of Chongquan walled. Duke Jian

died in his sixteenth year and was succeeded by his son, Duke Hui (II).

In Duke Hui's twelfth year his son Chuzei was born. In Duke Hui's thirteenth year Qin attacked Shu and seized Nanzheng. Duke Hui died and was succeeded by his son Chuzei, but in Chuzei's second year of rule the militia leader Gai escorted Duke Ling's son, Duke Xian, from the region of Hexi and set him up as ruler. He killed Chuzei and his mother and sank their bodies in the depths of the river. From this time on, Qin underwent frequent changes of rulership, ruler and subject clashing and contending with one another. As a result, Jin was able to regain power and to seize Qin's lands west of the Yellow River.

In Duke Xian's first year he prohibited the practice of "following in death". In his second year the city of Yueyang was walled.

In the first month of his fourth year, the day gengyin, the future Duke Xiao was born. In Duke Xian's eleventh year Dan, the grand historian of the Zhou court, had an interview with Duke Xian and said, "The states of Zhou and Qin were originally joined together, but later they separated. Five hundred years after the separation they will join together again, and seventy-seven years after they join together a dictator king will appear."³⁹

In Duke Xian's sixteenth year peach trees blossomed in winter, and in his eighteenth year it rained gold on Yueyang. In his twenty-first year Qin fought with Jin at Shimen and cut off the heads of 60,000 of the enemy. The Zhou Son of Heaven congratulated Qin by presenting it with an embroidered sacrificial dress. In Duke Xian's twenty-third year Qin fought with Wei and Jin at Shaoliang and captured their leader Gongsun Cuo. Duke Xian died in his twenty-fourth year of rule and was succeeded by his son, Duke Xiao, who was twenty-one years of age at the time.

Duke Xiao first year (361 BC): In the area east of the Yellow River and the mountains, six powerful states were in existence, the ruler King Wei of Qi, King Xuan of Chu, King Hui of Wei, Duke Dao of Yan, Duke Ai of Hann, and Duke Cheng of Zhao being ranged side by side, while in the region of the Huai and Si rivers there were ten or more smaller states. Chu and Wei adjoined Qin's borders. Wei had built a long wall extending from Zheng along the Luo River and then north, where Wei held the region of Shangjun, while Chu held possession of Ba and Qianzhong south of the Han River. The Zhou royal house had sunk into insignificance and the feudal lords ruled by force, wrangling with one another and annexing each other's lands. Qin was situated far out on the border in the old province of Yong and did not participate in the alliances of the feudal lords of the central states, being treated instead like a barbarian people.

Duke Xiao thereupon began to exercise kindness in his rule, assisting the orphaned and widowed; he invited fighting men, clarified the awards they would receive for their accomplishments, and circulated an order throughout his realm, saying: "In past times our Duke Mu, residing in the region of Mt. Qi and Yong, cultivated virtue and practised the martial arts,

in the east pacifying the troubles in Jin and fixing his borders along the Yellow River, while in the west he became overlord of the Rong and Di people and extended his territory 1,000 *li*. The Son of Heaven acknowledged his leadership and the feudal lords all offered congratulations — so glorious was the manner in which he opened the way for future accomplishment!

“But then came the time of dukes Ligong, Zao, and Jian, the disquiet of the Chuizi affair, when the state was beset by internal woes and there was no leisure to tend to outside affairs. Then the Three Jin⁴⁰ attacked and wrested from us the lands west of the Yellow River that had belonged to our former ruler, and the feudal lords looked down on Qin. No shame could have been greater than ours!

“As soon as Duke Xian assumed rule, however, he brought order to the borderlands and moved his capital to Yueyang, hoping to march east in attack and to recover the old territories held by Duke Mu, and to carry out the kind of government measures that Duke Mu had. When I recall these intentions cherished by the former ruler, my heart is constantly pained. If among the visitors to our state or the various officials there is anyone who can devise some effective plan for strengthening Qin, I will honour him with office and apportion lands to him.”

Duke Xiao then called out troops and sent them east to besiege the city of Shan, and west to cut down the leader of the Rong people of Huan. When Wei Yang heard of the order which Duke Xiao had circulated throughout his state, he journeyed west to Qin and sought an interview with Duke Xiao through the introduction of Jing Jian.⁴¹

Duke Xiao second year: the Son of Heaven sent him a gift of sacrificial meat.

Duke Xiao third year: Wei Yang spoke to the duke, urging him to change the laws, impose penalties, encourage agricultural pursuits within the state, and on the foreign front to reward those who would fight and die in battle. Duke Xiao approved of these proposals. Gan Long, Du Cui, and others disagreed, and an argument ensued, but in the end the duke put Wei Yang's laws into effect. The people at first complained bitterly, but after three years had passed, they acknowledged the suitability of the laws, and Wei Yang was elevated to the rank of *zuoshuzhang*.⁴² An account will be found in the chapter on Lord Shang.

Duke Xiao seventh year: the duke met with King Hui of Wei at Duping. Eighth year: he fought with Wei at Yuanli and proved successful. Tenth year: Wei Yang was promoted to the rank of *daliangzao*⁴³ and led the troops to besiege the Wei city of Anyi, forcing it to surrender. Twelfth year: the city of Xianyang was laid out and the Memorial Gate was constructed.⁴⁴ The Qin ruler moved his capital to Xianyang. The smaller hamlets and villages were grouped together to form large districts, with a magistrate to head each district. There were thirty-one districts. The ridges that bounded

the fields were opened up, and in the east the Qin territory extended beyond the Luo River.

Duke Xiao fourteenth year: the *fu* tax was first established. Nineteenth year: the Son of Heaven recognized the duke as a hegemon. Twentieth year: the other feudal lords all extended their congratulations. Qin dispatched Gongzi Shaoguan to lead the troops and convene the feudal lords for a meeting at Fengze and then pay respects at the court of the Son of Heaven. Twenty-first year: Qi defeated Wei at Maling. Twenty-second year: Wei Yang attacked Wei and captured the Wei leader Gongzi Ang. Wei Yang was enfeoffed as a marquis and given the title of Lord Shang.

Duke Xiao twenty-fourth year: the Qin army fought with Jin (Wei) at Yanmen, capturing its leader Wei Cu. Duke Xiao died and was succeeded by his son, the ruler Huiwen. This year Wei Yang was put to death (338 BC).

Earlier, when Wei Yang first promulgated the new laws for Qin, the laws were not effective, with even the heir apparent violating the prohibitions. Wei Yang said, "The reason the laws are not effective is that those in high position take the lead in violating them. If you want the laws to work, then begin by punishing the heir apparent!" Since the heir apparent could not be subjected to the punishment of tattooing, his tutor was tattooed in his place. After this the laws were heeded and the people of Qin were well ordered. But when Duke Xiao died and the heir apparent was set up, there were many members of the ruling family who hated Wei Yang. Wei Yang fled from the state and was accordingly accounted a traitor. In the end he was torn apart by carriages to serve as a warning to the state of Qin.

First year of the ruler Huiwen (337 BC): the men of Chu, Hann, Zhao, and Shu came to the court of Qin to pay their respects. Second year: the Son of Heaven sent congratulations. Third year: the ruler donned the cap of manhood.⁴⁵ Fourth year: the Son of Heaven presented the ruler with meat from the sacrifices to the Zhou ancestors Wen and Wu. The rulers of Qi and Wei took the title of king. Fifth year: the xishou, a native of Yinjin, was promoted to the rank of *daliangzao*.⁴⁶ Sixth year: Wei handed over the region of Yinjin to Qin. Yinjin was renamed Ningqin.

Seventh year: Gongzi Ang fought with Wei, capturing the Wei general Long Jia and cutting off 80,000 heads.⁴⁷ Eighth year: Wei handed over the territories west of the Yellow River to Qin. In the ninth year, Qin crossed the Yellow River and seized Fenyin and Pishi, met with the king of Wei at Ying, and besieged the city of Jiao, forcing its surrender. Tenth year: Zhang Yi became prime minister of Qin. The state of Wei handed over the fifteen districts of Shangjun to Qin. Eleventh year: the region of Yiqu was made into a district; Qin returned the cities of Jiao and Quwo to the state of Wei. The ruler of Yiqu acknowledged fealty to the Qin ruler, and Shaoliang was renamed Xiayang. Twelfth year: the la festival was celebrated for the first time.⁴⁸ Thirteenth year: on the day *mouwu* of the fourth month, the Wei

ruler took the title of king, and the ruler of Hann also became a king. Qin dispatched Zhang Yi to seize the city of Shan; its inhabitants were driven out and handed over to Wei.

Fourteenth year: the Qin ruler began numbering the years of his rule again, and this became the first year of the new numbering.⁴⁹ Second year: Zhang Yi met with the chief officials of Qi and Chu at Niesang. Third year: the heirs apparent of the states of Hann and Wei came to Qin to pay their respects. Zhang Yi became prime minister of Wei. Fifth year: the king of Qin journeyed to the northern bend of the Yellow River. Seventh year: Yue Chi became prime minister of Qin. Hann, Zhao, Wei, Yan, and Qi, leading a force of Xiongnu, joined in attacking Qin. Qin dispatched the militia leader Shuli Ji to do battle with them at Xiuyu. He captured their general Shen Cha, defeated the ducal son Ke of Zhao and the Hann heir apparent Huan, and cut off the heads of 82,000 of the enemy.⁵⁰

Eighth year: Zhang Yi once more became prime minister of Qin. Ninth year: Sima Cuo attacked the state of Shu and wiped it out. Qin also attacked and seized the Zhao cities of Zhongdu and Xiyang. Tenth year: Cang, the heir apparent of the state of Hann, came to Qin as a hostage. Qin attacked and seized the Hann region of Shizhang, attacked and defeated the Zhao general Ni, and attacked and seized twenty-five cities of Yiqu. Eleventh year: Shuli Ji attacked the Wei city of Jiao and forced it to surrender. Qin defeated Hann at Anmen and cut off 10,000 enemy heads; the Hann general, a xishou, fled from the field. Tong, a son of the Qin ruler, was enfeoffed in Shu. The ruler of the state of Yan ceded his throne to his minister Zi Zhi.

Twelfth year: the king of Qin met with the king of Liang at Linjin.⁵¹ The militia leader Shuli Ji attacked Zhao and captured the Zhao general Zhuang. Zhang Yi became prime minister of Chu. Thirteenth year: the militia leader Zhang attacked the forces of Chu at Danyang, captured the Chu general Qu Gai, and cut off the heads of 80,000 of the enemy. He also attacked the Chu region of Hanzhong, seized an area of 600 *li*, and set up the province of Hanzhong. When Chu besieged the Hann city of Yongzhi, Qin dispatched the militia leader Shuli Ji to go to the assistance of Hann and proceed east to attack Qi. Qin also ordered Dao Man to assist Wei in attacking in Yan. Fourteenth year: Qin attacked Chu and seized Shaoliang, and Dan and Li acknowledged fealty to Qin. Zhuang, the prime minister of Shu, killed the marquis of Shu and came to surrender to Qin.

King Huiwen died and was succeeded by his son, King Wu. Hann, Wei, Qi, Chu, and Zhao all came to Qin as guests to offer their support.

In his first year (310 BC) King Wu met with King Hui of Wei at Linjin.⁵² He put to death Zhuang, the prime minister of Shu. Zhang Yi and Wei Zhang both left Qin and went east to Wei. Qin attacked Yiqu, Dan and Li. Nangong Jie died. Second year: the office of chancellor was set up.⁵³ Shuli Ji and Gan

Mou were appointed chancellor of the right and left respectively. Zhang Yi died in Wei. Third year: King Wu met with King Xiang of Hann outside the city of Linjin. Shuli Ji became prime minister of Hann. King Wu said to Gan Mou, "I want to send my war chariots through the region of the three rivers and call on the Zhou royal house.⁵⁴ Then I can die without regret." That autumn he dispatched Gan Mou and the militia leader Feng to attack Yiyang. Fourth year: they overran Yiyang, cutting off 60,000 enemy heads, and then crossed the Yellow River and built defensive walls around Wusui. The heir apparent of Wei came to the Qin court.

King Wu of Qin was a very powerful man who loved feats of strength. Persons noted for their physical strength such as Ren Bi, Wu Huo, and Meng Yue all rose to high office under him. The king joined Meng Yue in a cauldron-lifting contest and broke his knee-cap. In the eighth month King Wu died and Meng Yue and his family were all put to death.

King Wu had taken a daughter of the Wei ruling house as his queen, but as she had borne him no sons, his younger brother by a different mother was set up as ruler to succeed him. This was King Zhaoxiang. King Zhaoxiang's mother, a member of the Chu ruling family, bore the surname Mi and the title Queen Dowager Xuan. When King Wu died, King Zhaoxiang was a hostage in the state of Yan, but the men of Yan escorted him back to Qin so he could become ruler.

In King Zhaoxiang's first year (306 BC) Shuli Ji or Lord Yan became prime minister. Gan Mou left Qin and went to Wei. Second year: a comet appeared. The militia leader Zhuang joined with the high ministers, marquises, and ducal sons of Qin in carrying out a revolt, but all were put to death. Even including the consort of King Hui, all died unnatural deaths. The consort of King Wu left Qin and returned to her native state of Wei.

King Zhaoxiang third year: the king assumed the cap of manhood. He met with the king of Chu at Huangji, handing over the region of Shangyong to Chu. Fourth year: Qin seized the city of Puban. A comet appeared. Fifth year: the king of Wei came to pay his respects to the Qin court at Yingting, and Qin returned the city Puban to Wei. Sixth year: Hui, the marquis of Shu, revolted. Sima Cuo restored order to Shu. The militia leader Huan attacked Chu and cut off 20,000 enemy heads. The ducal son Shi, Lord Jingyang, was sent to Qi as a hostage. There was an eclipse of the sun and it grew dark at midday. Seventh year: Qin captured the city of Xincheng. Shuli Ji died.

King Zhaoxiang eighth year: Qin sent its general Mi Rong to attack Chu and seize Xinshi. Qi dispatched Zhang Zi, Wei dispatched Gongsun Xi, and Hann dispatched Bao Yuan to make a joint attack on the Chu city of Fangcheng, in which they seized the Chu general Tang Mei. Zhao destroyed the state of Zhongshan and its ruler fled, eventually dying in Qi. The ducal son Jing of Wei and the ducal son Chang of Hann became marquises.

King Zhaoxiang ninth year: Xue Wen, Lord Mengchang, came to Qin to become its prime minister. Huan attacked Chu and seized eight cities,

killing the Chu general Jing Kuai. Tenth year: King Huai of Chu came to pay his respects at the Qin court, where Qin detained him. Xue Wen resigned the post of prime minister because of Jin Shou and Lou Huan became chancellor.⁵⁵

King Zhaoxiang eleventh year: the five states of Qi, Hann, Wei, Zhao, and Song, along with Zhongshan, joined in an attack on Qin, advancing as far as Yanshi before withdrawing. Qin handed over the regions of Hebei and Fengling to Hann and Wei in order to make peace. A comet appeared. King Huai of Chu escaped and fled to Zhao, but Zhao refused to grant him asylum and sent him back to Qin, where he died. His body was returned to Chu for burial. Twelfth year: Lou Huan resigned and Wei Ran, marquis of Rang, became prime minister. Qin gave Chu 50,000 piculs of grain. Thirteenth year: Xiang Shou attacked Hann and seized Wushi. The *zuogeng* Bai Qi attacked Xincheng.⁵⁶ The fifth rank counsellor Lü Li left Qin and fled to the state of Wei.⁵⁷ Ren Bi became governor of Hanzhong Province. Fourteenth year: the *zuogeng* Bai Qi attacked the Hann and Wei forces at Yique, cutting off 240,000 enemy heads, taking Gongsun Xi prisoner, and capturing five cities.

King Zhaoxiang fifteenth year: the *daliangzao* Bai Qi attacked Wei and seized Yuan, but then returned it. He attacked Chu and seized Wan. Sixteenth year: Sima Cuo seized Zhi and Deng. Wei Ran resigned the post of prime minister. Qin enfeoffed the ducal son Shi in Wan, the ducal son Kui in Deng, and Wei Ran in Tao, making them all marquises. Seventeenth year: Lord Chengyang came to the Qin court to pay respects, and the Eastern Zhou ruler also came to court. Qin exchanged the city of Yuan for Puban and Pishi. The king of Qin went to Yiyang. Eighteenth year: Sima Cuo attacked Yuan, Heyong, and Jueqiao and seized them.

King Zhaoxiang nineteenth year (288 BC): the king of Qin became Western Emperor and the ruler of Qi became Eastern Emperor. Both rulers then abandoned the titles.⁵⁸ The fifth rank counsellor Lü Li returned to Qin. Qi destroyed the state of Song and the king of Song took up residence in Wei. He died at Wen. Ren Bi died. Twentieth year: the king of Qin visited Hanzhong. He also visited Shangjun and the northern bend of the Yellow River.

King Zhaoxiang twenty-first year: Sima Cuo attacked the Henei area of Wei. Wei presented the city of Anyi to Qin. Qin expelled the inhabitants and moved its own people to the area east of the Yellow River, bestowing noble ranks and pardoning criminals in order to facilitate the move. The ducal son Shi, Lord Jingyang, was enfeoffed in Wan. Twenty-second year: Meng Wu attacked Qi. Nine districts were created in the area east of the Yellow River. The Qin ruler met with the king of Chu at Wan, and with the king of Zhao at Zhongyang. Twenty-third year: the Qin commandant Sili joined Hann, Wei, Zhao, and Yan in an attack on Qi, destroying Jixi. The Qin king met with the

king of Wei at Yiyang, and with the king of Hann at Xincheng. Twenty-fourth year: the Qin ruler met with the king of Chu at Yan and again at Rang. Qin seized the Wei city of Ancheng and advanced as far as Daliang, but Yan and Zhao came to its rescue and the Qin army withdrew. Wei Ran resigned as prime minister.

King Zhaoxiang twenty-fifth year: Qin captured two of Zhao's cities. The Qin ruler met with the king of Hann at Xincheng, and with the king of Wei at Xinming city. Twenty-sixth year: Qin pardoned criminals and moved them to the region of Rang. Wei Ran resumed the post of prime minister. Twenty-seventh year: Sima Cuo attacked Chu. Qin pardoned criminals and moved them to the region of Nanyang. Bai Qi attacked Zhao and seized the city of Guanglang in Dai. Qin also sent Sima Cuo to set out with troops from Longxi and, proceeding through Shu, to attack Qianzhong, which he overran. Twenty-eighth year: the *daliangzao* Bai Qi attacked Chu and seized Yan and Deng. Criminals were pardoned and transported to those areas. Twenty-ninth year: the *daliangzao* Bai Qi attacked Chu and seized the Chu capital of Ying, which was made into Nan Province. The Chu king fled. The Zhou ruler came to Qin. The king of Qin met with the king of Chu at Xiangling. Bai Qi was made Lord Wuan.

King Zhaoxiang thirtieth year (277 BC): Ruo, the governor of Shu, attacked Chu and seized Wujun and Jiangnan, which were made into Qianzhong Province. Thirty-first year: Bai Qi attacked Wei and seized two cities. The people of Chu revolted in Qin's region of Jiangnan. Thirty-second year: the prime minister Wei Ran attacked Wei, advancing as far as Daliang. He crushed the forces of Bao Yuan, cutting off 40,000 enemy heads; Bao Yuan fled. Wei presented Qin with three districts in a bid for peace. Thirty-third year: Hu Shang, a "guest minister" of Qin,⁵⁹ attacked the Wei cities of Juan, Caiyang, and Changshe and seized them. He carried out a surprise attack on Mang Mao's forces at Huayang, defeating them and cutting off 150,000 enemy heads. Wei offered Nanyang to Qin in a bid for peace. Thirty-fourth year: Qin gave Wei the Hann region of Shangyong and made it into a province. Officials who had been removed from office in Nanyang were transported there to take up residence.

King Zhaoxiang thirty-fifth year (272 BC): Qin aided Hann, Wei, and Chu in an attack on Yan. The province of Nanyang was set up. Thirty-sixth year: Zao, a guest minister of Qin, attacked Qi and seized Gang and Shou; these were handed over to Wei Ran, the marquis of Rang. Thirty-eighth year: the *zhonggeng* Hu Shang attacked the Zhao city of Eyu but was unable to seize it.⁶⁰ Fortieth year: the Qin heir apparent Dao died in Wei. His body was returned for burial in Zhiyang. Forty-second year: Bai Qi, Lord Wuan, attacked Hann and captured nine cities, cutting off 50,000 enemy heads. Forty-fourth year: Qin attacked Hann's Nan Province and seized it. Forty-fifth year: the fifth rank counsellor Ben attacked Hann and seized ten cities. The ducal son Kui, Lord Sheyang, left the capital to proceed to his fief, but

died before arriving.

King Zhaoxiang forty-seventh year (260 BC): Qin attacked Hann's region of Shangdang, which surrendered to the state of Zhao. Qin then launched an attack on Zhao. Zhao dispatched troops to meet the attack, and for a time they were stalemated. Qin then dispatched Bai Qi, Lord Wuan, to press the attack, and he inflicted a crushing defeat on Zhao at Changping, killing the entire force of over 400,000 men. Forty-eighth year: Hann presented the city of Yuanyong to Qin. The Qin army was divided into three parts. Bai Qi returned to Qin. Wang He led the forces of Qin in an attack on Zhao's cities of Wuan and Pilao and captured them. Sima Geng proceeded north to take control of Taiyuan, gaining possession of all of Hann's region of Shangdang.⁶¹ In the tenth month the fifth rank counsellor Ling attacked Zhao's city of Handan. Forty-ninth year: in the first month Qin dispatched more troops to assist Ling, but Ling was unsuccessful in battle and was relieved of his command, Wang He replacing him as commander. In the tenth month the Qin general Zhang Tang attacked Wei, but his commander Cai abandoned his post and failed to stick by it; on return to Qin he was executed.

King Zhaoxiang fiftieth year (257 BC): in the tenth month Bai Qi, Lord Wuan, was accused of a crime, reduced to the rank of common soldier, and exiled to Yinmi. Zhang Tang attacked Zheng and captured it. In the twelfth month more troops were sent to reinforce the army outside the city of Fencheng. Bai Qi, Lord Wuan, was accused of further crimes and put to death. Wang He attacked Handan but failed to capture it. He withdrew and fled with his troops to the army at Fencheng. Two or more months later he attacked the Wei army, cutting off 60,000 enemy heads. The bodies of 20,000 men of Wei and Chu washed down the Yellow River. Wang He attacked Fencheng and then joined Zhang Tang in capturing Ningxinzong. Ningxinzong was renamed Anyang. For the first time a bridge was built across the Yellow River.

King Zhaoxiang fifty-first year (256 BC): the Qin general Jiu attacked Hann, seized Yangcheng and Fumai, and cut off 40,000 enemy heads. He attacked Zhao and seized twenty or more districts, beheading or capturing 90,000 of the enemy. The Western Zhou ruler revolted against Qin and, entering into alliance with the other feudal rulers, led a force of crack troops drawn from all over the empire out of Yique in an attack on Qin, preventing Qin from maintaining contact with Yangcheng. Qin thereupon dispatched its general Jiu to attack Western Zhou. The Western Zhou ruler hastened to Qin to acknowledge his submission, bowing his head in recognition of guilt and offering his entire territory of thirty-six cities and 30,000 inhabitants to Qin. The Qin king accepted the gift and sent the Zhou ruler back to his capital in Zhou. Fifty-second year: the Zhou people fled to the east and their sacred vessels, including the nine cauldrons, passed into the hands of Qin.⁶² Thus the Zhou dynasty came to an end.

Fifty-third year: the various rulers of the empire came to Qin as guests, but the ruler of Wei was the last to do so. Qin dispatched Jiu to attack Wei, seizing Wucheng. When the king of Hann came to the Qin court, the state of Wei turned over its internal affairs to the direction of Qin. Fifty-fourth year: the king of Qin carried out the suburban sacrifice to the Lord on High at Yong. Fifty-sixth year: in the autumn King Zhaoxiang died and was succeeded by his son, King Xiaowen. King Xiaowen honoured his deceased mother Tang Bazi with the title Queen Dowager Tang and had her body interred with that of the former king. The king of Hann donned mourning garments and came to Qin to offer condolences and sacrifice. The other feudal rulers all sent their prime ministers to Qin to offer condolences and sacrifice and to be present at the burial ceremony.

King Xiaowen first year (250 BC): criminals were pardoned, meritorious ministers of the former ruler were treated with generosity, and prohibitions on the use of parklands were relaxed. His mourning duties completed, King Xiaowen ascended the throne on the day *jihai* of the tenth month. Three days later, on the day *xinchou*, he died. He was succeeded by his son, King Zhuangxiang.

King Zhuangxiang first year (250 BC): many criminals were pardoned, meritorious ministers of the former ruler were honoured, generous awards were handed out to the ruler's kin, and the people were treated with kindness. The Eastern Zhou ruler plotted with the other feudal lords to attack Qin, but the Qin prime minister Lü Buwei had him put to death and confiscated all his lands. Qin did not cut off the Zhou sacrifices, however, but bestowed the region of Yangren on the Zhou ruler so that he could carry on the sacrifices to his ancestor.⁶³ Qin ordered Meng Ao to attack Hann; Hann handed over the regions of Chenggao and Gong. Thus Qin's eastern boundary extended as far as Daliang and it set up the province of Sanchuan or Three Rivers. Second year: Qin ordered Meng Ao to attack Zhao and bring Taiyuan under control. Third year: Meng Ao attacked the Wei cities of Gaodu and Ji and captured them. He also attacked the Zhao cities of Yuci, Xincheng, and Langmeng, seizing thirty-seven cities. In the fourth month there was an eclipse of the sun.

King Zhuangxiang fourth year (247 BC): Wang He attacked Shangdang and the province of Taiyuan was set up. The Wei general Wuji led the forces of five feudal states in an attack on Qin and Qin was forced to withdraw beyond the Yellow River.⁶⁴ Meng Ao suffered defeat and his forces scattered and fled. In the fifth month, the day *bingwu*, King Zhuangxiang died and was succeeded by his son, Zheng, who became the First Emperor of the Qin.

In the twenty-sixth year of his rule (221 BC), King Zheng unified the empire, set up thirty-six provinces, and took the title *Shi Huangdi* or First Emperor of the Qin dynasty. He died in the fifty-first year of his rule (210 BC) and was succeeded by his son Huhai, who is known as the Second

Emperor. In the third year of his rule (207 BC) the feudal lords all rose in revolt against the Qin. Zhao Gao put to death the Second Emperor and set up Ziying. After Ziying had been ruler for a little over a month, the feudal lords executed him and thus wiped out the Qin dynasty. A discussion will be found in "The Basic Annals of the First Emperor".

The Grand Historian remarks: Qin's ancestors belonged to the Ying family, but later they were enfeoffed in various regions and took the names of their respective fiefs as their surname. Hence there was the Xu family, the Tan family, the Ju family, the Zhongli family, the Yunyan family, the Tuqiu family, the Jiangliang family, the Huang family, the Jiang family, the Xiuyu family, the Baiming family, the Feilian family, and the Qin family. But because the ancestor of the Qin family, Zaofu, had been enfeoffed in the city of Zhao, the last became known as the Zhao family.

SHI JI 6: THE BASIC ANNALS OF THE FIRST EMPEROR OF THE QIN

After the First Emperor became ruler, he united all Six States. He melted down the spears and used the metal to cast bells, putting aside shield and armour. He assumed an exalted title, calling himself emperor, making a show of military might and relying on force. The Second Emperor succeeded to the line, but Ziying surrendered and became a prisoner. Thus I made "The Basic Annals of the First Emperor of the Qin".

The First Emperor of the Qin was a son of King Zhuangxiang of Qin. When King Zhuangxiang was a hostage for the state of Zhao, he happened to see a concubine belonging to Lü Buwei.⁶⁵ Pleased with her, he took her for himself, and she bore the First Emperor. He was born in Handan in the first month of the forty-eighth year of King Zhaoxiang of Qin (259 BC). At his birth he was given the personal name Zheng; his family name was Zhao.⁶⁶

When he was thirteen years old, King Zhuangxiang died and Zheng succeeded him as king of Qin. At this time Qin had already annexed the regions of Ba, Shu, and Hanzhong and extended its territory past Wan to Ying, where it set up Nan Province. In the north it had taken possession of the area from Shang Province east, which comprised the provinces of Hedong, Taiyuan, and Shangdang, and east as far as Xingyang,⁶⁷ wiping out the two Zhou domains and setting up the province of Sanchuan or Three Rivers. Lü Buwei was prime minister and was enfeoffed with 100,000 households and the title of marquis of Wenxin. He had gathered a group of guests and wandering scholars, hoping to unite the world, and Li Si was one of his retainers. Meng Ao, Wang Ji, and Lord Biao commanded the army. As the king was still young and had just ascended the throne, he entrusted affairs of state to his chief ministers.

A revolt had arisen in Jinyang, and in the first year of the new ruler's reign (246 BC) General Meng Ao attacked and brought it under control. In the second year (245) Lord Biao led the troops in an attack on Juan in Wei, cutting off 30,000 enemy heads. In the third year (244) Meng Ao attacked Hann and captured thirteen walled cities. Wang Ji died. In the tenth month General Meng Ao attacked the Wei cities of Chang and Yougui. There was a severe famine this year. In the fourth year (243) Chang and Yougui capitulated, and in the third month the army was withdrawn. The Qin prince who had been a hostage in Zhao returned, and the Zhao heir apparent left

Qin and returned to his state. In the tenth month, on the day with the cyclical sign gengyin, swarms of locusts appeared from the east and darkened the sky. There was widespread pestilence. Commoners who contributed 1,000 piculs of grain to the government were granted one degree of noble rank.

In the fifth year (242) General Meng Ao attacked and seized control of the cities of Suanzao, Yan, Xu, Changping, Yongqiu, and Shanyang. In all he captured twenty cities. The province of Dong was set up. In winter there was thunder.

In the sixth year (241) the states of Hann, Wei, Zhao, Wey, and Chu joined in attacking Qin and seizing Shouling. Qin called out its troops, whereupon the forces of the five states withdrew. Qin attacked Wey and advanced on Dong Province. The Wey ruler Jue led his followers and moved to the region of Yewang, where he blocked the mountains in order to protect the area of Wei north of the Yellow River.

In the seventh year (240) a comet appeared in the east and then was seen in the north. In the fifth month it appeared in the west. General Meng Ao died. He had attacked Long, Gu, and Qingdu and was returning with his troops for an attack on Ji. The comet appeared in the west once more. On the sixteenth day of the month Queen Dowager Xia died.

In the eighth year (239) the king's younger brother Chengjiao, Lord Chang'an, led troops in an attack on Zhao but then revolted. He was killed at Tunliu. The officers of his army were all executed and the people of Tunliu were ordered to be transported to Lintao. When the army commander Bi was killed, the people of Tunliu and Puhao once more revolted. They were killed and their corpses exposed.⁶⁸ The Yellow River overflowed, strewing fish over the land. People set off east by light carriage or horseback in search of food.

Lao Ai was enfeoffed as marquis of Changxin, being assigned lands east of the mountains and instructed to take up residence there.⁶⁹ He had a free hand in matters of palaces, dogs and horses, clothing, parks, and hunting areas, and all affairs of state great and small were decided by him. The province of Taiyuan west of the Yellow River was also made part of his domain.

In the ninth year (238) a comet appeared, at times filling the sky. Qin attacked Yuan and Puyang in Wei. In the fourth month the king resided temporarily at Yong, and on the day *jiyou* he received the cap of manhood and put on girdle and sword.

It was discovered that Lao Ai, the marquis of Changxin, was plotting revolt. He had forged the seals of the king and the queen dowager and called out the district troops. Supplementing these with soldiers of the guard, government horsemen, and the chiefs of the Rong and Di tribes and their henchmen, he was preparing to attack the Qinian Palace at Yong and start a revolt. When the king learned of this, he ordered the prime minister,

Lord Changping, and Lord Changwen to call out troops and attack Lao Ai. Fighting took place in Xianyang and several hundred heads were cut off. All who cut off enemy heads were honoured with noble ranks, and all the eunuchs who joined in the hostilities were awarded one degree of noble rank. Lao Ai and the others fled in defeat.

An order was circulated throughout the kingdom offering 1,000,000 cash to anyone who captured Lao Ai alive, and 500,000 cash to anyone who killed him. Lao Ai and his supporters were all seized. Twenty men, including the commandant of the guard, Jie, the prefect of the capital, Si, the lancer of the left, Jie, and the chief of palace counsellors, Qi, were all beheaded and their heads exposed. Lao Ai was torn in two by carriages to serve as a warning and his clan was wiped out. Among his followers, those only slightly involved were assigned to provide "firewood for the spirits".⁷⁰ Over 4,000 families were deprived of noble rank and transported to Shu, being resettled in Fangling.

In the fourth month it was so cold that people froze to death. Yang Duanhe attacked Yanshi. A comet appeared in the west, then appeared again in the north, moving south from the Dipper for eighty days.

Tenth year (237): the prime minister Lü Buwei was implicated in the Lao Ai affair and removed from his post. Huan Ji became a commander of the army. Envoys from Qi and Zhao arrived and a banquet was held. Mao Jiao, a man of Qi, spoke to the king of Qin, saying, "Qin these days thinks in terms of the empire as a whole. But word has it that Your Majesty has moved your mother, the queen dowager, to another location. I fear that if the other feudal rulers hear of this, they will take it as a reason to turn against Qin."⁷¹

The king thereupon went to Yong to fetch the queen dowager and bring her back to Xianyang. Later he arranged for her to reside at the Palace of Sweet Springs. A great search was made for aliens and they were ordered expelled from the state. But when Li Si submitted a memorial arguing against the move, the order for the expulsion of aliens was rescinded.⁷²

Li Si took the opportunity to urge the king of Qin to first take over the state of Hann in order to terrify the other states. The king accordingly sent Li Si to negotiate the surrender of Hann. The king of Hann, distressed at this, plotted with Han Fei to weaken Qin's power.

A man named Wei Liao from Daliang came to Qin and spoke to the king, saying, "Qin's might is such that the rulers of the other states are like mere heads of a province or a district beside it. My only fear is that the other rulers will form an alliance and join in some unexpected move. That is just how Zhi Bo, King Fuchai, and King Min of Qi met with their downfall. I hope Your Majesty will not be sparing of goods and money but will hand out bribes to their leading ministers so as to disrupt their schemes. By laying out no more than 300,000 in gold, you can completely undo the other feudal rulers!"

The king of Qin decided to follow this advice. When he received Wei Liao, he treated him as an equal and shared his clothing and food and drink with him. Later Wei Liao remarked, "The king of Qin, with his arched nose and long eyes, puffed-out chest like a hawk and voice of a jackal, is a man of scant mercy who has the heart of a tiger or a wolf. When he is in difficulty he readily humbles himself before others, but when he has gotten his way, then he thinks nothing of eating others alive. I am a mere commoner, yet when he receives me he always acts as though he were my inferior. But if the king of Qin should ever get his way with the world, then the whole world will end up his prisoner. It doesn't do to stay around a man like that for long!"

He was about to leave, but the king of Qin, learning of his plans, managed to stop him, appointing him a state commandant. In the end he made use of Wei Liao's schemes, which Li Si put into effect.

Eleventh year (236): Wang Jian, Huan Ji, and Yang Duanhe attacked Ye and seized nine cities. Wang Jian attacked Eyu and Laoyang. Their forces were all combined into one army, which Wang Jian commanded for eighteen days. When the army returned, two out of every ten men in the lower ranks then went into action again. They seized Ye and Anyang, this time with Huan Ji in command.

Twelfth year (235): the marquis of Wenxin, Lü Buwei, committed suicide and was buried in secret. It was decreed that any of his retainers who observed mourning for him, if men of Wei, Hann, or Zhao, were to be banished; and if men of Qin and of the 600 picul rank or above, they were to be deprived of noble rank and transported. All retainers who were men of Qin and of the 500 picul rank or below, whether they mourned or not, were to be transported but not deprived of noble rank. "From now on if there are persons like Lao Ai or Lü Buwei who conduct state affairs in an unprincipled manner, their property shall be confiscated and their family members made government slaves. Take note of this!"⁷³

In autumn the followers of Lao Ai who had been transported to Shu were recalled. At this time there was a great drought throughout the empire which lasted from the sixth to the eighth month, when rain finally fell.

Thirteenth year (234): Huan Ji attacked Pingyang in Zhao, killed the Zhao general Hu Zhe, and cut off 100,000 enemy heads. The king journeyed to the area south of the Yellow River. In the first month a comet appeared in the east. In the tenth month Huan Ji attacked Zhao.

Fourteenth year (233): Qin attacked the Zhao army at Pingyang, stormed Yian and captured it, and killed its general. Huan Ji seized control of Pingyang and Wucheng. Han Fei came as an envoy to Qin. The king, heeding the advice of Li Si, detained him. Han Fei died at Yunyang.⁷⁴ The king of Hann requested that he be allowed to become a subject of the Qin ruler.

Fifteenth year (232): large numbers of troops were called up. One army

advanced as far as Ye, another advanced to Taiyuan and seized Langmeng. There was an earthquake.

Sixteenth year (231): in the ninth month troops were dispatched to accept control of the Hann region of Nanyang, with the prefect of the capital Teng as acting magistrate. For the first time men were ordered to register according to their ages. Wei presented territory to Qin; Qin founded the city of Li.

Seventeenth year (230): the prefect of the capital Teng attacked Hann, seized King An of Hann, and took over all of his territory. The region was made into a province with the name Yingchuan. There was an earthquake. Queen Dowager Huayang died. The people suffered from severe famine.

Eighteenth year (229): large numbers of troops were called up to attack Zhao. Wang Jian led the forces from Shang Province in subjugating Jingxing, Yang Duanhe led the forces from north of the Yellow River, and Qiang Hui attacked Zhao. Yang Duanhe surrounded the city of Handan.

Nineteenth year (228): Wang Jian and Qiang Hui seized complete control of all the Zhao territory and at Dongyang captured the king of Zhao. Then they led their troops on in preparation for an attack on the state of Yan, encamping at Zhongshan.

The king of Qin journeyed to Handan, where he put to death all the persons who had been enemies of his mother's family when he was growing up in Zhao. He then returned to Qin, going back by way of Taiyuan and Shang Province. The queen dowager, the mother of the First Emperor, passed away. Gongzi Jia, a member of the Zhao ruling family, led several hundred members of his clan to the region of Dai, where he set himself up as king of Dai and, joining his troops in alliance with those of Yan to the east, encamped at Shanggu. There was severe famine.

Twentieth year (227): Crown Prince Dan of Yan, fearful that the Qin troops would march against his state, in desperation sent Jing Ke to assassinate the king of Qin. When the king learned of the plot, he had Jing Ke torn limb from limb to serve as a warning. Then he dispatched Wang Jian and Xin Sheng to attack Yan. Yan and Dai called out their forces and fell on the Qin army, but the Qin army defeated Yan west of the Yi River.

Twenty-first year (226): Wang Pen attacked the Yan capital of Ji. Meanwhile, more and more troops were sent to reinforce Wang Jian's army, so that eventually he defeated the army of Crown Prince Dan, captured the Yan capital of Ji, and seized the Crown Prince's head. The king of Yan took control of the region of Liaodong and made himself king of it. Wang Jian asked leave to return to his home on grounds of old age and illness. A revolt broke out in Xinzheng. Lord Changping was transferred to Ying. There was a severe snowstorm, the snow piling up to a depth of two feet five inches.

Twenty-second year (225): Wang Pen attacked Wei, leading water from the Yellow River to flood the Wei capital of Daliang. The walls of Daliang collapsed and the king of Wei asked permission to surrender. All of his territory was seized.

Twenty-third year (224): the king of Qin summoned Wang Jian, requesting him to make a special effort to return to active duty. He sent him to lead troops in an attack on Jing.⁷⁵ He seized the region from Chen south to Pingyu and took the king of Jing captive. The king of Qin visited Ying and Chen. The Jing general Xiang Yan set up Lord Changping as the new king of Jing and held the region south of the Huai River in revolt against Qin.

Twenty-fourth year (223): Wang Jian and Meng Wu attacked Jing and smashed the Jing army. Lord Changping was killed and Xiang Yan committed suicide.

Twenty-fifth year (222): large numbers of troops were called out and Wang Pen was ordered to attack the Yan region of Liaodong. He captured King Xi of Yan. On his way back he attacked Dai and took prisoner King Jia of Dai. Wang Jian meanwhile finished seizing control of the region of Jing south of the Yangtze River. He forced the capitulation of the Yue ruler and the province of Kuaiji was set up in the region. In the fifth month a great feast was held throughout the whole domain.

Twenty-sixth year (221): King Jian of Qi and his prime minister Hou Sheng dispatched troops to defend the western border of the state and prevent the Qin forces from passing through. Qin ordered General Wang Pen to march south from Yan and attack Qi. He seized King Jian of Qi. With this Qin succeeded in bringing all of the states under its rule.

The king of Qin instructed the chancellor and the imperial secretary, saying, "In the past the king of Hann relinquished his territory and handed over his royal seals, requesting to become a vassal. Later, however, he went back on his promise and allied himself with Zhao and Wei to defy Qin. Therefore I called out troops to punish him, taking the king prisoner.

"I believed that things had been set right and hoped I could lay aside my arms. The king of Zhao then sent his prime minister Li Mu to conclude an oath of alliance, and I accordingly sent back the son who had been a hostage here. But the king violated his oath and turned against me at Taiyuan, so I called out troops to exact punishment by seizing the king. Then, because Gongzi Jia of Zhao set himself up as king of Dai, I called up troops to attack and wipe him out.

"The king of Wei at first promised to be submissive to Qin, but later he joined Hann and Zhao in plotting to attack Qin, so the Qin officers and men were sent in punishment, and they destroyed him. The king of Jing offered me the territory from Qingyang westward, but later he broke his promise by attacking my Nan Province. So I called out troops to punish him, seizing the king and taking control of the Jing territory.

"The king of Yan was stupid and unprincipled, and his heir, Crown Prince Dan, secretly sent Jing Ke on a mission of evil, but my troops punished them and wiped out their country. The king of Qi, heeding the schemes of Hou Sheng, broke off relations with Qin, hoping to start a rebellion, but my troops punished him, taking the king prisoner and restoring order to the

land of Qi.

"Insignificant person that I am, I have called up troops to punish violence and rebellion. Thanks to the help of the ancestral spirits, these six kings have all acknowledged their guilt and the world is in profound order. Now if some change in title is not carried out, there will be no way to celebrate these achievements and make them known to later generations. Let deliberations be held on an imperial title."

The chancellor Wang Wan, the imperial secretary Feng Jie, and the commandant of justice Li Si all replied: "In ancient times the Five Emperors possessed domains that were 1,000 *li* square. Beyond were the feudal lords who were submissive and the barbarians who were submissive. Of the feudal lords, some came to pay respects at court and some did not, but the Son of Heaven could not force his will on them.

"But now Your Majesty has raised troops to punish the evil and remiss, brought peace to the world, made the entire area within the seas into provinces and districts, and insured that laws and rulings shall proceed from a single authority. From highest antiquity to the present, such a thing has never occurred before, nor could the Five Emperors equal it. We have respectfully consulted with the court scholars, who tell us that in antiquity there was the Heavenly August, Earthly August, and Greatly August, of which the Greatly August was the most exalted. Therefore on pain of death we venture to propose this title, namely, that the king shall be known as Greatly August. His commands shall be known as edicts and his orders as decrees, and the Son of Heaven shall refer to himself by the pronoun *zhen*."

The king said, "We will drop the Greatly, keep the August, and adopt the title used by the emperors of high antiquity, calling ourselves Huangdi or August Emperor. Other matters shall be as in the proposal." Thus he gave his approval to the decree. He honoured his father, King Zhuangxiang, with the posthumous title of Grand Supreme August.

An edict was issued, saying: "We have heard that in high antiquity there were titles but no posthumous names. In middle antiquity there were titles, and posthumous names were assigned after the death of a person on the basis of his actions. This results in the son passing judgment on the father, and subjects passing judgment on their ruler. Such a procedure is highly improper and we will have none of it! From now on, this manner of assigning posthumous names shall be abolished. We ourselves shall be called First Emperor, and successive generations of rulers shall be numbered consecutively, Second, Third, and so on for 1,000 or 10,000 generations, the succession passing down without end."

The First Emperor believed that the Five Powers succeed each other in unending cycle, and he held that the Zhou dynasty had ruled by the power of fire. Since the Qin had replaced the Zhou, its power should therefore proceed from that which fire cannot overcome; the power of water had now begun its era of dominance.⁷⁶ He changed the time for the court

celebrations marking the beginning of the year, holding them all on the first day of the tenth month, and all clothing, flags, and pennants honoured the colour black. Among numbers, six was the standard, so that tallies and official caps were six inches, carriages were six feet, six feet were taken to make up one pace, and carriages were drawn by six horses. He also changed the name of the Yellow River, calling it "Powerful Water" to indicate that the era of the power of water had begun. Only by being stern and severe, by settling all affairs in the light of the law, by cutting and slashing without mercy or gentleness, he believed, could he comply with the destiny decreed by the Five Powers. Hence he assiduously applied the law and refused to pardon even crimes committed far in the past.

The chancellor Wang Wan and others stated the opinion that, since the feudal rulers had just recently been defeated and the regions of Yan, Qi, and Jing were situated far from the capital, unless kings were set up in such regions it would be impossible to control them. They therefore requested that sons of the ruler be set up, if the emperor would be so kind as to give his approval.

The First Emperor referred the proposal to the ministers for deliberation. The ministers all indicated their approval. But the commandant of justice Li Si voiced this opinion: "Kings Wen and Wu of the Zhou dynasty enfeoffed a great many of their sons, younger brothers, and other members of their own surname. Later, however, these men became increasingly estranged and even fell on one another like sworn enemies, and when the feudal rulers attacked each other in this manner, the Zhou Son of Heaven was helpless to restrain them. Now, thanks to the spiritual might of the sovereign, all the area within the seas has been united under a single rule and made into provinces and districts. If the sons of the ruler and the ministers who have won merit are rewarded with generous gifts from the public taxes, that will be quite sufficient. They can be easily controlled, and the world will be without dissension. This is the correct method for insuring peace. To establish feudal rulers would not be expedient."

The First Emperor said, "It was because of the marquises and kings that the world suffered so long from unending strife and warfare. Now thanks to the aid of the ancestral spirits, the world has at last been pacified. If the feudal states are re-established, this will encourage the use of arms. To hope for peace and tranquillity under such circumstances will be difficult indeed! The view of the commandant of justice is correct."

Thus the empire was divided into thirty-six provinces, each province provided with a governor, a military commandant, and a superintendent. The common people were renamed "black-headed ones". There was great feasting. Weapons from all over the empire were confiscated, brought to Xianyang, and melted down to be used in casting bells, bell stands, and twelve men made of metal. These last weighed 1,000 piculs each and were set up in the palace.⁷⁷ All weights and measures were standardized, the

gauge of wheeled vehicles was made uniform, and the writing system was standardized.

The empire extended east to the sea and to Chaoxian (Korea), west to Lintao and Qiangzhong, and south to Beihu. In the north fortresses were established along the Yellow River and then over the Yin Mountains to Liaodong.

Rich and powerful families from all over the empire, 120,000 families, were moved to Xianyang. The various ancestral temples, as well as the Zhangtai Palace and Shanglin Park, were all situated south of the Wei River. And whenever Qin would wipe out one of the feudal states, it would make replicas of its halls and palaces and reconstruct them on the slope north of Xianyang, facing south over the Wei. From Yongmen east to the Jing and Wei rivers, mansions, elevated walks, and fenced pavilions succeeded one another, all filled with beautiful women and bells and drums that Qin had taken from the feudal rulers.

Twenty-seventh year (220): the emperor toured Longxi and Beidi, going as far as Chicken Head Mountain and returning by way of Huizhong. He built the Xin Palace south of the Wei River and then renamed it Apex Temple in imitation of the Heavenly Apex.⁷⁸ A road was opened up from Apex Temple to Mt. Li, where the Front Hall of the Palace of Sweet Springs was built. A walled road was constructed for the emperor running from Xianyang to connect with it. This year officers were advanced one step in rank and fast roads were constructed.⁷⁹

Twenty-eighth year (219): the emperor visited the provinces and districts of the east and ascended Mt. Yi in Zhuo. He set up a stone marker and, consulting with the Confucian scholars of Lu, had it inscribed with praises of the virtue of the Qin. He also consulted with the scholars on matters pertaining to the Feng and Shan sacrifices and sacrifices to the various mountains and rivers. Afterward he ascended Mt. Tai, set up a stone marker, and performed the Feng sacrifice. On the way down, he encountered violent wind and rain and had to rest under a tree. He accordingly enfeoffed the tree with the title of fifth rank counsellor. He performed the Shan sacrifice at Liangfu and set up a stone marker inscribed with these words:⁸⁰

The August Emperor mounted the throne, issuing edicts, clarifying laws, which his subjects observe and obey.

In the twenty-sixth year of his rule he first united the world; there were none who did not come to him in submission.

In person he visited the people of distant regions, ascending Mt. Tai, surveying the eastern extremity all around.

The ministers in his retinue, mindful of his deeds, seeking the source of his achievements, reverently praise his merits and virtue.

The way of good government is implemented, the various occupations

obtain what is needful, all is gauged by law and pattern.

His great principles are noble and pre-eminent, to be bestowed on future generations, who will receive and honour them without change.

The August Emperor, sage that he is, has brought peace to the world, never neglectful of his rule.

Early rising, late to retire, he takes measures to bring lasting benefit, devoting himself earnestly to instruction and precept.

His admonitions circulate, his proclamations spread abroad, so that near and far alike are properly ordered, and all bow to the will of the sage.

Eminent and humble are clearly distinguished, men and women are observant of ritual, cautious and attentive to their duties.

Inner and outer concerns are carefully demarked, uniformly faultless and pure, to be passed on to future heirs.

His transforming influence is unending, in ages after his decrees will be honoured, handed down forever with gravest caution.

The emperor then proceeded east from Bohai, passed through Huang and Chui, climbed to the top of Mt. Cheng, and ascended Mt. Zhifu, setting up a stone praising the virtue of the Qin. He then went south to ascend Mt. Langya, which delighted him so greatly that he remained there for three months. He ordered 30,000 households of the black-headed people to be moved to Langya Terrace, exempting them from taxation and labour services for a period of twelve years.

Having constructed the Langya Terrace, he set up a stone praising the virtue of the Qin and making clear its accomplishments. It said:

In his twenty-eighth year the August Emperor made a new beginning.

He adjusted the laws and regulations, standards for the ten thousand things.

He clarified human concerns, bringing concord to father and son, sage, wise, benevolent and righteous, making plain the principle of the Way.

In the east he toured the eastern lands, inspecting their officers and men, and when his tasks were grandly completed, he gazed down on the sea.

The merit of the August Emperor lies in diligently fostering basic concerns,

exalting agriculture, abolishing lesser occupations, so the black-headed people may be rich.

All under heaven are of one mind, single in will.

Weights and measures have a single standard, words are written in a uniform way.

Wherever sun and moon shine, where ships and wheeled vehicles bear cargo,

all fulfil their allotted years, none who do not attain their goal.

To initiate projects in season — such is the August Emperor's way.

He rectifies diverse customs, crossing rivers, traversing the land.

He pities the black-headed people, morning and evening never neglectful.
He erases doubt and establishes laws, so all will know what to shun.
Local officials have their respective duties; order is achieved with ease.
Decisions are certain to be just, none not clear as a drawing.
The August Emperor in his enlightenment scrutinizes the four quarters.
Exalted, lowly, eminent or humble never overstep their proper course.
Evil and wrongdoing are not permitted; all practise goodness and integrity.

Exerting utmost strength in matters great and small, none dare to be lax or remiss.

Near and far, in remotest comers, they strive to be strict and thorough.

Upright, honest, fervent and loyal, they are constant in devotion to duties.

The August Emperor's virtue preserves and brings calm to the four extremes.

Punishing disorder, dispelling harm, he furthers benefit and calls down good fortune.

His frugal undertakings are timely, so that all occupations prosper and multiply.

The black-headed people are at peace, never needing to take up arms.

The six kinships guard one another, ever free from bandits and marauders.

All delight in honouring instructions, complete in their knowledge of the laws.

Within the six directions, the domain of the August Emperor,
west to the flowing sands, south all the way to Beihu,
east to the eastern sea, north beyond Daxia,
wherever human tracks may reach, there are none who are not his subjects.

In merit he tops the Five Emperors, his bounty reaching oxen and horses,
none untouched by the ruler's virtue, each at rest in his home.

The king of Qin, having unified all under heaven, adopted the title of August Emperor. Then he toured the eastern lands, going as far as Langya. The ranged marquises, the marquis of Wucheng, Wang Li, and the marquis of Tongwu, Wang Pen; the marquises without fief the marquis of Jiancheng, Zhao Hai, the marquis of Changwu, Cheng, and the marquis of Wuxia, Wang Wuze; the chancellors Wei Zhuang and Wang Wan; the ministers Li Si and Wang Wu; and the fifth rank counsellors Zhao Ying and Yang Jiu, having accompanied the emperor and deliberated together by the sea, spoke thus: "The emperors of ancient times had domains that did not exceed 1,000 *li*, and the feudal lords guarded their own fiefs, sometimes coming to court to pay respects, sometimes not. All attacked one another in violence and disorder, never ceasing their assaults, yet they inscribed bronze and stone with records of their deeds. The Five Emperors and Three Kings of antiquity, though aware that their teachings were not identical and that

their laws and regulations were unclear, relied on the authority of the spirits and gods to deceive the people of distant regions. But because the reality did not accord with their claims, they were unable to continue for long. Even before their lives had come to an end, the feudal lords turned on them in revolt, and their commands ceased to be observed.

“But now the August Emperor has unified the whole area within the seas, making it into provinces and districts and bringing peace to all under heaven. He has shed light on the ancestral temples, embodying the Way, enacting virtue, and fulfilling his exalted title. His various officials join together to praise the merit and virtue of the August Emperor, inscribing it on metal and stone so that it may be a model and standard.”

After the stone had been set up, a native of Qi named Xu Fu and others submitted a memorial saying that in the midst of the sea were three spirit mountains named Penglai, Fangzhang, and Yingzhou, with immortals living on them. They asked that they be allowed to fast and purify themselves and to go with a group of young boys and girls to search for them.

The emperor thereupon ordered Xu Fu to gather a group of several thousand young boys and girls and set out to sea to search for the immortal men.

The First Emperor returned by way of Pengcheng, where he fasted and purified himself and performed sacrifices, hoping to recover the cauldrons of Zhou from the Si River. He ordered 1,000 persons to dive into the water and search for them, but they could not find them.⁸¹

He then proceeded southwest across the Huai River to Mt. Heng and Nan Province. Floating down the river, he reached the shrine at Mt. Xiang. There he encountered strong winds and was almost unable to get across the river. He questioned his academicians, saying, “What sort of deity is the Mistress of the Xiang?”

The academicians replied, “They say she was the daughter of Emperor Yao and the wife of Emperor Shun and that she is buried here.”

The First Emperor, enraged, ordered 3,000 convict labourers to cut down all the trees on Mt. Xiang, leaving it denuded. Then he returned from Nan Province by way of the Wu Pass.

Twenty-ninth year (218): the First Emperor journeyed east, and when he reached Bolangsha in Yangwu he was frightened by bandits. Having searched for them and failed to apprehend them, he ordered the entire empire to carry out a great search for ten days.⁸²

He ascended Mt. Zhifu and had a stone inscribed with these words:

The twenty-ninth year, the season of mid-spring, when the gentle warmth is rising:

The August Emperor journeyed east and in his travels ascended Zhifu, gazing down upon the sea.

The ministers in his retinue, pondering the source of his magnificence, recall with praise the beginning he made.

The great sage initiated order, establishing laws and regulations, making manifest his rules and standards.

Abroad he instructed the feudal rulers, shedding the light of cultured blessing, enlightening them with the principles of righteousness.

The Six States were recalcitrant, insatiable in greed and perversity, pillaging and slaughtering endlessly.

The August Emperor, pitying the multitude, called out his chastising armies, brandishing his military power.

Through righteous punishment, trustworthy acts, he displayed his might in all quarters, till there were none who failed to submit.

He wiped out the powerful and unruly, rescuing the black-headed people, bringing peace to the four corners of the empire.

Far and wide he dispensed his enlightened laws to bind and regulate all under heaven, to stand as a model unending.

How great, that throughout the whole universe the will of the sage should be heeded and obeyed!

The host of officials praise his merits, begging to inscribe them on stone, to be handed down as an unchanging pattern.

The inscription for the eastern tour read:

In the twenty-ninth year the August Emperor set forth in spring, inspecting and visiting the distant regions.

Advancing to the brink of the sea, he ascended Mt. Zhifu, gazing down at the morning sun.

The vista was vast and beautiful, and the ministers in his retinue all pondered, searching out the source of his supreme enlightenment.

When the sage's laws were first promulgated, they brought purity and order within the borders and punished the unruly and powerful beyond them.

His warlike might was brandished on wide, shaking the four corners of the land; he took captive the kings of the Six States.

Uniting all under heaven, he put an end to harm and disaster, and then for all time he laid aside his arms.

The bright virtue of the August Emperor aligns and orders the whole universe; he sees and listens without tiring.

He has established his great righteousness, providing all with the implements required, each with his own badge and pennant.

Office holders have the honour due them, each understands his duties, so all proceeds without ill-feeling or doubt.

The black-headed people have undergone transformation, near and far share a single rule, an achievement far surpassing antiquity.

Constant occupations have been fixed, heirs hereafter will carry on the tasks, insuring continuance of the sage's good order.

The host of officials rejoice in his virtue, respectfully praising the sage's magnificence, and beg to set up this inscription at Zhifu.

On his way back the emperor went to Langya and then from Shangdang returned to the capital.

The thirtieth year (217): passed without incident.

Thirty-first year (216): in the twelfth month the *la* festival was renamed Rejoicing in Peace.⁸³ The black-headed people were rewarded with six piculs of grain and two sheep for each community.

The First Emperor went out incognito in the city of Xianyang, accompanied only by four armed men. Going out at night, he encountered bandits at Lanchi and his life was threatened, but the armed guards attacked and killed the bandits. A thorough search was made in the area within the passes for twenty days.

One picul of grain cost 1,600 cash.

Thirty-second year (215): the First Emperor journeyed to Jieshi, where he commissioned a native of Yan named Scholar Lu to go in search of the immortals Xianmen and Gaoshi. He had an inscription carved on the gate of Jieshi which read:⁸⁴

He called out his armies to punish the unprincipled, and the workers of evil have been wiped clean.

His arms cut down the violent and contentious, his civil arts restored the guiltless, and the hearts of the multitude are submissive.

Generously he judged merit and worth, his rewards extending to oxen and horses, and his bounty fattened the land.

The August Emperor displayed his might, his virtue brought together the feudal lords, for the first time bestowing unity and peace.

He demolished walls and fortifications, opened up waterways, cut through embankments, and levelled the steep declivities.

When the shape of the land had been fixed, the masses were freed from corvée labour, and all the empire was comforted.

Now men delight in their tasks, women pursue their occupations, each affair ranged in proper order.

His bounty extends to every occupation, all have their allotted work in the fields, none without a place of rest.

The host of officials praise his magnificence, begging leave to inscribe this stone, that his example may be made known to future ages.

At this time the emperor dispatched Han Zhong, Lord Hou, and Master Shi to search for the immortals and their herbs of everlasting life. The First Emperor, having toured the northern border region, returned to the capital by way of Shang Province.

Master Lu, a native of Yan, who had been sent out to sea, returned and, claiming that it had come to him from the gods and spirits, submitted a document that said: "Qin will be destroyed by Hu."⁸⁵ The First Emperor thereupon ordered General Meng Tian to call out 300,000 troops and lead them north to strike at the Hu barbarians. The general invaded and seized

the area south of the bend of the Yellow River.

Thirty-third year (214): a number of men who had absconded in the past, had been adopted into their wife's family, or were shopkeepers, were sent to invade and seize the Luliang region.⁸⁶ The provinces of Guilin, Xiang, and Nanhai were created and convicts sent to garrison them. In the northwest the Xiongnu were driven back and the region from Yuzhong east along the Yellow River was joined with Mt. Yin, being divided up into thirty-four districts. Fortifications were built along the river to protect the border.

Meng Tian was also ordered to cross the Yellow River and seize Gaoque, Mt. Tao, and Beijia. Outposts were constructed in order to drive out the Rong people, and convicts were transported to the region to populate the new districts. It was forbidden to offer sacrifices to the Morning Star. A comet appeared in the western sky.

Thirty-fourth year (213): officials in charge of lawsuits who had been unjust in their dealings were transported to the Great Wall to work at its construction, or to the region of Southern Yue.

The First Emperor set out wine in his palace in Xianyang, and seventy academicians assembled in his presence to wish him long life. The archery captain Zhou Qingchen stepped forward and spoke these words of praise: "In former times Qin's territory did not exceed 1,000 *li*. But Your Majesty, through your spiritual power and enlightened sageness, has pacified all within the seas and driven out the Man and Yi barbarians. Wherever the sun and moon shine there is no one who does not come in submission. The domains of the feudal lords have been made into provinces and districts. Each person finds rest and happiness, free from the threat of warfare, such blessings to be handed down for 10,000 generations. Since the highest antiquity there has been nothing to equal Your Majesty's might and virtue."

The First Emperor was delighted. But another academician, a man of Qi named Chunyu Yue, came forward and said: "I have heard that the kings of the Yin and Zhou dynasties ruled for 1,000 years or more, for they enfeoffed their sons and younger brothers and their meritorious ministers to aid and support them. Now Your Majesty possesses all within the seas, yet your sons and younger brothers are mere commoners. If a Tian Chang or the six great ministers of Jin should suddenly appear, you would be without support or assistance, and how could you be saved?"⁸⁷ I have never heard of any undertaking that failed to imitate the example of antiquity and yet was able to endure for long! And Zhou Qingchen by flattering you to your face is simply compounding Your Majesty's error — he is no loyal subject!"

The First Emperor referred the matter to his ministers for discussion. The chancellor Li Si said: "The Five Emperors did not imitate each other, the Three Dynasties did not carry on each other's ways, yet each was well governed. It was not that they rejected one another, but that the times changed.

"Now Your Majesty has initiated this great undertaking, establishing

merit that will last 10,000 generations. This is not the sort of thing that a stupid Confucianist would understand! Chunyu Yue has spoken of the Three Dynasties, but why should they be worth taking as a model? In other times the feudal rulers vied with one another in inviting wandering scholars to their courts and treating them generously. But now all under heaven has been pacified and laws and ordinances proceed from a single source. The common people in their homes devote their efforts to agriculture and crafts, while gentlemen study the laws and ordinances and practise how to avoid prohibitions.

“But nowadays scholars, instead of looking to the present, study antiquity in order to criticize their own age, misleading and confusing the black-headed people. As chancellor, your servant Li Si must speak out on pain of death. In the past the empire was fragmented and in confusion and no one was able to unite it. Therefore the feudal rulers rose up side by side, all of them declaiming on antiquity in order to disparage the present, parading empty words in order to confuse the facts. Men prided themselves on their private theories and criticized the measures adopted by their superiors.

“Now the August Emperor has unified all under heaven, distinguishing black from white and establishing a single source of authority. Yet these adherents of private theories band together to criticize the laws and directives. Hearing that an order has been handed down, each one proceeds to discuss it in the light of his theories. At court they disapprove in their hearts; outside they debate it in the streets. They hold it a mark of fame to defy the ruler, regard it as lofty to take a dissenting stance, and they lead the lesser officials in fabricating slander. If behaviour such as this is not prohibited, then in upper circles the authority of the ruler will be compromised, and in lower ones cliques will form. Therefore it should be prohibited.

“I therefore request that all records of the historians other than those of the state of Qin be burned. With the exception of the academicians whose duty it is to possess them, if there are persons anywhere in the empire who have in their possession copies of the *Odes*, the *Documents*, or the writings of the hundred schools of philosophy, they shall in all cases deliver them to the governor or his commandant for burning. Anyone who ventures to discuss the *Odes* or *Documents* shall be executed in the marketplace. Anyone who uses antiquity to criticize the present shall be executed along with his family. Any official who observes or knows of violations and fails to report them shall be equally guilty. Anyone who has failed to burn such books within thirty days of the promulgation of this order shall be subjected to tattoo and condemned to ‘wall dawn’ labour.⁸⁸ The books that are to be exempted are those on medicine, divination, agriculture, and forestry. Anyone wishing to study the laws and ordinances should have a law official for his teacher.”

An imperial decree granted approval of the proposal.

Thirty-fifth year (212): a road was opened up from Jiuyuan to Yunyang, mountains being cut through and valleys filled up so that the road could run in a straight line.

The First Emperor felt that, in view of the large population of Xianyang, the palace of the former kings of Qin was too small. "I have heard," he said, "that King Wen of the Zhou had his capital at Feng, and King Wu had his at Hao. The area between Feng and Hao is fit for the capital of an emperor or a king." He accordingly began construction of a state palace in the Shanglin Park south of the Wei River. First he built a front hall at Epang which measured 500 *bu* from east to west and fifty *zhang* from north to south.⁸⁹ The upper part could seat 10,000 persons, and in the lower part flag poles five *zhang* high could be erected. It was surrounded by covered walks which then led from the hall directly south to the Southern Mountains. The summit of the Southern Mountains was designated to be the gate of the palace. An elevated walk extended from Epang north across the Wei River to connect the palace with Xianyang, in imitation of the way in which in the heavens a corridor leads from the Heavenly Apex star across the Milky Way to the Royal Chamber star.

The palace at Epang had not been completed at this time. The emperor intended to select some appropriate name for it when it was completed, but meanwhile, since it was being built at a place called Epang, everyone referred to it as the Epang Palace. Over 700,000 persons condemned to castration and convict labourers were called up, part of them being put to work building the Epang Palace and part assigned to Mt. Li.⁹⁰ Stone was quarried from the northern hills and timber transported from the regions of Shu and Jing, all being brought to the site.

In the area within the passes there were a total of 300 palaces, while beyond the passes there were more than 400. The emperor had a stone set up at Qujie on the eastern sea, declaring that it was the eastern gate of Qin. He had 30,000 households transported to the town at Mt. Li, and 50,000 households to Yunyang, exempting them all from taxes and corvée labour for a period of ten years.⁹¹

Master Lu said to the First Emperor, "I and the others have searched for zhi fungus, rare herbs, and the immortals, but we can never seem to encounter them. There would appear to be some entity that is blocking us. The magic arts teach that the ruler of men should at times move about in secret so as to avoid evil spirits. If evil spirits are avoided, one can reach the status of True Man. If the whereabouts of the ruler of men are known to his ministers, this hinders his spiritual power. A True Man can enter water without getting wet, enter fire without getting burned, soar over the clouds and air, and endure as long as heaven and earth. But now Your Majesty, though ruling the whole world, has not yet been able to attain calm and quietude. When you are in the palace, do not let others know where you are. Once that is done, I believe that the herbs of immortality can be obtained."

The emperor said, "I long to become a True Man. From now on I will refer to myself as True Man and will not call myself *zhen*."

He then had elevated walks and walled roads built to connect all the 270 palaces and scenic towers situated within the 200 *li* environs of Xianyang. He filled the palaces with curtains and hangings, bells and drums, and beautiful women, each assigned to a particular post and forbidden to move about. Anyone revealing where the emperor was visiting at any particular moment was put to death.

The First Emperor visited the palace at Mt. Liang and happened to look down from the mountain and observe the carriages, outriders, and attendants of the chancellor. He was not pleased. One of the eunuchs reported this to the chancellor, who thereafter reduced the number of his carriages and outriders. The First Emperor was furious, saying, "Someone among the eunuchs is leaking word of what I say!" He examined the eunuchs, but none would confess to the crime. He then ordered the arrest of all those who had been in attendance, and had every one put to death. From that time on, no one knew where he was when he was absent from the palace. Whenever he listened to reports or passed on decisions to his officials, it was always done at the palace in Xianyang.

Master Hou and Master Lu plotted together, saying, "The First Emperor is by nature obstinate, cruel, and self-willed. He rose up from among the feudal rulers to unite the entire empire, and now that he has achieved his ends and fulfilled his desires, he believes that there has never been anyone like him since remote antiquity.

"He entrusts everything to the law officials, and the law officials alone are allowed into his presence. Although seventy men have been appointed as academicians, they are mere figureheads and are never consulted. The chancellor and the other major officials are all handed decisions that have already been made, and they simply second the emperor's opinion. The emperor delights in showing his authority by punishing and killing, and everyone throughout the empire dreads punishment and tries merely to maintain his position, none daring to exert true loyalty. The emperor never learns of his mistakes and hence grows daily more arrogant, while his underlings, prostrate with fear, flatter and deceive him in order to curry favour.

"Qin law forbids a person to practise more than one kind of magical art, and if he fails to show results, he is summarily put to death. There are 300 men who practise the art of divining by the stars and exhalations, all of them experts, but they are so terrified of giving offence that they merely flatter the ruler and do not dare speak out and tell him his faults. All the affairs of the empire, great and small, are decided by the emperor. He even has the documents weighed, making certain that each day and night produces a picul's weight of them. He will not rest until they come up to that weight! When he is as greedy for authority and power as this, we can never hope to search out the herbs of immortality!" They accordingly fled in

secret.

When the First Emperor was informed of this, he was enraged. "In the past," he said, "I confiscated all the books from the empire and got rid of all those that were of no use. I also summoned a great many learned scholars and practitioners of various magic arts, hoping to initiate an era of great peace. The magicians said they wanted to employ their skills to search for rare herbs. But now Han Zhong has disappeared without any report, and Xu Fu and the others, after expending countless tens of thousands of cash, have never been able to obtain the herbs, and daily I hear reports that they are merely scheming for illicit gain. I have shown the utmost generosity in showering Master Lu and the others with honours and gifts, but now they speak slanderously of me so as to exaggerate my lack of virtue. I have also directed people to question the various scholars residing in Xianyang, and it appears that some are spreading dubious stories in order to mislead the black-headed people!"

He then ordered the imperial secretary to subject all the scholars to investigation. The scholars reported on one another in an attempt to exonerate themselves. Over 460 persons were convicted of violating the prohibitions, and were executed at Xianyang, word of it being publicized throughout the empire so as to act as a warning to later ages.⁹² In addition, increasing numbers of convicts were transported to the border regions.

The First Emperor's eldest son Fusu remonstrated with him, saying, "The empire has just been set at peace and the black-headed people in distant regions have not yet been won over. The scholars all praise Confucius and take him as a model. But in all affairs Your Majesty emphasizes the place of law and employs it as a corrective. I fear this may cause unrest in the empire. I hope you will give this some thought."

The First Emperor, angered, sent Fusu north to supervise the activities of Meng Tian in Shang Province.

Thirty-sixth year (211): Mars lodged in the mansion of the Heart Star. A meteor fell on Dong Province, turning into a stone when it reached the ground. One of the black-headed people inscribed on the stone: "The First Emperor will die and his land be divided." When the First Emperor heard of this, he sent the imperial secretary to investigate, but no one would confess to the deed. In the end the emperor had all the persons living in the vicinity of the stone seized and put to death, and had the stone burned and pulverized.

The First Emperor, much disquieted, ordered the academicians to compose a poem on the immortals and on the True Man, which also described the emperor's travels throughout the empire. It was distributed and musicians were designated to sing the poem to musical accompaniment.

In the autumn an envoy returning from east of the Hangu Pass reported that as he was passing along the Pingshu road in Huaiyin at night a man carrying a jade disc blocked the way, saying, "Give this to the lord of Hao

Lake for me." He also said, "This year the primal dragon will die."

When the envoy asked the meaning of this, the man suddenly disappeared, but he left the jade disc behind. The envoy accordingly presented the disc along with his report.

The First Emperor listened in silence and then after a long time said, "These mountain spirits cannot predict anything beyond the events of a single year!" But after he had retired from court, he said, "The primal dragon must mean the leader of men."⁹³

The emperor ordered the imperial treasury to examine the jade disc. They found that it was one that had been cast into the Yangtze when the emperor crossed the river on a tour in his twenty-eighth year. The First Emperor had divination made by the milfoil stalks and the response indicated that a journey would be propitious.

Thirty thousand households were ordered moved to Beihe and Yuzhong and granted one step in noble rank.

Thirty-seventh year (210): in the tenth month, on the day *guichou* (Nov. 1), the First Emperor set out on a trip. The chancellor of the left Li Si accompanied him, while the chancellor of the right Feng Quqi remained in the capital. The emperor's youngest son Huhai, whom he was very fond of, asked to be allowed to go along, and the emperor gave him permission.

In the eleventh month the emperor reached Yunmeng, where he gazed at Mt. Jiuyi from afar and sacrificed to the sage ruler Yu Shun. Then he sailed down the Yangtze to view Jike, crossed Haizhu, passed Danyang, and arrived at Qiantang, overlooking the Zhe River. Because the waves on the river were so high, he went 120 *li* to the west and crossed the river at a narrower point. He climbed Mt. Kuaiji and sacrificed to the sage ruler Great Yu. Gazing far off at the southern sea, he erected a stone inscribed with praises of the virtue of the Qin. The text read:

The August Emperor in his magnificence pacified and united the universe; his virtue and bounty are long lasting.

In his thirty-seventh year he toured the empire in person, viewing the distant regions all around.

He ascended Mt. Kuaiji, examining customs and folkways, and the black-headed people were circumspect and respectful.

The host of officials praise his merits, tracing the source of his undertakings, thinking back on his lofty enlightenment.

The sage of Qin rules the nation, for the first time defining penalties and names, making clear the old regulations.

For the first time he adjusted the laws and precedents and delineated offices and responsibilities in order to establish constant procedures.

The kings of the Six States, bent only on rebellion, greedy, cruel, and rapacious, led their hosts, certain of their power.

Violent, unruly, they acted wilfully, trusting to strength in their arrogance, again and again fielding their troops.

They exchanged envoys in secret, forming an alliance against us, acting in evil fashion.

Within the state they disguised their plotting, abroad they came to plunder our borders, and in time brought disaster on themselves.

Through the power of righteousness our ruler chastised them, obliterating the lawless and disorderly, wiping out and destroying the brigands.

The virtue of the sage is vast and all-inclusive; throughout the six directions it sheds unbounded blessing.

The August Emperor has united the universe, he lends ear to manifold affairs, near and far are universally cleansed.

He tends to a multitude of matters, examines and verifies their substance, so that each bears the name it deserves.

He has cognizance of both eminent and lowly, good and bad are ranged before him, nothing remains hidden from sight.

Those who gloss over error in the name of righteousness, women with sons who remarry, unchastely turning against the dead -

Such conduct he bars at home and abroad, prohibits unlicensed behaviour, so that men and women are pure and honest.

If a husband behaves in bestial fashion, killing him will incur no guilt; thus are men made to embrace righteousness.

If a wife runs away and remarries, her sons shall disown their mother; so all will be led to clean and upright conduct.

His great rule purifies the folkways, the whole empire acknowledges its sway; it blankets the world in splendid regulation.

All honour his rules and maxims, harmonious, peaceful, and diligent; there are none who do not heed his command.

The black-headed people are orderly and virtuous, individuals delighting in a common rule, rejoicing in and guarding the great peace.

Posterity will obey his laws, his constant governance knowing no end, like carriages and boats that never overturn.

The officials in his retinue praise his brilliance, begging to inscribe this stone; may its glorious message shine through the ages.

On his way back the emperor passed through Wu, crossed the Yangtze at Jiangcheng, and followed north along the seacoast to Langya.

Xu Fu and the other magicians who had set out to sea in search of the herbs of immortality had passed several years without finding anything, consuming huge sums of money. Fearful of punishment, they deceived the emperor by saying, "The herbs of Penglai can surely be obtained. But always there are large fish that cause difficulty, and therefore we are unable to reach the island. We would like to request that a skilled archer be assigned to accompany us so that if we sight any fish, he can shoot at them with a repeating crossbow."

The First Emperor dreamed that he was struggling with an ocean god who had the shape of a human being. When he consulted an academician who

was an interpreter of dreams, he said, "The water god himself cannot be seen, but he may manifest himself in the form of a large fish or dragon. Now Your Majesty conducts sacrifices with great diligence, and yet this evil god has appeared. It must be driven away so that the good gods can appear."

The emperor ordered that those who set out to sea should carry along equipment for seizing a gigantic fish. He himself carried a repeating crossbow and watched for a great fish to appear so he could shoot it. He proceeded north from Langya as far as Mt. Rongcheng but saw nothing. When he reached Zhifu, however, he saw several huge fish and shot and killed one of them. He then followed along the shore, turned west, and had gone as far as Pingyuan Ford when he fell ill.

The First Emperor hated any talk of dying, and none of his officials dared even allude to the matter of death. When his illness grew increasingly grave he wrote a letter under the imperial seal to be sent to his son, Prince Fusu, saying, "When mourning is announced, proceed to Xianyang and carry out the burial." The letter had already been sealed and deposited with Zhao Gao, chief of the office of imperial carriage, who had charge of official seals, but it had not yet been entrusted to a messenger.

In the seventh month, the day *bingyin*,⁹⁴ the First Emperor passed away at the Ping Terrace in Shaqiu or Sand Hill. Because the emperor had died outside the capital, the chancellor Li Si feared that the other princes and their supporters in the empire might start an uprising, and therefore he kept the matter secret and did not announce a period of mourning.

The coffin was placed in a carriage that could be opened up for cooling or closed for warmth, with the ruler's oldest and most trusted eunuchs riding in attendance. At each stopping place, food was delivered to the carriage. The various officials continued as before to submit matters for the emperor's approval, and at such times the eunuchs would immediately approve them and hand them down from the closed carriage. Only the emperor's son Huhai, Zhao Gao, and five or six of the trusted eunuchs knew that the emperor had died.

Zhao Gao had in the past instructed Huhai in matters pertaining to writing, criminal investigations, and laws and regulations, and Huhai was very friendly with him. Zhao Gao accordingly joined with Prince Huhai and the chancellor Li Si in plotting in secret, destroying the sealed letter that the emperor had prepared to be sent to Prince Fusu. They then forged a testamentary edict that was supposed to have been received by the chancellor Li Si from the emperor at Shaqiu which designated Huhai as heir apparent. They also prepared a new letter to be sent to Prince Fusu and Meng Tian, accusing them of various crimes and ordering them to commit suicide. (A fuller discussion will be found in The Biography of Li Si.)

The party proceeded from Jingxing to Jiuyuan, but as the weather was hot, the body of the emperor in the closed carriage began to smell. An imperial order was issued to the accompanying officials ordering them to load each

of their carriages with a picul's weight of dried fish so as to disguise the odour. In this way they proceeded by the Straight Road to Xianyang, where the mourning was announced. The heir apparent Huhai ascended the throne and is known as the Second Emperor.

In the ninth month the First Emperor was interred at Mt. Li. When the emperor first came to the throne he began digging and shaping Mt. Li. Later, when he unified the empire, he had over 700,000 men from all over the empire transported to the spot. They dug down to the third layer of underground springs and poured in bronze to make the outer coffin. Replicas of palaces, scenic towers, and the hundred officials, as well as rare utensils and wonderful objects, were brought to fill up the tomb. Craftsmen were ordered to set up crossbows and arrows, rigged so they would immediately shoot down anyone attempting to break in. Mercury was used to fashion imitations of the hundred rivers, the Yellow River and the Yangtze, and the seas, constructed in such a way that they seemed to flow. Above were representations of all the heavenly bodies, below, the features of the earth. "Man-fish" oil was used for lamps, which were calculated to burn for a long time without going out.⁹⁵

The Second Emperor said, "Of the women in the harem of the former ruler, it would be unfitting to have those who bore no sons sent elsewhere." All were accordingly ordered to accompany the dead man, which resulted in the death of many women.

After the interment had been completed, someone pointed out that the artisans and craftsmen who had built the tomb knew what was buried there, and if they should leak word of the treasures, it would be a serious affair. Therefore, after the articles had been placed in the tomb, the inner gate was closed off and the outer gate lowered, so that all the artisans and craftsmen were shut in the tomb and were unable to get out. Trees and bushes were planted to give the appearance of a mountain.

First year of the reign of the Second Emperor (209): the Second Emperor was twenty-one. Zhao Gao as chief of palace attendants was entrusted with the handling of state affairs. The Second Emperor handed down a decree ordering an increase in the sacrifices in the mortuary temple of the First Emperor and the rituals observed in sacrifices to the rivers, mountains, and the various other deities. He instructed the officials to discuss proper ways of paying honour to the temple of the First Emperor.

The officials all bowed their heads and replied: "In ancient times the Son of Heaven had seven mortuary temples, the feudal lords five, and the grandees three. Now the First Emperor has his Apex Temple, which will never be destroyed though 10,000 generations may pass.⁹⁶ All regions within the four seas send articles of tribute to it, the sacrifices have been increased, and all the rituals are thoroughly carried out — there is nothing more to add. As for the mortuary temples of the former kings of Qin, some are situated to the west in Yong and some are in Xianyang. The Son of

Heaven should consider it his duty to offer libations and sacrifices only in the temple of the First Emperor. The temples of the Qin rulers from Duke Xiang on down should be destroyed, so that only seven temples remain in existence.⁹⁷ The various officials should make offerings and sacrifices in these according to ritual, and should honour the temple of the First Emperor by calling it the Temple of the Imperial Ancestor. The emperor should also resume the practice of referring to himself by the pronoun *zhen*."

The Second Emperor plotted with Zhao Gao, saying, "I, the sovereign (*zhen*), am still young and have just ascended the throne, and the black-headed people are not yet won over to me. The former emperor made progresses through the provinces and districts in order to display his might and cause all within the seas to be awed and submissive. Now if I do not make a similar progress in a self-assured manner, they will regard me as weak and I will have no way to make them serve me as subjects should!"

In the spring the Second Emperor journeyed to the provinces and districts of the east, with Li Si accompanying him. When he reached Jieshi, he proceeded south along the seacoast to Kuaiji. He added inscriptions to all the stones that the First Emperor had earlier set up, on the side of the stone listing the names of the high officials who had accompanied the former sovereign in order to make manifest his merits and accomplishments and his outstanding virtue. The inscription read:

The emperor said: "These inscriptions on metal and stone were all made by the First Emperor. Now we have succeeded to the title of emperor, but since the inscriptions on metal and stone do not contain the words 'First Emperor', there is a danger that after a long time has passed it may appear as though the inscriptions were made not by the First Emperor but by one of his later heirs, and this will not serve to praise his merits and accomplishments and his outstanding virtue."

We, the chancellors Li Si and Feng Quqi and the imperial secretary De, therefore brave death by requesting that the words of this imperial decree be inscribed on the stones so as to make this fact clear. We brave death by making this request. An imperial decree granted approval of the request.

The emperor went as far as Liaodong and then returned to the capital.

The Second Emperor respected Zhao Gao and heeded his advice in applying the laws and ordinances. He plotted with Zhao Gao in secret, saying, "The chief ministers are unsubmissive, the various officials still have great power, and the other imperial princes are certain to contest my rule. What can I do?"

Zhao Gao replied, "I have long wanted to speak of this, but had not ventured to do so. The chief ministers of the former emperor are all men of eminent families that have been famous throughout the empire for ages, families that have piled up merit and passed these offices along from

generation to generation for many years. I, on the other hand, come originally from a humble background, but Your Majesty has been kind enough to raise me up and assign me to a high position where I can supervise the affairs of the palace. The chief ministers are disgruntled at this. In outward appearance they may seem compliant enough, but at heart they do not truly submit.

"Now Your Majesty has just been on a tour, but you did not make use of the opportunity to examine the governors and military commandants of the provinces and districts and punish those who are guilty of some crime. By doing so you can strike terror into the empire as a whole, and at the same time do away with those who disapprove of your actions. This is not the time to seek your model in the arts of peace but to decide all through brute power. I beg Your Majesty to follow along with the times and not be in doubt. There is no need to consult with the host of officials. The enlightened ruler raises up those people who would otherwise be overlooked. The humble he makes eminent, the poor he enriches, the distant he draws close to him. Then those both high and low can be won over and the nation will be secure."

"Excellent!" said the Second Emperor, and he proceeded to impose punishments on the chief ministers and the imperial princes, accusing them of crimes and errors and arresting even petty officials close to the ruler or the three categories of palace attendants, so that no one was certain of his position.

Six of the imperial princes were put to death at Du. Only Prince Jianglü and his two brothers, who were held prisoner in the palace while their crimes were being investigated, were left alive. The Second Emperor sent a messenger to them, saying, "You have failed to act as proper subjects, and for this crime you deserve death. The officials have been instructed to carry out the law!"

Jianglü said, "In matters of court ritual I have never ventured to disobey the director of the guests, in taking my place in the hall of state I have never ventured to overstep my position, in accepting and responding to commands I have never ventured to use improper language. How have I failed to act as a proper subject? I wish to be informed of my crime before I die!"

The messenger replied, "I am not authorized to discuss such matters with you. I receive my instructions and carry them out!"

Jianglü looked up to heaven and cried out to it in a loud voice three times, saying, "This is Heaven's doing! I have committed no crime!" The three brothers all wept bitterly as they drew their swords and took their own lives.

The members of the imperial family shook with terror. Those officials who remonstrated were all accused of slander. The high officers merely clung to their posts and endeavoured to ingratiate themselves, while the black-headed people trembled with fear.

In the fourth month the Second Emperor, having returned to Xianyang from his tour, announced: "The former emperor regarded the court at Xianyang as too small, and therefore began building a palace at Epang. Before the halls could be completed, however, the ruler passed away. Construction there was halted and workmen assigned to supply dirt for the mound at Mt. Li. The project at Mt. Li has been carried to completion, and if we do not now finish construction of the palace at Epang, it will appear as though the former emperor was mistaken in his undertakings."

Work was accordingly resumed on the Epang Palace, while on the foreign front efforts were continued to subdue the barbarians on the four borders, all as the First Emperor had originally planned. Fifty thousand crossbowmen were called up from all over the empire and assigned to garrison and protect Xianyang, where they were to give instruction in archery. It was estimated that they and their dogs, horses, and other animals would require large amounts of food and that food supplies would be insufficient. An order was circulated to the provinces and districts instructing them to send supplies of beans, millet, grass, and fodder to the capital. All persons transporting the supplies were ordered to bring their own rations with them. Within a radius of 300 *li* of Xianyang, farmers were forbidden to consume their own grain. Thus the laws and regulations became increasingly severe.

In the seventh month Chen She and others of his band of garrison troops revolted in the old territory of Jing, calling themselves "Magnifiers of Chu". Chen She set himself up as king of Chu, with his residence in Chen, and sent out his generals to seize control of the lands east of the mountains. The young men of the provinces and districts, having suffered under the Qin officials, all murdered the governors and commandants or the magistrates and aides of their respective provinces and districts and declared themselves a part of Chen She's revolt. Countless numbers of them, having appointed themselves marquises or kings, joined forces and turned their eyes west, declaring their intention to attack the Qin.

When a master of guests who had been sent east on official business returned from the area, he reported the rebellion to the Second Emperor. The Second Emperor, enraged, had him turned over to the law officials for punishment. Thereafter, when envoys arrived and the emperor questioned them, they would reply, "Just a bunch of bandits. The governors and commandants of the provinces are now in the process of pursuing and capturing them. They'll have them all in no time — there is no need to worry!" Then the emperor would be pleased.

Meanwhile Wu Chen set himself up as king of Zhao, Wei Jiu became king of Wei, Tian Dan became king of Qi, the governor of Pei started his uprising in Pei, and Xiang Liang raised an army in the province of Kuaiji.

Second year (208), winter: Zhou Zhang, a military leader who had been dispatched by Chen She, pushed west as far as Xi with a force of several hundred thousand soldiers. The Second Emperor, greatly alarmed,

consulted with his officials, saying, "What's to be done?"

Zhang Han, the privy treasurer, said, "The bandits are already close by in great numbers and force. There is no time to call up forces from the nearby districts. There are many convict labourers at Mt. Li. I would like to ask that they be pardoned and given arms so they can be used for an attack."

The Second Emperor thereupon issued a general amnesty to the empire and ordered Zhang Han to lead the attack. Zhang Han struck at and defeated Zhou Zhang's army and sent it fleeing, and eventually killed Zhou Zhang at Caoyang. The Second Emperor sent Sima Xin and Dong Yi, chief officials in the office of the chancellor, to assist Zhang Han in his attacks on the bandits. They killed Chen She at Chengfu, defeated Xiang Liang's forces at Dingtao, and wiped out Wei Jiu at Linji. By this time all the outstanding bandit leaders in the region of Chu were dead, and so Zhang Han led his forces north across the Yellow River to attack Zhao Xie, the king of Zhao, and his followers at Julu.

Zhao Gao advised the Second Emperor, saying, "The former emperor ruled the world for a long period of time and therefore his officials did not dare act wrongfully or speak nonsense. But now Your Majesty is young in years and you have just come to the throne. Why discuss matters with the high ministers when making decisions? If you should make an error in judgment, you would look bad in the eyes of the officials. The Son of Heaven refers to himself by a special pronoun, *zhen*, because his own voice is never heard."⁹⁸

Accordingly the Second Emperor remained within the inner recesses of the palace and decided affairs in consultation with Zhao Gao. Thereafter the high ministers seldom had an opportunity to see him at court.

The bandits and brigands continued to grow in numbers, and troops were endlessly called up from the area within the passes and sent east to attack them. The chancellor of the right Feng Quqi, the chancellor of the left Li Si, and General Feng Jie came forward to remonstrate with the emperor, saying, "East of the pass, bands of brigands rise up in one place after another, and though the Qin has dispatched troops to attack and punish them, and though great numbers have been killed, still there is no end to them. Bandits are so numerous solely because of the burdens of garrison duty, the transportation of supplies, and other types of construction and *corvée* labour, and because taxes are so heavy. We request that construction work on the Epang Palace be suspended and that garrison and transport duty for the four frontiers be reduced."

The Second Emperor said, "I have heard from Master Han that emperors Yao and Shun did not plane the speckled beams of their palaces or trim the thatch of their roofs; they ate their rice from earthen pots and sipped soup from earthen jars. Even the lot of a gatekeeper could not have been as cramped as theirs. Emperor Yu chiselled through Dragon Gate and opened up Daxia, fixing the courses of the rivers and allowing the water to flow to

the sea. In person he took up plough and spade, labouring till there was no more hair on his shins. Even the toil of a slave taken prisoner in the wars could not have been more arduous than his.⁹⁹

"The reason people think it an honour to hold possession of the empire is that one may indulge his desires and carry out his wishes to the full. If the ruler takes care to clarify the laws, then those under him will not dare to act wrongly and all within the four seas will be well governed. But if rulers like Shun and Yu, though honoured with possession of the empire, must impose hardship and labour on themselves so as to set an example for their people, then what good are laws?

"I am honoured with the title of lord of ten thousand chariots, but I do not enjoy the reality. Now I want to be provided with 1,000 chariots, to be attended by 10,000, so that I can live up to my name and title!

"The former emperor rose up from among the feudal lords to unite the empire. After the empire had been set at rest, he drove back the four barbarian tribes in order to bring peace to the border regions, and he built halls and palaces as a symbol of his success. You, my lords, must have seen how his great accomplishments have been carried on.

"Now, during the two years when I have been on the throne, bands of robbers have risen in one place after another, and you have not been able to suppress them. Moreover, you want to put a halt to the former emperor's enterprises. On a higher level you are failing to repay the debt you owe the former emperor, and on a secondary one you are not exerting your utmost loyalty and strength for my sake! Why then should you remain in your posts?"

He had Feng Quqi, Li Si, and Feng Jie handed over to the law officials, who subjected them to examination to see if they were guilty of other crimes as well. Feng Quqi and Feng Jie said, "Generals and ministers must not endure such disgrace!" and they committed suicide. Li Si was put in prison and sentenced to the five penalties.

Third Year (207): Zhang Han and the other Qin generals led troops and surrounded the city of Julu. Xiang Yu, the supreme general of the Chu forces, went to the rescue of Julu.

In the winter Zhao Gao became chancellor and, concluding the investigation of charges against Li Si, had him executed.

In the summer Zhang Han fought with the Chu troops and several times suffered defeat. When the Second Emperor dispatched envoys to berate him, he grew fearful and sent the chief official Sima Xin to the capital to ask for further instructions. But Zhao Gao refused to see him or to believe his account of events. Alarmed, Sima Xin fled from the capital. Zhao Gao sent men to overtake and arrest him, but they were too late.

When Sima Xin reappeared before Zhang Han, he said, "Zhao Gao handles all affairs in the palace. You will be put to death, General, whether you are successful in battle or not!"

Xiang Yu pressed his attacks on the Qin army and took the Qin general Wang Li prisoner. Zhang Han and the others then surrendered with their troops to the leaders of the states.

Eighth month, the day *jihai* (Sept. 27): Zhao Gao was contemplating treason but was afraid the other officials would not heed his commands, so he decided to test them first. He brought a deer and presented it to the Second Emperor but called it a horse. The Second Emperor laughed and said, "Is the chancellor perhaps mistaken, calling a deer a horse?"

Then the emperor questioned those around him. Some remained silent, while some, hoping to ingratiate themselves with Zhao Gao, said it was a horse, and others said it was a deer. Zhao Gao secretly arranged for all those who said it was a deer to be brought before the law. Thereafter the officials were all terrified of Zhao Gao.

Earlier, Zhao Gao had several times advised the emperor that the bandits east of the pass were incapable of causing serious trouble. But after Xiang Yu captured the Qin general Wang Li at Julu and began advancing, the armies of Zhang Han and the others suffered repeated defeat and they had sent letters to the capital requesting reinforcements. The former states of Yan, Zhao, Qi, Chu, Hann, and Wei had all set up kings to head them, and in the area east of the Hangu Pass almost everyone had revolted against the Qin officials and gone over to the side of the leaders of the states, who were all leading their troops toward the west. The governor of Pei, heading a force of 30,000 or 40,000 men, had already wiped out the defenders of the Wu Pass and sent a man to communicate in secret with Zhao Gao.

Zhao Gao, fearful that the Second Emperor would be angered at these events and that he himself would be subjected to punishment, pleaded illness and did not appear at court.

The Second Emperor dreamt that a white tiger sank its teeth in the outside left horse in his team of four and killed it. Troubled in mind by the dream and uncertain of its meaning, he questioned an expert in the interpretation of dreams. The diviner replied, "The Jing River is exercising a malevolent influence." The Second Emperor conducted a fast at the Wangyi Palace, intending to sacrifice to the Jing River by drowning four white horses in it. At the same time he sent an envoy to Zhao Gao to berate him over the bandit uprisings.

Zhao Gao, terrified, began plotting in secret with his son-in-law Yan Yue, the magistrate of Xianyang, and his younger brother Zhao Cheng, saying, "The emperor refused to listen to admonition, and now that the situation is grave he wants to shift the blame to our family. I want to remove the emperor and set up Prince Ziying in his place. Ziying is kindhearted and modest and the people will all listen to what he says."

Zhao Gao arranged for the chief of palace attendants to assist him from within the palace by spreading false reports that a large number of bandits had appeared and ordering Yan Yue to call out troops to expel them. Zhao Gao took Yan Yue's mother into custody and held her in his own quarters as

a hostage.¹⁰⁰ Then he dispatched Yan Yue with a force of over 1,000 men to go to the gate of the Wangyi Palace. Yan Yue arrested and bound the commander of the guard and the archery captain, saying, "When the bandits broke in here, why didn't you stop them!"

The commander of the guard replied, "I have surrounded the buildings with my men and taken every precaution. How could bandits possibly have entered the palace!"

Yan Yue proceeded to cut down the commander of the guard and lead his band of officials straight into the palace, shooting arrows as he went. The palace attendants and eunuchs were overcome with astonishment, some fleeing, others putting up a fight. Those who resisted were summarily killed, the dead numbering thirty or forty persons.

Yan Yue and the chief of palace attendants entered the hall together and shot arrows at the curtains surrounding the emperor's throne. The Second Emperor angrily called for his attendants, but they were all too confused and terrified to resist. Only one eunuch remained by the emperor's side, not daring to desert him.

The emperor, escaping into an inner apartment, said, "Why didn't you warn me earlier, before things came to this!"

The eunuch replied, "I didn't dare speak out, and that's why I'm still alive. Anyone who had dared to speak out would have been put to death long ago — he wouldn't be around now!"

Yan Yue came forward and at once began berating the Second Emperor, saying, "You are arrogant and wilful and you punish and kill people without reason! The whole empire has turned against you. You had better settle things for yourself!"

"May I see the chancellor?" said the Second Emperor.

"Impossible!" said Yan Yue.

"I would like to be made king over just one province," said the Second Emperor, but this request was denied. "I would like to become a marquis of 10,000 households," he said, but this was denied.

"I would like to become one of the black-headed people along with my wife and children and to be treated like the other princes."

Yan Yue said, "I have my orders from the chancellor to punish you on behalf of the empire. Whatever you may propose, I would never dare grant it." Then he summoned his soldiers to come forward. The Second Emperor committed suicide.

Yan Yue returned and reported to Zhao Gao. Zhao Gao then summoned all the major officials and princes of the ruling family and informed them of how he had punished the Second Emperor. "The state of Qin was formerly ruled by a king," he said. "The First Emperor made himself sovereign of the empire, and therefore called himself emperor. Now, however, the Six States have declared their independence once more and Qin's territory is steadily diminishing. It would not do to go on using the empty title of emperor. We

should use the title of king as before.”

Then he set up Ziyang, the son of one of the Second Emperor’s older brothers, as king of Qin.¹⁰¹

The Second Emperor was buried at the Yichun Garden at Du’nan with the rites appropriate to one of the black-headed people. Then Ziyang was ordered to fast and present himself at the ancestral temple to receive the jade seal of office.

After fasting for five days, Ziyang plotted with his two sons, saying, “The chancellor Zhao Gao killed the Second Emperor at the Wangyi Palace, but because he is afraid that the other officials will punish him, he pretends to be acting righteously by setting me up as ruler. I have heard that Zhao Gao is secretly in league with the men of Chu and intends to wipe out the Qin ruling family and make himself king of the region within the passes. Now he has instructed me to fast and appear in the ancestral temple, so he must intend to kill me in the temple. If I say I am ill and fail to go, the chancellor will surely come here, and when he does so, we can kill him!”

Zhao Gao several times sent messengers to Ziyang requesting him to proceed to the temple, but Ziyang failed to go. As expected, Zhao Gao then came in person, saying, “The service of the ancestral temple is a grave affair. Why doesn’t Your Majesty proceed?”

Ziyang stabbed and killed Zhao Gao in the palace where he was fasting, and put to death Zhao Gao’s three sets of relatives to serve as a warning to the people of Xianyang.

Ziyang had been king of Qin for forty-six days when the governor of Pei, the military leader from Chu, defeated the Qin armies, entered the Wu Pass, and advanced as far as Bashang. He sent men to bargain with Ziyang and persuade him to surrender. Ziyang accordingly tied a rope around his neck, came in a plain carriage drawn by white horses, handed over the seals and credentials of the Son of Heaven, and surrendered by the side of Zhi Rod.¹⁰²

The governor of Pei then entered Xianyang, sealed up the palaces and storehouses, and returned to encamp at Bashang. A month or so later, the forces of the other states arrived, with Xiang Yu as their leader. He killed Ziyang and the other princes of the Qin ruling family and their relatives, and then went on to massacre the inhabitants of Xianyang, burn the palaces, take prisoner the men and women that staffed them, and confiscate their goods and treasures, which were divided up among the various leaders.

After the Qin dynasty had been overthrown, the area was divided into three parts, with three rulers known respectively as the king of Yong, the king of Sai, and the king of Di; they were referred to as the Three Qin. Xiang Yu made himself “Dictator King of Western Chu”, issuing commands to the empire and dividing it up among the various kings and marquises. Thus the Qin was finally wiped out. Five years later, peace was restored to the empire by the Han.

The Grand Historian remarks: Qin's ancestor Boyi won distinction in the time of emperors Yao and Shun and was presented with territory and a surname. Later, when the Xia and Yin dynasties were in power, the family was dispersed and remained in obscurity, but when the power of the Zhou dynasty waned, the Qin rose to prominence, building its capital in the western borderland. From the time of Duke Mu on, it gradually ate away at the domains of the other feudal rulers until the process was finally completed by the First Emperor.

The First Emperor believed that his merits exceeded those of the Five Emperors of antiquity, and that his lands were broader than those of the Three Dynasties, and was ashamed to be ranked with them. Master Jia has written an excellent discussion of the matter: [103](#)

Qin annexed the lands of the other feudal rulers and created over thirty provinces, putting in order the fords and passes, relying on the steep places and barrier points, and stationing armed men to guard the region. And yet Chen She and his several hundred garrison soldiers, scattered and disordered as they were, lifted up their arms and gave a loud cry. They used no bows or spears as their weapons, but mere plough handles and bare sticks, eating their way from house to house and rampaging over the empire. The men of Qin were unable to guard their narrow defiles or block the passes and bridges, their long spears would not slash, their strong crossbows would not shoot. The armies of Chu entered deep into the heartland, battling at Hongmen and never once encountering any barriers or fortifications to impede them. Thus the area east of the mountains was plunged into great confusion, the leaders of the states rose up on all sides, and brave men and heroes one after the other came to the fore.

Qin ordered Zhang Han to lead his troops east and restore order. But Zhang Han used the three armies under his command to secure land holdings abroad and plot against his own sovereign. From this one can see how untrustworthy the Qin officials were.

When Ziying came to the throne, he failed to awaken to reality. If Ziying had possessed even mediocre ability as a ruler, if he had been able to recruit even middling assistants, then despite the turmoil east of the mountains, Qin would have been able to retain control of its territory and the sacrifices in its ancestral temples need never have been cut off.

The old territory of Qin is well protected by mountains and girdled by the Yellow River, a state fenced in on four sides. From the time of Duke Mu to that of the First Emperor, Qin had over twenty rulers, and at all times they were leaders among the feudal lords. Surely this was not because generation after generation they were worthy men, but because of the strategic position they occupied. Once before, the empire had joined together in heart and pooled its strength to attack Qin. [104](#) At that time

worthy and sagacious rulers abounded, skilled generals headed the armies, and wise ministers cooperated in laying plans. But they were frustrated by the steep slopes and narrow defiles and were unable to advance. To entice them inside and draw them into battle, Qin purposely opened the passes, and the invading troops, though a million strong, were forced to flee in defeat and were utterly crushed. Surely this was not because they were lacking in bravery or wisdom, but because the shape of the land was against them and the circumstances were not to their advantage.

Qin had little towns but it linked them together with big walls. It guarded its defiles and frontiers with armies, heightened its fortifications rather than engaging in battle, closed its passes, relied on its barriers, shouldered its spears and stood guard. The leaders of the rebellion rose up from among the common people and joined forces for their own profit — they did not act in the manner of natural-born kings. They were not linked by bonds of kinship, nor were their subjects as yet deeply attached to them. In name their goal was to overthrow Qin, but in reality they were out for profit. If they had observed that Qin's barriers would be difficult to penetrate, they would surely have withdrawn their armies, remained in the safety of their own lands, rested their people, and waited for Qin's power to decline.

One who succours the weak and aids the weary, as the ruler of a great kingdom is commanded to do, need never worry that he will not gain his way with the lands within the seas. But when one is honoured with the position of Son of Heaven, possesses all the riches of the empire, and yet ends up as a captive, it must be because he has failed to remedy his errors.

The First Emperor trusted his own judgment, never consulting others, and hence his errors went uncorrected. The Second Emperor carried on in the same manner, never reforming, compounding his misfortune through violence and cruelty. Ziying stood alone and friendless, weak and imperilled, with no one to aid him. All three rulers were deluded, and to the end failed to awaken — is it not fitting that they perished?

At that time the world was not without men of deep insight and an understanding of change. The reason they did not dare exert their loyalty and correct the errors of the ruler was that Qin's customs forbade the mentioning of inauspicious matters. Before their words of loyal advice were even out of their mouths, they would have been condemned to execution. This insured that the men of the empire would incline their ears to listen, stand in an attitude of solemn attention, but clamp their mouths shut and never speak out. Therefore when the three rulers strayed from the Way, the loyal ministers did not dare remonstrate, and the men of wisdom did not dare offer counsel. The empire was already in rebellion, but the ruler was never informed of the villainy — how pitiful!

The kings of former times knew the harm brought to the nation by suppression and concealment. Therefore they appointed high ministers and palace officials to put the laws in order and establish penalties, and the empire was well governed. While they themselves were still powerful, they

were able to outlaw violence and punish the unruly, and the empire submitted to them. And later, when they became weak, the Five Hegemons carried out punitive expeditions and forced the other feudal rulers to comply. Hence, though they were stripped of territory, they could guard their inner realm, the surrounding states supported them, and they were able to preserve their altars of the soil and grains.[105](#)

In the case of Qin, however, while it was in a flourishing state, its manifold laws and stem punishments caused the empire to tremble. But when its power declined, then the people eyed it with hatred and the whole area within the seas rose up in revolt.

Hence, because the Zhou dynasty set up the five noble ranks and ruled according to the Way, it was able to endure for over 1,000 years without break. But the Qin was in error from first to last, and therefore it did not continue for long. From this we can see that the course of action leading to safety, and that leading to peril, are far apart indeed. The homely proverb says, "Former affairs, not forgot, teach those who come after." That is why, when the gentleman is given charge of a state, he observes how things were done in ancient times, tests them in terms of the present day, sees how they tally with human concerns, examines into the cause of flourishing and decay, perceives what is fitting in the light of circumstances, initiates actions in the proper order, and changes with the times. As a result, his days as ruler are long and many, and his altars of the soil and grain rest secure.[106](#)

Duke Xiao of Qin, relying upon the strength of Mt. Yao and the Hangu Pass and basing himself in the area of Yongzhou, with his ministers held fast to his land and eyed the house of Zhou, for he cherished a desire to roll up the empire like a mat, to bind into one the whole world, to bag all the land within the four seas; he had it in his heart to swallow up everything in the eight directions. At this time he was aided by Lord Shang, who at home set up laws for him, encouraged agriculture and weaving, and built up the instruments of war, and abroad contracted military alliances and attacked the other feudal lords. Thus the men of Qin were able with ease to acquire territory east of the upper reaches of the Yellow River.

After the death of Duke Xiao, kings Huiwen and Wu carried on the undertakings of their predecessor and, following the plans he had laid, seized Hanzhong in the south and Ba and Shu in the west, and acquired rich land in the east and provinces of strategic value. The other feudal lords in alarm came together in council to devise some plan to weaken Qin, sparing nothing in gifts of precious objects and rich lands to induce men from all over the empire to come and join with them in a "vertical alliance", and pool their strength. At this time there was Lord Mengchang in Qi, Lord Pingyuan in Zhao, Lord Chunshen in Chu, and Lord Xinling in Wei. These four lords were all men of intelligence and loyalty, generous and kind to others, who honoured worthy men and took good care of their followers. They rejected

the Horizontal Alliance and instead formed the Vertical Alliance, which united all the forces of the states of Hann, Wei, Yan, Chu, Qi, Zhao, Song, Wey, and Zhongshan. At this time among the distinguished men of the Six States were men like Ning Yue, Xu Shang, Su Qin, and Du He, who laid the plans; Qi Ming, Zhou Zui, Chen Zhen, Zhao Hua, Lou Huan, Di Jing, Su Li, Yue Yi, and their followers who carried out these plans; and Wu Qi, Sun Bin, Dai Tuo, Er Liang, Wang Liao, Tian Ji, Lian Po, and Zhao She, who commanded the troops. With a force of 1,000,000 soldiers drawn from an area ten times that of Qin, they beat upon the Pass and pressed forward toward Qin. But the men of Qin opened the Pass to entice the enemy in, and the armies of the Nine States fled and did not dare advance. Qin, without expending a single arrow or losing a single arrowhead, threatened the feudal rulers of the entire empire.

With this the Vertical Alliance collapsed, its treaties came to naught, and the various states hastened to present Qin with parts of their territory as bribes for peace. With its superior strength Qin pressed the crumbling forces of its rivals, pursued those who had fled in defeat, and overwhelmed and slaughtered the army of 1,000,000 until their shields floated upon a river of blood. Following up the advantages of its victory, Qin gained mastery over the empire and divided up its mountains and rivers. The powerful states begged to submit to its sovereignty and the weaker ones paid homage at its court.

Then followed kings Xiaowen and Zhuangxiang, whose reigns were short and uneventful. After this came the First Emperor who, carrying on the glorious spirit of his six predecessors, cracked his long whip and drove the universe before him, swallowed up the eastern and western Zhou, and overthrew the feudal lords. He ascended the throne of honour and ruled the six directions, scourging the world with his lash, and his might shook the four seas. In the south he seized the land of the hundred tribes of Yue and made of it Guilin and Xiang provinces, and the lords of the hundred Yue bowed their heads, hung halters from their necks, and pleaded for their lives with the lowest officials of Qin. Then he sent Meng Tian north to build the Great Wall and defend the borders, driving back the Xiongnu over 700 *li*, so that the barbarians no longer ventured to come south to pasture their horses and their men dared not take up their bows to vent their hatred.

Thereupon he discarded the ways of the former kings and burned the books of the hundred schools of philosophy in order to make the black-headed people ignorant. He destroyed the walls of the great cities, put to death the powerful leaders, and collected all the arms of the empire, which he had brought to his capital at Xianyang, where the spears and arrowheads were melted down and cast to make twelve human statues. All this he did in order to weaken the black-headed people. After this he ascended and fortified Mt. Hua, set up fords along the Yellow River, and strengthened the heights and precipices overlooking the fathomless valleys, in order to secure his position. He garrisoned the strategic points with skilled generals

and strong crossbowmen and stationed trusted ministers and well-trained soldiers to guard the land with arms and question all who passed back and forth. When he had thus pacified the empire, the First Emperor believed in his heart that, with the strength of his capital within the passes and his walls of metal extending 1,000 miles, he had established a rule that would be enjoyed by his sons and grandsons for 10,000 generations.

For a while after the death of the First Emperor the memory of his might continued to awe the common people. Yet Chen She, born in a humble hut with tiny windows and a wattle door, a day labourer in the fields and a garrison conscript, whose abilities could not match even the average, who had neither the worth of Confucius and Mo Di nor the wealth of Tao Zhu or Yi Dun, stepped from the ranks of the common soldiers, rose up from the paths of the fields, and led a band of some hundred poor, weary soldiers in revolt against Qin. They cut down trees to make their weapons and raised their flags on garden poles, and the whole world gathered like a cloud, answered like an echo to a sound, brought them provisions, and followed after them as shadows follow a form. In the end the leaders east of the mountains rose up together and destroyed the house of Qin.

The empire of Qin at this time was by no means small or feeble. Its base in Yongzhou, its stronghold within Mt. Yao and the Pass, were the same as before. The position of Chen She could not compare in dignity with the lords of Qi, Chu, Yan, Zhao, Wei, Song, Wey, and Zhongshan. The weapons which he improvised from hoe handles and tree branches could not match the sharpness of spears and battle pikes; his little band of garrison conscripts was nothing beside the armies of the Nine States. In deep plotting and far-reaching stratagems, in methods of warfare, he was far inferior to the men of earlier times. And yet Chen She succeeded in his undertaking where they had failed, though in ability, size, power, and strength his forces could in no way compare to those of the states east of the mountains that had formerly opposed Qin. Qin, beginning with an insignificant amount of territory, reached the power of a great kingdom and for 100 years made the ancient eight provinces pay homage at its court. Yet, after it had become master of the six directions and established its palaces within the passes, a single commoner opposed it and its seven ancestral temples toppled, its ruler died by the hands of men, and it became the laughing stock of the world. Why? Because it failed to rule with humanity and righteousness, and did not realize that the power to attack, and the power to retain what one has thereby won, are not the same.

The Qin ruler, having annexed the lands of all the other feudal lords, faced south and called himself an emperor, proprietor of all within the four seas, and the gentlemen of the empire docilely bowed before the wind of his influence. Why was this?

I would reply that the world in recent times had for a long time been without a true king. The royal house of Zhou had sunk into insignificance, the Five Hegemons had passed from the scene, and there was no one whose

commands were obeyed throughout the empire. Hence the feudal rulers in governing relied on strength alone, the powerful impinging on the weak, the many lording it over the few. Weapons were never set aside and the people grew exhausted and impoverished.

Then Qin faced south to call itself ruler of the empire, which meant that the world now had a Son of Heaven to head it. The masses hoped that they would be granted the peace and security to live out their lives, and there was not one of them who did not set aside selfish thoughts and look up to the sovereign in reverence. This was the moment for demonstrating authority and proving one's merit as a ruler, laying the foundation for lasting peace in the empire.

But the First Emperor was greedy and short-sighted, confident in his own wisdom, never trusting his meritorious officials, never getting to know his people. He cast aside the kingly Way and relied on private procedures, outlawing books and writings, making the laws and penalties much harsher, putting deceit and force foremost and humanity and righteousness last, leading the whole world in violence and cruelty. In annexing the lands of others, one may place priority on deceit and force, but insuring peace and stability in the lands one has annexed calls for a respect for authority. Hence I say that seizing, and guarding what you have seized, do not depend upon the same techniques.

Qin put an end to the Warring States period and made itself ruler of the empire, but it did not change its ways or reform its system of government, which shows that the means employed to seize an empire differ from those needed to guard it. Qin tried to guard it alone and singlehanded, and therefore its downfall was merely a matter of time.

If the First Emperor had reflected upon the practices of antiquity and noted the accounts of the Yin and Zhou dynasties in formulating the institutions for his government, then although wilful and dissolute rulers might appear in later times, there would have been no danger that the ruling house would be imperilled or overthrown. The founders of the Three Dynasties, when they ruled the empire, were renowned for their good names, and the regimes they initiated endured for a long time.

When the Second Emperor came to the throne, there was no one in the empire who did not look toward his government with anxious hopes. One who is cold will welcome even a skimpy coat of serge, one who is starving will relish the coarsest dregs. The hungry hopes of the empire offer aid to a new sovereign, for a weary people are easy to govern when treated with benevolence.

If the Second Emperor had acted in the manner of even a mediocre ruler, if he had employed loyal and worthy men and had joined with his officials in single-mindedly caring for the nation's ills, correcting the errors of the former emperor while still in mourning garments; if he had divided the land and apportioned it to the people, enfeoffing the heirs of meritorious ministers, or had set up states with rulers over them so the empire would be

ordered by ritual; if he had emptied the prisons, pardoned those condemned to execution, abolished slavery and other forms of humiliating punishment, allowing each person to return to his native village; if he had opened the granaries and disbursed funds to succour the orphaned and lonely and those in dire poverty; if he had lightened taxes and corvée labour to relieve the distress of the common people, simplified the laws and reduced penalties for the sake of posterity; if he had allowed the people of the empire to make a new beginning, each tending to his own well-being through the practice of integrity and good conduct, fulfilling the longings of the 10,000 people and presiding over the empire with authority and virtue, then the empire would have flocked to him. Then within the four seas all would have been perfectly content, each enjoying and finding security in his own station, fearful only that some change might occur.

Then even if wily and unscrupulous persons should appear, so long as there was no turning against the sovereign, then unprincipled officials would have no way to gloss over their schemes and the threat of violence and rebellious action would come to an end.

The Second Emperor, however, did not adopt such policies, but made the situation even graver by his departures from the Way, destroying ancestral temples and people and resuming work on the Epang Palace. He multiplied the laws and made punishments even sterner, his law officers becoming even harsher and more thorough in their investigations. His rewards and penalties were unjust, his taxes and levies knew no bounds. The empire was assigned so many tasks that the officials could not supervise them all; the people sank into poverty and destitution and the ruler offered them no pity or help. Thereafter villainy and deceit rose on every side and superiors and inferiors turned against one another. Those accused of crimes were so numerous that condemned men were within sight of each other on the roads, and the whole empire groaned. From lords and high ministers on down to the mass of commoners, all feared for their safety, all tasted in person the realities of hardship, none felt secure in his position. Therefore they were easily roused to action. As a result, though Chen She had none of the worth of a King Tang or King Wu, though he possessed no noble title of duke or marquis to rely on, he had only to raise his arm in defiance in Daze and the whole world responded to his call, because the people felt threatened.

The former kings perceived the changes that occur in the course of events and understood the secret of survival or downfall. Therefore their way of shepherding the people was simply to assure them of security. Then although treasonous subjects might appear in the empire, there would be no one to respond to them or aid them. So it is said, a people who feel secure may be led into righteous ways, but a people who feel threatened easily turn to evil. To be honoured as a Son of Heaven, to possess the riches of the empire, and yet be unable to escape execution comes from failure to correct

misdirection. Such was the Second Emperor's error.[107](#)

SHI JI 15: REFLECTIONS ON THE RISE OF THE QIN

[This introduction to the “Chronological Table of the Six States,” *Shi ji* 15, is given with a title supplied by the translator.]

After the Spring and Autumn period, the ministerial families directed affairs of government and the rulers of the powerful states began to call themselves kings. This continued until the Qin at last united all the Xia lineage states, abolished the feudal domains, and arrogated to itself the title of emperor. Thus I made “The Chronological Table of the Six States”.

When as Grand Historian I read the annals of Qin, I come to the time when the Dog Rong defeated King You, the Zhou dynasty moved its capital east to Luoyang, and Duke Xiang of Qin was enfeoffed as one of the feudal lords. He established the Altar of the West, using it to sacrifice to the Lord on High. Here one can see the beginnings of usurpation. For the *Book of Rites* says: “The Son of Heaven sacrifices to heaven and earth, the feudal lords sacrifice to the famous mountains and major rivers within their domains.”[108](#)

Qin’s customs were mixed with those of the Rong and Di barbarians. It put violence and cruelty first and benevolence and righteousness last, and though it occupied the position of a vassal state, it carried out suburban sacrifices in the manner of the Son of Heaven. It is enough to fill a gentleman with fear!

Later Duke Wen advanced beyond Long and drove back the Yi and Di barbarians, paid honour to the Treasures of Chen, and set up his capital between Mt. Qi and Yong. Duke Mu applied himself to government and extended his territory east to the Yellow River, becoming an equal of the lords of the Central Kingdom such as Duke Huan of Qi and Duke Wen of Jin.

After this, government passed into the hands of the ministerial families, the grandees held their posts for generation after generation, and the six high ministers of Jin usurped authority, carrying out punitive expeditions and meeting to conclude oaths of alliance, their authority outweighing that of the feudal rulers. In time Tian Chang assassinated his sovereign Duke Jian and became prime minister of the state of Qi, while the other feudal rulers sat by passively and failed to punish him, until all within the seas were contending for military supremacy. So the three ministerial families in the end divided up the state of Jin among themselves, and Tian He wiped out the Qi ruling family and took possession of the state. This marked the beginning of the era when the Six States flourished.[109](#)

All efforts were directed at strengthening arms and annexing rivals. Plots and deceptions came into use, and men appeared who argued for the vertical or horizontal alliances or pointed out the strong or weak points of such alliances. False titles sprang up like bees, vows and covenants could not be trusted, and though men exchanged hostages and split tallies, there was no way to enforce promises and agreements.

Qin began as a small state situated in a far-off region, shunned by the Xia lineage states and classed with the Rong and Di barbarians. But after the time of Duke Xian, it was always a leader among the feudal rulers. Qin at its most virtuous and righteous could not compare to Lu and Wey at their most violent and cruel, and its military strength was no match for that of the Three Jin states. Yet in the end it united the whole world under its rule. This was not necessarily due to its mountain barriers or the advantages of its geographic situation. Rather it was as though Heaven had aided it.

It is sometimes said that things first come to life in the east and reach their fulfilment in the west. The beginning of an undertaking invariably occurs in the southeast, and the reaping of rewards always takes place in the northwest. Hence Emperor Yu arose among the Western Qiang tribes, King Tang had his start in Bo, the Zhou leaders became kings when from their capital at Feng and Hao they attacked the Yin dynasty, Qin became emperor by using Yongzhou as a base, and Han came to power from Han in Shu.¹¹⁰

After the Qin had achieved its goal of unification, it burned all the copies of the *Odes* and *Documents* in the empire, along with the historical records of the various feudal rulers, numerous as they were, because they contained sharp criticisms of the Qin. The reason the *Odes* and *Documents* have reappeared is that many copies were stored away in people's houses. But the historical records were stored only in the Zhou archives, and hence were all destroyed. How regrettable! How regrettable! All we have left are the Qin historical records, though they do not record days and months and the text is sketchy and incomplete.

Nevertheless, there are things worth noting even in the shifts of power of the Warring States period. Why must one learn only from high antiquity? Qin's seizure of the empire was accompanied by much violence, yet it managed to change with the times and its accomplishments were great.

A certain text tells us to "model ourselves on the rulers of later times"¹¹¹ Why? Because they were closer to us, their customs and the happenings of their times resemble ours, and their ideals are lowly and easy to practise.

Scholars, influenced by what they have heard, see that the Qin occupied the position of emperor for only a short period, and they fail to examine the beginning and end of the matter. Hence they refer to the Qin only as an object of ridicule and decline to say anything more about it. This is as ridiculous as trying to eat with one's ear, and lamentable indeed.

I have accordingly followed the Qin annals, beginning shortly after the

Spring and Autumn period with the reign of King Yuan of the Zhou (476 - 469 BC). I have made a chronological table of the events of the Six States down to the time of the Second Emperor, a period of 270 years in all, recording the beginnings of success and failure as they have been reported. I hope in future times there will be gentlemen who will peruse my work.

SHI JI 68: THE BIOGRAPHY OF LORD SHANG

Gongsun Yang, quitting Wey and journeying to Qin, was able to expound his techniques of government. He strengthened Duke Xiao, made him a hegemon, and later ages have honoured his laws. Thus I made "The Biography of Lord Shang".

Lord Shang was a son of the ruling family of Wey¹¹² by a concubine. His personal name was Yang and his family name Gongsun, the Gongsun being a branch of the Ji clan.

In his youth he was fond of the teachings on penalties and names.¹¹³ He served as attendant to the sons of the nobility under Gongshu Cuo, the prime minister of the state of Wei.

Gongshu Cuo recognized Yang's worth but had not yet recommended him for advancement when he was taken ill. King Hui of Wei went in person to call on Gongshu Cuo and inquire how he was. "You are sick, Gongshu," he said. "If the worst should happen, I am wondering what will become of our altars of the soil and grain."

Gongshu replied, "I have an attendant named Gongsun Yang. He is young in years but has extraordinary talent. I hope Your Majesty will raise him to the position of prime minister and heed his advice." The king remained silent.

When the king was about to leave, Gongshu Cuo dismissed those around him and said, "If you are unwilling to make use of Gongsun Yang, then be sure to have him killed. Don't allow him to leave the state!"

The king agreed to do so and departed.

Gongshu Cuo sent for Yang and, apologizing for his action, said, "Just now, when the king asked me who could be appointed prime minister, I mentioned you, but from his expression it appeared he did not agree with me. Since I put concerns of the ruler first and those of his subjects second, I then told the king that if he did not intend to employ you, he should have you killed, and this time he assented. So you had better hurry on your way before you are arrested!"

But Gongsun Yang replied, "If the king was unwilling to heed your advice to employ me, then why would he heed your advice to have me killed?" In the end he did not run away.

When the king emerged from his interview with Gongshu Cuo, he said to his attendants, "Gongshu is very sick. Sad to say, he actually wanted me to turn over the state to Gongsun Yang! He must be quite out of his mind."

After Gongshu Cuo died, Yang heard that Duke Xiao of Qin had circulated an order throughout his state seeking for men of worth, hoping to carry on

the labours of his predecessor Duke Mu and to invade the lands to the east.¹¹⁴ Yang thereupon journeyed west to Qin, where he requested Duke Xiao's favourite minister Jing Jian to arrange an interview for him with the duke.

Duke Xiao granted Gongsun Yang an interview, and Yang talked to him at great length. Duke Xiao now and then dozed off, not even listening. When the interview was over, the duke remarked angrily to Jing Jian, "That visitor of yours is a mere imposter! What use could a man like that be?"

Jing Jian thereupon berated Gongsun Yang, but Yang said, "I discoursed to the duke on the way of an emperor, but it did not seem to take his fancy."

Five days later, Jing Jian asked the duke to see Yang once more. Yang again had an interview with him and spoke with even greater fervour, though he still failed to interest the duke. After the interview, the duke again complained to Jing Jian and Jing Jian in turn berated Yang. Yang said, "I discoursed to the duke on the way of a king, but it did not appeal to him. I would like to be granted another interview."

When Yang was granted another interview, the duke expressed approval, but was still unwilling to employ him. When the interview was over and Yang had withdrawn, Duke Xiao said to Jing Jian, "That visitor of yours is a good man — someone worth talking to!"

Yang explained to Jing Jian, "I discoursed to the duke on the way of a hegemon. It seems as though he would like to try it out. If he will see me once more, I will know what to say this time!"

When Yang appeared for another interview, the duke talked with him, inching forward until before he knew it he was kneeling on the very edge of his mat. They talked for several days without tiring.

Jing Jian said, "How did you manage to impress our ruler so? He is overjoyed!"

Gongsun Yang said, "I discoursed to the ruler on the ways of the emperor and the king, such as were in use in the Three Dynasties of old. But he said, 'That takes too much time. I can't wait that long. A worthy ruler is one who can make himself famous throughout the world in his own lifetime. Who can sit around fretting for thirty or forty or 100 years in hopes of becoming an emperor or a king?' Therefore I discoursed to the ruler on the techniques for strengthening the state, and the ruler was pleased. Of course, it will still be hard for him ever to equal the virtue of the Yin or Zhou dynasties."

After Duke Xiao had appointed Gongsun Yang to official position, the latter wanted to change the laws, but Duke Xiao was afraid the world would criticize him. "The hesitant in action win no fame, the hesitant in execution win no gain," Gongsun Yang said. "If you are going to act the part of a great man, you must expect the censure of the age. When one is unique in the wisdom of his foresight, he is bound to rouse the animosity of the people. The stupid are blind even to things already done, but the wise can spy what has yet to put out sprouts. One cannot plan with the people the beginning of

an affair, one can only rejoice with them in its completion. He who discourses on perfect virtue cannot stay in tune with the vulgar; he who would win great merit cannot consult with the mob. If the sage should wish to strengthen the state, he must not pattern himself on old ways; if he should wish to profit the people, he cannot abide by old rites.”

“Excellent!” said Duke Xiao.

But Gan Long said, “Not so! The sage does not make the people over, he educates them. The wise man does not change the laws, he makes them work. Go along with the people and educate them and one can achieve results without effort. Leave the laws as they are and see that they work and the officials will know their routine and the people be at ease.”

Gongsun Yang said, “Gan Long’s view is the commonly accepted one. Ordinary people feel easy with established ways, scholars are enamoured of what they already know. These two types of men will do to occupy posts and maintain the laws. But one cannot discuss with them what is beyond the law. The Three Dynasties were not alike in their rites, yet their rulers were all kings. The Five Hegemons did not observe the same laws, yet all were *ba*.¹¹⁵ Wise men make laws, stupid men are constrained by them. Worthy men change rites, unworthy men merely cling to them.”

Du Chi said, “Unless the benefits are a hundredfold one does not change the laws. Unless the advantages are tenfold one does not alter the ritual vessels. Follow the old and you commit no error; abide by ritual and you are without fault.”

Gongsun Yang said, “To govern the age one need not adopt a single course, to benefit the state one need not follow the old. Tang and Wu did not follow the old, yet they became kings.¹¹⁶ The Xia and Yin dynasties did not alter the rites and yet they perished. Going against old ways is not necessarily to be condemned, and abiding by rites is not necessarily deserving of praise.”

“Excellent!” said Duke Xiao, and proceeded to elevate Gongsun Yang to the rank of *zuoshuzhang*.¹¹⁷ Then he gave the order to carry out changes in the laws.

The people were to be grouped in units of five and ten households, exercising mutual surveillance and mutually responsible before the law. Anyone failing to report an offence was to be cut in two at the waist. Reporting an offence was to be rewarded in the same way as cutting off the head of an enemy. Concealing an offender was to be punished in the same way as surrendering to an enemy.

If a family of the common people had more than two sons but failed to establish a separate household, its taxes were to be doubled. Those who had won military merit were to receive ranks in the nobility proportionate to their achievement. Those who engaged in private vendettas were to be penalized according to the gravity of the offence. Old and young were to exert all their strength in the basic occupations of farming and weaving.

Those producing large amounts of grain and cloth were to be excused from corvée labour, while those who engaged in secondary occupations for profit, or who became poor out of laziness, were to be rounded up and made government slaves. Even members of the ruling family, if they had achieved no military merit, were not to be listed in the rosters of the nobility. Degrees of social superiority or inferiority, ranks in the nobility, and other marks of status were to be made clear in each case, and the extent of privately owned fields and houses, male and female servants, and articles of clothing were to be fixed for each family. Those who had won merit were to enjoy affluence and social position, but those who had won no merit, even if they were rich, were to be permitted no show of wealth.

When the laws had been drawn up but not yet promulgated, Gongsun Yang was afraid the people would not trust him. Therefore he set up a three-yard pole by the south gate of the capital market and announced that any member of the populace who could move it and set it up by the north gate would be given ten pieces of gold. The people were suspicious and no one ventured to move the pole.

Then Yang announced, "Anyone who can move it will be given fifty gold pieces!" When one man moved the pole, he was promptly given fifty gold pieces, thus making clear that there was no deception. Then the laws were promulgated.

When the laws had been in effect among the populace for the space of a year, the people of Qin who poured into the capital complaining that the new laws were unsuitable numbered in the thousands. At that time the heir apparent violated the law. Gongsun Yang said, "The reason the laws are not effective is that the superiors themselves violate them!" He was about to punish the heir apparent, but because the heir apparent was the son and heir of the ruler, it was impossible to impose the penalty upon him personally. So his tutor Gongzi Qian was punished instead, and his teacher Gongsun Jia was condemned to be tattooed. The next day the people of Qin all accepted the new laws.

By the time the laws had been in effect for ten years, the people of Qin were delighted. No one picked up objects dropped in the road, the mountains were free of robbers and bandits, and each family had enough of what it needed. The people were brave in public warfare and fearful of private vendettas. Profound order prevailed in the hamlets and towns.

The people of Qin who had earlier complained that the laws were unsuitable now came forward to say how suitable they were. Gongsun Yang said, "People like these are the source of confusion and bad influence!" and he had them all transported to the border areas. After that none of the people ventured to make any comment whatsoever on the laws.

Gongsun Yang was promoted to the rank of *daliangzao*.¹¹⁸ He led troops to surround the Wei city of Anyi and forced it to surrender. Three years later he carried out construction of the Memorial Gate and of palaces and

gardens in Xianyang, and the state of Qin moved its capital there from Yong.

An order was issued prohibiting fathers and sons and older and younger brothers from living in the same house. The smaller cities, towns and hamlets were grouped together to form districts, with a magistrate and his assistant appointed to head each one. There were thirty-one districts in all. The ridges that marked the boundaries of the fields under cultivation were opened up.¹¹⁹ Taxes were made equitable and weights and measures standardized.

Four years after this was done, Gongzi Qian, tutor to the heir apparent, once more violated the law and was punished by having his nose cut off. When five years more had gone by, the inhabitants of Qin were so rich and powerful that the Son of Heaven sent a gift of sacrificial flesh to Duke Xiao and the other feudal lords all tendered their congratulations.

The following year Qi defeated the Wei forces at Maling, captured the Wei heir apparent Shen, and killed its general Pang Juan.

The year after, Gongsun Yang said to Duke Xiao, "Wei is to the state of Qin like an ailment of the belly or the heart afflicting a person! Either Wei must annex Qin, or Qin will annex Wei. Why? Because Wei is situated west of the rugged mountainous area, with its capital at Anyi. The Yellow River marks the border between it and Qin, but it alone is able to enjoy the advantages of the area east of the mountains. When it is to its advantage, it marches west to invade Qin, and when it is weary of that, it draws on the lands to the east.

"Now you are a sage and worthy ruler, with a prosperous state to support you, while Wei last year suffered a major defeat at the hands of Qi and the other feudal lords have deserted it. You must seize this opportunity to attack Wei. If Wei is unable to withstand the attack of Qin, it is bound to move east. And if it moves east, then Qin can rely on the protection of the Yellow River and the mountains to face east and impose its will on the other feudal lords. Such an undertaking will make you an emperor or a king!"

Duke Xiao, approving of this, dispatched Gongsun Yang to lead the forces in an attack on Wei. Wei appointed Gongzi Ang as its general to meet the attack. When the two armies confronted each other, Gongsun Yang sent a letter to the Wei general Gongzi Ang, saying, "You and I started out as friends, and now we are both generals of our respective states. I cannot bring myself to attack you. It would be best if we meet face to face, swear an oath of alliance, enjoy a drink together, and then dismiss our troops, thus bringing peace to both Qin and Wei."

The Wei general Gongzi Ang, considering this reasonable, met with his opponent, swore an oath, and afterward drank with him. Meanwhile, Gongsun Yang concealed armed troops, who carried out a surprise attack on Gongzi Ang and took him prisoner. He then proceeded to attack the Wei army and inflicted a total defeat before returning to Qin.

The armies of King Hui of Wei had suffered repeated defeats by Qi and

Qin, the resources of his state were exhausted, and his territory was dwindling daily. Frightened of the consequences, he dispatched an envoy offering to present the state of Qin with the land west of the Yellow River in exchange for peace. Eventually Wei abandoned Anyi and moved its capital east to Daliang. King Hui said, "How sorry I am that I did not follow the advice of Gongsu Cuo!"

When Gongsun Yang returned after having defeated the Wei forces, Qin enfeoffed him with fifteen towns in Shang and Yu, awarding him the title of Lord Shang.

Lord Shang served as prime minister of Qin for ten years, and many of the members of the ruling family and the families related to it by marriage came to hate him.

When Zhao Liang had an interview with Lord Shang, the latter said, "Meng Langao kindly arranged for me to meet you. I would like to become your friend. Is that possible?"

Zhao Liang replied, "That is more than I would venture to hope for. Confucius has said, 'If a man promotes worthy men and employs them, he will advance. But if he gathers unworthy men around him in hopes of becoming a ruler, he will fail.' I am an unworthy man, and therefore would not venture to accept your offer.

"I have heard that to occupy a position one is not qualified for is to be greedy for position, and to bask in fame that is not one's own is to be greedy for fame. If I were to heed your suggestion, I am afraid I would be greedy for both position and fame. Therefore I dare not consent."

Lord Shang said, "You do not like the way I govern Qin?"

Zhao Liang replied, "Listening to the self is true hearing, looking within is true vision, overcoming oneself is true strength. The sage ruler Shun said, 'To lower oneself is to rise.' You will do best to follow the way of Shun. There's no need to question me."

Lord Shang said, "In the past, Qin followed the customs of the Rong and Di barbarians, ignoring the distinction between father and son, living all together in the same house. Now I have decreed that the customs be changed so that the proper distinctions are observed between men and women. I have built great structures like the Memorial Gate, laying them out like those of Lu and Wey. When you observe the way I have governed Qin, who would you say is more worthy, Lord Five Ram Skins or myself?"¹²⁰

Zhao Liang replied, "A thousand sheepskins are not worth the fur in the armpit of a single fox, and 1,000 persons going 'yes, yes!' are not worth one man with a bold 'no!' King Wu had his bold 'no!'-sayers and he flourished; Zhou of Yin had his silent assenters and he perished. If you do not disapprove of King Wu, then have I your permission to go on all day giving you sound advice without fear of punishment?"

Lord Shang said, "The saying has it, appealing words are flowers, apt

words are fruit; bitter words are medicine, sweet words are a sickness. If in fact you will consent to go on all day giving me words of sound advice, it will be medicine for me. I am at your service. What counsel do you have for me?"

Zhao Liang replied, "Lord Five Ram Skins was a simple country dweller of the state of Jing. Hearing of the worth of Duke Mu of Qin, he longed for an interview with him. He travelled to Qin but, lacking resources, had to sell himself into service to the state, donning coarse clothing and feeding the oxen. After a year, Duke Mu recognized his worth and lifted him up from below the muzzles of the oxen and set him above the hundred families of the state. Throughout Qin, no one dared to eye him with anger.

"He served as prime minister of Qin for six or seven years, attacking Zheng in the east, three times setting up a ruler in the state of Jin, and on one occasion rescuing the state of Jing from misfortune.¹²¹ He spread his teachings within the borders of Qin and the people of Ba came bearing tribute; he bestowed his virtue upon the feudal lords and the eight tribes of Rong came in submission. You Yu, hearing of him, knocked at the Pass, requesting an interview.¹²²

"When Lord Five Ram Skins was prime minister, though he was weary, he never sat down in his carriage, and though it was hot, he never used a canopy. Travelling about the country, he had no entourage of carriages accompanying him, no bearers of shields or halberds. The record of his merit and fame is stored away in the archives, and his virtuous deeds continue to benefit the ages after. When Lord Five Ram Skins died, the men and women of Qin wept; young boys no longer sang their songs, and the pounders of grain ceased to beat time with their pestles. Such was the virtue of Lord Five Ram Skins.

"Now you, sir, when you had your interview with the ruler of Qin, were a guest of the eunuch Jing Jian, which does little to enhance your name. When you became prime minister of Qin, you failed to act on behalf of the hundred families, but instead built elaborate structures such as the Memorial Gate, which is hardly a deed of merit. You inflicted tattooing and other punishments on the tutor and teacher of the heir apparent and brought mutilation and injury to the people with your harsh penalties. This is simply to store up hatred and nourish disaster. Your actions influence the people even more profoundly than do the commands of the ruler, for the people are quicker to ape their superiors than to heed orders. Now you resort to specious measures and initiate outlandish changes — that is no way to educate the people!

"Furthermore, you sit facing south and call yourself lord of a domain, day after day inflicting chastisement on the noblemen of Qin. But the *Book of Odes* says:

See the rat — it has a body,
but this man has no manners!

A man with no manners,
why doesn't he hurry up and die!¹²³

Judging from the ode, the course you are following will hardly lead to long life. One of the noblemen, Gongzi Qian, has shut his gate for eight years now, too ashamed to step outside it. In addition, you have executed Zhu Huan and subjected Gongsun Jia to tattooing. The *Book of Odes* say:

He who wins men over will rise,
he who loses them faces downfall.

These various actions of yours are not the way to win men over!

"When you go out, you have tens of carriages trailing after, carriages heaped with weapons to accompany you, powerful and burly men attending at your side, and others bearing lances and brandishing pikes and spears to run alongside your carriage. If even one of these components is lacking, you refuse to venture forth. But the *Book of Documents* says: 'He who relies on virtue prospers, he who relies on arms is lost.'

"Your existence is as precarious as the morning dew. And do you still hope to live out your years and reach old age? If you do, then why not return the fifteen towns of your fief, retire to the countryside and water your garden? Encourage the Qin ruler to bring to prominence the recluses hidden in their mountain caves, to nourish the aged and protect the orphaned, to show respect to fathers and elder brothers, promote men of merit, and honour those of virtue. Then you may hope for some measure of safety.

"And yet you go on coveting the wealth of Shang and Yu, exploiting your favoured position to dictate the ways of Qin, and thereby nourishing the hatred of the hundred families. If one morning the ruler of Qin should take leave of his guests and no longer appear at court, the state of Qin will have more than a few grounds for placing you under arrest. Your demise would be speedy indeed!"

Lord Shang ignored this advice. Five months later, Duke Xiao of Qin died and the heir apparent succeeded him as ruler.

The followers of Gongzi Qian accused Lord Shang of plotting revolt. The law officials were dispatched to arrest him but he fled. When he reached the Pass, he tried to put up at the guest lodge, but the keeper of the lodge, unaware of who he was, said, "Lord Shang's laws stipulate that anyone giving lodging to a person who lacks proper credentials will be prosecuted." Lord Shang sighed and said, "I made the law — and this is what I get!"

He left Qin and went to Wei, but the people of Wei, hating him for having deceived Gongzi Ang and defeated the Wei army, refused to give him asylum. He wanted to go to some other state, but the men of Wei said, "Lord Shang is a traitor to Qin. If a traitor to a powerful state like Qin comes to Wei, we have no choice but to send him back." So they returned him to Qin.

Once back in Qin, he hurried to his domain in Shang and joined with his followers in calling out the troops of the domain and heading north for a

surprise attack on Zheng. Qin sent out its own forces to attack him and killed him at Min Lake in Zheng. King Hui of Qin had Lord Shang's body torn in two by carriages to serve as a warning, saying, "Let no one imitate the rebel Yang of Shang!"¹²⁴ Eventually the whole of Lord Shang's family was wiped out.

The Grand Historian remarks: Lord Shang was a man endowed by heaven with a cruel and unscrupulous nature. If we note how he approached Duke Xiao with discourses on the way of the emperor and the king, we see that he was proffering mere empty theories that did not represent his true intent. Moreover, he gained an interview through the introduction of a eunuch. Later, when he had been taken into service, he inflicted penalties on Gonzi Qian, deceived the Wei general Gongzi Ang, and failed to take warning from the advice of Zhao Liang. These actions likewise reveal that Lord Shang was a man of little mercy.

I have read Lord Shang's book on opening up barriers and on agriculture and warfare, and I see that it matches the actions of the man himself.¹²⁵ That he ended in such ill repute in the state of Qin is not without reason!

SHI JI 71: THE BIOGRAPHIES OF SHULI ZI AND GAN MOU

It was because of the strategies of Shuli Zi and Gan Mou that Qin was able to advance east and become master of the feudal lords. Thus I made “The Biographies of Shuli Zi and Gan Mou”.

SHULI ZI

Shuli Zi, whose personal name was Ji, was a younger brother of King Hui of Qin by a different mother, his mother being from the state of Hann. Shuli Zi was a man of great wit and wisdom and the people of Qin dubbed him Wisdom Bag.

In King Hui's eighth year (330 BC) Shuli Zi was awarded the rank of *yougeng*¹²⁶ and ordered to lead the troops in an attack on the city of Quwo. He seized the city, expelled its inhabitants, and handed it over to Qin.

In King Hui's twenty-fifth year (313 BC) Shuli Zi was ordered to lead an attack on Zhao. He took the Zhao general Zhuang Bao prisoner and captured the region of Lin. The following year he assisted Wei Zhang in attacking Chu, defeating the Chu general Qu Gai and seizing the region of Hanzhong. Qin enfeoffed Shuli Zi with the title of Lord Yan.

When King Hui of Qin died and the heir apparent, King Wu, was set up (310 BC), Zhang Yi and Wei Zhang were dismissed from office and Shuli Zi and Gan Mou appointed as chancellor of the right and left respectively. Qin dispatched Gan Mou to attack Hann and capture the city of Yiyang. Shuli Zi was ordered to proceed with an entourage of 100 carriages to the Zhou capital. The Zhou ruler sent out soldiers to greet him and treated him with great respect.

The king of Chu, angered by this, berated the Zhou king for according Qin's representative such high honour. But You Teng, a visitor from another state, spoke to the king of Chu on Zhou's behalf, saying, “When Zhi Bo attacked the state of Jiuyou, he first sent in broad wagons and then followed them up with troops, and so Jiuyou was destroyed. Why? Because it was not on its guard. When Duke Huan of Qi attacked the state of Cai, he said, ‘I'm punishing Chu!’ but in fact he pounced on Cai. Now Qin, a country of tigers and wolves, has sent Shuli Zi with an entourage of 100 carriages to visit the Zhou capital. But Zhou recalls the fate of Jiuyou and Cai. Therefore it has long lances going before him, and strong crossbows bringing up the rear. In name it is ‘guarding him’, but in fact it has made him its prisoner. How could Zhou fail to be concerned for its altars of the soil and grain? Indeed, if

it should one morning go out of existence, that would be a worry even to Your Majesty!" With this the king of Chu's anger gave way to delight.

When King Wu of Qin died and was succeeded by King Zhaoxiang, Shuli Zi was treated with even greater respect than before. In the first year of King Zhaoxiang (306 BC) Shuli Zi led an attack on the city of Pu. The defenders of Pu, fearful of the outcome, requested Hu Yan to speak to Shuli Zi on Pu's behalf.

Hu Yan said to Shuli Zi, "Are you attacking Pu for the sake of Qin, or for the sake of Wei? If it is for the sake of Wei, that is fine. But if it is for the sake of Qin, then your efforts are misdirected.

"The reason the state of Wey can continue to exist is because of Pu. Now if you attack Pu, it will turn for help to Wei, and if it does so, then Wey is certain to give in and follow suit. In the past Wei lost the territories it held west of the Yellow River to your state, and it has not been able to regain them because it is weak in military might. But now if Wey throws in its lot with Wei, then Wei will become strong. And the day Wei becomes strong, your territories west of the Yellow River are bound to be threatened. Moreover, the king of Qin will be watching your every move, and if you injure Qin's interests to benefit Wei, he is certain to call you to account!"

"Then what should I do?" said Shuli Zi.

Hu Yan replied, "Call off your troops and cease the attack on Pu. I will enter the city and try speaking to the inhabitants for you so that the ruler of Wey will benefit."

"Excellent!" said Shuli Zi. Hu Yan then entered Pu and addressed its defenders, saying, "Shuli Zi knows that you are hard pressed and says that he is certain to capture the city. But I can make him cease his attack and leave Pu alone!"

The defenders of Pu, terrified, bowed twice and said, "We beg you to do all you can!" Then they offered him 300 catties of gold, saying, "If the Qin troops withdraw, we will surely recommend you to the ruler of Wey and see that you are given a fief."

Hu Yan thereupon took the gold from the men of Pu and used it to win himself a position of honour in Wey. Shuli Zi ceased his attack on Pu and left, withdrawing and attacking the Wei city of Pishi instead, but when Pishi failed to surrender, he left that as well.

In the seventh year of King Zhaoxiang (300 BC), Shuli Zi died. He was buried east of the Zhang Terrace on the south side of the Wei River. He said, "A hundred years from now there will be palaces of the Son of Heaven flanking my grave on either side." Shuli Zi's house was situated west of the mortuary temple of King Zhaoxiang, in the village of Shuli Zi or the Gentleman of Shuli. Later, when the Han dynasty arose, the Palace of Lasting Joy was situated to the east of his grave and the Eternal Palace to the west, while the arsenal was directly in front of it. The people of Qin used to say: "For strength, Ren Bi; for wisdom, Shuli."

GAN MOU

Gan Mou was a native of Xiakai in Chu. He studied under Master Shi Ju of Xiakai, learning the theories of the hundred schools of philosophy. He requested Zhang Yi and Shuli Zi to arrange an interview for him with King Hui of Qin. The king granted the request and, pleased with him, made him a general and ordered him to assist Wei Zhang in invading and gaining control of the region of Hanzhong.

When King Hui died and King Wu came to the throne (330 BC) Zhang Yi and Wei Zhang left Qin and went east to Wei. Zhuang, the prime minister to Hui, the marquis of Shu, revolted. Qin ordered Gan Mou to restore order in Shu. On his return, Gan Mou was appointed chancellor of the left, with Shuli Zi as chancellor of the right.

In the third year of his rule King Wu said to Gan Mou, "I want to send my war chariots through the region of the three rivers and call on the Zhou royal house. Then though I die my name will never perish."¹²⁷

Gan Mou said, "If I may have permission to go to Wei, I will get Wei to promise to join us in an attack on Hann." The king instructed Xiang Shou to accompany Gan Mou to Wei.

When they arrived in Wei, Gan Mou said to Xiang Shou, "Please go back and tell the king that Wei has agreed to my proposal, but ask him not to carry out the attack. Once the affair is successfully completed, I will give all the credit to you."

Xiang Shou returned and made his report to King Wu. The king went as far as Xirang to meet Gan Mou. When Gan Mou arrived, the king asked his reason for abandoning the attack.

Gan Mou replied, "Yiyang is a major district, and Shangdang and Nanyang have for a long time been stocked with supplies. In name they are districts, but in fact they amount to provinces. Now if Your Majesty were to make your way over numerous passes, journeying 1,000 *li*, it would be difficult to attack them.

"Long ago, when the philosopher Zeng Can was living in Bi, an inhabitant of Lu who had the same surname and given name as Zeng Can killed a man. Someone came to Zeng Can's mother and said, 'Zeng Can killed a man!' but his mother went on weaving just as before. After a while someone else came and said, 'Zeng Can killed a man!' but still his mother went on with her weaving. After a while, however, when a third person came and said, 'Zeng Can killed a man!', his mother dropped her shuttle, scrambled down from the loom, climbed over the wall and ran away. Worthy as Zeng Can was, and as much as his mother trusted him, when three people cast suspicion on him, even his mother became frightened.

"Now my worth is no match for Zeng Can's, and no ruler trusts his ministers the way Zeng Can's mother trusted her son. So it would hardly take three people to make Your Majesty begin doubting me. I am afraid,

that is, that you may 'drop the shuttle'.

"In the past, when Zhang Yi marched west to annex the regions of Ba and Shu for Qin, when in the north he opened up the lands beyond the Yellow River and in the south seized Shangyong, the world did not count it to Zhang Yi's credit but rather praised the wisdom of King Hui, the former ruler of Qin. And there was the time when Marquis Wen of Wei ordered Yue Yang to lead an attack on Zhongshan. After three years he managed to conquer it. But when he returned and his merit was being discussed, Marquis Wen showed him a box full of letters criticizing him, and Yue Yang, bowing his head twice, said, 'The victory was due to no merit of mine, but to the might of our lord and ruler!'

"Now I have journeyed to Qin from a foreign state to take up office. If two men such as Shuli Zi and Gongsun Shi should side with Hann and criticize my plan for attacking it, then Your Majesty would be certain to heed them. In that case you would be accused of going back on your word to Wei, and I would incur the hatred of the Hann prime minister Gongzhong Chi."

The king said, "I will not listen to such men! I will swear an oath with you!"

So in the end he ordered the chancellor Gan Mou to lead the troops in an attack on Yiyang. Five months passed and Gan Mou had not captured the city when, as he had feared, Shuli Zi and Gongsun Shi began criticizing him. King Wu sent a summons to Gan Mou, intending to abandon the attack, but Gan Mou replied, "We swore an oath at Xirang!"

"I remember!" said the king, and he proceeded to call out all his forces and order Gan Mou to press the attack. Gan Mou cut off 60,000 enemy heads and in the end captured Yiyang. King Xiang of Hann ordered Gongzhong Chi to journey to Qin with his apologies and conclude a peace agreement with Qin. King Wu in the end journeyed to the Zhou capital and died there. He was succeeded by his younger brother, King Zhaoxiang.

The king's mother, Queen Dowager Xuan, was a woman of Chu. King Huai of Chu deeply resented the fact that, when he had been defeated by Qin at Danyang, the state of Hann had failed to come to his rescue. He now sent troops to surround the Hann city of Yongshi. Hann dispatched Gongzhong Chi to report its distress to Qin.

King Zhaoxiang, however, had just become ruler, and since his mother was a woman of Chu, he did not dare go to Hann's assistance. Gongzhong Chi then requested Gan Mou to speak on Hann's behalf to the king of Qin. Gan Mou addressed King Zhaoxiang in these words: "Gongzhong Chi at present believes that Qin will come to the rescue of Hann, and therefore he ventures to hold out against Chu. But now, although Hann's city of Yongshi is besieged, Qin's troops do not advance beyond the Yao Pass. If Gongzhong Chi is thus placed in a difficult position, he will no longer be able to face the Hann court. And then his rival, Gongshu, may decide that Hann should face south and throw in its lot with Chu. In that case Chu and Hann will become allies, and Wei will not dare do otherwise than follow suit. Then the

circumstances will be ripe for a concerted attack on Qin. Which is better, to sit by and wait for others to attack, or to take the initiative in attacking others?"

"Very well," said the king, and he ordered his troops to advance from Yao and go to the aid of Hann, whereupon the Chu forces withdrew. Qin then sent Xiang Shou to bring order to the Hann city of Yiyang, and ordered Shuli Zi and Gan Mou to attack the Wei city of Pishi. Xiang Shou was a distant relative of Queen Dowager Xuan and had grown up with King Zhaoxiang. Therefore the king employed him in this manner.

Earlier, when Xiang Shou visited Chu, the king of Chu, hearing that Qin held Xiang Shou in high esteem, had accorded him a very generous reception. Now Xiang Shou was guarding the city of Yiyang for Qin and preparing to attack Hann. Gongzhong Chi of Hann sent Su Dai to speak to Xiang Shou, saying, "An animal at bay may overturn a carriage. In the past you defeated Hann and inflicted shame on Gongzhong Chi. But Gongzhong Chi has persuaded his state to enlist once more on the side of Qin, because he believes that by doing so he will surely receive a fief from Qin.

"Now you have presented the Qin territory of Jiekou to Chu, and Chu has in turn enfeoffed you in Duyang with the title of a minor magistrate. But if Qin and Chu pool their forces to attack Hann again, then Hann is certain to be doomed. And if Hann is doomed, then Gongzhong Chi out of desperation will lead his own private forces in an assault on Qin. I hope you will give this careful thought!"

Xiang Shou said, "In bringing Qin and Chu together as allies, I am not attempting to threaten Hann. Please tell Gongzhong Chi for me that Qin and Hann may also become allies."

Su Dai replied, "Ah, but I would like to tell you something. People say that the eminent are accorded eminence because there is something about them that merits eminence. In terms of affection and intimacy, you are not as close to the king of Qin as Gongsun Shi, and in terms of wisdom and ability, you are no match for Gan Mou. But neither of these two men is allowed to play a vital role in the affairs of Qin, while you alone join with the king in deciding upon matters of state. Why? Because there is some fault that attaches to these two. Gongsun Shi is in the party that favours Hann, and Gan Mou is in the party that favours Wei. Therefore the king does not trust them.

"But now, when Qin and Chu are vying for power, if you ally yourself with the party that favours Chu, then you will be travelling the same road as Gongsun Shi and Gan Mou. How will you be any different from them?

"People all say that Chu is expert at shifting sides. And if it should do so, then you will have to flee the state. And you will have brought it on yourself. It would be better, therefore, to consult with the king of Qin so as to anticipate such shifts. If you prepare against Chu's inconstancy by befriending Hann, you can avoid difficulty. Hann first of all follows the advice of Gongsun Shi in matters of state, and as a next step entrusts itself

to Gan Mou. In trusting these men in this way, it is in a sense your enemy. Therefore, when you recommend that Qin guard against Chu's inconstancy by befriending Hann, it will appear that in foreign affairs you do not hesitate to recommend an enemy."¹²⁸

"All right," said Xiang Shou. "I would like very much to join forces with Hann."

Su Dai replied, "Gan Mou has promised Gongzhong Chi that Qin will give back Wusui and let the inhabitants of Yiyang return to their city."¹²⁹ But now with you occupying Yiyang, that is difficult to carry out."

"Then what should I do?" said Xiang Shou. "Wusui can never be given back to Hann in any case."

Su Dai replied, "Why don't you have Qin bring pressure on Chu to return the region of Yingchuan to Hann? Hann donated it to Chu in the first place. If you make the request and it is granted, that will show how much influence you exercise over Chu, and at the same time you will be doing Hann a favour in terms of territory. And if you make the request and it is not granted, then the enmity between Chu and Hann will remain unappeased and they will compete with one another for the friendship of Qin. Now that Qin and Chu are vying for power, you can afford to be somewhat critical of Chu and thereby bring Hann over to your side. This will be to Qin's advantage."

"How so?" said Xiang Shou.

"This is a very good plan!" Su Dai replied. "Gan Mou would like to enlist the help of Wei in attacking Qi, while Gongsun Shi would like to enlist the help of Hann in attacking Qi. Now you will have gained merit by arranging a settlement in Yiyang, you will have brought both Chu and Hann over to the side of Qin, and with that assurance you may all three punish Qi and Wei for their faults. In that case Gongsun Shi and Gan Mou will be as powerless as ever."

Gan Mou eventually spoke to King Zhaoxiang of Qin, urging him to return the city of Wusui to Hann. Xiang Shou and Gongsun Shi opposed the move but were unable to prevent it. Angered over this, Xiang Shou and Gongsun Shi spoke slanderously of Gan Mou. Gan Mou, alarmed, ceased his attack on the Wei city of Puban and fled. Shuli Zi meanwhile concluded peace talks with Wei and withdrew his troops.

When Gan Mou had fled from Qin and was hurrying toward Qi, he met Su Dai along the way. Su Dai was going to Qin on a mission for the state of Qi. Gan Mou said, "I have become a criminal in the eyes of Qin and am running away in fear of the consequences, though I am afraid no place will have me. I have heard that a poor girl and a rich girl were once spinning thread together. The poor girl said, 'I have no money to buy a torch, but your torch gives more than enough light and some to spare. Perhaps you can lend me a spare beam. It won't mean any less light for you, and it will be a big help to me!' Now I am in trouble, and you happen to be on your way to a mission in

Qin. My wife and children are still in Qin. Perhaps you can help me out with some of your 'spare beams'."

Su Dai agreed to do what he could, and when he had reached Qin and completed his mission, he took the opportunity to speak to the king of Qin as follows: "Gan Mou is no ordinary man. While he resided in Qin, he held important posts under a succession of rulers. Moreover, he is thoroughly familiar with the land formations and the steep and easy places in the area from Yao Pass to Devil Valley. If he should persuade Qi to ally with Hann and Wei and should turn around and start plotting against Qin, that would hardly be to Qin's advantage."

"But what can I do about it?" asked the king of Qin.

Su Dai said, "Your Majesty would do best to treat him generously and offer him a large stipend in order to induce him to return. Then when he comes, you can establish him in Acacia Valley and see that he is confined there for the rest of his days."[130](#)

"Very good," said the king, and he bestowed a high ministerial position on Gan Mou, sending the seals of a prime minister of Qin and inviting him to return to Qin. Gan Mou declined to go.

Later Su Dai spoke to King Min of Qi, saying, "Gan Mou is a very worthy man. Qin has bestowed a high ministerial post on him, sending the seals of a prime minister and urging him to return to Qin. But Gan Mou is grateful to you for the gifts you have bestowed on him and is happy to be your minister, so he has declined the offer and refuses to go. Now I wonder how you intend to reward him for this."

"Yes, of course," said the king, and he assigned Gan Mou to a high post and kept him on in Qi. Qin thereupon restored Gan Mou's family and household belongings to him in order to buy favour with Qi.

Qi then dispatched Gan Mou on a mission to Chu. King Huai of Chu had recently taken a bride from the ruling family of Qin and was on intimate terms with Qin. When Qin heard that Gan Mou was in Chu, it sent an envoy to ask the king of Chu to have Gan Mou escorted to Qin.

The king of Chu questioned Fan Yuan, saying, "I would like to install someone as prime minister of Qin. Who would be suitable?"[131](#)

"That sort thing is beyond my competence," Fan Yuan replied.

"I would like to make Gan Mou prime minister," said the king of Chu. "Would that do?"

"I'm afraid it wouldn't," replied Fan Yuan. "His teacher, Shi Ju, was a gatekeeper of Xiagai. On a higher plane Shi Ju did not serve his ruler, on a lower one he took no care of his family, but simply won a reputation as a mean, lowly person who was extraordinarily finicky."[132](#) But Gan Mou studied under him and somehow managed to get along. Therefore, despite King Hui's perceptiveness, King Wu's powers of scrutiny, and Zhang Yi's discrimination, Gan Mou was able to serve them all, holding ten offices and never once incurring fault. He is indeed a worthy man. But it will not do to

have him acting as prime minister of Qin. For if Qin has a worthy prime minister, it will not be to Chu's benefit.

"In the past Your Majesty installed Shao Hua as prime minister in Yue and internal revolt broke out under Zhang Yi. As a result of the confusion in Yue, Chu had to close the Li Gate on its southern border and make the region of Jiangdong into a province. Thanks to Your Majesty's wise planning, measures such as these could be taken and so, though there was confusion in Yue, Chu remained in good order.

"But now, although Your Majesty knew the proper measures to take in Yue you are forgetting the measures appropriate to Qi. It seems to me that you are making a great mistake. If you wish to install a prime minister in Qin, then surely no one would be more suitable than Xiang Shou. Xiang Shou is a relative of the king of Qin. As children they shared the same clothes; as adults they ride in the same carriage so the king may consult him on affairs of state. If Your Majesty sees to it that Xiang Shou becomes prime minister of Qin, that will certainly be to Chu's advantage."

Chu then sent an envoy to Qin asking that it appoint Xiang Shou as its prime minister. Qin in the end did so. Gan Mou was never permitted to re-enter Qin, but died in Wei.

GAN LUO

Gan Mou had a grandson named Gan Luo. After Gan Mou died, when the boy was still only twelve years old, he entered the service of Lü Buwei, the marquis of Wenxin, who was the prime minister of Qin at the time.

The First Emperor of Qin had sent Cai Ze, the lord of Gangcheng, as his envoy to the state of Yan, and three years later King Xi of Yan agreed to send his heir, Prince Dan, as a hostage to the state of Qin. Qin then ordered Zhang Tang to become prime minister of Yan, hoping that Yan would join Qin in an attack on Zhao so that it could broaden the territory under its control in the region between the Yellow River and the Zhang River.

Zhang Tang spoke to Lü Buwei, the marquis of Wenxin, about this, saying, "In the past I was ordered by King Zhaoxiang of Qin to carry out an attack on Zhao. The Zhao ministers in their wrath announced that 'Anyone who seizes Zhang Tang gets a 100 *li* tract of land!' Now if I go to Yan, I will invariably have to pass through Zhao. I am afraid I cannot undertake such a journey."

The marquis was unhappy at his refusal but had no way of forcing him to go. Gan Luo said, "My lord, why are you so very unhappy?"

The marquis replied, "I sent Cai Ze, the lord of Gangcheng, on a mission to Yan three years ago, and as a result Prince Dan, the heir apparent of Yan, has already come to Qin as a hostage. But now I have personally requested Lord Zhang to go to Yan to become prime minister, and he is unwilling to

go!"

Gan Luo said, "With your permission, I'll see that he goes!"

"Off with you!" said Lü Buwei, scolding the boy. "I personally asked him to do so and he refused. How could you make him go?"

Gan Luo said, "Xiang Tuo was only seven when he acted as teacher to Confucius.¹³³ And in my case I'm already twelve! Just let me try — there's no need to start scolding!"

Gan Luo then went to see Zhang Tang and said to him, "How do your lordship's achievements compare with those of Lord Wuan?"¹³⁴

Zhang Tang replied, "Lord Wuan has thwarted the power of Chu to the south and overawed Yan and Zhao in the north; the battles won, the raids carried out, the towns and villages captured and overrun are in his case beyond numbering. My achievements could never rival his!"

Gan Luo said, "And who exercises greater influence in Qin, the marquis of Ying¹³⁵ or the marquis of Wenxin?"

Zhang Tang replied, "The marquis of Ying cannot match the marquis of Wenxin in influence."

Gan Luo said, "Do you really understand, then, that nothing can match the influence of the marquis of Wenxin?"

"I understand."

Gan Luo said, "The marquis of Ying wanted to attack Zhao. Lord Wuan ventured to criticize the plan, but before he had gone more than seven *li* from the capital city of Xianyang, the order came for him to die at Duyou. Now the marquis of Wenxin has personally requested you to become prime minister of Yan, but you are unwilling to go. I do not know how far your lordship will get before the order comes for your death!"

Zhang Tang said, "At your suggestion, young man, I believe I will go," and he ordered his baggage for the journey.

On the day of his departure, Gan Luo said to his master, the marquis of Wenxin, "If you will lend me five carriages, I would like permission to go to Zhao and make a report on Zhang Tang's behalf."

Lü Buwei went to court and spoke to the First Emperor, saying, "The former minister Gan Mou has a grandson named Gan Luo. He is still only a boy, but since he is descended from a famous family, the other feudal rulers have all heard of him. Recently, Zhang Tang pleaded illness and was unwilling to go to Yan, but Gan Luo has persuaded him to make the journey. Now I would like to send the boy ahead to report this to Zhao and ask Zhao to permit him to pass through its territory."

The First Emperor summoned Gan Luo to an audience and then sent him to Zhao. King Xiang of Zhao came out to the suburbs of his capital to greet Gan Luo.

Gan Luo said to the king, "Has Your Majesty heard that Prince Dan, the heir apparent of Yan, has gone to Qin as a hostage?"

"I have heard that."

"Has Your Majesty heard that Zhang Tang is to be the prime minister of Yan?"

"I have heard that."

"Prince Dan of Yan's going to Qin as a hostage is proof that Yan does not intend to play false with Qin. And Zhang Tang's becoming prime minister of Yan is proof that Qin does not intend to play false with Yan. And if Yan and Qin do not intend to play false with one another, then Zhao is in danger of attack."

"The reason Yan and Qin will not play false with one another is that they hope to attack Zhao and broaden their territories in the area between the Yellow and Zhang rivers. Your Majesty would do best to give me five cities so I can broaden Qin's territory in the area between the rivers. Then I will ask Qin to send Prince Dan back to Yan, and Qin can join with this powerful state of Zhao in attacking a weak Yan."

The king of Zhao immediately detached five of his cities and turned them over to Qin to broaden its territory in the area between the rivers. Qin then returned Prince Dan to Yan, and Zhao attacked Yan and seized thirty cities in the region of Shanggu, eleven of which it gave to Qin.

When Gan Luo returned and reported on his mission, Qin enfeoffed him and made him a high minister. It also presented him with the fields and houses that had earlier belonged to his grandfather, Gan Mou.

The Grand Historian remarks: Shuli Zi enjoyed high esteem because of his kinship with the ruler, and it was only natural that he should have done so. But the people of Qin recognized his wisdom and therefore took special note of his actions. Gan Mou rose up from the lanes and byways of Xiandai to gain prominence and fame among the feudal rulers, enjoying favour in the powerful states of Qi and Chu. Gan Luo was only a boy, but he devised one unusual scheme and his name is still mentioned in later ages. Though he was not what could be called a gentleman of sterling conduct, he deserves to be ranked with the strategists of the Warring States period. At that time, with Qin so powerful, the world was only too happy to resort to deceitful plots!

SHI JI 72: THE BIOGRAPHY OF THE MARQUIS OF RANG

He wrapped up the Yellow River and the mountains, encircled Daliang, and obliged the other feudal rulers to cease their resistance and serve the Qin. Such was the merit of Wei Ran. Thus I made “The Biography of the Marquis of Rang”.

Wei Ran, the marquis of Rang, was a younger brother of Queen Dowager Xuan, the mother of King Zhaoxiang of Qin. The queen’s forbears were men of Chu and belonged to the Mi family. When King Wu of Qin died (307 BC), he left no son and so his younger brother was set up as ruler and became King Zhaoxiang. King Zhaoxiang’s mother was at that time known as Lady Mi Bazi, but when her son became King Zhaoxiang she was given the title Queen Dowager Xuan. Queen Dowager Xuan was not the mother of King Wu; his mother bore the title Queen Huiwen and died before King Wu himself did.[136](#)

Queen Dowager Xuan had two younger brothers. The older of these, who had a different father from the Queen Dowager, was the marquis of Rang, whose surname was Wei and whose given name was Ran. The younger brother, who had the same father as the Queen Dowager, was named Mi Rong and was enfeoffed as Lord Huayang. King Zhaoxiang also had two younger brothers by the same mother as himself, Lord Gaoling and Lord Jingyang. Among all these, Wei Ran was the most worthy.

Wei Ran was employed in various offices from the time of King Hui and King Wu. And when King Wu died and his younger brothers were vying for succession, it was the power of Wei Ran alone that enabled King Zhaoxiang to ascend the throne.

After King Zhaoxiang became ruler, he appointed Wei Ran a general and ordered him to guard Xianyang and punish those involved in the uprising of Lord Ji.[137](#) He expelled the consort of King Wu from the capital and sent her back to her native state of Wei, and also wiped out all the evilly inclined older and younger brothers of King Zhaoxiang, until the whole state of Qin trembled before his authority. King Zhaoxiang was still a boy and the government was in the hands of his mother, Queen Dowager Xuan, who entrusted the administration of affairs to Wei Ran.

In King Zhaoxiang’s seventh year (300 BC) Shuli Zi died and Lord Jingyang was sent to be a hostage in Qi. Lou Huan, a native of the state of Zhao, came to Qin to assume the office of prime minister. But when this proved unbeneficial to Zhao, it sent Qiu Yi to go to Qin and request that Wei Ran be appointed prime minister of Qin.

When Qiu Yi was about to depart on this errand, his retainer Song Gong said to him: "Even if Qin does not heed your request, Lou Huan is certain to be resentful of your interference. You had best say to Lou Huan that out of consideration for him, you do not intend to press your request that Qin appoint Wei Ran as prime minister. If the king of Qin sees that Zhao is not pressing its request to have Wei Ran made prime minister, he will probably not heed your request, and then when the affair comes to nothing, Lou Huan will feel grateful to you. And if your request should be heeded, then it will be Wei Ran's turn to feel grateful!"

Qiu Yi followed this advice, and Qin in the end did in fact dismiss Lou Huan and appoint Wei Ran to the post of prime minister. Wei Ran was about to punish Lü Li when the latter escaped from Qin and fled to Qi.

In King Zhaoxiang's fourteenth year (293 BC) Wei Ran promoted Bai Qi and ordered him to replace Xiang Shou as general. He attacked the forces of Hann and Wei and defeated them at Yique, cutting off 240,000 enemy heads and capturing the Wei general Gongsun Xi. The following year he also seized the Chu cities of Wan and She.

Wei Ran asked permission to resign the post of prime minister because of illness and appointed Shou Zhu, a "guest minister" of Qin, as prime minister in his place. The following year Shou Zhu resigned and Wei Ran resumed the position of prime minister. At this time Wei Ran was enfeoffed in Rang, a fief that was later enlarged to include Tao. He was given the title of marquis of Rang.

Four years after he was enfeoffed as marquis of Rang, he led the Qin forces in an attack on Wei. Wei presented an area of 400 square *li* east of the Yellow River to Qin. Qin invaded the Henei region of Wei, capturing over sixty cities of various sizes.

In the nineteenth year of King Zhaoxiang (288 BC) the Qin ruler took the title of Western Emperor and the Qi ruler took that of Eastern Emperor. A month or so later, Lü Li came to Qin and the Qi and Qin rulers went back to calling themselves kings. Wei Ran became prime minister of Qin once more. After six years he resigned, but two years later again became prime minister.

Four years later (279 BC), he ordered Bai Qi to attack Chu. Bai Qi captured the Chu capital city of Ying. Qin set up Nan Province. Bai Qi was enfeoffed as Lord Wuan. Bai Qi had been promoted to office by the marquis of Rang and the two were close friends. At this time the wealth of the marquis of Rang exceeded that of the Qin ruling house.

King Zhaoxiang, thirty-second year (275 BC): the marquis of Rang, acting as prime minister, led the troops in an attack on Wei, putting the Wei general Mang Mao to flight, advancing into Beizhai, and eventually surrounding the Wei capital city of Daliang.

The Liang (Wei) counsellor Xu Jia spoke to the marquis of Rang regarding this, saying, "I have heard the leading officials of Wei say to the king of Wei: 'In the past when King Hui of Liang (Wei) attacked Zhao, he won victory at

Sanliang and captured the Zhao capital of Handan. But the ruler of Zhao refused to relinquish title to the land, and so eventually it was returned to Zhao. Similarly, when the men of Qi attacked Wey, captured its former capital, and killed Zi Liang, the men of Wey refused to make any territorial concessions, and so they were in time able to get their former lands back. The reason the states of Wey and Zhao could remain intact and keep up their military strength without having their lands annexed by the other feudal rulers was that they were willing to bear up under hardship and were loath to hand over territory. The states of Song and Zhongshan, on the other hand, ceded territory as often as they were attacked, and as a consequence they perished.

“In our opinion, therefore, Wey and Zhao should be a model to us, and Song and Zhongshan should be a warning. Qin is a greedy and rapacious state, friendly to no one. In silkworm fashion it eats away at the Wei family, having already devoured what was left of the state of Jin. When it defeated Bao Zi in battle, it demanded that eight districts be ceded to it, and before it had finished annexing those, it sent out its troops once again. When will Qin ever be surfeited?

“Now it has routed Mang Mao and advanced into Beizhai. But this does not mean it is going to venture an attack on Wei. It simply intends to intimidate Your Majesty so that it can demand more territorial concessions. Your Majesty must by no means heed its demands!

“If Your Majesty turns against Chu and Zhao and makes peace with Qin, then Chu and Zhao in their anger will desert Your Majesty and instead vie with you in playing up to Qin. Qin of course will accept their offer of support. Then when Qin has the forces of Chu and Zhao to support it from either side, it will renew its attacks on Liang (Wei), and there will be no hope of the kingdom’s escaping destruction. Therefore we beg Your Majesty not to make peace with Qin under any circumstances. And if you should consider doing so, then keep concessions of territory to a minimum and insist upon Qin sending a hostage to our state. Otherwise you are certain to be cheated.

“This is the advice that I heard the Wei officials give to the king of Wei. I hope you will give careful thought to it. The *Book of Zhou* says: ‘The mandate is never constant’.¹³⁸ Which means you cannot count on good fortune time and again. Defeating Bao Zi in battle and winning the concession of eight districts was not the result of superlative military strength, nor was it the fruit of careful planning. It was in large part a stroke of luck from Heaven. And to go on to rout Mang Mao, advance into Beizhai, and launch an attack on Daliang is to assume that this sort of luck from Heaven is a constant occurrence. No wise man, however, would make such an assumption.

“I have heard that the ruler of Wei has called up those who are capable of bearing arms from every one of his hundred districts and set them to

guarding Daliang. I would guess he cannot have less than 300,000 men. With a force of 300,000 defending the hundred-yard high walls of Daliang, even King Tang or King Wu come to life again would find it hard to attack, I believe. To make light of the forces of Chu and Zhao menacing you from behind, to scale these hundred-yard walls, fight against a force of 300,000, and expect to gain victory is something that in my opinion has never been heard of since heaven and earth first parted ways! And if you attack the city but fail to capture it, then the Qin forces will be worn out, your fief of Tao will be lost, and all your former achievements will count for nothing!

"At the moment the ruler of Wei is in doubt as to how to proceed. Now is the time to settle for a small concession of territory. Before the troops of Chu and Zhao arrive here at Daliang, I urge you to accept a small concession of land in exchange for a settlement with Wei. The ruler of Wei is doubtful as to how to proceed, and if he finds he can gain a profitable settlement through a small concession of land, he will be anxious to do so. Then you will have got what you wanted. Chu and Zhao meanwhile will be angry at Wei for having settled things without waiting for them, and in their haste to curry favour with Qin will disperse their troops. After that, you can decide what policy to follow.

"If you are interested in gaining territory, why must it be through the use of arms? When the area of the old state of Jin was being carved up, the Qin forces did not even have to attack and Wei handed over the cities of Jiang and Anyi. And if you open two new roads to Tao, you will have control of almost all the old area of Song, and in that case Wei will surely hand over Danfu. The Qin forces will have suffered no loss, and you will be in control. What could you ask for that would not be given you, what could you undertake that would not succeed? I hope you will consider the matter carefully and not proceed on the path to danger!"

"Very good," said the marquis of Rang, and he abandoned the siege of Daliang.

The following year (274 BC) Wei turned its back on Qin and joined in an alliance with Qi. Qin ordered the marquis of Rang to attack Wei. He cut off 40,000 enemy heads, routed the Wei general Bao Yuan, and seized three of Wei's districts. The marquis of Rang's fief was increased.

The next year (273 BC) the marquis of Rang joined with Bai Qi and Hu Yang, a Qin official from another state, in once more attacking Zhao, Hann, and Wei. They defeated Mang Mao at Huayang, cut off 100,000 enemy heads, and seized the Wei cities of Juan, Caiyang, and Changshe, and Zhao's city Guanjin. They returned Guanjin to Zhao and joined their forces with those of Zhao in preparation for an attack on Qi.

King Xiang of Qi, alarmed, engaged Su Dai to send a letter to the marquis of Rang in secret pleading on Qi's behalf. It read: "I have heard passersby say that Qin is about to lend Zhao an additional 40,000 armed men to conduct an attack on Qi. I have privately informed the ruler of our humble state of this, saying, 'The king of Qin is intelligent and astute in planning

and the marquis of Rang is wise and experienced in affairs. They would certainly not lend Zhao 40,000 armed men for an attack on Qi!’ Why did I say this? The alliance formed by the Three Jin constitutes a deadly enemy to Qin.¹³⁹ A hundred times it has betrayed Qin, a hundred times it has cheated Qin, yet it does not look on itself as faithless or believe that it has acted wrongly. Now to inflict defeat on Qi would be to fatten Zhao, and as Zhao and Qin are bitter enemies, that would not be to the profit of Qin. This is the first reason.

“Qin’s strategists are no doubt assuming that in defeating Qi, they will be wearing out Qin’s allies, the Three Jin and Chu, and that later they will be able to gain victory over the latter. But Qi is a state whose power is exhausted. For the world to unite in attacking Qi is like using a thousand-pound crossbow to puncture a suppurating boil. Of course Qi is doomed, but how will that wear out Jin and Chu? This is the second reason.

“If Qin contributes only a few troops to the undertaking, then Jin and Chu will not trust it. And if it contributes a large number of troops, then Jin and Chu will be overshadowed by Qin. In that case Qi in its alarm will not look to Qin for mercy but will invariably turn to Jin and Chu. This is the third reason.

“If Qin carves up Qi and feeds the pieces to Jin and Chu, and Jin and Chu have to station troops to secure the areas, then Qin will appear to be an enemy rather than an ally. This is the fourth reason. And in the end it will seem as though Jin and Chu have been using Qin to undo Qi, and using Qi to undo Qin, and people will think, how wise of Jin and Chu, and how stupid of Qin and Qi! This is the fifth reason.

“Therefore if Qin should acquire Anyi and treat it well, then it would surely have nothing to worry about. And if Qin acquires Anyi, then Hann will surely lose possession of Shangdang. Which would be more profitable, to seize on the very vitals of the empire, or to send out troops and fear they may never return again? That is why I said to my ruler, ‘The king of Qin is intelligent and astute in planning, and the marquis of Rang is wise and experienced in affairs. They would certainly never lend Zhao 40,000 armed men for an attack on Qi!’”¹⁴⁰

The marquis of Rang accordingly abandoned the plan and returned with his troops to Qin.

King Zhaoxiang, thirty-sixth year (271 BC): the prime minister of Qin, the marquis of Rang, consulted with Zao, a “guest minister” of Qin, hoping to attack Qi and seize Gangshou so that he could enlarge his fief at the city of Tao. At this time Fan Ju, a native of Wei who went by the alias of Master Zhang Lu, criticized the marquis of Rang’s plan to attack Qi, since it involved passing through the Three Jin in order to carry out the attack. He managed to gain a hearing with King Zhaoxiang of Qin, who appointed him to office. Fan Ju warned that Queen Dowager Xuan was conducting affairs in a dictatorial manner, that the marquis of Rang had complete control of

relations with the other feudal lords, and that lords Jingyang and Gaoling and their followers were enjoying excessive luxury, their wealth surpassing that of the royal house. King Zhaoxiang, awaking to the situation, finally dismissed the marquis of Rang from the post of prime minister and ordered Lord Jingyang and all the others to quit the capital area and proceed to their respective fiefs in the area beyond the Hangu Pass. When the marquis of Rang went out of the pass, he was accompanied by over 1,000 wagons loaded with his belongings. He died in his fief in Tao and was buried there. Qin then took over the region of Tao once more and made it into a province.

The Grand Historian remarks: The marquis of Rang was an uncle and blood relative of King Zhaoxiang. The fact that Qin was able to expand its lands in the east, weaken the other feudal rulers, and for a time call itself emperor of the world, so that all the world turned west and bowed their heads before it, was thanks to the marquis of Rang. But when his wealth and eminence became excessive, one man spoke out against him and he was stripped of power, forced to humble himself, and died in despondency, almost worse than if he had been an alien from another state!

SHI JI 73: THE BIOGRAPHIES OF BAI QI AND WANG JIAN

South they captured Yan and Ying, north they overran Changping, and in the end surrounded Handan, for Lord Wuan was their leader. What destroyed Jing and wiped out Zhao was the plotting of Wang Jian. Thus I made “The Biographies of Bai Qi and Wang Jian”

BAI QI

Bai Qi was a native of Mei in Qin. Being skilled in the use of arms, he served under King Zhaoxiang of Qin.

In King Zhaoxiang's thirteenth year (294 BC) Bai Qi was given the rank of *zuoshuzhang*, appointed a general, and sent to make a surprise attack on Hann's city of Xincheng. This year the marquis of Rang became prime minister of Qin and appointed Ren Bi to be governor of Hanzhong.

The following year Bai Qi was promoted to the rank of *zuogeng* and attacked the Hann and Wei forces at Yique, cutting off 240,000 enemy heads. He also took prisoner the enemy leader Gongsun Xi and captured five cities. Bai Qi was transferred to the post of state commandant and, crossing the Yellow River, seized the area from Anyi east to Ganhe.

The following year Bai Qi was given the rank of *daliangzao*. He attacked Wei, defeating it, and seized sixty-one cities of various sizes. The following year he and Sima Cuo, a “guest minister” of Qin, attacked the city of Yuan and captured it.

Five years later, Bai Qi attacked Zhao and captured the city of Guanglang. Seven years later he attacked Chu and captured five cities, including Yan and Deng. The following year he attacked Chu and captured the Chu capital city Ying, burned Yiling, and pushed east as far as Jingling. The king of Chu, abandoning his capital, left Ying and fled east to take up residence in Chen. Qin then made Ying into Nan Province and promoted Bai Qi to the position of Lord Wuan. Bai Qi went on to gain control of Chu and bring order to the provinces of Wu and Qianzhong.

King Zhaoxiang, thirty-fourth year (273 BC): Bai Qi attacked Wei and captured Huyang, routing Mang Mao, capturing one of the Three Jin generals, and cutting off 130,000 enemy heads. He engaged the Zhao general Jia Yan in battle, at which time 20,000 of Zhao's men were drowned in the Yellow River.

King Zhaoxiang, forty-third year (264 BC): Bai Qi attacked the Hann city of Jing, captured five cities, and cut off 50,000 enemy heads. Forty-fourth

year (263 BC): Bai Qi attacked Nanyang and cut off the road leading to Taihang.

King Zhaoxiang, forty-fifth year (262 BC): Qin attacked the region of Yewang in Hann. Yewang surrendered to Qin, thus cutting off the road to Shangdang. Feng Ting, the governor of Shangdang, consulted with his people, saying, "The road to the capital area of Zheng is cut off and you can no longer expect to be treated as people of Hann. The Qin forces press forward day by day and Hann is powerless to withstand them. The best thing would be to turn Shangdang over to the state of Zhao. If Zhao accepts us, Qin in its anger will surely attack Zhao. And if Zhao is faced with attack, it will be certain to ally with Hann. Once Hann and Zhao are united, then they can face up to Qin!"

He accordingly sent a man to report his decision to Zhao. King Xiaocheng of Zhao consulted with Lord Pingyang and Lord Pingyuan.¹⁴¹ Lord Pingyang said, "Better not accept the offer. If we accept, the headaches will outweigh the gain." But Lord Pingyuan said, "With no effort on our part we acquire a province — surely we should accept!" Zhao accepted the offer and enfeoffed Feng Ting as Lord Huayang.

Forty-sixth year (261 BC): Qin attacked the Hann cities of Goushi and Lin and captured them.

Forty-seventh year (260 BC): Qin dispatched the *zuoshuzhang* Wang He to attack Hann. He seized Shangdang, whereupon the inhabitants of Shangdang fled to Zhao. The Zhao army encamped at Changping in order to take charge of the refugees from Shangdang.

In the fourth month Wang He launched his attack on Zhao. Zhao appointed Lian Po as commander of its forces. When the soldiers of the Zhao army clashed with the Qin scouting forces, the Qin scouts cut down the Zhao assistant general Jia. In the sixth month Qin gained momentary advantage over the Zhao army and seized two of its outposts and four commanders.

Seventh month: the Zhao army constructed walled fortifications and guarded its position. Qin attacked the fortifications, captured two commanders, and broke through the Zhao ranks, seizing the western section of the walled fortifications. Lian Po strengthened his walls and waited for Qin to attack.

Qin repeatedly challenged Lian Po to battle, but the Zhao forces refused to venture out of their fortifications, though the king of Zhao several times berated Lian Po. Meanwhile the Qin prime minister, the marquis of Ying, sent men to use large sums of money in spreading rumours among the people of Zhao, saying, "All Qin is afraid of is that Zhao Kuo, the son of Lord Mafu, may take commands."¹⁴² Lian Po is easy to deal with and will soon surrender."

The king of Zhao was already angry at Lian Po's army because of its many failures and frequent defeats, and now he saw that it held fast to its defence

works and did not dare to fight, and he had also heard the rumours that Qin had spread abroad. He accordingly ordered Zhao Kuo to replace Lian Po as commander and to lead a strike against Qin.

When Qin heard that Zhao Kuo, the son of Lord Mafu, had taken command, it appointed Bai Qi, Lord Wuan, to be supreme commander of the army, with Wang He as assistant general, and circulated an order throughout the army that anyone daring to reveal that Lord Wuan was in command would be cut in two.

When Zhao Kuo arrived to take over, he sent out his troops in a surprise attack on the Qin army. The Qin army, feigning defeat, raced from the field, leaving two lines of ambush troops ready to fall on the enemy. The Zhao army, following up its supposed victory, pursued the enemy as far as the Qin fortifications, where the defenders of the fortifications drove them back and prevented them from gaining entrance. Then the Qin ambush forces, numbering 25,000 men, cut off the rear of the Zhao army, while another division of 5,000 cavalry sealed off the Zhao fortifications. Thus the Zhao army was split into two parts and its supply lines were cut off. Qin then dispatched lightly armed men to make sudden strikes. The Zhao forces, realizing they could not win in combat, built more fortifications and held tight to their position, awaiting the arrival of reinforcements.

When the king of Qin received word that Zhao's food supply had been cut off, he journeyed in person to the Henei region, where he bestowed one grade of noble rank on the population and called up all males over fifteen years of age and sent them to Changping to block Zhao's relief forces and food supplies.

By the time the ninth month arrived, the Zhao soldiers had had no food for forty-six days and many were secretly killing and eating their comrades. Forming themselves in four battalions, they attacked the Qin fortifications four or five times, attempting to break out of the encirclement, but could not do so. The Zhao army commander Zhao Kuo called out his finest men and led them into combat, but the Qin army shot and killed him with arrows. Thus Zhao Kuo was defeated, and 400,000 of his soldiers surrendered to Lord Wuan.

Lord Wuan recalled that earlier, when Qin had captured the region of Shangdang, the inhabitants of Shangdang, unhappy at the thought of becoming Qin subjects, had gone over to the side of Zhao. He calculated, therefore, that since the Zhao troops might well turn against him, he would face the danger of revolt if he did not kill them all. He consequently devised some deception and had them all massacred, sending only 240 of the youngest ones back to Zhao. Counting earlier and later actions, he took prisoner or cut off the heads of 450,000 men, leaving the people of Zhao trembling with fear.

Forty-eighth year (259 BC), tenth month: Qin once more sent forces to restore order in the province of Shangdang. It divided its army into two, Wang He attacking and capturing Pilao and Sima Geng restoring order to

Taiyuan. Hann and Zhao in alarm sent Su Dai to go with lavish gifts and speak to the prime minister of Qin, the marquis of Ying. "Has Lord Wuan taken captive the son of Lord Mafu?" asked Su Dai.

"He has," said the marquis.

"And is he now besieging the Zhao capital city of Handan?"

"He is."

"If Zhao is destroyed, then the king of Qin will be king of that area as well, and Lord Wuan will become one of the three highest ministers of the state. On Qin's behalf Lord Wuan has won victories, attacking and seizing over seventy cities. In the south he has gained control of Yan, Ying, and Hanzhong, and in the north he has taken prisoner the army of Zhao Kuo. Even the achievements of the Duke of Zhou, the Duke of Shao, and Lü Wang, the three highest ministers of the Zhou dynasty, could not top this! Now if Zhao is destroyed, Qin will be its king, and if Qin is its king, then Lord Wuan is certain to become one of the three highest ministers. Can you bear to be subordinate to him? Indeed, whether you wish it or not, you will have no choice!

"In the past, when Qin attacked Hann and besieged the city of Xingqiu, it placed Shangdang in a difficult position. But the people of Shangdang all chose to put themselves under Zhao's rule. For many long days the world has been unhappy at the thought of becoming subjects of Qin! So now if you destroy Zhao, its northern regions will go over to Yan, its eastern regions to Qi, its southern regions to Hann and Wei, and then how many people will you have won in the action? Therefore you would do best to settle for a concession of land rather than merely adding to the achievements of Lord Wuan!"

The marquis of Ying accordingly spoke to the king of Qin, saying, "Qin's soldiers are worn out. I beg permission to make peace with Hann and Zhao in exchange for territorial concessions so we can rest our men."

The king gave his permission, and the Hann region of Yuanyong and six cities of Zhao were ceded to Qin in exchange for peace. In the first month,¹⁴³ all Qin troops were withdrawn. When Lord Wuan received the order, it became the start of bad feeling between him and the marquis of Ying. In the ninth month Qin once more called out its troops, ordering fifth rank counsellor Wang Ling to attack the Zhao capital city of Handan. At this time Lord Wuan was ill and could not undertake the journey.

Forty-ninth year (258 BC), first month: Wang Ling attacked Handan and won a slight advantage. Qin called out more troops to assist him. Wang Ling lost five companies of men. Lord Wuan's illness abated.

The king of Qin wanted to send Lord Wuan to replace Wang Ling as commander. But Lord Wuan said, "Handan is in fact not easy to attack, and relief forces from the other feudal rulers will be arriving any day. The other rulers have for a long time borne great hatred toward Qin. Now, although Qin has destroyed the enemy army at Changping, over half of its own men

have died in the action and the country's resources are exhausted. We have embarked on a distant expedition beyond the Yellow River and the mountains, hoping to wrest control of another country's capital. But if Zhao rallies its forces from within, while the other rulers attack from without, Qin's army is certain to be defeated. This will not do!"

The king of Qin personally ordered Lord Wuan to accept command, but when this had no effect, he sent the marquis of Ying to make a polite request. But Lord Wuan persisted in his refusal, unwilling to undertake the mission, and finally pleaded illness. The king of Qin then ordered Wang He to replace Wang Ling as commander.

The Qin forces besieged the city for eight or nine months but could not capture it. Meanwhile Chu ordered Lord Chunshen and the Wei ducal son Wuji to lead a force of several tens of thousands of men and attack the Qin army, which suffered large losses.

Lord Wuan said, "Qin would not heed my counsel, and now see what happens!"

When the king of Qin heard of the remark, he was furious and tried to force Lord Wuan to return to active duty, but Lord Wuan insisted that his illness was too grave. He likewise refused when the marquis of Ying repeated his earlier request. Lord Wuan was forthwith stripped of all honours, reduced to the rank of a common soldier, and ordered into exile in Yinmi, but being ill, he could not undertake the trip.

By the time the third month arrived, the other feudal rulers were pressing their attack on the Qin army, which was several times forced to fall back. Messengers arrived daily in the Qin capital. The king of Qin sent men to expel Bai Qi from the capital, saying he was not permitted to remain in Xianyang any longer. He finally set out, leaving by the west gate of Xianyang and proceeding ten *li* until he reached Duyou.

King Zhaoxiang, after deliberating with the marquis of Ying and the other officials, said, "When Bai Qi set off for exile, he was still disgruntled and unsubmitive in attitude and offered complaints!" The king thereupon dispatched a messenger to present Bai Qi with a sword and ask him to make his own settlement of the matter.

As Bai Qi drew the sword and prepared to cut his throat, he said, "What crime have I committed against Heaven that I should come to this?" Then after some time he said, "In fact I deserve to die. In the battle of Changping, when several hundred thousand soldiers of Zhao surrendered to me, I tricked them and had them buried alive. That is cause enough why I should die!" Then he committed suicide.

Lord Wuan's death took place in the eleventh month of the fiftieth year of King Zhaoxiang of Qin (257 BC). Since he died without having committed any crime, the people of Qin pitied him and all the hamlets and towns offered sacrifices to his spirit.

WANG JIAN

Wang Jian was a native of East Hamlet in Pinyang in Qin. From his youth he was fond of military affairs and served the First Emperor of Qin.

In the eleventh year of the First Emperor's reign (236 BC), Wang Jian led an attack on the Zhao region of Eyu and conquered it, capturing nine cities.

In the eighteenth year (229 BC) he led an attack on Zhao, and after a year or more succeeded in conquering it. The king of Zhao surrendered, and the entire territory of Zhao was taken over by Qin and made into provinces.

The following year the state of Yan sent Jing Ke in an attempt to assassinate the Qin ruler. The king of Qin ordered Wang Jian to attack Yan. King Xi of Yan fled to Liaodong and Wang Jian gained control of the Yan capital of Ji before withdrawing.

Qin ordered Wang Jian's son Wang Ben to make a surprise attack on Jing.¹⁴⁴ After defeating Jing's forces, he returned and attacked Wei. The king of Wei surrendered and Qin took over the territory of Wei.

By this time the First Emperor of Qin had wiped out Hann, Wei, Zhao, the Three Jin, had put the king of Yan to rout, and had several times defeated the Jing armies. Li Xin, a Qin general noted for his youth and daring, had in the past led a force of several thousand men in pursuit of Dan, the heir apparent of the state of Yan, advancing as far as the Yan River and defeating and capturing Dan. The First Emperor, admiring Li Xin's worth and bravery, questioned him, saying, "I want to attack and take control of Jing. In your estimation, how many men will it take to do so?"

"Not more than 200,000," replied Li Xin.

The First Emperor then questioned Wang Jian, and Wang Jian said, "You cannot do with less than 600,000 men."

"You are getting old, General Wang!" said the emperor. "Why so timorous? General Li, now, has his youth and daring to rely on! I'll go by his word."

In the end he ordered Li Xin and Meng Tian to lead a force of 200,000 men south in an expedition against Jing. Since Wang Jian's advice had not been heeded, he asked to be excused from service on grounds of illness and retired to Pinyang to spend his old age.

Li Xin attacked Pingyu, Meng Tian attacked Qin, and they dealt a crushing blow to the Jing army. Li Xin also attacked the cities of Yan and Ying and captured them. Then he led his forces back west and joined Meng Tian at Chengfu. The men of Jing followed him, pushing ahead for three days and three nights without once stopping to rest, and inflicted a major defeat on Li Xin's army, breaking through his fortifications at two points and killing seven commandants. The Qin army fled in confusion.

When the First Emperor heard of this he was enraged. He galloped in person to Pinyang and apologized to Wang Jian, saying, "I failed to listen to your counsel, General, and as a result Li Xin has brought disgrace on the

Qin army. Now word has come that the Jing forces are advancing day by day. Though I know you are ill, I trust you will not be heartless enough to abandon me at a time like this!"

But Wang Jian declined, saying, "I am old and infirm, hardly in my right senses any more. Your Majesty has only to select some other commander worthy of the post."

The emperor renewed his apologies, saying, "Please, General. No more talk of that kind."

Wang Jian said, "If Your Majesty is determined to employ me, then I must have 600,000 men — no less will do!"

"Whatever you advise, General," said the emperor.

Wang Jian was accordingly put in command of a force of 600,000 men, and the emperor saw him off as far as the Ba River. As they were going on their way, Wang Jian requested the emperor for the gift of a great many fine fields and houses, gardens and ponds.

The emperor said, "Just go on your way, General. Why all this worry over poverty?"

Wang Jian replied, "Though many of Your Majesty's generals have achieved merit, they have never succeeded in being enfeoffed as marquises. So while I enjoy Your Majesty's favour, I want to use the opportunity to ask for fields and ponds for the sake of my sons and grandsons, that is all."

The emperor roared with laughter.

By the time Wang Jian reached the Hangu Pass, he had five times sent messengers back to the capital to repeat his request for suitable farm lands. Someone said to him, "Aren't you being a bit too persistent in the way you beg for rewards, General?"

"Not at all," replied Wang Jian. "The king of Qin is suspicious and puts no trust in others. Now he has emptied the state of Qin of all its armed men and turned them over to my sole authority. If I do not ask for a lot of fields and houses for the sake of my sons and grandsons and seem to be thinking only of my own interests, then I will just give him occasion to doubt my motives."

Thus Wang Jian in the end replaced Li Xin as leader of the attack on Jing. When the king of Jing heard that Wang Jian was on his way with a greatly augmented army, he called out all the soldiers in the country to repel the Qin forces.

Arriving in Jing, Wang Jian proceeded to build strong fortifications and stay within them, unwilling to engage in battle. The Jing soldiers repeatedly challenged him to combat, but he would never emerge from his defences. Each day Wang Jian rested his soldiers, allowing them to bathe and wash their hair, and kept them content with good food and drink. He mingled with his men and ate the same food they did. After some time, he sent someone to ask what amusements they indulged in. "Stone-throwing and high-jumping" was the answer. With that Wang Jian said, "The men are now in shape for use."

Though Jing had repeatedly challenged the Qin troops to battle, they refused to come forth, and so the Jing troops began to withdraw and go back east. Wang Jian then called out all his men and went in pursuit, ordering the young men to lead the attack, and dealt a crushing blow to the Jing army. Advancing as far as the area south of the Qi River, he killed the Jing general Xiang Yan, and with this the Jing forces fled in defeat. Taking full advantage of the victory, the Qin army seized control of one after another of Jing's cities and towns, and a year or so later captured the Jing king Fuchu. Thus Wang Jian put down all resistance in the region of Jing, which was made into provinces and districts, and then proceeded south to subjugate the rulers of the Hundred Yue tribes. Meanwhile Wang Jian's son Wang Ben joined with Li Xin in defeating and gaining control of the states of Yan and Qi. By the twenty-sixth year of his reign (221 BC), the First Emperor had united the entire realm under his rule. The Wang and Meng families achieved the greatest merit in this process, and their fame has been handed down to later ages.

By the time of the Second Emperor, both Wang Jian and his son Wang Ben were dead, and the Meng family had been wiped out. When Chen She began his revolt against the Qin, the Qin dispatched Wang Li, the grandson of Wang Jian, to attack and besiege the king of Zhao and Zhang Er in the city of Julu. Someone said, "Wang Li is a renowned general of Qin. Now if he leads the powerful forces of Qin in an attack on the newly re-established state of Zhao, he is certain to crush it!"

"Not so!" said one of the man's retainers. "Any family that acts as generals for three generations will surely meet with defeat. Why? Because the earlier members inevitably will have attacked and killed many people, and those who come after will suffer the bad luck that results. And Wang Li's family have been generals now for three generations!"

Not long after, Xiang Yu came to Zhao's rescue, launching an attack on the Qin army. As the retainer had predicted, Wang Li was taken prisoner and his army surrendered to the feudal leaders.

The Grand Historian remarks: The proverb says, "There's something short about a foot, and something long about an inch". Bai Qi gauged the enemy, adapted to the shifts of circumstance, and came up with an inexhaustible supply of strategies, until his name made the whole world tremble. Yet he could not save himself from his troubles with the marquis of Ying.

As a general of the Qin, Wang Jian brought the Six States under Qin rule. At that time he was a veteran military leader and enjoyed the esteem of the First Emperor. Yet he was unable to aid the Qin in establishing virtue so as to make firm the roots of its power, but instead sought only to accommodate himself to the situation, to do what was acceptable, and so to live out his days. Was it not right, then, that his grandson Wang Li fell captive to Xiang Yu? Both men had "something short" about them.

SHI JI 79: THE BIOGRAPHIES OF FAN JU AND CAI ZE¹⁴⁵

Able to endure the abuse of Wei Qi, entrusted with authority in powerful Qin, these two men promoted persons of worth and relinquished their posts to them. Thus I made “The Biographies of Fan Ju and Cai Ze”.

Fan Ju, whose polite name was Shu, was a man of the state of Wei. As an itinerant adviser to the feudal rulers, he hoped to obtain office under the king of Wei. But because his family was poor and he was lacking in resources, he first took service under the Wei palace counsellor Xu Jia.

Xu Jia was sent by King Zhao of Wei on a mission to the state of Qi. Fan Ju accompanied him, and they remained in Qi several months without being able to receive a reply on the matter they had come for. Meanwhile King Xiang of Qi, hearing of Fan Ju’s reputation for eloquence, sent someone to present him with ten catties of gold and gifts of beef and wine. Fan Ju declined the presents, not venturing to accept them.

Xu Jia, hearing of the incident, was extremely angry, for he supposed that Fan Ju must have given Qi information on the secrets of the state of Wei in order to receive such gifts. He ordered Fan Ju to accept the beef and wine but to return the money.

After they returned to Wei, Xu Jia, still angry with Fan Ju, reported the matter to the prime minister of Wei. The prime minister, Wei Qi, was a son of the ruling family of Wei. He too was incensed and ordered his stewards to beat Fan Ju. Fan Ju, his ribs broken and teeth knocked out, pretended to be dead, whereupon he was wrapped in a reed mat and dumped in the privy. There the guests who were drinking with the prime minister at the time, drunk, took turns pissing on him, deliberately heaping insult on him as a warning to others never to blurt out secrets.

Still wrapped in the reed mat, Fan Ju said to the man guarding him, “If you can get me out of this, I’ll see that you are generously rewarded.” The guard accordingly asked to be allowed to dispose of the body in the mat. Wei Qi, drunk at the time, gave permission, and thus Fan Ju was able to escape. Later Wei Qi regretted his action and sent people to look for Fan Ju. But a man of Wei named Zheng Anping, hearing what had happened, spirited Fan Ju into hiding and kept him concealed, changing Fan Ju’s name to Zhang Lu.

At this time King Zhaoxiang of Qin had sent his master of guests Wang Ji on a mission to Wei. Zheng Anping arranged by some subterfuge to be among the servants waiting on Wang Ji. Wang Ji asked, “Does Wei have any

worthy men that I could take back west with me?"

Zheng Anping replied, "In my neighbourhood there is a Master Zhang Lu who would like to meet you and discuss the affairs of the world. But he has made certain enemies and does not dare be seen abroad in the daytime."

"Then bring him with you in the evening," said Wang Ji. Zheng Anping accordingly went at night with Zhang Lu to see Wang Ji. They had not concluded their discussion when Wang Ji, realizing that Fan Ju was a man of worth, said, "Please be kind enough to wait for me south of the third post station." Having privately promised to do so, Fan Ju left. Wang Ji then took leave of Wei and, picking Fan Ju up along the way and putting him in his carriage, returned to Qin.

They had reached Hu in Qin when they saw a carriage and outriders approaching from the west. Fan Ju said, "Who is this coming?"

Wang Ji replied, "It is the marquis of Rang, the prime minister of Qin, on his way to the eastern districts."

Fan Ju said, "I have heard that the marquis of Rang exercises sole authority in Qin and hates to have visitors from the other feudal rulers entering the state. He may well make trouble for me — I had better hide in the carriage."

Before long the marquis of Rang arrived and, thanking Wang Ji for his mission, stopped the carriage to chat "Is anything new happening east of the pass?" he asked.

"Nothing new," said Wang Jr.

"And are you not perhaps bringing back a visitor with you from one of the feudal lords? They're no good, you know! They just cause confusion in other people's states!"

"I wouldn't dare to," said Wang Ji. The two men then parted.

Fan Ju said, "I had heard that the marquis of Rang was a wise man, but in fact he is rather neglectful, isn't he? Just now, he suspected there was someone in your carriage, but he forgot to have it searched." Then Fan Ju stepped down from the carriage and set off at a run, saying, "He's bound to have second thoughts!"

The marquis had gone only ten *li* or more when, as Fan Ju predicted, he sent one of his outriders back to search the carriage. Finding no one, he let the matter end there. So Wang Ji and Fan Ju entered the capital city of Xianyang.

When Wang Ji had finished reporting on his mission, he took the opportunity to say to the Qin ruler, "In Wei there is a Master Zhang Lu who is a man of great eloquence. He said to me, 'The king of Qin's situation is as precarious as a stack of eggs. If he has me to advise him, he will be all right, but it is not something I can convey to him by letter!' So I brought the man along."

The king of Qin was not convinced by this and merely ordered that Fan Ju be provided with lodging and simple fare. Fan Ju spent a year or more waiting for further instructions.

At this time King Zhaoxiang was already in his thirty-sixth year of rule (271 BC). In the south his forces had captured the Chu cities of Yan and Ying, and King Huai of Chu had died in confinement in Qin. In the east Qin had inflicted a defeat on Qi, and though King Min of Qi had for a time taken the title of emperor, he later abandoned it. Qin had also several times made trouble for the Three Jin, the states of Hann, Wei, and Zhao. But the king was weary of “men of great eloquence” and put no faith in them.

The marquis of Rang and Lord Huayang were younger brothers of King Zhaoxiang’s mother, Queen Dowager Xuan, while Lord Jingyang and Lord Gaoling were both younger brothers of King Zhaoxiang by the same mother. The marquis of Rang served as prime minister, while the other three men took turns serving as military leader. All were enfeoffed with cities, and because of their kinship with the Queen Dowager, their private wealth exceeded that of the ruling house. Later, when the marquis of Rang became military leader of Qin, he hoped to cross through the states of Hann and Wei and attack the Qi city of Gangshou so that he could broaden his fief in Tao.

At this point Fan Ju submitted a letter to the king which said: “I have heard that when an enlightened ruler conducts his government, persons of merit never fail to receive reward, and persons of ability never fail to receive office. Those whose achievements are great receive generous emolument, those whose merits are many are awarded noble rank, and those who can govern the masses are given high office. Hence persons who lack ability do not dare accept assignment, while those who have ability are not allowed to remain in the shade. Therefore if you think my words worth heeding, please permit me to put them into practice and so bring increase and benefit to your regime. And if you think them not worth heeding, then it is pointless to detain me here any longer.

“The saying has it that the mediocre ruler rewards those he loves and punishes those he hates. But the enlightened ruler is not like this. His rewards go only to those with merit, and his penalties go only to those judged guilty of crime. Now although I may not even be worth the trouble it takes to haul me before the executioner’s block or subject me to the blow of the axe, I would hardly venture to take up Your Majesty’s time with mere nonsense. And although you might dismiss me as a worthless person, one lightly to be scorned, you would surely think it a grave matter to suspect the one who recommended me of playing false with you, would you not?¹⁴⁶

“I have heard that Zhou has its Zhiai, Song its Jielu, Liang its Xuanli, and Chu its Hepu. These four precious jewels were produced by the earth but at first were overlooked even by expert craftsmen, though they have since become objects renowned throughout the world. Is it not possible, then, that among the persons cast aside by the sage ruler there are those who can enrich the state?

“I have heard that if one is looking for someone who can enrich his family, he searches throughout the state. But if he is looking for one who can

enrich the state, he searches among all the feudal rulers in the empire. So when there is an enlightened ruler in the world, the other feudal rulers cannot monopolize those who are good at enriching. Why? Because the enlightened ruler grabs them for his own embellishment.

"Just as a good physician understands what will bring life or death to his patient, so a sage ruler perceives what will bring success or failure to his undertakings. If it brings benefit, he carries it out, if it brings harm, he discards it, and if he is in doubt, he tries a little of it. Even if the sages Shun or Yu came back to life today, they could find no fault with this.

"Words that are truly pertinent I would not venture to entrust to a letter. And those that are shallow would not be worth the heeding. I wonder if it is because I am stupid that I have failed to stir Your Majesty's heart? Or could it be because the person who recommended me is unworthy that I am not employed? If it is neither, then may I beg to be granted a moment when Your Majesty is not engaged in outings and excursions so I may gaze afar on your countenance? If at that time I utter one word that is ineffectual, may I be condemned to the axe!"

King Zhaoxiang was very pleased with the letter and, apologizing to Wang Ji, sent a relay carriage to fetch Fan Ju. So Fan Ju was granted an interview at the detached palace. Pretending not to know his way around, Fan Ju wandered into the passageway leading to the inner palace. When the king arrived, the eunuchs in charge angrily pushed him out of the passageway, saying, "The King is coming!"

Fan Ju, still dissembling, said, "Qin has a king? I thought Qin just had the Queen Dowager and the marquis of Rang!" He hoped in this way to rouse the ire of King Zhaoxiang.

When King Zhaoxiang arrived and heard the eunuchs wrangling with Fan Ju, he led Fan Ju into the hall and, apologizing, said, "I should have received your instruction in person long ago, but I happened to be very much pressed by the Yiqu affair and every morning and evening was obliged to consult with the Queen Dowager.¹⁴⁷ Now, however, the Yiqu affair is settled and so I am able to receive your instruction. I fear you will find me pitifully ignorant, but I will do my best to receive you as a guest."

Fan Ju declared himself unworthy of such politeness, while among the various officials who were present at the interview, there were none who did not look on with awe and amazement.

The king of Qin then dismissed all those around him, until there was no one left in the hall. Kneeling politely on his mat, he said, "Now, sir, may I ask what instruction you have to give me?"

"Yes, of course," said Fan Ju.

After a while the king, once more kneeling politely on his mat, said, "May I ask, sir, what instruction you have to give me?"

"Yes, of course," said Fan Ju.

This happened three times when the king of Qin, still kneeling, said,

"Then, sir, is it not your intention to favour me with any instruction?"

"Oh, no," said Fan Ju. "But I have heard that long ago, when Lü Shang met with King Wen of the Zhou dynasty, he was nothing more than a fisherman angling on the banks of the Wei. At that time their association was a very shallow one. Later, after Lü Shang had spoken to the king, the latter appointed him grand tutor and returned with him in the same carriage to the capital, because their discussions had become more profound. Therefore King Wen was able to reap benefit through Lü Shang and in the end to become ruler of all under heaven. If King Wen had continued to treat Lü Shang in a shallow manner and had not held profound discussions with him, then Zhou would never have enjoyed the position of Son of Heaven, and Wen and Wu would never have brought to completion their royal undertaking.

"Now I am a traveller from another state and my association with Your Majesty is a shallow one. And yet the matters I wish to speak about all pertain to reforms in the ruler's conduct of affairs and touch upon his own flesh and blood. I would like to speak in utter frankness and loyalty, stupid though I may be, but I do not know yet how Your Majesty will respond. Therefore when you questioned me three times, I did not venture to reply.

"It is not fear that causes me to hesitate. I am quite aware that if I speak out before you today, I may well face execution tomorrow, and yet I dare not remain silent. For if Your Majesty is truly willing to put my words into action, then mere death would be no grief to me, exile would be no sorrow, and I might paint my body with lacquer to become a leper, or loose my hair like a madman, without any sense of shame.¹⁴⁸

"Sages such as the Five Emperors have died, as have men of benevolence such as the kings of the Three Dynasties, worthy men such as the Five Hegemons, strong men such as Wu Huo and Ren Bi, and brave men such as Cheng Jing, Meng Ben, Prince Qingji, or Xia Yu. Death is a thing no human being can escape. But if, while facing the inescapable, I can at the same time be of some assistance to Qin, that would fulfil my most fervent desire. Then what grief would it be to me?

"Wu Zixu hid himself in a sack and so escaped through the Zhao Pass, travelling by night, hiding by day, till he reached the Ling River, when he had not a morsel to put in his mouth.¹⁴⁹ He crawled on his knees, inched over the ground, bowed his head, bared his arms, drummed on his stomach, and blew a flute, begging in the marketplace of Wu, yet in the end he raised Wu to greatness and made its ruler, King Helü, a hegemon. If I could offer all my counsels as did Wu Zixu, then although I might be condemned to prison for the remainder of my days and never again admitted into your presence, as long as my advice was put into practice, what sorrow would it be to me?

"Ji Zi and Jieyu painted their bodies with lacquer to induce leprous sores and loosed their hair to feign madness, though it proved no benefit to their

rulers.¹⁵⁰ But if by imitating Ji Zi's actions I could assist a ruler whom I deem worthy, that would be a great honour for me. How could it be a source of shame? My only fear would be that after I am gone the men of the world, observing that I exerted the utmost loyalty and still met with death, would seal their lips, stay their feet, and never again be willing to journey to Qin.

"If you should be intimidated by the sternness of the Queen Dowager and misled by the machinations of treacherous ministers, dwelling deep within the confines of the palace, forever shielded by your tutors, remaining all your life misled and confused and never waking to the treachery, then at worst you might bring destruction to the entire ruling family, and at best you would face danger to your person. This is the only thing that I fear. As to distress or insult to myself, or the threat of death or exile, these I would not venture to fear. If by dying I can bring order to Qin, then I would be of greater worth dead than alive."

Still kneeling, the king of Qin said, "What is this you are saying, sir! The state of Qin is situated far away here on the border, and I am ignorant and unworthy. But since you have been kind enough to come all this distance, it must be that Heaven is troubling you for my sake, tasking you with the preservation of the ancestral temples of Qin's former kings. If I may receive instruction from you, it will mean that Heaven smiles on the former kings and has not cast me aside. Why then do you speak as you do, sir?"

"No matter how great or small the matter, whether it touches upon the Queen Dowager or the great officials, I beg you to give me all the instruction you have and never doubt my motives!"

Fan Ju bowed in acknowledgment and the king of Qin returned the bow. Fan Ju said, "Your Majesty's state is well protected on all four sides. To the north is Sweet Springs and Valley Mouth, to the south the long-stretching Jing and Wei rivers, to the right Long and Shu, to the left the Hangu Pass and Shang Slope.¹⁵¹ With a striking force of 1,000,000 men and 1,000 war chariots, if it is profitable to do so, you may venture forth to attack; if it is not, you may guard your stronghold. It is the kind of territory fit for a ruler. Your people are cowardly in private vendettas but brave in public warfare — the kind of subjects fit for a ruler. Thus you possess both these assets.

"If Qin were to utilize the bravery of its soldiers and the plentitude of its chariots and riders to impose its will on the other feudal lords, it would be like loosing the swift hound Hanlu to strike down a lame rabbit! Qin could advance to the position of a hegemon king!

"But none of its ministers are worthy of their posts, and so for fifteen years now the passes have been closed and Qin has not ventured to show its troops east of the mountains. This is because the marquis of Rang has been disloyal in plotting affairs for Qin, and Your Majesty's plans have been in some respects amiss."

The king of Qin, kneeling, said, "I want to hear where my plans have been amiss!"

But many of the king's attendants were eavesdropping on the conversation, and Fan Ju was afraid to speak of internal matters. Therefore he spoke of foreign affairs in order to observe what the king of Qin's response would be.

Moving closer, Fan Ju said, "The marquis of Rang hopes to cross through Hann and Wei and attack the city of Gangshou in Qi, but this is not good planning. If he sets out with too small a force, he will not have strength enough to inflict damage on Qi. And if he calls out too large a one, he will do harm to Qin. I believe Your Majesty's plan is to send out a small force and then have Hann and Wei call out all their troops, but that is hardly fair to them. And just because Qi, an allied state, chooses to be unfriendly, can you cross through someone else's state to attack it? This is bad planning indeed!

"In the past King Min of Qi marched south to attack Chu, defeating its army, killing its leader, and expanding Qi's territory by 1,000 *li*. But Qi in the end could not retain possession of an inch of that land, not because it did not want the land, but because the circumstances would not permit it. For when the other feudal rulers saw that Qi's troops were exhausted and that ruler and subject were at loggerheads, they called out their own men and attacked Qi, inflicting a defeat. Its officers suffered shame, its soldiers bowed down, and all blamed the king, saying, 'Who made this plan?' The king said, 'Tian Wen made it!' and the great ministers thereupon revolted and drove Tian Wen from the state. Thus Qi's great defeat came about because in attacking Chu it played into the hands of Hann and Wei. This is what is called lending arms to bandits and providing rations to thieves.

"Your Majesty would do best to cultivate friendly relations with distant states and attack those close by. Then if you win an inch of land, it will be *your* inch, and if you win a foot, it will be *your* foot. To do otherwise and attack those who are far away is surely an error!

"In past times the state of Zhongshan measured 500 *li* square. But Zhao all by itself swallowed it up, winning merit, gaining fame, and annexing all the benefits to itself so that no one in the world could harm it.

"Now the states of Hann and Wei occupy the centre of the realm, the pivot of the world. If Your Majesty wishes to become a hegemon, you must ally yourself with the centre of the realm, the pivot of the world, and thereby overawe Chu and Zhao. If Chu is strong, join up with Zhao; if Zhao is strong, join up with Chu. And if you can join with both Chu and Zhao, then Qi will be terrified, and if Qi is terrified, it will come with humble words and rich gifts to court favour with Qin. With Qi on your side, you can make Hann and Wei your captives."

The king said, "Actually, I have wanted for some time to become friendly with Wei. But Wei is a country of many shifts and I have been unable to win its friendship. May I ask how I should go about winning over Wei?"

Fan Ju replied, "Court it with humble phrases and rich gifts. If that does not work, bribe it with territorial concessions. And if that does not work, call out your troops and attack it!"

The king said, "I will honour your instructions." He appointed Fan Ju a "guest minister" for the planning of military affairs. Heeding Fan Ju's advice, he dispatched the fifth rank counsellor Wan to attack Wei, where he captured Huai. Two years later he captured Xingqiu.

The guest minister Fan Ju spoke once more with King Zhaoxiang, saying: "The territories of Qin and Hann are interwoven like the strands of an embroidery. And Hann's existence is to Qin like a wood-borer to a tree, or a disease of the heart or belly to a man. As long as there is no drastic upset in the world, then it is all right. But if there should be some drastic upset, then no state will cause greater worry to Qin than Hann! Your Majesty would do best to take over Hann."

King Zhaoxiang said, "I would like very much to take over Hann. But suppose Hann will not listen — what will I do then?"

Fan Ju replied, "Why would Hann fail to listen? If you send troops to attack Xingyang,¹⁵² then the road to Gong and Chenggao will be cut off. And in the north this will block the road to the Taihang Mountains, so the army stationed in Shangdang cannot come south. Thus by sending your troops out in a single attack on Xingyang, you can cut the state of Hann into three pieces. If Hann sees that it is faced with certain destruction, why would it fail to listen? And If Hann listens to you, then you can lay plans to become a hegemon."

"Very good," said the king, and he made preparations to send an envoy to Hann.

Fan Ju day by day enjoyed greater intimacy with the king. After his suggestions had been heeded for several years, he requested a moment of the king's leisure and spoke to him as follows: "When I was living east of the mountains I heard about Tian Wen in Qi, but I never heard that Qi had a king. I heard about the Queen Dowager, the marquis of Rang, and lords Huayang, Gaoling, and Jingyang in Qin, but I never heard that Qin had a king.

"The one who wields power in the state is called the king, the one who can dole out benefit or injury is called the king, the one who has the authority to kill or let live is called the king. Yet now the Queen Dowager wields authority without glancing in your direction, the marquis of Rang dispatches envoys without reporting to you on the matter, lords Huayang and Jingyang hand out penalties without compunction, and Lord Gaoling promotes and demotes men without asking leave. With four persons of such eminence, I have never heard of the state escaping peril. Where four persons of such eminence preside, one may say there is no king. How can the king's authority fail to be subverted? How can he hope to issue his own orders?

"I have heard that one who is skilled at governing a country will make certain that his authority is firmly established within the state, and that his word is respected abroad. Yet the envoys of the marquis of Rang have

usurped the king's authority, deciding on relations with the other feudal rulers, handing out fiefs to the world, attacking states, punishing opponents, and no one dares disobey them. If there is victory in battle, if the attacks succeed, then the benefits go to the marquis of Rang's fief in Tao and the losses are borne by the other feudal lords. And if the battles end in defeat, then it is the common people of Qin who are moved to anger, and it is Qin's altars of the soil and grain that will suffer misfortune in the end.

"The *Book of Odes* says:

If the fruits of the tree are too many
they will break the branches,
and if they break the branches,
they will injure the tree's heart.
Enlarging the other cities
endangers the capital,
heaping too great honour on a subject
demeans the ruler.^{[153](#)}

"When Cui Shu and Nao Chi wielded power in Qi, they shot the king in the thigh, or pulled out the king's tendons and hung him from the beam of the ancestral temple so that in one night he died. When Li Dui wielded power in Zhao, he imprisoned the ruler Zhufu at Sand Hill and after 100 days he died of starvation.^{[154](#)} Now I hear that in Qin the Queen Dowager and the marquis of Rang manage affairs, with lords Gaoling, Huayang, and Jingyang assisting them, and it is as though the king of Qin did not exist. The situation is like that under Nao Chi or Li Dui.

"The reason the rulers of the Three Dynasties lost their states was that they delegated power to others, while they amused themselves drinking or raced about hunting and shooting, paying no heed to government affairs. Those to whom they delegated power envied worth and ability, blocking the advancement of those below them, deceiving those above them, and thereby promoting their private interests and failing to consider the interests of the rulers. And the rulers never woke up to this, so that eventually they lost their states.

"Now among the holders of noble rank and the higher level ministers, as well as among Your Majesty's personal attendants, there are none who are not the marquis of Rang's men. When I see Your Majesty standing all alone in court, I cannot help fearing that, after your years of life are ended, those who rule the state of Qin will not be Your Majesty's descendants!"

King Zhaoxiang, thoroughly alarmed at these words, said, "You are quite right!" He then demoted the Queen Dowager and obliged the marquis of Rang and lords Gaoling, Huayang, and Jingyang to leave the capital and go beyond the Pass. He honoured Fan Ju with the post of prime minister, relieving the marquis of Rang of the seals of office and sending him to his fief in Tao. The government was ordered to supply wagons and oxen for the

move, and a train of over 1,000 vehicles arrived at the Pass. The officials at the Pass, examining the contents, found that the precious vessels and other rare and unusual objects exceeded those in the possession of the royal house.

Qin enfeoffed Fan Ju in the region of Ying, giving him the title of marquis of Ying. The time was the forty-first year of King Zhaoxiang's reign (266 BC).

Fan Ju thus became prime minister of Qin, but Qin knew him by the name Zhang Lu. The people of Wei, his native state, unaware of his whereabouts, supposed that Fan Ju had died long ago.

When Wei heard that Qin was about to march east to attack Hann and Wei, it sent Fan Ju's old employer Xu Jia as an envoy to Qin. Fan Ju, learning of this, set off incognito, wearing shabby clothes and proceeding alone and on foot to the government lodge to see Xu Jia. When Xu Jia saw him, he was greatly startled and exclaimed, "Fan Shu! Are you alive and well?"¹⁵⁵

"I am," said Fan Ju.

"And have you come to Qin to offer advice?" asked Xu Jia with a laugh.

"No," said Fan Ju. "But some time ago I got into trouble with the prime minister of Wei and so I fled here to Qin. How would I dare offer advice?"

"And what are you doing now?" asked Xu Jia.

"I am working as a hired man for someone," said Fan Ju.

Xu Jia, feeling sorry for Fan Ju, invited him to stay a while and have something to eat and drink. "How hard up you look, Fan Shu!" he said, and taking one of his robes of coarse silk, he gave it to Fan Ju as a present.

Then he began to question Fan Ju, saying, "Lord Zhang, the prime minister of Qin — do you know him? I hear he enjoys great favour with the king and all matters of every kind are decided by him. The success or failure of this mission I am on depends entirely on this man. You wouldn't happen to know anyone who has access to him, would you, my boy?"

Fan Ju said, "My employer knows him very well, and even I am allowed into his presence on occasion. Let me arrange an interview with Lord Zhang for you."

"Ah, but my horse is ailing and the axle of my carriage is broken," said Xu Jia. "And if I don't have a large carriage and a team of four, I would never dare pay a call."

Fan Ju said, "I will ask my employer if I can borrow a large carriage and team of four for you."

Fan Ju returned to his quarters, called out a large carriage and team of four and, driving it himself, fetched Xu Jia and drove with him to the office of the Qin prime minister. As they approached the office, the people in the office, recognizing the carriage from a distance, all disappeared from sight, which struck Xu Jia as peculiar.

When they reached the gate of the prime minister's residence, Fan Ju said, "Wait for me. I'll go in ahead and inform the prime minister of your

arrival."

Xu Jia waited by the gate, but after sitting in the carriage for some time, he said to the gatekeeper, "I wonder why Fan Shu doesn't come out?"

"There's no Fan Shu here," said the gatekeeper.

"The person who came with me in the carriage a while ago and went inside!" said Xu Jia.

"That was Lord Zhang, our prime minister," said the gatekeeper.

Xu Jia realized to his astonishment that he had been tricked. Getting down on his knees and baring his arms, he asked the gatekeeper to convey his confession of guilt.

Fan Ju, surrounded by curtains and with a host of attendants, received him in audience. Xu Jia bowed his head and acknowledged that he was deserving of death. "I had not imagined you could have risen so high above the blue clouds!" he said. "I will never again venture to read the world's books or comment on the world's affairs. I have committed a crime for which I deserve to be boiled alive, though with your permission I may perhaps be allowed to take myself far off to the lands of the Hu and Mo barbarians. My life and death are in your hands."

Fan Ju said, "How many are your crimes?"

"Though I plucked out the hairs of my beard to tally them all, they would not suffice!"

"No," said Fan Ju. "Your crimes are only three. Long ago, in the time of King Zhao of Chu, Shen Baoxu saved Chu by driving back the armies of Wu. The king of Chu wanted to enfeoff him with 5,000 households in Chu, but he refused to accept, saying that he had done what he did simply because his ancestral graves were in Chu. Now the graves of my ancestors are in Wei, and yet in the past you supposed that I had betrayed Wei to the state of Qi and spoke ill of me to Wei Qi. That was your first crime.

"When Wei Qi subjected me to shame by putting me in the privy, you did not stop him. That was your second crime. And when the drunkards took turns pissing on me, you could stand to see it happen — your third crime!

"Nevertheless, you will not be subjected to the death penalty, because of the kindness expressed by a coarse silk garment and the concern showed for an old friend. Because of those I am setting you free."

Thus Xu Jia's apologies were accepted and Fan Ju went in to speak with King Zhaoxiang, who decided to dismiss Xu Jia and send him back to Wei.

When Xu Jia came to take leave of Fan Ju, the latter prepared a great banquet, inviting all the envoys of the other feudal rulers and sitting with them in the upper part of the hall, where vast quantities of food and drink were set out. But he seated Xu Jia in the lower part of the hall, had chopped hay and beans placed before him, and stationed two tattooed criminals on either side to force him to eat in horse fashion. Then he berated him, saying, "Tell the king of Wei this for me — he had better bring me the head of Wei Qi at once! If not, I'll massacre every person in the Wei capital of Daliang!"

When Xu Jia returned to Wei, he reported this to Wei Qi. Wei Qi fled in

terror to Zhao, hiding at the home of Lord Pingyuan, a prince of Zhao.

After Fan Ju had become prime minister, Wang Ji, the master of guests who first introduced him to the king, said to Fan Ju, "There are three things you can never know, and three things you can do nothing about once it is too late. When the ruler may pass away — that's the first thing you can never know. When you yourself may suddenly take leave of life — that's the second thing you can never know. And when I may suddenly end tumbled in a ditch — that's the third thing you can never know. Once the ruler has passed away, then it will be too late to regret what you might have done for me. Once you yourself have suddenly taken leave, then it will be too late for such regrets. And once I have suddenly ended tumbled in a ditch, then it will be too late!"

Fan Ju, troubled by these words, went in and spoke to the king, saying, "If it had not been for Wang Ji's loyalty to the state, no one would have allowed me to enter the Hangu Pass. And if it had not been for Your Majesty's sageliness and worth, no one would have thought of elevating me to high office. Now I have advanced to the post of prime minister and am ranked among the marquises, yet Wang Ji's office is still that of master of guests. This is surely not what he expected when he first allowed me to enter Qin!"

King Zhaoxiang then summoned Wang Ji and honoured him with the post of governor of Hedong, not requiring him to submit government reports for the first three years. At Fan Ju's recommendation, he also appointed Zheng Anping, Fan Ju's old benefactor in Wei, to the position of general.

Fan Ju used his private wealth to repay all those who had helped him when he was starving and in distress. Persons who aided him with no more than a single meal invariably received their reward, but those who had so much as glared at him angrily were likewise paid back in full.

When Fan Ju had been prime minister of Qin for two years, in the forty-second year of King Zhaoxiang's reign (265 BC), Qin advanced east, attacking the Hann cities of Shaoqu and Gaoping and capturing them. King Zhaoxiang of Qin, hearing that Fan Ju's old enemy Wei Qi was at the home of Lord Pingyuan, wanted to help Fan Ju carry out his revenge. So, feigning a friendly tone, he wrote a letter to Lord Pingyuan, saying, "I have heard of your high ideals and would like very much to associate with you on terms of simple friendship. If you will be good enough to visit me, I wish to spend ten days drinking with you."

Lord Pingyuan was fearful of Qin and, accepting the letter at face value, journeyed to Qin to visit King Zhaoxiang. After he and King Zhaoxiang had drunk together for several days, the king said, "Long ago, when King Wen of the Zhou acquired the services of Lü Shang, he addressed him as Grand Duke, and when Duke Huan of Qi acquired Guan Zhong, he addressed him as Uncle. Now Lord Fan is in like manner an Uncle to me. Lord Fan's enemy is staying at your home. I would like you to send someone to go and fetch his head. If not, I will not permit you to leave the Pass."

Long Pingyuan replied, "When one is eminent he cultivates friends

because he may some day be humble, and when he is rich he cultivates friends because he may some day be poor. Wei Qi is a friend of mine. Even if he were at my home, I would never hand him over. And in fact he is no longer there.”

King Zhaoxiang then sent a letter to the king of the state of Zhao, saying, “Your younger brother is here in Qin, and Wei Qi, the enemy of our Lord Fan, is at the home of Lord Pingyuan in Zhao. You had better send someone to bring Wei Qi’s head here as quickly as possible. Otherwise I will call out my troops and attack Zhao, and I will also see to it that your younger brother does not get out of the Hangu Pass!”

King Xiaocheng of Zhao dispatched soldiers to surround the house of Lord Pingyuan with all speed. Wei Qi fled in the night, and then went to call on the Zhao prime minister, Yu Qing. Yu Qing, convinced that he would never be able to reason with the king of Zhao, divested himself of the seals of the prime minister of Zhao and fled into hiding with Wei Qi.

Believing that there were none of the other feudal lords whom they could turn to in such an emergency, they hurried to the Wei capital of Daliang, hoping that Lord Xinling, a prince of Wei, would arrange for them to take refuge in Chu. But when Lord Xinling learned of the situation, he hesitated out of fear of Qin and was unwilling to grant them an interview. “What sort of person is Yu Qing?” he asked.

At that time a man named Hou Ying was attending him, and he replied, “It is no easy matter to judge a man correctly, or for a man to be correctly judged by others! Yu Qing, wearing straw sandals and shouldering a sunshade, had a single interview with the king of Zhao and the king presented him with a pair of white jade discs and 100 catties of gold. A second interview and he was honoured with a high ministerial post, a third interview and he received the seals of the prime minister and was enfeoffed as a marquis of 10,000 households. At that time the whole world scrambled to get to know him.

“Wei Qi, because he was in trouble and hard pressed, turned to Yu Qing. And Yu Qing, not daring to consider the lofty rank and emolument he would be losing, took off the seals of prime minister, cast aside his marquissate of 10,000 households, and escaped into hiding. But now this gentleman who is in deep trouble comes to you, Prince, and all you say is, ‘What sort of person is he?’ Truly it is no easy matter to judge a man correctly, or for a man to be judged correctly by others!”

Lord Xinling, much chagrined, sent a carriage to the outskirts of the city to fetch the two men. But when Wei Qi learned that Lord Xinling had at first objected to granting him an interview, he was so angry that he cut his own throat. The king of Zhao, receiving word of this, was thus able in the end to turn over Wei Qi’s head to Qin. King Zhaoxiang of Qin then permitted Lord Pingyuan to return to Zhao.

King Zhaoxiang, forty-third year (264 BC): Qin attacked and captured the Hann regions of Fen and Xing and proceeded to fortify the city of Guangwu

on the Yellow River. Five years later, King Zhaoxiang, employing a strategy suggested by Fan Ju, the marquis of Ying, spread false rumours among the men of Zhao to deceive them. As a result, Zhao relieved Lian Po of command of the Zhao forces and replaced him with Zhao Kuo, the son of Lord Mafu. Qin inflicted a crushing defeat on Zhao at Changping and went on to besiege the Zhao capital city of Handan. Later, however, the marquis of Ying had a falling out with the Qin general Bai Qi, Lord Wuan, and spoke slanderously of him, bringing about his death.

Qin also ordered Zheng Anping, Fan Ju's old benefactor from Wei, to carry out a strike against Zhao, but when Zheng Anping was surrounded by the Zhao forces and hard pressed, he surrendered to Zhao along with the 20,000 soldiers under his command. Fan Ju, the marquis of Ying, spread a mat of straw and asked to be punished for his crime. (According to Qin law, if a person whom one has recommended is guilty of a misdeed, the recommender suffers the same punishment as the perpetrator of the misdeed.) It was judged that the marquis of Ying should be punished by having his three sets of relatives taken into custody. King Zhaoxiang, however, did not wish to do anything that would discomfort the marquis of Ying, and he accordingly circulated an order throughout the state that anyone venturing even to refer to the affair of Zheng Anping would be guilty of the same crime as Zheng himself. He also showered gifts of food and goods on the marquis of Ying and treated him with greater favour each day in order to reassure him. Two years later, however, Wang Ji, whom Fan Ju had also recommended and who was governor of Hedong, was accused of having secret dealings with the other feudal rulers and was condemned to death. The marquis of Ying grew more and more uneasy with each day.

One day when King Zhaoxiang was holding court, he heaved a sigh. The marquis of Ying stepped forward and said, "I have heard that if the ruler has worries, the minister should work to relieve them;¹⁵⁶ and if the ruler suffers disgrace, the minister should die. Now Your Majesty appears at court in this state of worry — may I ask to receive the punishment that is my due?"

King Zhaoxiang said, "I hear that the iron swords of Chu are sharp and its entertainers are clumsy. If its iron swords are sharp, then its fighting men will be valorous, and if its entertainers are clumsy, then the ruler will turn his thoughts to distant campaigns. And if the ruler begins to think of distant campaigns and has valorous men at his command, I fear that Chu may have designs on Qin!

"Unless one stores up articles ahead of time, he will have no way to meet sudden needs. Now Lord Wuan is already dead and Zheng Anping and his men have turned against me. I have no good generals here at home, but many enemy states abroad. That is what causes me worry!"

The king wished in this way to inspire the marquis of Ying to greater effort. But the marquis in his anxiety did not know how to respond. Cai Ze,

hearing of the situation, thereupon journeyed to Qin.

CAI ZE

Cai Ze was a native of the state of Yan. He travelled around to advance his studies and seek employment with the feudal rulers, visiting a number of states both large and small, but met with no success.

He asked Tang Ju to examine his face and tell his fortune, saying, "I hear, Master, that you examined Li Dui and predicted that within 100 days he would take over the affairs of a state. Is that true?"

"I did."

"And what would you say about me?"

Tang Ju looked carefully at Cai Ze and then said with a laugh, "You, now, snub-nosed, giant-shouldered, bulging forehead, wrinkles on your nose, bandy legs — I've heard that sages are not much to look at — perhaps that applies to you."

Cai Ze knew that Tang Ju was joking and so he said, "Wealth and honour I can get for myself. But I don't know how long I'll live. That's what I want to hear."

Tang Ju said, "As for your life span, you've got forty-three more years."

Cai Ze laughed, thanked him, and took his leave. Later Cai Ze said to his carriage driver, "Plenty of grain, fat meat to chew on, dashing around with fast horses, seals of yellow gold in my robe, purple cords of office tied at my waist, bowing before the ruler — if I can eat meat and enjoy that kind of wealth and honour, then forty-three years will be enough!"

Leaving Tang Ju, Cai Ze went to Zhao, but he was expelled from the state. He went to Hann and Wei, but had his cooking pot stolen along the way. He heard that the marquis of Ying had recommended Zheng Anping and Wang Ji for office, but that both men had committed grave crimes against the state of Qin, causing serious embarrassment to the marquis of Ying. Cai Ze thereupon journeyed west to Qin.

Hoping to gain an interview with King Zhaoxiang, he sent someone to incite the marquis of Ying to anger by announcing, "Cai Ze, a visitor from Yan, is a man of extraordinary talent, one of the most eloquent and knowledgeable men in the world. If he once gains an interview with the king of Qin, the king is certain to make trouble for you and deprive you of your position!"

When the marquis of Ying heard this, he said, "I already know all about the Five Emperors and the Three Dynasties of antiquity, and I can refute any amount of eloquence put forward by these talkers. How is this man going to make trouble for me and steal my position away?"

Then he sent someone to summon Cai Ze. When Cai Ze entered, he bowed curtly to the marquis. The marquis was put out to begin with, and when he

saw Cai Ze and met with this display of arrogance, he began to berate him, saying, "I hear you've been spreading word around that you want to replace me as prime minister of Qin. Is that true?"

"It is," was the reply.

"And may I hear how you intend to do it?" said the marquis.

Cai Ze said, "Ah, how slow you are to understand! As the four seasons take their round, so the achiever must give ground! While one is alive, to have sturdy limbs, nimble hands and feet, sharp ears and eyes, and a mind that is sage and wise — this is what a man wishes for, is it not?"

"Yes," said the marquis.

Cai Ze said, "To embody benevolence, cling to righteousness, practise the Way and dispense its blessings, to realize one's ambitions in the world, be welcomed, admired and respected by the world, so that everyone wishes to have him for their ruler — is this not what a man of wisdom and eloquence hopes for?"

"Yes," said the marquis.

Cai Ze said, "Wealth, honour, approbation, glory, helping the ten thousand things to attain order and completion, enabling each to find its place; a full life span, living out the years Heaven gave you without injury, everyone in the world carrying on his respective line, pursuing his undertakings, handing them down so they never come to an end; name and reality of the highest purity, blessings flowing out 1,000 miles, age after age singing praises without end, as long-lasting as Heaven and earth themselves — these are the marks of the Way and its virtue, these are what the sages call good fortune and happy outcome, are they not?"

"Yes," said the marquis.

Cai Ze said, "To be like the statesmen Lord Shang of Qin, Wu Qi of Chu, and Dafu Zhong of Yue — that's what one should wish for, then?"

The marquis of Ying knew that Cai Ze was trying to use his arguments to force him into a corner, but he pretended to go along. "Yes, why not?" he said. "When Gongsun Yang or Lord Shang served Duke Xiao of Qin, he did his utmost without considering twice, gave all thought to public concerns and none to private ones. He established the penalties of the saw and knife in order to put an end to nefarious actions, made sure that rewards and punishments were carried out unfailingly so as to bring about good government. He laid bare the true feelings of his heart and mind, at times incurring enmity or censure, sometimes deceiving old friends, as when he seized the Wei leader Gongzi An, but bringing safety to Qin's altars of the soil and grain and profit to its people. So for the sake of Qin he captured enemy generals, smashed armies, and snatched 1,000 *li* of territory.

"When Wu Qi served King Dao of Chu, he made certain that private interests could not harm the public good, that slander could not darken true loyalty. His words were not shaped merely to be agreeable nor his actions merely to be acceptable. Danger did not deflect him from a course of action, and in observing right he did not turn aside from difficulty. In working to

make the ruler a hegemon and to strengthen the state, he did not hesitate to face misfortune or evil.

"When Dafu Zhong served the king of Yue, though the ruler was troubled and disgraced, Dafu Zhong exerted all his loyalty without ever slacking; though the ruler faced destruction, he exhausted his abilities and never deserted his post. Though he gained merit, he never boasted; though honoured and wealthy, he was never arrogant or lazy.

"These three men in fact represent the ultimate in righteous conduct, the model of loyalty. Therefore the gentleman, when faced with difficulties, will die for what is right, for then he looks on death as his destination. Rather than live in disgrace, he prefers to die in glory. He is fully prepared to sacrifice himself for the sake of his name; so long as it is in the cause of right, he will die without regret. So why not wish to be like these men?"

Cai Ze said, "When the sovereign is a sage and his ministers are worthy, that is the greatest good fortune for the world as a whole. When the ruler is clear-sighted and his ministers are honest, that is the good fortune of the state. When fathers are loving and sons filial, husbands trustworthy and wives faithful, that is the good fortune of the family.

"Nevertheless, though Bi Gan was loyal, he could not save the Yin dynasty, though Wu Zixu was wise, he could not preserve the state of Wu, and though Prince Shensheng was filial, his country of Jin was beset by disorder. These states all possessed loyal ministers and filial sons, yet they encountered disorder and downfall. Why? Because there was no clear-sighted ruler or worthy father to heed the ministers and sons. Therefore the world heaps censure and shame on the rulers and fathers and pities the ministers and sons. Similarly, Lord Shang, Wu Qi, and Dafu Zhong carried out their role as ministers correctly, but the rulers they served were at fault. Therefore the world praises these three as men who achieved merit but failed to receive reward. But it surely doesn't wish to imitate their unfortunate deaths!

"If one must die first before he can prove his loyalty or establish his name, then Wei Zi was no model of benevolence, Confucius was unworthy to be called a sage, or Guan Zhong to be called great. When a man sets out to achieve merit, surely he hopes that he will be able to preserve his life at the same time, does he not? If he can preserve both life and name, that is the finest. If he leaves behind a model name but loses his life in the process, that is the next best. But if his name is heaped with censure and shame, while his life continues, that is the lowest of all."

The marquis of Ying indicated his approval.

After a little while, Cai Ze found an occasion to resume, saying, "Lord Shang, Wu Qi, and Dafu Zhong as ministers exerted utmost loyalty and achieved merit, and in that sense one could wish to be like them. But when Hong Yao served King Wen and the Duke of Zhou assisted King Cheng, surely they too were loyal and sage. From the point of view of the ideal relationship between ruler and minister, who is more worthy to be

emulated, Lord Shang, Wu Qi, and Dafu Zhong, or Hong Yao and the Duke of Zhou?”

“Lord Shang, Wu Qi, and Dafu Zhong of course cannot compare with Hong Yao and the Duke of Zhou,” said the marquis.

Cai Ze said, “And your own ruler — how does he compare to the rulers these men served, Duke Xiao of Qin, King Dao of Chu, or the king of Yue, in terms of kindness and benevolence, in trusting loyalty, in being faithful and generous to old associates, in sticking by the worthy and wise, the men of the Way, or in making it a principle never to betray a meritorious minister?”

“I would not know how to answer that,” said the marquis.

Cai Ze said, “The present ruler in his concern for loyal ministers hardly surpasses Duke Xiao of Qin, King Dao of Chu, or the king of Yue. And you — how do you compare with Lord Shang, Wu Qi, or Dafu Zhong in exercising wisdom and ability, in striving for the sake of your ruler to overcome peril, improve government, put down disorder, reinforce the armies, skirt danger and surmount difficulty, broaden the territory and increase grain supplies, enrich the nation and its families and strengthen the ruler, bring honour to the altars of the soil and grain and glory to the ancestral temples, so that no one in the world will dare cheat or defy him, and so that his achievements may be manifest to those ten thousand miles away, and his fame shine so brightly it will be handed down for 1,000 generations?”

“I am no match for them,” said the marquis.

Cai Ze said, “The present ruler in his concern for loyal ministers or the way he remembers old associates cannot compare to Duke Xiao, King Dao, or King Goujian of Yue. And in terms of merits and achievements or the trust, intimacy, and favour you enjoy with the ruler you cannot compare to Lord Shang, Wu Qi, or Dafu Zhong. And yet your position is one of great distinction, your emolument generous, and your private wealth surpasses that of those three gentlemen. And if you do not withdraw in time, I fear you may meet up with even worse troubles than they did. For your sake I cannot help feeling alarmed.

“The proverb says, ‘The sun at its height moves on, the moon when it’s full starts to wane. Things when they flourish must decay.’ This is the constant rule of Heaven and earth. To advance and retreat, expand and shrink, changing with the times — this is the constant way of the sage. Therefore, when the state possesses the Way, he takes office, but when the state does not possess the Way, he goes into hiding. The sage says: ‘Flying dragon in the heavens; it is profitable to see the great man.’ ‘Wealth and honour not rightly gained are to me like floating clouds.’¹⁵⁷

“Now you have settled your scores with old enemies and repaid your debts of kindness. Your wishes are fulfilled. Not to plan for some change would, I venture to say, be unwise of you. The kingfisher and the snow goose, the rhinoceros and the elephant — it’s not that they don’t live in surroundings far removed from the threat of death. The reason they meet

death is that they are beguiled by the bait. Men like Su Qin and Zhi Bo — it's not that they didn't have wisdom enough to avoid shame and stay far away from death. The reason they met death is that they were beguiled by greed and profit and did not know when to stop.

"Therefore the sage lays down codes of behaviour and regulates desires, observing moderation in what he exacts from the people, employing them only in the proper season and seeing that they have some rest from their labours. Hence his ambitions are never excessive, his actions are not arrogant; he is at all times in accord with the Way and never goes astray. And hence the world acquiesces and never turns against him.

"Long ago Duke Huan of Qi nine times called the other feudal lords together, and in one stroke brought order to the world. But at the meeting at Sunflower Hill he showed himself arrogant and boastful in his ambitions, and nine of the feudal states turned against him.¹⁵⁸ King Fuchai of Wu had armies unrivalled by anyone in the world, but in his daring and might he was contemptuous of the other feudal rulers and lorded it over Qi and Jin, and therefore in the end he met death and his kingdom perished. Xia Yu and the grand historian Jiao roared so loud they startled the Three Armies, but both died at the hands of common soldiers.¹⁵⁹ These men all rode on a wave of splendid success and failed to return to the principle of the Way. They suffered because they did not assume a humble and retiring posture or observe restraint and moderation.

"When Lord Shang served Duke Xiao of Qin, he worked to clarify the laws and regulations and cut off evil conduct at the root, seeing to it that those deserving of noble rank were duly rewarded, and those who were guilty were duly punished. He adjusted scales, standardized measures, and made weights uniform. He broke down the barriers in the fields in order to stabilize the livelihood of the people, unify their customs, and encourage them to devote themselves to agriculture and get the greatest benefit from the soil. One family was not to pursue two occupations, but to work the fields and store up produce, and also to practise the arts of war. Hence when the troops were put into action, the territory of the state was extended, and when the troops were at rest, the state enjoyed prosperity. As a result, Qin stood unrivalled in the world, able to overawe the other feudal lords and fulfil the destiny of the state. But after Lord Shang had accomplished all these deeds, in the end he was torn in two by carriages.

"The state of Chu measures several thousand square *li* in area and boasts a million lance bearers. Yet Bai Qi, leading an army of 30,000 or 40,000 engaged Chu in battle and in one battle captured Yan and Ying and put Yiling to the torch. And in a second battle he advanced south and annexed the regions of Shu and Han. In addition, he crossed through Hann and Wei and attacked the powerful state of Zhao, in the north defeating Lord Mafu and massacring his host of 40,000 or more, wiping them all out at Changping, till the blood flowed in rivers and the cries rose up like thunder.

Then he pushed on to lay siege to Handan, so that Qin could aspire to the position of emperor. Chu and Zhao were the most powerful states in the world and Qin's chief enemies. But from this time on both Chu and Zhao bowed down in terror and did not venture to attack Qin — because of Bai Qi's exertions. In person he conquered over seventy cities, yet after he had accomplished these deeds, in the end he was presented with a sword and ordered to die at Duyou.

“Wu Qi set up laws for King Dao of Chu, humbling the authority of the great ministers, dismissing those without ability, doing away with those who were unfit. He abolished posts that were not essential, blocked the road to private appeal, unified the customs in the state of Chu, prohibited visitors from other states, and trained men in agriculture and warfare. In the south he took over Yang and Yue, in the north annexed Chen and Cai, smashing the states allied horizontally, scattering those allied vertically, so that the advocates of such alliances could not even open their mouths. He prohibited cliques in order to encourage the common people and brought stability to the Chu government, so that its armies made the whole world tremble and the other feudal lords bowed before its might. But after he had accomplished all that, at the last he was torn limb from limb.

“Dafu Zhong devised deep plans and far-reaching schemes for the king of Yue, rescuing him from peril at Kuaiji, turning destruction into survival, transforming shame into glory. He opened up the grasslands and founded cities, broadened the territory and planted grain, leading men from the four directions, commanding the strength of both high and low. He helped King Goujian, already a wise ruler, to carry out vengeance on his enemy King Fuchai, in the end taking prisoner the ruler of powerful Wu. He enabled Yue to become a hegemon, his accomplishments were manifest and indisputable, and yet at the last King Goujian turned on him and killed him.

“These four men were ‘achievers who failed to give ground’, and so misfortune befell them. This is what is called being able to stretch but not to contract, to go but not to return. Fan Li understood this, and so he blithely withdrew from the world and lived many more years under the name of Lord Zhu of Tao.¹⁶⁰ Haven't you ever watched a gambler? Sometimes he tries for a big haul, other times he is just out for little winnings. Surely this is the sort of thing that you are familiar with and can understand.

“Now you are serving as prime minister of Qin. You lay plans without stirring from your seat, concoct schemes without venturing from the hall of state, yet you can control the other feudal rulers, draw on the benefits of the Three Rivers, and make Yiyang yours. You have closed the Sheep Gut pass, blocked the road to Taihang, and sealed off the routes to Fan and Zhonghang, so that the Six States cannot join in alliance against Qin. You have built plank roads a thousand *li*, opening up communication with Shu and Han, and all the world stands in fear of Qin. Qin's desires have been gratified, and your merit could be no greater. But at the moment Qin is

merely out for 'little winnings', and if you do not take this opportunity to retire, you will end up like Lord Shang, Bai Qi, Wu Qi, and Dafu Zhong.

"I have heard it said: 'He who mirrors himself in water his features may see; he who mirrors himself in men may learn his destiny.' The *Book of Documents* says: 'Where great deeds have been done, one cannot linger long.'¹⁶¹ Do you think you can stand up against the misfortune that befell those other four men?

"Why not take this opportunity to return the seals of prime minister, make way for some other worthy person by relinquishing your post, and retire to live among the cliffs and contemplate the streams? In integrity you will be hailed as another Bo Yi, and you may continue to be called marquis of Ying, as may your descendants for generation after generation. Which is better, to rival Xu You and Prince Yanling in unselfishness and enjoy the longevity of Prince Qiao and the Master of Red Pine, or to end in disaster? Which fate will you choose? If you are too reluctant to tear yourself away, too hesitant to come to your own decision, you will invariably encounter the same misfortune as those four men.

"The *Book of Changes* says: 'The lofty dragon has regrets.'¹⁶² This describes one who knows how to go up but not how to come down, how to stretch but not how to contract, how to go but not how to return. Consider the matter carefully, I beg you!"

"Very well," said the marquis. "I have heard that when desire knows no stopping, one will lose what he desires, and when possession knows no surfeit, one will lose what he possesses. You, sir, have been kind enough to instruct me. I will respectfully heed your words." Then he led Cai Ze into the inner apartments and seated him in the place of honour.

After a few days, Fan Ju went to court and spoke to King Zhaoxiang of Qin, saying, "A visitor named Cai Ze has recently arrived from east of the mountains. He is a man of great eloquence, well versed in the affairs of the Three Dynasties, the achievements of the Five Hegemons, and the vicissitudes of the times. He is worthy to be entrusted with the government of the state of Qin. I have seen many men, but none who can match him. I am in no way his equal. That is why I venture to mention him."

King Zhaoxiang summoned Cai Ze to an audience and talked with him. Much pleased, he appointed him a "guest minister". Fan Ju, the marquis of Ying, thereupon pleaded illness and asked to be allowed to return the seals of prime minister. King Zhaoxiang urged him to remain in office, but Fan Ju insisted that his illness was too grave. Thus in the end he retired from the post of prime minister.

King Zhaoxiang, more delighted than ever by Cai Ze's schemes and proposals, eventually appointed him prime minister, and in the east appropriated the territory of the Zhou royal house. After Cai Ze had been prime minister for several months, someone spoke evil of him. Fearful of punishment, Cai Ze pleaded illness and returned the seals of prime minister,

thereafter being known as Lord Gangcheng. He lived in Qin for over ten years, serving King Zhaoxiang, King Xiaowen, and King Zhuangxiang, and finally the First Emperor. He acted as Qin's envoy to the state of Yan, and three years later Yan sent its heir apparent, Prince Dan, to be a hostage in Qin.

The Grand Historian remarks: Han Fei Zi says: Long sleeves make a good dancer, much money makes a good merchant.¹⁶³ How true are these words! Fan Ju and Cai Ze were what the age calls men of superlative eloquence. But both travelled around expounding their ideas to the feudal lords until their heads were grey without ever meeting with success, not because their schemes were inept, but because the persons they addressed wielded little power. Once these two travellers came to Qin, however, they one after the other received the seals of prime minister and accomplished deeds that are known to all the world. This was no doubt because the backing they had was weak in the former cases and strong in the latter.

And yet there is also an element of luck in such situations. There are many men who were as worthy of these two, but who never had an opportunity of fully expounding their ideas — too many, in fact, to finish describing! Nevertheless, if these two men had not met with adversity, they might never have been inspired to such efforts.¹⁶⁴

SHI JI 85: THE BIOGRAPHY OF LÜ BUWEI

He strengthened family ties between Zichu and his royal kin and set the counsellors of the feudal lords to vying with one another, seeing who could lend most eloquent support to his bid for power in Qin. Thus I made “The Biography of Lü Buwei”.

Lü Buwei was a great merchant of Yangdi who, by travelling here and there, buying cheap and selling dear, had accumulated a fortune amounting to thousands in gold.

In the fortieth year of the reign of King Zhaoxiang of Qin (267 BC), the crown prince died, and two years later, in the forty-second year of his reign, the king designated his second son, Lord Anguo, as crown prince. Lord Anguo had over twenty sons. He had a concubine of whom he was extremely fond and whom he had designated as his consort with the title of Lady Huayang, but she had borne him no sons. By another concubine, of the Xia family, who no longer enjoyed his favour he had a son named Zichu, one of the younger among his twenty or more sons. Zichu had been sent by the state of Qin to be a hostage at the court of Zhao,¹⁶⁵ and since, in spite of this, Qin had several times invaded Zhao, the Zhao court accordingly treated Zichu with scant respect. Being merely a grandson of the king of Qin and the son of a concubine, and having been sent as hostage to one of the other feudal states, Zichu was poorly provided with carriages and other equipment and had to live in straightened circumstances, unable to do as he pleased. Lü Buwei, visiting Handan, the capital of Zhao, on business, saw him and was moved to pity. “Here is a rare piece of goods to put in my warehouse!” he exclaimed.

He then went and called on Zichu, remarking, “I know how to enlarge your gate for you!”

Zichu laughed and said, “You’d better enlarge your own gate before you worry about mine!”

“You don’t understand,” said Lü Buwei. “The enlarging of my gate *depends* on the enlarging of yours!”

Zichu, guessing what was in his mind, led him to a seat in an inner room and the two were soon deep in conversation. “The king of Qin is old and Lord Anguo has been designated crown prince,” Lü Buwei said. “I am told that Lord Anguo is very much in love with Lady Huayang, and since she has no son of her own, it will be up to her alone to decide which son shall be appointed as the rightful heir. Now you have twenty or more brothers, and from the point of view of age, you are about halfway down the line. You enjoy no particular favour and have been a hostage at the court of one of

the other feudal lords for a long time. If your grandfather, the old king, should pass away and Lord Anguo become king, I'm afraid you would have little chance of competing for the position of crown prince with your elder brothers or with your other brothers who are there in person morning and evening to wait upon your father."

"True," said Zichu. "But what can I do about it?"

Lü Buwei said, "You are poor and living in a foreign land. You have nothing to use as gifts to present to the members of your family or to attract a band of followers about you. I too am poor, but with your permission I would like to take a thousand measures of gold and travel west on your behalf to Qin, where I will wait upon Lord Anguo and Lady Huayang and see to it that you are made the rightful heir."

Zichu bowed his head and said, "If indeed it should turn out as you say, when the day comes I hope you will allow me to divide the state of Qin and share it with you !"

Lü Buwei accordingly took 500 measures of gold and presented it to Zichu to be used as expense money in attracting a band of followers, and with another 500 he purchased various rare objects, trinkets, and toys, which he took with him west on a trip to Qin. There he sought an interview with the elder sister of Lady Huayang and asked that the gifts he had brought be presented to Lady Huayang. He took the opportunity to mention how virtuous and wise Zichu was, how he had friends among the followers of the various feudal lords all over the world, how he was constantly heard to exclaim, "Her Ladyship is as precious as Heaven itself to me!", and how he wept day and night with longing for his father, the crown prince, and Lady Huayang. Lady Huayang was very pleased with this message.

Lü Buwei then persuaded the elder sister to speak to Lady Huayang to this effect: "They say that one who has only beauty to offer a man will find, as beauty fades, that his love grows cold. Now you wait upon the crown prince but, though he loves you dearly, you have no son. Before it is too late, should you not take this opportunity to choose one of his sons whom you deem worthy and befriend him, seeing to it that he is elevated to the position of rightful heir and treating him as your own son? Then, as long as your husband lives, you will enjoy honour; and when his hundred years of life are ended and the one whom you call son becomes king, you need never fear any loss of position. This is what they call 'speaking one word that brings ten thousand years of gain.' But if now in blossom time you do not make certain that your roots are firm, then when beauty has faded and love grown cold, though you might hope for a chance to 'speak one word', how could you gain a hearing? Now Zichu is a worthy man and, being far down the line, knows that he cannot hope to become heir by the normal order of succession. In addition, his mother enjoys no favour, and so he offers all his devotion to you. If you were truly willingly to use this moment to pluck him from the line of succession and make him the heir, then to the end of your days you would enjoy favour in the state of Qin!"

Lady Huayang, convinced of the truth of this argument, waited until her husband, the crown prince, was at leisure and then casually mentioned that Zichu, who had been sent as hostage to Zhao, was a man of outstanding worth and that everyone coming from abroad praised him highly. Then, with tears in her eyes, she said, "I have been fortunate enough to be assigned to your women's quarters, but not so fortunate as to bear a son. I beg you to give me Zichu for a son and to set him up as the rightful heir so that I may have someone to entrust my fate to!"

Lord Anguo gave his consent and had a jade tally engraved to this effect which he divided with Lady Huayang, promising that he would make Zichu his rightful heir.¹⁶⁶ Then Lord Anguo and Lady Huayang sent rich gifts to Zichu and asked Lü Buwei to act as his tutor. As a result, Zichu became increasingly renowned among the feudal lords.

Lü Buwei had selected from among the ladies of Handan one of matchless beauty and great skill in dancing and had lived with her, and in time he learned that she was pregnant. Zichu, joining Lü Buwei in a drinking bout, happened to catch sight of her and was pleased. Immediately he stood up, proposed a toast to Lü's long life, and asked if he might have her. Lü Buwei was outraged, but soon recalled that he had by now invested all of his family's wealth in Zichu in hopes of fishing up some wonderful prize, and so in the end he presented the woman to him. She concealed the fact that she was pregnant, and when her time was up, she bore a son who was named Zheng. Zichu eventually made her his consort.

In the fiftieth year of his reign (257 BC) King Zhaoxiang of Qin sent Wang Yi to lay siege to Handan and, when the situation grew critical, the men of Zhao wanted to kill Zichu. Zichu and Lü Buwei plotted together, however, and distributed 600 catties of gold to the officers who were in charge of guarding them. In this way Zichu managed to escape, make his way to the Qin army, and eventually return home. The men of Zhao then proposed to kill Zichu's wife and child, but because his wife was the daughter of a wealthy family in Zhao, she was able to go into hiding; thus both mother and son escaped alive.

King Zhaoxiang of Qin passed away in the fifty-sixth year of his reign (251 BC). The crown prince, Lord Anguo, succeeded him as king, Lady Huayang became queen, and Zichu was made crown prince. The state of Zhao obliged by sending Zichu's wife and son Zheng to their new home in Qin. The king of Qin passed away after one year of rule and was given the posthumous title of King Xiaowen. The crown prince Zichu succeeded him and is known as King Zhuangxiang. Queen Huayang, whom King Zhuangxiang had come to treat as a mother, was given the title of Queen Dowager Huayang, and his real mother, whose family name was Xia, was called Queen Dowager Xia.

In the first year of his reign (250 BC), King Zhuangxiang made Lü Buwei his chancellor and enfeoffed him as marquis of Wenxin with the revenue

from 100,000 households in Henan and Luoyang.

King Zhuangxiang passed away after three years on the throne and the crown prince Zheng became king. He honoured Lü Buwei with the position of prime minister and as a mark of respect addressed him as Zhongfu or Uncle. The new king of Qin was still young and his mother, the former concubine of Lü Buwei, who had now become queen dowager, from time to time had sexual relations with Lü Buwei in secret. Lü Buwei had some 10,000 male servants in his household.

This was the period of Lord Xinling of Wei, Lord Chunshen of Chu, Lord Pingyuan of Zhao, and Lord Mengchang of Qi, all men who were willing to humble themselves before others and who delighted in gathering bands of followers about them, seeking in this way to outdo one another. Lü Buwei felt that, since Qin was a powerful state, it was disgraceful for it not to do likewise, and so he too set about attracting gentlemen to his service with offers of generous rewards and treatment, and in time gathered as many as 3,000 men who lived and ate at his expense. This was also the period when there were many skilled debaters in the various feudal states, men such as Xun Qing¹⁶⁷ who wrote books and circulated them throughout the world. Lü Buwei accordingly ordered each of his retainers to write down what he himself had learned, and then collected and edited the results into a work comprising eight *lan* or “surveys”, six *lun* or “discussions”, and twelve *ji* or “records”, totalling over 20,000 characters. It was intended to embrace all the affairs of heaven, earth, the ten thousand things, yesterday, and today, and was entitled “The Spring and Autumn of Mr Lü.”¹⁶⁸ The text was posted on the market gate of Xianyang, the Qin capital, with 1,000 pieces of gold suspended above it. An invitation to the wandering scholars and retainers of the various feudal lords informed them that the 1,000 in gold would be awarded to anyone who could add or subtract a single character from it.

The king of Qin, who was later to bear the title of First Emperor of the Qin, in time grew to manhood, but his mother, the queen dowager, did not cease her wanton behaviour. Lü Buwei began to fear that, if her conduct were ever brought to light, he himself would become involved in the scandal. He therefore searched about in secret until he found a man named Lao Ai who had an unusually large penis, and made him a servant in his household. Then, when an occasion arose, he had suggestive music performed and, instructing Lao Ai to stick his penis through the centre of a wheel made of paulownia wood, had him walk about with it, making certain that the report of this reached the ears of the queen dowager so as to excite her interest. She received the report and, as had been expected, wanted to have the man smuggled into her quarters. Lü Buwei then presented Lao Ai, at the same time getting someone to pretend to accuse him of a crime for which the punishment was castration. Lü Buwei spoke to the queen

dowager in private, pointing out that, if the man were subjected to a mock castration, he could then be taken into service in the queen's private apartments. The queen accordingly sent lavish gifts in secret to the official who was in charge of performing the castration, who then pretended to carry out the sentence, plucking out the man's beard and eyebrows and making him into a "eunuch". In this way he eventually came to wait on the queen, who carried on clandestine relations with him and grew to love him greatly. In time she became pregnant and, fearing discovery, pretended to conduct a divination that indicated that, in order to avoid a period of evil influences, she should move from the palace and take up residence in Yong. Lao Ai was constantly in attendance on her and received lavish gifts and awards. All decisions were made by Lao Ai, who was waited upon by an entourage of several thousand male servants. His followers numbered over 1,000, all men who flocked to him in hopes of attaining government office.

In the seventh year of the king's reign (240 BC) Queen Dowager Xia, the mother of King Zhuangxiang, passed away. Earlier Queen Dowager Huayang, the queen of King Xiaowen, had been buried with her husband, King Xiaowen, at Shouling, and Queen Dowager Xia's son, King Zhuangxiang, had been buried at Zhiyang. Accordingly, Queen Dowager Xia was buried separately at a spot east of Du where, in her words, "I may look eastward to my son and westward to my husband. After 100 years, a city of 10,000 households will surely grow up by my side."

In the ninth year of the king's reign someone reported that Lao Ai was not a real eunuch at all, but had constantly been engaging in secret misconduct with the queen dowager, and that she had borne him two sons, both of whom were being kept in hiding. "He and the queen dowager have agreed," said the report, "that, when the present king passes on, one of these sons shall succeed him."

The king thereupon referred the matter to his officials for investigation and all the facts were brought to light, including those that implicated the prime minister Lü Buwei. In the ninth month Lao Ai and his three sets of relatives were executed, the two sons whom the queen dowager had borne were put to death, and the residence of the queen was officially transferred to Yong. Lao Ai's followers were all deprived of their household goods and sent into exile in Shu.

The king of Qin wanted to put the prime minister Lü Buwei to death as well but, because he had won great distinction in the service of the former king, and because so many followers and men of eloquence came forward to speak on his behalf, the king could not bring himself to apply the death penalty. In the tenth month of the tenth year of his reign the king of Qin removed Lü Buwei from the office of prime minister.

Later Mao Jiao, a man of Qi, spoke to the king of Qin and persuaded him to send to Yong for his mother, the queen dowager, and allow her to return to residence in Xianyang. The king also ordered Lü Buwei, the marquis of Wenxin, to leave the capital and proceed to his fief in Henan. A year or so

later he learned that so many of the followers and envoys of the various feudal lords were travelling to Henan to call on Lü Buwei that their carriages were never out of sight of each other on the road. Fearful that there might be some plot afoot, the king sent a letter to Lü Buwei saying, "What did you ever do for the state of Qin that Qin should enfeoff you in Henan with the revenue from a 100,000 households? What relation are you to the ruler of Qin that you should be addressed as 'Uncle'? Be so good as to take your family and retinue and move your residence to Shu!"

Lü Buwei judged that he would only have to suffer increasing insult and, fearing the death penalty,¹⁶⁹ he drank poison and died. With Lü Buwei and Lao Ai, the two men who had been the butt of his anger, both dead, the king recalled Lao Ai's retainers who had been exiled to Shu. In the nineteenth year of his reign his mother, the queen dowager, passed away and was given the posthumous title of Empress Dowager. She was buried with her husband, King Zhuangxiang, at Zhiyang.

The Grand Historian remarks: Lü Buwei and Lao Ai were both honoured with fiefs, the former receiving the title of marquis of Wenxin. When accusations were first made against Lao Ai, Lao got word of it. The king of Qin questioned those about him as to the truth of the charges but had not yet uncovered any definite evidence when he set off for Yong to perform the suburban sacrifice. Lao Ai, fearful that calamity was about to befall him, plotted with the members of his clique and, using the queen dowager's seal of authority without her permission, called out troops and initiated a revolt in the Qinian Palace. The king dispatched officers to attack Lao Ai's forces and Lao Ai fled in defeat. He was pursued and cut down at Haozhi, and eventually his whole clan was wiped out. This marked the beginning of Lü Buwei's fall from power. What Confucius said about the "man of fame" might well apply to this Master Lü, might it not?¹⁷⁰

SHI JI 86: THE BIOGRAPHIES OF THE ASSASSIN-RETAINERS (EXCERPT)

The Biography of Jing Ke [171](#)

Some 220 years later there was the affair of Jing Ke in Qin. Jing Ke was a native of Wey, though his family came originally from Qi. The men of Wey referred to him as Master Qing, the men of Yan, as Master Jing. He loved to read books and practise swordsmanship. He expounded his ideas to Lord Yuan of Wey, but Lord Yuan failed to make use of him. Later, Qin attacked Wey, established Dong Province, and moved the collateral kinsmen of Lord Yuan of Wey to Yewang.

Jing Ke once visited the area of Yuci, where he engaged Gai Nie in a discussion on swordsmanship. In the course of the talk, Gai Nie got angry and glared fiercely at Jing Ke, who immediately withdrew. Someone asked Gai Nie if he did not intend to summon Jing Ke back again. "When I was discussing swordsmanship with him a little while ago," said Gai Nie, "we had a difference of opinion and I glared at him. Go and look for him if you like, but I'm quite certain he has gone. He wouldn't dare stay around!" Gai Nie sent a messenger to the house where Jing Ke had been staying, but Jing Ke had already mounted his carriage and left Yuci. When the messenger returned with this report, Gai Nie said, "I knew he would go. I glared at him and frightened him away."

Again, when Jing Ke was visiting the city of Handan, he and a man named Lu Goujian got into a quarrel over a chess game. Lu Goujian grew angry and began to shout, whereupon Jing Ke fled without a word and never came to see Lu Goujian again.

In the course of his travels Jing Ke reached the state of Yan, where he became close friends with a dog butcher and a man named Gao Jianli who was good at playing the lute. Jing Ke was fond of wine, and every day he would join the dog butcher and Gao Jianli to drink in the market place of the Yan capital. After the wine had begun to take effect, Gao Jianli would strike up the lute and Jing Ke would join in with a song. In the middle of the crowded market place they would happily amuse themselves, or if their mood changed they would break into tears, exactly as though there were no one else about. But, although Jing Ke spent his time with drunkards, he was a man of depth and learning. Whatever feudal state he travelled to, he always became close friends with the most worthy and influential men. When he went to Yan, Master Tian Guang, a gentleman of Yan who was living in retirement, treated him very kindly, for he realized that he was no ordinary man.

After Jing Ke had been in Yan some time, Prince Dan, the heir apparent of

Yan, who had been a hostage in Qin, escaped and returned home. Previously Prince Dan had been a hostage in Zhao. Zheng, the king of Qin, was born in Zhao, and in his youth had been very friendly with Prince Dan; later, when Zheng became king, Prince Dan went as a hostage to the Qin court. But the king of Qin treated him very shabbily until, in anger, he escaped from the state and returned to Yan. After his return, he looked about for someone who would undertake to get back at the king of Qin for him; but because Yan was small and powerless, there was nothing he could do. Meanwhile, Qin day by day dispatched more troops east of the mountains, attacking Qi, Chu, Hann, Wei, and Zhao and gradually eating away at the lands of the other feudal lords, until it became obvious that Yan's turn would be next. The ruler of Yan and his ministers all feared imminent disaster, and Prince Dan, likewise worried over the situation, asked his tutor Ju Wu what could be done.

Ju Wu replied, "Qin's lands fill the world and its might overawes the rulers of Hann, Wei, and Zhao. To the north it occupies the strongholds at Sweet Springs and Valley Mouth, and to the south the fertile fields of the Jing and Wei river valleys; it commands the riches of Ba and Han and the mountain ranges of Long and Shu to the west, and the vital Hangu and Yao passes to the east. Its people are numerous and its soldiers well trained, and it has more weapons and armour than it can use. If it should ever decide to march against us, we could find no safety south of the Great Wall or north of the Yi River.¹⁷² Angry as you are at the insults you have suffered, you surely would not want to brush against its bristling scales!"¹⁷³

"Then what should I do?" said Prince Dan.

"Let me retire and think it over," replied Ju Wu.

Shortly afterwards the Qin general Fan Yuqi, having offended the king of Qin, fled to Yan, where Prince Dan received him and assigned him quarters. Ju Wu admonished the prince, saying, "This will not do! Violent as the king of Qin is, and with the resentment he nurses against Yan because of your escape, it is already enough to make one's heart turn cold. And what will he be like when he hears where General Fan is staying? This is what men call throwing meat in the path of a starving tiger — there will be no help for the misfortune that follows! Even if you had ministers as wise as Guan Zhong and Yan Ying, they could think of no way to save you! I beg you to send General Fan at once to the territory of the Xiongnu barbarians to get him out of the way. Then, after you have negotiated with Hann, Wei, and Zhao to the west, entered into alliance with Qi and Chu on the south, and established friendly relations with the leader of the Xiongnu to the north, we may be able to plan what move to make next."

"The scheme you propose will require a great deal of time," said Prince Dan. "As anxious as I feel at the moment, I am afraid I cannot wait that long! And that is not all. General Fan, having been hounded throughout the world, has come to entrust his fate to me. No matter how much I might be

pressed by Qin and its power, I could never bear, when he is in such a pitiful plight, to betray his friendship and abandon him by sending him off to the Xiongnu! This is a matter of life and death to me. I beg you to consider the question once more."

Ju Wu said, "To pursue a dangerous course and hope for safety, to invite disaster while seeking good fortune; with too little planning and too much hatred to disregard a serious threat to the whole nation because of some lately incurred debt of friendship to one man — this is what is known as 'fanning resentment and abetting disaster'! Drop a swan's feather into a burning brazier and puff! — it is all over in an instant. And when Qin, like a ravening hawk, comes to vent its anger, will Yan be able to last any longer? However, there is a certain Master Tian Guang in Yan who is a man of deep wisdom and great daring. He would be a good person to consult."

"I would like you to introduce me to him," said Prince Dan. "Can you arrange it?"

"With pleasure," said Ju Wu, and went to see Master Tian, informing him that the crown prince wished to consult him on matters of state. "I will be happy to comply," said Master Tian. He went to call on the prince, who came out to greet him, politely led him inside, knelt, and dusted off a mat for him to sit on.

When Tian Guang was settled on his seat and those about them had retired, the prince deferentially moved off his mat and addressed his request to his visitor: "Yan and Qin cannot both stand! I beg you to devote your mind to this problem."

"They say," replied Tian Guang, "that when a thoroughbred horse is in its prime, it can gallop 1,000 *li* in one day; but when it is old and decrepit, the sorriest nag will outdistance it. It appears that you have heard reports of how I was when I was in my prime, but do not realize that my strength is by now wasted and gone. Nevertheless, though I myself would not venture to plan for the safety of the state, I have a friend named Master Jing who could be consulted."

"I would like you to introduce me to him," said Prince Dan. "Is it possible?"

"With pleasure," said Tian Guang and, rising from his mat, he hurried from the room. The prince escorted him as far as the gate and there warned him, "What we have been discussing is a matter of vital concern to the nation. Please do not let word of it leak out!"

Tian Guang lowered his gaze to the ground and replied with a laugh, "I understand."

Then, stooped with age, he made his way to the house of Master Jing. "Everyone in Yan knows that we are good friends," he said. "The crown prince, having heard reports of me when I was in my prime and unaware that by now my powers have failed, has told me that Yan and Qin cannot continue to exist side by side and begged me to devote my mind to the problem. Rather than refuse his request, I took the liberty of mentioning

your name. May I ask you to go call on him at his palace?"

"I will be glad to comply," said Jing Ke.

"They say," Tian Guang continued, "that a worthy man does not act in such a way as to arouse distrust in others. Now the prince has warned me that the matter we discussed is of vital concern to the nation and begged me not to let word of it leak out. Obviously he distrusts me, and if my actions have aroused his distrust, then I am no gentleman of honour!" Tian Guang had decided to commit suicide in order to spur Jing Ke to action, and he continued: "I want you to go at once and visit the prince. Tell him I am already dead, so he will know that I have not betrayed the secret!" With this he cut his throat and died.

Jing Ke went to see the prince and informed him of Tian Guang's death and last words. The prince bowed twice and then, sinking to his knees, crawled forward, the tears starting from his eyes. After some time he said, "I only cautioned Master Tian not to speak so that we could be sure of bringing our plans to a successful conclusion. Now he has actually killed himself to show me that the secret will never be betrayed — as though I could have intended such a thing!"

After Jing Ke had settled himself, the prince moved off his mat, bowed his head, and said, "Master Tian, unaware of how unworthy a person I am, has made it possible for me to speak my thoughts to you. It is clear from this that Heaven has taken pity upon Yan and has not abandoned me altogether.

"Qin has a heart that is greedy for gain, and its desires are insatiable. It will never be content until it has seized all the land in the world and forced every ruler within the four seas to acknowledge its sovereignty. Now, having already taken captive the king of Hann and annexed all his lands, Qin has mobilized its troops to strike against Chu in the south, while in the north it stands poised for an attack on Zhao. Wang Jian, leading several hundred thousand troops, is holding Zhang and Ye, while Li Xin leads another force against Taiyuan and Yunzhong. Zhao, unable to withstand the might of Qin, will undoubtedly submit and swear allegiance to it. And when Zhao has gone under, Yan will stand next in line for disaster!

"Yan is small and weak, and has often fared badly in war. Even if we were to mobilize the entire nation, we obviously could not stand against Qin; and once the other feudal lords have bowed to its rule, none of them will dare to become our allies. Nevertheless, I have a scheme of my own which, foolish as it may be, I would like to suggest — that is, to find a really brave man who would be willing to go as our envoy to the court of Qin and tempt it with some offer of gain. The king of Qin is greedy, and under the circumstances would surely listen to our offer. If this man could then somehow threaten the king, as Cao Mei threatened Duke Huan of Qi,¹⁷⁴ and force him to return to the feudal lords all the land he has seized, that would be the best we could ask for. And if that proved impossible, he might still be able to stab and kill the king. With the Qin generals free to do as

they wished with the troops in the outlying areas, and the Qin court in a state of confusion, dissension would surely arise between ruler and subject. The feudal lords could then take advantage of the situation to band together once more, and in that case the defeat of Qin would be inevitable. This is what I would like to see more than anything else, but I do not know who could be entrusted with such a mission. I can only ask that you give it some thought!"

After some time Jing Ke said, "This is a matter of grave importance to the state. I am a person of little worth and I fear I would be unfit for such a mission."

The prince moved forward and, bowing his head, begged and begged Jing Ke to accept the proposal and not to decline any longer, until at last Jing Ke gave his consent. The prince then honoured him with the title of Chief Minister and assigned him the finest quarters in the capital. Every day the prince went to call at his mansion, presenting gifts of food, supplying him with all manner of luxuries, and from time to time pressing him to accept carriages, rider attendants, and waiting women, indulging his every wish so as to insure his cooperation.

Time passed, but Jing Ke showed no inclination to set out on the mission. Meanwhile the Qin general Wang Jian defeated Zhao, took prisoner its king, and annexed its entire territory. Then he advanced north, seizing control of the land as he went, until he reached the southern border of the state of Yan. Crown Prince Dan, filled with terror, begged Jing Ke to set off. "Any moment now the Qin forces may cross the Yi River, and if that happens, though I might wish to continue to wait upon you, how could I do so?"

"I intended to say something, whether you mentioned it or not," said Jing Ke. "The trouble is that, if I set off now, without any means of gaining the confidence of the king of Qin, I will never be able to get close to him. The king of Qin has offered 1,000 catties of gold and a city of 10,000 households in exchange for the life of his former general, Fan Yuqi. If I could get the head of General Fan and a map of the Dukang region of Yan, and offer to present these to the king of Qin, he would certainly be delighted to receive me. Then I would have a chance to carry out our plan."

But the prince replied, "General Fan has come here in trouble and distress and entrusted himself to me. I could never bear to betray the trust of a worthy man for the sake of my own personal desires. I beg you to think of some other plan."

Jing Ke realized that the prince would never bring himself to carry out his suggestion, and so he went in private to see Fan Yuqi. "Qin's treatment of you has been harsh indeed!" he said. "Your father, your mother, and all the members of your family have been done away with; and now I hear that Qin has offered a reward of 1,000 catties of gold and a city of 10,000 households for your head! What do you intend to do?"

Fan Yuqi looked up to heaven and gave a great sigh, tears streaming down his face. "I think of nothing else, until the ache of it is in my very

bones! But I do not know what I can do!"

"Suppose I said that one word from you could dispel the troubles of the state of Yan and avenge the wrong you have suffered?"

Fan Yuqi leaned forward. "What is it?" he asked.

"Give me your head, so that I can present it to the king of Qin! Then he will surely be delighted to receive me. With my left hand I will seize hold of his sleeve, with my right I'll stab him in the breast, and all your wrongs will be avenged and all the shameful insults which Yan has suffered will be wiped out! What do you say?"

Fan Yuqi bared his shoulder and gripped his wrist in a gesture of determination. Moving forward, he said, "Day and night I gnash my teeth and eat out my heart trying to think of some plan. Now you have shown me the way!" Then he cut his throat.

When the crown prince heard what had happened, he rushed to the spot and, throwing himself upon the corpse, wept in deep sorrow. But, since there was nothing that could be done, he took Fan Yuqi's head and sealed it in a box. Earlier he had ordered a search for the sharpest dagger that could be found, and had purchased one from a man of Zhao named Xu Furen for 100 measures of gold. He ordered his artisans to coat the blade with poison and try it out on some men; though the thrust drew hardly enough blood to stain the robe of the victim, every one of the men dropped dead on the spot. The prince then began to make final preparations for sending Master Jing on his mission. There was a brave man of Yan named Qin Wuyang who at age thirteen had murdered someone, and was so fierce that no one dared even to look at him crossly. This man the prince ordered to act as a second to Jing Ke.

There was another man whom Jing Ke wished to have along in his party, but he lived a long way off and had not yet arrived in Yan. Meanwhile preparations for the journey were completed but, though time passed, Jing Ke still did not set off. The prince began to fret at the delay and to suspect that Jing Ke had changed his mind. He therefore went to Jing Ke and pressed his request. "The day for departure has already passed, and I am wondering what you intend to do. Perhaps I should send Qin Wuyang on ahead ..."

"What do you mean, send Qin Wuyang on ahead?" roared Jing Ke angrily. "Send that little wretch alone and you may be sure he'll never return successful — setting off with a single dagger to face the immeasurable might of Qin! The reason I have delayed is that I was waiting for a friend I wanted to go with me. But, if you feel it is growing too late, I beg to take my leave."

Then he set out. The crown prince and all his associates who knew what was happening put on white robes and caps of mourning to see the party off, accompanying them as far as the Yi River. After they had sacrificed to the god of the road and chosen their route, Gao Jianli struck up his lute and Jing Ke joined in with a song in the mournful *bianzhi* mode. Tears streamed

from the eyes of the company. Jing Ke came forward and sang this song:

Winds cry *xiao xiao*,
Yi waters are cold.
Brave men, once gone,
Never come back again.

Shifting to the yu mode with its martial air, Jing Ke sang once more; this time the eyes of the men flashed with anger and their hair bristled beneath their caps. Then he mounted his carriage and set off, never once looking back.

In time he arrived in Qin, where he presented gifts worth 1,000 measures of gold to Meng Jia, an attendant to the sons of the nobility and one of the king's favourite ministers. Meng Jia in turn spoke on his behalf to the king of Qin: "The king of Yan, trembling with awe before Your Majesty's might, has not ventured to call out his troops to oppose our forces, but requests that he and all his people may become vassals of Qin, so that he may be ranked among the other feudal lords and present tribute and perform labour services in the manner of a province or a district; in this way he hopes to be allowed to continue the sacrifices at the temple of his ancestors, the former kings of Yan. In his terror he has not dared to come and speak in person, but has respectfully sent the severed head of Fan Yuqi sealed in a box, along with a map of the Dukang region in Yan, to be presented to you. Bowing respectfully in his courtyard, he has sent these gifts, dispatching his envoys to inquire Your Majesty's pleasure. He awaits your command."

When the king of Qin heard this, he was delighted and, donning his court robes and ordering a full dress reception, he received the envoys of Yan in the Xianyang Palace. Jing Ke bore the box with Fan Yuqi's head, while Qin Wuyang carried the map case; step by step they advanced through the throne room until they reached the steps of the throne, where Qin Wuyang suddenly turned pale and began to quake with fear. The courtiers eyed him suspiciously. Jing Ke turned around, laughed at Qin Wuyang, and then stepped forward to apologize: "This man is a simple rustic from the barbarous region of the northern border, and he has never seen the Son of Heaven. That is why he shakes with fright. I beg Your Majesty to pardon him for the moment and permit me to complete my mission before you."

"Bring the map he is carrying!" said the king to Jing Ke, who took the map container from Qin Wuyang and presented it to the king. The king opened the container, and when he had removed the map, the dagger appeared. At that moment Jing Ke seized the king's sleeve with his left hand, while with his right he snatched up the dagger and held it pointed at the king's breast, but he did not stab him. The king jerked back in alarm and leapt from his seat, tearing the sleeve off his robe. He tried to draw his sword, but it was long and clung to the scabbard and, since it hung vertically at his side, he could not, in his haste, manage to get it out.

Jing Ke ran after the king, who dashed around the pillar of the throne

room. All the courtiers, utterly dumbfounded by so unexpected an occurrence, milled about in disorder.

According to Qin law, no courtier or attendant who waited upon the king in the upper throne room was permitted to carry a weapon of any kind. The palace attendants who bore arms were ranged in the lower hall, and without a command from the king they were forbidden to ascend to the throne room. In his panic the king had no chance to give a command to the soldiers to appear, and thus Jing Ke was able to pursue him. Having nothing with which to strike at Jing Ke, the king in panic-stricken confusion merely flailed at him with his hands. At the same time the physician Xia Wuju, who was in attendance, battered Jing Ke with the medicine bag he was carrying.

The king continued to circle the pillar, unable in his confusion to think of anything else to do. "Push the scabbard around behind you!" shouted the king's attendants, and, when he did this, he was at last able to draw his sword and strike at Jing Ke, slashing him across the left thigh. Jing Ke, staggering to the ground, raised the dagger and hurled it at the king, but it missed and struck the bronze pillar. The king attacked Jing Ke again.

Jing Ke, wounded now in eight places, realized that his attempt had failed. Leaning against the pillar, his legs sprawled before him, he began to laugh and curse the king. "I failed because I tried to threaten you without actually killing you and exact a promise that I could take back to the crown prince!" As he spoke, the king's attendants rushed forward to finish him off.

It was a long time before the king regained his composure. When at last he came to himself, he discussed with his ministers the question of who deserved a reward for his part in the incident, and who deserved punishment. To the physician Xia Wuju he presented 200 taels of gold, "because Xia Wuju, out of love for me, hit Jing Ke with his medicine bag."

After this the king in a rage dispatched more troops to join his army in Zhao and commanded Wang Jian to attack Yan. Ten months later the Qin army captured the city of Ji. King Xi of Yan, Prince Dan, and the others of the court, leading their best troops, fled east to Liaodong for safety. The Qin general Li Xin pursued and attacked them with ever increasing fury.

King Jia of Dai sent a letter to King Xi of Yan which read: "It is all because of Prince Dan that Qin is harassing you with such vehemence. If you would only do away with the prince and present his corpse to Qin, the king's anger would surely be appeased and he would leave you in peace to carry on the sacrifices to your altars of the soil and grain."

Shortly after this, Li Xin pursued Prince Dan as far as the Yan River, where the prince hid among the islands of the river. Meanwhile the king of Yan sent an envoy to cut off the prince's head, intending to present it to Qin, but Qin dispatched more troops and reopened its attack on Yan. Five years later, Qin finally destroyed the state of Yan and took its ruler, King Xi, prisoner. The following year (221 BC), the king of Qin united all the empire under his rule and assumed the title of August Emperor.

The Qin ruler then began a campaign to ferret out the associates of Prince

Dan and Jing Ke, and as a result they all went into hiding. Gao Jianli, who was among the group, changed his name, hired himself out as an indentured workman, and went into hiding in a household in the city of Songzi, enduring for a long time the hardships of a labourer's life. Whenever he heard some guest of the family playing the lute in the main hall of the house, he would linger outside, unable to tear himself away, and after each performance he would say, "That man plays well" or "That man is not very good". One of the servants reported this to the master of the house, saying, "That hired man must know something about music, since he ventures to pass judgment on everyone's playing."

The master of the house summoned Gao Jianli to appear and play the lute before his guests, and when he did so, everyone in the company praised his playing and pressed wine on him. Gao Jianli thought of the long time he had been in hiding, and of the seemingly endless years of hardship and want that lay ahead; finally he went back to his room, got his lute and good clothes out of the trunk where he had stored them and, changing his clothes, appeared once more in the hall. The guests were overcome with surprise and, bowing and making room for him as an equal, they led him to the seat of honour and requested him to play the lute and sing. When the performance was over, there was not a guest who left the house dry-eyed.

Gao Jianli was entertained at one home after another in Songzi, and in time his fame reached the ears of the Qin emperor. The emperor summoned him to an audience, but when he appeared, someone who had known him in the past exclaimed, "This is Gao Jianli!" The emperor, unable to bring himself to kill such a skilled musician, ordered his eyes put out and commanded him to play in his presence. The emperor never failed to praise his playing and gradually allowed him to come nearer and nearer. Gao Jianli then got a heavy piece of lead and fastened it inside his lute, and the next time he was summoned to play at the emperor's side, he raised the lute and struck at the emperor. He missed and was summarily executed, and after that the emperor never again permitted any of the former followers of the feudal lords to approach his person.

When Lu Goujian heard of Jing Ke's attempt to assassinate the king of Qin, he sighed to himself and said, "What a pity that he never properly mastered the art of swordsmanship! And as for me — how blind I was to his real worth! That time when I shouted at him in anger, he must have thought I was hardly human!"

The Grand Historian remarks: When people these days tell the story of Jing Ke, they assert that at the command of Prince Dan the heavens rained grain and horses grew horns.¹⁷⁵ This is of course a gross error. They likewise say that Jing Ke actually wounded the king of Qin, which is equally untrue. At one time Gongsun Jigong and Master Dong were friends of the physician Xia Wuju and they learned from him exactly what happened. I

have therefore reported everything just as they told it to me.

Of these five men, from Cao Mei to Jing Ke, some succeeded in carrying out their duty and some did not. But it is perfectly clear that they had all determined upon the deed. They were not false to their intentions. Is it not right, then, that their names should be handed down to later ages?

SHI JI 87: THE BIOGRAPHY OF LI SI

He knew how to elucidate his schemes and, moving with the times, he propelled Qin forward until it was able to have its way with the whole area within the seas. Li Si was its chief planner. Thus I made “The Biography of Li Si”.

Li Si was a native of Shangcai in Chu. In his youth he served as a petty clerk in the province. In the privy of the clerks’ quarters he saw how the rats ate the filth and how, when people or dogs came near, they were frequently alarmed and terrified. And when he entered the storehouse he saw how the rats in the storehouse ate the heaps of grain and lived under a big roof, never having to worry about people or dogs. Li Si sighed and said, “Whether a man turns out to be worthy or good-for-nothing is like the rats — it all depends on the surroundings he chooses for himself!”

In time he became a student of Xun Qing,¹⁷⁶ learning the methods appropriate to an emperor or a king. When he completed his studies, he estimated that the king of Chu would not be worth serving and that, since all of the Six States were weak, he would have no opportunity to win merit under any of them. He therefore decided to go west and enter the service of Qin.

When he took his leave of Xun Qing, he said, “I have heard that one must never be lazy in seizing the moment. Now is a time when the rulers of 10,000 chariots are vying for power, when those in search of employment can take command of affairs. The king of Qin wants to swallow up the world, to call himself emperor and rule it. This is the moment for commoners like myself, the harvest season for those with ideas to expound. To occupy a mean and lowly station and never plan for advancement is to be like a bird or beast who spies something to eat but, because there are people around, forces itself to pass it by. Therefore I say, there is no greater disgrace than being mean and lowly, and no greater sorrow than poverty and want. To continue for long in a mean and lowly station, in a situation of hardship and trial, to condemn the age, speak ill of gain, and deliberately choose a course of inaction — this is contrary to human nature. Therefore I plan to go west and speak to the king of Qin!”

When he reached Qin, however, he found that King Zhuangxiang had died.¹⁷⁷ He therefore sought service under the prime minister of Qin, Lü Buwei, the marquis of Wenxin, becoming one of his retainers. Lü Buwei thought highly of him and employed him as a court gentleman. Thus Li Si was able to expound his ideas.

He spoke to the king of Qin in these words: “A menial man is one who lets

his chances slip away. But an accomplisher of great deeds is one who takes advantage of the cracks and openings and can bear to do what has to be done.

“In the past, when Duke Mu of Qin was hegemon, he never advanced east to annex the other six states. Why was this? Because at that time the other feudal rulers were still numerous and the virtue of the Zhou dynasty had not yet waned. Therefore the Five Hegemons arose one after the other, and each in turn paid homage to the Zhou royal house.

“But from the time of Duke Xiao of Qin on, the Zhou royal house sank into insignificance and the feudal rulers annexed each other’s land, until east of the Pass there were only six states left. Qin, taking advantage of its victories, was able to command the other feudal lords for a period of six reigns.¹⁷⁸

“Now the feudal lords are so submissive to Qin that they are like so many provinces and districts. With the power that Qin possesses and Your Majesty’s worth, it would be as easy to wipe out the feudal lords, found an imperial dynasty, and unite the whole world under one rule as it would to dust off the top of an oven! This is an opportunity that comes once in 10,000 ages. If one is lazy and fails to act quickly, the feudal lords will recover their strength and join in an alliance against Qin, and then, though one might be as worthy as the Yellow Emperor, he could never unite them!”

The king of Qin honoured Li Si with the post of aide and heeded his suggestions, secretly sending out strategists with gold and jewels to visit the feudal rulers and speak to them persuasively. Among the noted men in the service of the feudal lords, those who could be bought over by wealth were to be subverted with generous gifts, and those who refused were to be stabbed with sharp knives, so as to frustrate the plans of the rulers and their ministers. The king of Qin then dispatched his skilled generals to follow in the wake of the strategists.

The king of Qin had honoured Li Si by making him a “guest minister”. But just at this time a man of the state of Hann named Zheng Guo had come to Qin to supervise construction of an irrigation canal, and the true purpose of his mission had come to light.¹⁷⁹ The members of the Qin ruling family and the high officials all said to the king of Qin: “Persons who come from the states of the other feudal rulers to take office in Qin are in most cases simply seeking in a covert manner to further the interests of their own rulers. We request that all such ‘guests’ or aliens be expelled.”

Li Si was among those who were under consideration for expulsion. He therefore submitted a letter to the king which read:

I have heard that the officials are debating whether to expel aliens. In my humble opinion that would be a mistake. In the past, when Duke Mu was looking for men, he selected You Yu from among the Rong people of the west, acquired Baili Xi from Wan in the east, welcomed Jian Shu from Song, and summoned Pi Bao and Gongsun Zhi from Jin. These five men were not

native sons of Qin, but Duke Mu, by employing them, was able to annex twenty states and eventually become hegemon over the Western Rong.

Duke Xiao, by utilizing the laws of Shang Yang, reformed manners and changed customs, so that the population flourished, the state became rich and powerful, the people delighted in their public duties, and the other feudal lords were friendly and submissive. He captured the armies of Chu and Wei and acquired 1,000 *li* of territory, and the nation to this day remains strong and well governed.

King Hui, employing the strategies of Zhang Yi, snatched the region of the Three Rivers, annexed Ba and Shu in the west, acquired Shang Province in the north, and seized Hanzhong in the south.¹⁸⁰ He assimilated the nine Yi tribes, gained control of Yan and Ying, in the east relied on the Chenggao passes to slice off pieces of fertile territory, and eventually broke up the vertical alliance of the Six States and obliged them to face west and serve Qin, and the fruits of his achievements continue to be enjoyed to the present.

King Zhaoxiang obtained the services of Fan Ju, dismissed the marquis of Rang, and expelled Lord Huayang, strengthening the ruling house, closing the door to private privilege, eating away silkworm-fashion at the lands of the other feudal lords, and making it possible for Qin to set up an imperial regime.

These four rulers all had visitors from other states to aid them in their accomplishments. In view of this fact, how can one say that such visitors are disloyal to Qin? If these four rulers had rejected these visitors and refused to admit them to their presence, if they had scorned such men and failed to employ them, then they would have caused Qin to miss out on the realities of wealth and gain, and Qin would never have become famous for power and greatness.

Now Your Majesty imports jade from the Kun Mountains and possesses the treasures of Sui and He. Dangling moon-bright pearls, you buckle on the sword Taia, are drawn by fine steeds like Xianli, set up phoenix banners blazoned with kingfisher feathers, and employ drums of sacred lizard skin. Not one of these various precious things is a product native to Qin, and yet Your Majesty takes joy in them. Why?

If something must be a product of Qin before it can be acceptable, then no night-shining jewels would adorn the court chambers, no vessels of rhinoceros horn or elephant tusk would amuse and delight you, no women of Zheng and Wey would throng the harem, and no fine horses and spirited thoroughbreds would fill your stables. The gold and tin from south of the Yantze could not be utilized, the vermilion and blue of Shu could not be used for pigment.

If the things that adorn the women's quarters and fill the lesser apartments, that please the heart and mind and gladden the ear and eye, must originate in Qin before they can be acceptable, then no hairpins of

Wan pearls, no gem-studded earrings, no robes of white silk from Donga, no decorations of brocade or embroidery, could be laid before you, and no lovely and enchanting women of Zhao, such as blend in with our customs and lend elegance to the scene, would stand by your side.

To thump a water jar and bang a pot, to twang a zither, slap one's thigh and sing *woo-woo* as a means of pleasing the ear and eye — this is the true Qin sound. But the songs of Zheng, Wey, and Sangjian, the Zhao, Yu, Wu, and Xiang — these are the music of other states. Yet now you set aside the jar-thumping and pot-banging and turn to the music of Zheng and Wey, you reject the zither-twanging and call for the Zhao and Yu music. Why is this? Simply because one wants something that delights the mind, that is a pleasure to watch.

But when you select men, you do not proceed in this manner. You do not ask if the person is suitable or not, you do not inquire whether he is straightforward or devious. He is not a native of Qin, so away with him! Because he is an alien, expel him! From this it would appear that you take great care when it is a matter of feminine beauty or music, jewels or jade, but little care when it is a matter of people. This is hardly the procedure for one who would straddle the whole area within the seas and lord it over the other feudal rulers.

I have heard that when lands are extensive, grain is plentiful; when a country is great, its population is numerous; when weapons are powerful, the fighting men are brave. Mt. Tai does not give away a grain of soil, and therefore it can become large. The rivers and oceans do not refuse the tiniest trickle, and therefore they can become deep. A king does not reject the commonest rabble, and therefore he can manifest his virtue. His realm knows no distinction of east or west, north or south, his people no distinction of native land. All four seasons for him are replete with beauty, and the gods and spirits send down good fortune. This is why the Five Emperors and the kings of the Three Dynasties were without rivals.

But now Qin would cast away members of the black-headed people so they become an asset to enemy countries, would reject visitors from abroad and thereby further the interests of the other feudal rulers, making it so that gentlemen of the world turn aside and do not venture to face west, halt their steps and refrain from entering Qin. This is what is called lending arms to bandits and supplying rations to thieves.

"There are many objects not produced in Qin that are worthy to be deemed precious, and numerous gentlemen not native to Qin who are anxious to render it loyal service. Now if you expel aliens and thereby aid enemy states, deplete the population and thereby increase your opponents, you will be emptying your own state and implanting resentment among the other feudal rulers. If you hope in this way to free Qin from danger, your hopes will be in vain.

The king of Qin thereupon withdrew the order for the expulsion of aliens

and restored Li Si to his former position. In the end he followed Li Si's advice on planning, and Li Si in time advanced to the position of commandant of justice.

Some twenty years or more after the above incident the Qin ruler united the empire and was honoured with the title of August Emperor. Appointing Li Si as chancellor, he levelled the walls of the provincial and district cities and melted down the swords and other weapons to show that they would no longer be used. He also saw to it that Qin did not parcel out so much as a foot of territory in fiefs. He did not set up his sons or younger brothers as kings, or his meritorious ministers as feudal lords, intending in this way to insure that the empire would never again be troubled by warfare.

In the thirty-fourth year of his reign (213 BC) the First Emperor set out wine in his palace in Xianyang. The academicians and the archery captain Zhou Qingchen eulogized the might and virtue of the First Emperor. But a man of Qi named Chunyu Yue stepped forward and delivered this admonition: "I have heard that the kings of the Yin and Zhou dynasties ruled for 1,000 years or more, for they enfeoffed their sons and younger brothers and their meritorious ministers to aid and support them. Now Your Majesty possesses all within the seas, yet your sons and younger brothers are mere commoners. If a Tian Chang or the six great ministers of Jin should suddenly appear, you would be without support or assistance, and how could you be saved?¹⁸¹ I have never heard of any undertaking that failed to imitate the example of antiquity and yet was able to endure for long! And Zhou Qingchen and the others, by flattering you to your face, are simply compounding Your Majesty's error — they are no loyal subjects!"

The First Emperor referred the matter to the chancellor for discussion. The chancellor considered that the proposal was mistaken and disapproved of such assertions. He submitted a letter to the emperor that read:

In the past the empire was fragmented and in confusion and no one was able to unite it. Therefore the feudal rulers rose up side by side, all of them declaiming on antiquity in order to disparage the present, parading empty words in order to confuse the facts. Men prided themselves on their private theories and criticized the measures adopted by their superiors.

Now Your Majesty has unified all under heaven, distinguishing black from white and establishing a single source of authority. Yet these adherents of private theories band together to criticize the laws and directives. Hearing that an order has been handed down, each one proceeds to discuss it in the light of his private theories. At court they disapprove in their hearts; outside they debate it in the street. They hold it a mark of fame to criticize the ruler, regard it as lofty to take a dissenting stance, and they lead the lesser officials in fabricating slander. If behaviour such as this is permitted, then in upper circles the authority of the ruler will be compromised, and in lower ones cliques will form. Therefore it should be prohibited.

I request that all writings, the *Odes*, the *Documents*, and the sayings of

the hundred schools of philosophy, be discarded and done away with. Anyone who has failed to discard such books within thirty days from the time this prohibition reaches them shall be subjected to tattooing and condemned to "wall down" labour. The books that are to be exempted are those on medicine, divination, agriculture, and forestry. Anyone wishing to study these should have a law official for his teacher.

The First Emperor approved this proposal and accordingly confiscated and did away with the *Odes*, *Documents*, and sayings of the hundred schools in order to make the common people ignorant and see to it that no one in the empire used the past to criticize the present.

The clarification of laws and regulations and fixing of statutes all began with the First Emperor. He unified the system of writing, built detached palaces and pleasure halls, and made a tour throughout the empire. The following year he once more went on a tour, expelling the barbarians on all four sides. Li Si played an important role in all these activities.

Li Si's eldest son You was governor of the province of Sanchuan. All Li Si's sons were married to daughters of the Qin ruling family, and his daughters were all married to princes of the ruling family.

When Li You, the governor of Sanchuan, returned to Xianyang to make his report on government affairs, Li Si set out wine in his home and all the senior officials came to offer their congratulations, the carriages and outriders that crowded his gate and courtyard numbering in the thousands. Li Si sighed and said, "Ah, I have heard Xun Qing say that one must beware of too much prosperity! I started out as a commoner in Shangcai, one of the black-headed people of the lanes and alleys. But the emperor, not realizing how worthless and inept I am, has raised me up to all this. Among all his subjects, none stands higher than I do; mine may be called the pinnacle of wealth and honour. But when a thing reaches its pinnacle, it must decline. I cannot tell where my journey will end!"

In the thirty-seventh year (210 BC), the tenth month, the First Emperor set out on a trip, journeying to Kuaiji, then following along the seacoast till he reached Langya. The chancellor Li Si and the chief of the office of palace carriage Zhao Gao both accompanied him, bearing the imperial seals and tending to government affairs. The First Emperor had over twenty sons. The eldest, Fusu, had several times remonstrated with the emperor in an outspoken manner, and the emperor had sent him to oversee military affairs in Shang Province, where Meng Tian was in command. His youngest son Huhai, whom he was very fond of, had asked to join the expedition, and the emperor had allowed him to do so, but none of the other sons were in attendance.

In the seventh month, when the First Emperor reached Sand Hill, he fell gravely ill. He ordered Zhao Gao to send a letter to Prince Fusu saying, "Hand over your troops to Meng Tian and come to Xianyang to join the funeral cortege and carry out the burial." The letter had already been

sealed but had not yet been handed over to the courier when the First Emperor passed away.

The letter and the imperial seals were all in the possession of Zhao Gao. Only Prince Huhai, the chancellor Li Si, Zhao Gao, and five or six of the trusted eunuchs knew that the First Emperor had passed away. None of the other officials were aware of the fact.

In view of the fact that the emperor had died away from the capital and that no heir had been designated, Li Si decided to keep the matter secret, placing the emperor's body in a carriage that could be opened for cooling or closed for warmth. The officials in attendance continued to deliver state papers and food to the carriage as before, and the eunuchs immediately marked the papers with the emperor's approval and handed them down from the closed carriage.

Zhao Gao kept the letter to Prince Fusu and the imperial seals in his possession and said to Prince Huhai, "The emperor has passed away and has left no edict enfeoffing his sons as kings, but only a letter for his eldest son. When the eldest son arrives, he will be set up as August Emperor, and you will be without so much as a foot of territory. What will you do?"

Huhai said, "That should be obvious! I have heard that an enlightened ruler knows his subjects, and an enlightened father knows his sons. If our father has left orders that there are to be no enfeoffments, then what can we, the sons, say?"

"Not so!" said Zhao Gao. "At this moment the decision of who shall take control of the empire lies with you, me, and the chancellor alone. I beg you to think of this! To make others your subjects or to be a subject of others, to control men or be controlled by them — these two are so far apart one cannot even speak of them in the same day!"

Huhai said, "To cast aside an elder brother and set up a younger one goes against righteousness. To fail to honour a father's edict out of fear of death goes against filial duty. To be poor in ability and lacking in talent and rely solely on the efforts of others goes against possibility. All three are offences against virtue. The empire would never consent, I would be in a position of peril, and the altars of the soil and grain would never accept my sacrifices."

Zhao Gao said, "Kings Tang and Wu killed their sovereigns but the world called them righteous; no one accused them of being disloyal. The lord of Wey killed his father but the state of Wey lauded his virtue and Confucius made a record of the event; no one said he was lacking in filial piety.¹⁸² Great actions do not wait on petty scruples, abundant virtue does not trouble with niceties, and the hundred officials do not all work for the same ends. He who looks after the little and forgets the big will surely pay for it later; he who vacillates and entertains doubts later will have regrets. Only dare to be decisive and the gods and spirits will step aside, so that thereafter you may win success. I beg you to see this through!"

Huhai sighed and said, "The royal demise has not yet been announced,

the burial rites are not completed — how can it be right to consult the chancellor on such a matter?”

Zhao Gao said, “The time, the time! No leisure for planning now. Load up the provisions, set the horses to galloping, and just hope we get there in time!”

When Huhai had agreed to do as Zhao Gao proposed, the latter said, “If we do not consult with the chancellor, I am afraid we cannot carry this off successfully. Let me consult with him on your behalf.”

Then he went and spoke to the chancellor Li Si in these words: “The emperor has passed away, leaving a letter for his eldest son instructing him to meet the funeral cortege at Xianyang and designating him as heir. But the letter has not yet been sent. The emperor has passed away, but no one is aware of it yet. The letter addressed to his eldest son, along with the imperial seals, are all in the possession of Huhai. The choice of an heir apparent depends solely upon your say, my lord, and mine. What do you intend to do?”

Li Si said, “How can you speak words that might destroy the nation! This is no matter for a ruler’s subjects to be debating!”

Zhao Gao said, “Consider for yourself, my lord. In ability, can you compare to Meng Tian? In accumulation of merit, can you compare to Meng Tian? In devising long-range plans that never fail, can you compare to Meng Tian? In the freedom from enmity he enjoys in the world, can you compare to Meng Tian? In the length of friendship and the confidence he enjoys with the eldest son, can you compare to Meng Tian?”

Li Si replied, “On none of these five counts can I compare to Meng Tian. But why do you tax me so severely?”

Zhao Gao said, “I have never been anything but a mere lackey of the inner chambers. But I had the good fortune to be recognized for my ability with the writing brush and scraper, and to be promoted to service in the Qin palace, where I have handled affairs for more than twenty years now. In that time, however, I have never seen any former chancellor or meritorious minister of the Qin who was enfeoffed and was able to pass his fief on to his heirs in the next generation. All in the end have been condemned and put to death.

“The emperor has over twenty sons, and you are familiar with them all. The eldest son is strong willed and brave, one who trusts others and inspires loyalty in his men. Once he has ascended the throne he will undoubtedly appoint Meng Tian as his chancellor. And it is quite obvious, my lord, that you will no longer be able to retain your seals as a marquis when you retire to your native village.

“I was commanded by the emperor to give instruction to Huhai, tutoring him in legal matters for several years, and I have never known him to make a mistake. He is kindhearted and generous, thinks little of wealth but much of his men, is keen in mind and reserved in speech, punctilious in ritual and respectful of others. None of the other sons of the Qin ruling family can

match him. He should be appointed heir. I hope you will consider the matter and make the choice."

Li Si said, "Please return to your post. I will honour the command of my sovereign and heed the mandate of Heaven. What 'choice' could come about through my consideration?"

Zhao Gao said, "Safety can be endangered, danger can be rendered safe. If one cannot choose between safety and danger, then what are sages for?"

Li Si said, "I was a commoner from the lanes and alleys of Shangcai. The emperor favoured me by promoting me to the office of chancellor and enfeoffing me as a marquis, and my sons and grandsons have all risen to positions of honour and enjoy generous stipends. And since the preservation and safety of the nation have been entrusted to me, how could I betray that charge? A loyal subject, whatever his hopes, does not hesitate to face death, but a filial son, no matter how diligent, avoids courting danger. That is because each man has his own duty to perform. I beg you to say no more of this, or you will force me to commit a crime!"

Zhao Gao said, "They say that the sage keeps shifting, never constant, going along with change and following the times. He sees the tip and understands the root, observes the finger and perceives where it is pointing. It is in the nature of things to change — how can you devise any constant rule?"

"At this moment the fate of the empire hangs on Huhai, and I can divine where his ambitions lie. To try to control the inside by imposing force from without may be termed delusion, and to try to control superiors from an inferior position deserves the name of villainy. But when autumn frost descends, then the grass and flowers wither, and when spring waters stir and flow, the ten thousand things come to life. This is the natural and inevitable consequence. How can you be so slow to see it!"

Li Si said, "I have heard that the state of Jin changed its choice of heir apparent and three generations of turmoil ensued. Duke Huan of Qi contended with his brothers for the throne and death was the outcome. The tyrant Zhou put his kinsmen to death, refusing to heed remonstrance, and his kingdom became a wilderness, its altars of the soil and grain imperilled. All three offended against Heaven, and their ancestral temples refused to accept their sacrifices. I am the kind of person I am — what use in talking to me of plots?"

Zhao Gao said, "When superiors and inferiors are in accord, things will endure for long; when inside and outside are as one, there will be no back or front to affairs. If you listen to my counsel, you can keep possession of your fief and title, and for generation after generation your heirs will call themselves marquis. In longevity you will rival the immortal Prince Qiao and Red Pine, in wisdom you will be like Confucius or Mo Zi. But if you permit this occasion to slip away, then the disaster that will extend to your sons and grandsons is enough to make the heart turn cold! The skilful man turns disaster into blessing. How will you proceed?"

Li Si looked up at the heavens in sorrow and, shedding tears and heaving a great sigh, said, "Alas, that I alone should face such troubled times! I failed to die when I should have — now what fate can I hope for?"

With this Li Si finally agreed to Zhao Gao's proposal. Zhao Gao then reported this to Huhai, saying, "I request permission to relay your command as heir apparent to the chancellor. He will surely not dare to disobey."

The three then plotted together, pretending they had received an edict from the First Emperor instructing the chancellor to set up Huhai as heir apparent. They wrote a new letter to be sent to the eldest son, Prince Fusu, saying: "I, the sovereign, have been touring the empire and performing sacrifices to the deities of the famous mountains in order to prolong my life. Fusu and General Meng Tian, commanding an army of several hundred thousand, have garrisoned the border for over ten years now. They have been wholly unable to advance, but have thrown away the lives of numerous of their men without winning so much as a foot of territory. Not only that, but Fusu has several times sent letters openly criticizing and slandering my conduct, night and day resentful and impatient because he cannot leave his post and return to the capital to become heir apparent. Fusu has not acted as a filial son. I present him with a sword so he may settle the matter for himself. General Meng Tian, while residing on the border with Fusu, has done nothing to correct his faults, though he must be aware of Fusu's plots. As a subject he has acted disloyally. I present him with the opportunity to take his own life, directing him to hand over his troops to the assistant general Wang Li."

They sealed the letter with the seal of the emperor and dispatched one of Huhai's followers to deliver it to Fusu in Shang Province.

When the messenger arrived and presented the letter, Fusu retired weeping to his inner quarters, intending to commit suicide. But Meng Tian stopped him, saying, "His Majesty has been residing away from the capital and has not yet designated an heir apparent. He has put me in command of 300,000 men to guard the border and ordered you to act as supervisor. Such assignments are among the most crucial in the whole empire. Now one messenger appears and immediately you prepare to commit suicide. How do you know that this is not some sort of deception? I urge you to ask for confirmation. If the order is confirmed and you then take your life, no one can say you acted tardily."

The messenger several times urged the prince to act. Fusu, being a warmhearted person, said to Meng Tian, "If a father instructs his son to commit suicide, how can he ask for confirmation of the order?" He proceeded to take his life.

Meng Tian, however, was unwilling to commit suicide, and so the messenger turned him over to the law officials, who imprisoned him at Yangzhou. The messenger then returned to the capital to report on his mission.

Huhai, Li Si, and Zhao Gao were delighted, and when the funeral cortege

arrived in Xianyang, the burial was carried out. The heir apparent then ascended the throne, being known as the Second Emperor, with Zhao Gao as chief of palace attendants constantly by his side in the inner palace to tend to affairs of state.

One day when the Second Emperor was at leisure, he summoned Zhao Gao to consult with him. "A person lives in this world no longer than the time it takes for a team of six thoroughbreds to gallop past a crack in the wall," he said. "I want to savour all the pleasures of eye and ear, to exhaust the delights of heart and mind, insuring the safety of the ancestral temples and joy to the 10,000 clans, remaining long in possession of the empire and living out my allotted years. Is there some way to attain this?"

Zhao Gao replied, "This is something that is possible for a worthy ruler, but prohibited to one who is benighted and unruly. I hope you will allow me to speak on the matter, though I venture to do so with a frankness that merits the death penalty, and I ask Your Majesty to reflect a little on what I say.

"The other princes and the chief ministers are all suspicious of the plot that was carried out at Sand Hill. The other princes are all elder brothers of Your Majesty, and the chief ministers were put in office by the former emperor. Now Your Majesty has just come to the throne, and these persons are disgruntled in mind and wholly unsubmissive, perhaps even to the point of rebellion. Meng Tian is already dead, but Meng Yi is in command of troops in the outlying area. I am filled with alarm and trepidation, only fearing that your life may be cut short. How could Your Majesty possibly enjoy the kind of pleasures you speak of?"

"What should I do then?" asked the Second Emperor.

Zhao Gao said, "Make the laws sterner and penalties more severe. See that persons charged with guilt implicate others as well, and that punishments extend to the families of the criminals. Wipe out the chief ministers and sow dissension among kin, enrich those who are poor, elevate those who are humble, rid yourself of the old officials appointed by the former emperor and surround yourself with men who are close to and can be trusted by Your Majesty. Then all gratitude for personal favour will be directed toward Your Majesty, harm will be expelled and devious plots thwarted. There will be none among the officials not enriched by your largesse, the recipient of generous bounty. Your Majesty may then rest easy in mind, indulge your wishes, and enjoy delight to the full. No plan could be better than this!"

The Second Emperor, approving of Zhao Gao's suggestion, proceeded to invent further laws and ordinances. When any of the officials or princes of the ruling family were accused of a crime, they were immediately handed over to Zhao Gao with orders for him to examine and punish them. He put to death Meng Yi and others of the chief ministers, had twelve of the princes executed in the market place of Xianyang, and executed and tore apart the bodies of ten princesses at Du. The wealth and goods of the condemned

persons were confiscated by the government. Those who were implicated along with the guilty parties were too numerous even to be counted.

One of the princes named Gao contemplated fleeing, but he feared that the members of his family would be arrested. He accordingly submitted a memorial to the throne which read: "While the former emperor was still in good health, I was favoured with gifts of food when in the palace and carriages when I went abroad. Robes from the imperial wardrobe and prize horses from the palace stables were graciously bestowed on me. I should by rights have followed the former emperor in death, but I failed to do so. As a son I have acted in an unfilial manner, and as a subject I have been disloyal, and one who acts disloyally wins no fame in the world. I ask leave to follow the former emperor in death, requesting that my body may be buried at the foot of the mausoleum at Mt. Li. I can only hope that the emperor will take pity and grant my request."

When the memorial was submitted, Huhai was delighted. Summoning Zhao Gao, he showed him the memorial and said, "I've got them on the run now, haven't I!"

Zhao Gao said, "Your subjects are so worried about death they have no time for anything else! Where would they get the leisure to plot rebellion?"

Huhai approved the memorial and presented the man with 100,000 cash to cover the cost of his burial. Thus the laws and regulations, the punishments and penalties became more numerous and more severe with each day. Each man began to fear for his own safety, and those who longed to revolt were many. In addition there was the construction work on the Epang Palace and the building of fast roads and direct roads; taxes and levies grew increasingly heavy and calls for garrison duty and corvée labour were endless.

At this point Chen She and Wu Guang, leaders of a group of garrison soldiers in Chu, began a rebellion, rising up in the area east of the mountains. Heroes and brave men appeared on all sides, setting themselves up as marquises and kings and challenging the Qin rule, their soldiers advancing all the way to Hongmen before being driven back.¹⁸³

Li Si several times requested a moment of the emperor's time so he could remonstrate with him, but the Second Emperor refused to heed him. Instead he berated Li Si, saying, "I have a few opinions of my own! I have heard from Master Han that when Emperor Yao ruled the world, his halls were only three feet off the ground, the speckled beams were not planed, and the thatch of the roofs was left untrimmed. Even someone lodging in a humble inn was not as meanly housed as this. Winter days he wore a deerskin, summer days a robe of kudzu cloth. With coarse millet for food, a soup of greens, he ate his meal from an earthen pot and sipped from an earthen jar. Even the lot of a gatekeeper could not have been as cramped as this.

"Emperor Yu chiselled through Dragon Gate and opened up Daxia, clearing courses for the nine rivers, bordering them with nine

embankments, and cutting a channel for the stagnant water so that it flowed to the sea. He worked till there was no more down on his thighs or hair on his shins, till his hands and feet were calloused and his face was burned black, and in the end he died far from the capital and was buried at Kuaiji. Even the toil of a slave taken prisoner in the wars could not have been more arduous than this.¹⁸⁴

“But if one has the honour of possessing the empire, he surely does not want to weary his body and strain his spirit by lodging like someone in a humble inn, eating the fare of a gatekeeper, and toiling with his hands like a slave taken in the wars! This is a task for a mere dullard to work at, certainly not the undertaking of a man of worth.

“When a man of worth possesses the empire, his sole concern is to use the empire to gratify himself. This is why it is considered an honour to hold possession of the empire. A truly worthy ruler should be capable of bringing security to the empire and order to the 10,000 people. But now if I cannot even benefit myself, how can I hope to bring order to the empire at large? That is why I wish to indulge my whims, broaden my desires, enjoy for long the pleasures of the empire, and be free from harm. How shall I go about it?”

Li Si's son Li You was governor of the province of Sanchuan, but when Wu Guang and his band of robbers invaded the western part of the province and passed through, he was unable to stop them. The Qin general Zhang Han eventually defeated Wu Guang's forces, but envoys were sent to Sanchuan one after the other to investigate the matter. Li Si was strongly reprimanded and asked why, since he occupied one of the three highest posts, he had permitted such outbreaks of bandits. Fearful of what might happen, but reluctant to lose his title and stipend, Li Si did not know how to proceed. So, toadying to the Second Emperor's wishes and hoping to get into his good graces, he wrote a letter replying to emperor's question in these words:

The worthy ruler invariably uses all the means at his command to apply the techniques of supervision and reprimand. When supervised and reprimanded, subjects do not dare do otherwise than exhaust their abilities in serving their ruler. In this way the roles of ruler and subject are fixed, the duties of superior and inferior made clear, and thereafter there will be no one in the empire, whether worthy man or dullard, who will fail to exert his utmost strength to carry out his responsibilities in serving his ruler. Hence the ruler alone imposes controls on the empire, and is himself subject to no control whatever. So he can experience the height of enjoyment. Can a worthy and enlightened ruler fail to look into this matter?

Therefore Master Shen said, “One who possesses the empire but does not enjoy himself as he pleases may be said to be fettered by the empire.”¹⁸⁵ Indeed, he is just that. If one cannot supervise and reprimand others, but on the contrary wears himself out on behalf of the people of the empire, as

emperors Yao and Yu did, he deserves to be called fettered. If he cannot apply the enlightened methods of Master Shen and Master Han, carry out the procedures for supervision and reprimand, and thereby exploit the empire for his own gratification, but merely makes it his duty to weary his body and strain his spirit in order to serve the hundred clans, then he is a lackey of the black-headed people, not the caretaker of the empire. How could such a man be called honoured?

If you make others serve you, then you are honoured and others are lowly. But if you must serve others, then you are lowly and others are honoured. Therefore serving others is a lowly act, but to be served by others is to be honoured. From antiquity to the present, there has never been a time when this was not so. All those who in ancient times were esteemed as worthy were held so because they were honoured. And those who were despised as dullards were viewed so because they were lowly. Yao and Yu, as we have seen, undertook to serve the empire. If we esteem them because of it, then we are mistaking the very reason why men are honoured as worthy! This is a grave error. Is it not fitting that they should in fact be called the fettered ones? Their fault was that they failed to supervise and reprimand.

So Master Han has said, "A kindly mother may have a no-good son, but in a strict household there are no unruly slaves."¹⁸⁶ This is because the slaves know they are certain to be punished. According to the laws of Lord Shang, anyone discarding ashes in the roadway was subject to penalty. Discarding ashes is a minor offence, and imposing a penalty may seem a heavy punishment. But it is in fact only the enlightened ruler who can supervise and keep careful track of even minor crimes. And if he can supervise and keep careful track of even minor crimes, then how much more so in the case of major crimes. Therefore the people do not dare commit offences.

Therefore Master Han said, "If it's a scrap of common cloth, even an ordinary person will pick it up, but if it's 100 taels of molten gold, even Robber Zhi won't touch it. It's not that the ordinary person is so profoundly greedy for a scrap of common cloth and Robber Zhi so few in his desires, or that the latter despises 100 taels of gold. But because he knows that if he touches it his hand will surely be injured, Robber Zhi will not touch even 100 taels. And because he knows he will not be punished for the act, the ordinary person will not pass up even a scrap of cloth."¹⁸⁷

Hence even the nimble Louji could not easily climb a city wall fifty feet high, but lame sheep can graze on top of Mt. Tai, which is 100 times higher. If Louji has difficulty climbing up a mere fifty feet, how can lame sheep manage ten times that height with ease? Because the steepness of the climb differs in the two cases. The reason the enlightened ruler and the sage king can retain his lofty position for so long, continuing to wield might and authority and monopolizing the benefits of the empire, is not that he has some unusual way of proceeding, but because he can decide things for himself, be thorough in his supervising and reprimanding, and certain in the

application of harsh penalties. Therefore the empire does not dare disobey him. But if one does not take the steps needed to prevent disobedience, and instead proceeds like the kindly mother who spoils her child, he cannot be said to have understood the secret of how to be a sage. And if he cannot apply the techniques of a sage, he will find himself cast out and made a lackey of the empire, and then what will he do? Can one help but pity him?

When frugal and straightlaced men, men of benevolence and righteousness,¹⁸⁸ stand at court, then wild and abandoned pleasures cease. When deliverers of sharp reprimand and masters of discourse stand by the ruler's side, then carefree wishes are cut short. When men of ardour, who would die for their principles, gain recognition in the world, then frivolous delights come to an end. Therefore the enlightened ruler knows how to rid himself of these three types of men. He alone applies the techniques of the ruler, using them to insure docile and obedient subjects and to put into effect his enlightened laws. Therefore he is revered and his authority is weighty. Generally speaking, if one would be a worthy ruler, he must be willing to defy the world and remake its customs, to do away with what he dislikes and encourage what pleases him. Then while he is alive he will be revered and command great authority, and when he is dead he will enjoy a posthumous title expressive of his worth and intelligence.

Thus the enlightened sovereign decides things for himself, and therefore power never resides with his ministers. Hence he can obliterate the path of benevolence and righteousness, stop up the mouths of the speechifiers, make it hard for men of ardour to carry out their deeds, close the eyes and ears of others and rely solely on his own sight and hearing. Then when he goes abroad he cannot be swayed by the men of benevolence and righteousness, the men of ardour, and at court he cannot be persuaded by the arguments of the remonstrators, the deliverers of impassioned protest. Therefore he can blithely walk his own way, indulging the desires of his heart, and no one will dare challenge him.

When he has done this, then he may be said to understand the techniques of Shen Buhai and Han Fei and to apply the laws of Lord Shang. And when laws are applied and techniques clearly understood, I have never heard of the empire being in disorder. Therefore they say: The way of the king is simple and easy to carry out, but only an enlightened ruler can do so.

When such a situation is achieved, it may be called the true application of supervision and reprimand. When supervision and reprimand are truly applied, then subjects will be free of evil. When subjects are free of evil, then the empire will be at peace. When the empire is at peace, then the ruler will be respected. When the ruler is respected, then supervision and reprimand will be applied with certainty. When supervision and reprimand are applied with certainty, then what is sought will be gained. When what is sought may be gained, then the state as a whole will be rich. When the state as a whole is rich, the ruler will enjoy abundant delight. Therefore, if the

technique of supervision and reprimand is correctly applied, then one cannot fail to get whatever one wishes. It will be as much as the officials and populace can do just to try to save themselves from error, so how would they dare to plot insurrection?

When this is done, then the way of an emperor is made complete, and one may be said to have clearly understood the techniques of ruler and subject. Even if Shen Buhai and Han Fei returned to life again, they could add nothing more!

When the letter was submitted, the Second Emperor was pleased and proceeded to carry out supervision and reprimand activities with increasing severity. Those who squeezed the largest amount of taxes out of the people were deemed model officials; "Men like this may truly be said to be supervising and reprimanding!" the Second Emperor would say. Half of all the people passing along the roads had suffered punishment, and the bodies of the dead daily piled up in the market place. Those who put the largest numbers of people to death were called loyal ministers; "Men like this may truly be said to be supervising and reprimanding!" the Second Emperor would say.

Earlier, when Zhao Gao was acting as chief of palace attendants, he put many persons to death or did away with them for reasons of private enmity, and he was afraid that when the chief ministers came to court to report on matters of state, they would speak ill of him. He accordingly advised the Second Emperor, saying, "The reason the Son of Heaven is held in honour is that only his voice is heard and none of the officials are allowed to look on his face. Hence he refers to himself by the special pronoun *zhen*. Now Your Majesty is young in years and is not yet thoroughly conversant with matters of state. If when you are seated before the court you should make some error in your demotions or promotions to office, you would be exposing your shortcomings before the chief ministers. This is no way to go about displaying godlike enlightenment to the empire.

"For the time being, Your Majesty might better remain with folded hands in the inner recesses of the palace, where I and the other attendants who are versed in the law may wait on you. Then when some matter comes up, we can assist you in disposing of it. The high officials will not dare to refer questionable matters to the throne, and the world will praise you as a sage monarch."

The Second Emperor followed his advice. He no longer sat in the court and showed himself to the high officials, but remained within the recesses of the palace. Zhao Gao constantly attended him and handled affairs of state, so that all decisions in such matters were made by Zhao Gao.

Zhao Gao, having heard that Li Si had commented on this situation, went to see the chancellor and said, "The robber bands east of the mountains have grown numerous, but at the moment the emperor is busy calling out more labourers to work on the Epang Palace or busying himself with dogs

and horses and other useless activities. I would like to reprimand him, but my position is a lowly one. This is really a matter for you, sir. Why don't you reprimand him?"

Li Si replied, "You are quite right. I have wanted to do so for some time. But nowadays the ruler does not sit in the court. He stays deep within the palace, so I have no way to relay to him what I would like to say, and no chance to see him when I wish to!"

"If you really intend to reprimand him," said Zhao Gao, "then allow me to assist you. I will see when he is at leisure and let you know."

Zhao Gao waited until the Second Emperor was feasting and enjoying himself in the company of his women, and then sent a messenger to inform the chancellor that the emperor was at leisure and could be approached on matters of state. The chancellor proceeded to the palace gate and sent in word requesting an interview.

When this had happened three times, the emperor exclaimed angrily, "There are plenty of ordinary times when I am at leisure, but the chancellor never comes. Then, as soon as I am enjoying myself in private, immediately he appears and wants to talk about state affairs. Is it because I'm so young that he treats me this way, or because he thinks I'm stupid?"

"This could be dangerous!" said Zhao Gao, seizing the opportunity. "The chancellor was a party to the plot at Sand Hill. But now Your Majesty has become emperor, and the chancellor's position is no higher than before. Perhaps he's hoping he can slice off a piece of territory and call himself a king.

"Also, I would never have ventured to mention this if Your Majesty had not asked me, but the chancellor's eldest son Li You is the governor of Sanchuan Province. Chen She and the other bandit leaders in Chu are all men from the districts around the chancellor's home area. That is why, when the Chu bandits marched brazenly through the province of Sanchuan, the governor stayed within his city walls and was unwilling to attack. I have heard that letters went back and forth between the two parties, though, since I do not as yet have clear proof, I have not ventured to mention this. There is also the fact that the chancellor resides outside the palace and so can wield greater authority than Your Majesty."

The Second Emperor agreed with Zhao Gao and wanted to have the chancellor subjected to investigation, but he was afraid there would be no proof of wrongdoing. He therefore sent an envoy to look into the charges that the governor of Sanchuan had been in communication with the bandits.

Li Si learned of this, but at that time the Second Emperor was at the palace at Sweet Springs, amusing himself with wrestling bouts and entertainments put on by actors, and so Li Si was unable to see him. Instead he submitted a memorial describing Zhao Gao's faults in these words:

I have heard that where a subject could be mistaken for the ruler, there is sure to be danger to the state, and where a wife could be mistaken for the

husband, there is sure to be danger to the family. Now a certain high minister of Your Majesty arbitrarily dispenses profit and harm in a way no different from Your Majesty. This is a most undesirable situation.

In the past, when the supervisor of walls Zihan was prime minister of the state of Song, he personally administered punishments, doing so in a dictatorial manner, and by the end of the year he had succeeded in deposing the ruler. When Tian Chang was in the service of Duke Jian of Qi, he enjoyed a title and rank unrivalled in the state, and the private wealth of his family equalled that of the ducal house. Distributing bounty and conferring favours, he won over the common people under him and his fellow officials in higher circles. Scheming in secret to seize control of Qi, he killed Zai Yu in the courtyard, assassinated Duke Jian at court, and eventually made himself ruler of Qi. These are events known to the whole world.

Now Zhao Gao, with his evil and unbridled ambitions and dangerous and treasonable ways, resembles Zihan, the prime minister of Song, while in the private wealth he has accumulated he is like the Tian family of Qi. Following a treacherous path that combines the deeds of Zihan and Tian Chang, he is undermining Your Majesty's authority, hoping to do as Han Yi did when he was prime minister to King An of Hann.¹⁸⁹ If Your Majesty does not give thought to this, I fear he will turn traitor!

The Second Emperor replied, "What is this! Zhao Gao is a eunuch with many years of service. But he does not act willfully when sure of himself, or entertain thoughts of disaffection when he feels threatened. He has been scrupulous in conduct and practised good ways in all his service up to now. He has advanced through loyalty and maintained his position through good faith. I, the sovereign, personally consider him a man of worth. Why do you distrust him?

"I was a young man when I lost my father, and I had no knowledge of state affairs and no experience in governing the people. And you were already well along in years. I was afraid that I would become cut off from the empire. If I had not turned to Mr Zhao for help, whom could I have employed? Mr Zhao is a man of integrity and diligence. He understands other people's feelings, and he knows how to please me. I hope you will not distrust him any longer!"

Li Si said, "I cannot agree. Zhao Gao is from a lowly background. He has no understanding of principles, but is insatiable in his greed and never ceases his quest for gain. In rank and authority he is second to the ruler, and his hopes and desires are boundless. Therefore I say he is dangerous!"

The Second Emperor had from past time trusted Zhao Gao and was afraid that Li Si would put him to death. He therefore informed Zhao Gao in private of the situation.

Zhao Gao said, "I'm the only one the chancellor is worried about. Once I'm dead, the chancellor thinks he can do as Tian Chang did!"

With this the Second Emperor gave instructions that Li Si be handed over to the chief of palace attendants, ordering Zhao Gao to conduct an investigation and take appropriate measures. When Li Si was bound with shackles and taken to prison, he looked up at the heavens and said with a sigh, "This is sad work! How can one lay plans for an unprincipled ruler? In ancient times Jie put to death Guan Longfeng, Zhou put to death Prince Bi Gan, and King Fuchai of Wu put to death Wu Zixu. These three ministers were surely not disloyal, yet they could not escape death. They died because the ones they were loyal to were at fault. Now I cannot equal these three in wisdom, and the Second Emperor is far more unprincipled than Jie, Zhou, and Fuchai. It is only right that I die for my loyalty.

"How can the Second Emperor's reign fail to face disorder? Earlier he destroyed his brothers to make himself ruler, put to death his loyal ministers and elevated lowly persons in their stead, continued construction of the Epang Palace and burdened the empire with taxes and levies. It is not that I did not admonish him, but he would not heed me.

"The sage kings of antiquity as a rule observed moderation in food and drink, restricted the number of their carriages and implements and the size of their palaces. In issuing orders and initiating undertakings they prohibited what was costly and brought no benefit to the people. Therefore they were able to continue in power and their reigns were peaceful.

"But now we have one who turns viciously on his brothers and never stops to consider his offence, who mistreats and puts to death his loyal ministers with no thought of misfortune, who enlarges his palaces and increases the tax burden without any care for expenditure. Since he has committed these three types of actions, the empire no longer heeds him. Even now over half the empire has turned against him. But he fails to waken to the situation and continues to use Zhao Gao as his helper. I will live to see the insurrectionists enter Xianyang and the wild deer roam in the palace!"

The Second Emperor ordered Zhao Gao to press ahead with his investigation into the chancellor's guilt, accusing him of plotting rebellion in league with his son Li You. All their family members and retainers were taken into custody. Zhao Gao subjected Li Si to over 1,000 blows of the bastinado, till he could no longer endure the pain and falsely confessed to the charges.

The reason Li Si did not take his own life was that he had confidence in his eloquence and his past merits, and was in fact innocent of treasonous intentions. He thought that if the ruler would only permit him to submit a letter explaining his case, the Second Emperor would understand and bestow pardon on him. He therefore submitted the following letter from prison:

As chancellor I have governed the people for over thirty years, beginning in the era when Qin's lands were narrow and confined. In the time of the former king, Qin's territory did not measure over 1,000 *li* and its soldiers

numbered several hundred thousand. Exerting my paltry talents and diligently upholding the laws and commands, I sent out strategists in secret, providing them with gold and treasures and dispatching them to speak on our behalf at the courts of the feudal rulers. I also covertly stored up weapons, put the government policies in order, promoted military men to office and honoured meritorious ministers, seeing to it that they enjoyed appropriate titles and stipends. So in the end we were able to intimidate Hann and weaken Wei, defeat Yan and Zhao, conquer Qi and Chu, and eventually annex all the Six States, making prisoners of their kings and elevating the Qin ruler to the position of Son of Heaven. This was my first crime.

Though Qin's land was not without breadth to begin with, I went on to drive out the Hu and Mo barbarians in the north and to gain control of the Hundred Yue tribes of the south, in that way displaying Qin's might. This was my second crime. I heaped honour on the chief ministers, showering them with titles and position, and in that way insured their loyalty, which was my third crime. I set up altars of the soil and grain and repaired the ancestral temples, thus making clear the worth of the ruler — my fourth crime. I changed the regulations and made the weights and measures and ordinances uniform, promulgating them throughout the empire and thus bringing fame to the Qin dynasty — my fifth crime. I constructed direct and fast roads and built pleasure parks and scenic towers, impressing on all the privileges of the ruler — my sixth crime. I relaxed penalties and lessened taxes and levies, in that way enabling the ruler to win the hearts of the multitude, so that the 10,000 people would uphold him and never forget him even in death — my seventh crime.

This is the kind of subject I have been, and my crimes have long been deserving of death. But the ruler has graciously permitted me to go on exhausting my strength and ability down to the present time. I beg Your Majesty to consider this.

When the letter was submitted, Zhao Gao ordered his clerks to throw it away and not forward it to the emperor, saying, "How can a prisoner submit a letter to the throne!"

Zhao Gao had ten or more of his own retainers pretend to be from the imperial secretary or the master of guests and palace attendants and sent them one after another to examine Li Si once more on the charges. When Li Si would reply with truthful answers, however, Zhao Gao would immediately have him subjected to further beating. Later the Second Emperor sent a man to examine him, but Li Si, assuming he was the same as those who had examined him earlier, in the end refused to say anything more. He submitted to the charges, and the case was then referred to the emperor for sentencing.

The Second Emperor remarked with delight, "If it hadn't been for Mr Zhao, I would have been betrayed by the chancellor!"

Earlier, the Second Emperor had sent an envoy to investigate Li You, the governor of Sanchuan Province, but by the time the envoy arrived, the governor had already been attacked and killed by the rebel general Xiang Liang. The envoy returned to the capital just when Li Si was handed over to the law officials. Zhao Gao falsified all the reports to make it appear that there had been treasonable activity.

In the second year of the Second Emperor's reign (208 BC), the seventh month, Li Si was sentenced to undergo the five penalties and to be cut in two at the waist in the market place of Xianyang.¹⁹⁰

As Li Si left the prison, he was accompanied by his younger son, who had been imprisoned with him. Turning to his son, he said, "I wish you and I could once more take our yellow dog and go out the eastern gate of Shangcai to chase the wily rabbits. But there's little hope of that, is there!" Then father and son wept, and Li Si and all his three sets of relatives were executed.

After Li Si's death, the Second Emperor promoted Zhao Gao to the position of chancellor within the palace. All affairs of state, whether great or small, were summarily decided by Zhao Gao. To test the weight of his authority, he presented a deer to the emperor but called it a horse. The Second Emperor questioned those around him, saying, "Surely this is a deer!" But those in attendance all replied, "It is a horse."

The Second Emperor, alarmed, supposed he must be suffering from some sort of delusion. He summoned the Grand Diviner and had him conduct a divination. The Grand Diviner replied, "When Your Majesty performs the suburban sacrifice in the spring and autumn and attends the spirits of the ancestral temples, the fasting and purification are not carried out in a clearcut manner. Therefore this has come about. You should rely upon your manifold virtue and be clearcut in your fasting and purification."

The emperor therefore retired to the Shanglin Park to fast and purify himself, though in fact he spent the days amusing himself in gaming and hunting. When a passerby happened into the park, the Second Emperor himself shot and killed the man.

Zhao Gao instructed his daughter's husband, Yan Yue, the magistrate of Xianyang, to bring charges, saying that someone of unknown identity had wantonly killed a man and moved the body to the Shanglin Park.¹⁹¹ Zhao Gao then admonished the Second Emperor, saying, "The Son of Heaven for no reason has wantonly killed an innocent man. Such conduct is forbidden by the Lord on High and unacceptable to the gods and spirits. Heaven will send down misfortune! You must retire far from the palace and carry out sacrifices!"

The Second Emperor accordingly left the capital and took up residence in the Wangyi Palace, remaining there for three days. Zhao Gao forged an edict to the imperial guards, ordering them all to don white clothing, hold their weapons in readiness, and face the inner chambers of the palace. He

himself entered and announced to the Second Emperor, "The rebel forces from east of the mountains have arrived in great numbers!" The Second Emperor climbed the observation tower and, looking out and seeing the guards, was terrified. Zhao Gao then threatened him until he had forced him to commit suicide.

Zhao Gao took the imperial seals and hung them from his own belt, but none of the hundred officials in attendance on the emperor would obey him. He mounted the throne room, but the throne room shook three times as though it would collapse. Zhao Gao realized then that Heaven would not sanction his action and that none of the officials would agree to it, and so he summoned a grandson of the First Emperor and turned over the seals to him.¹⁹²

After the grandson, Ziyang, had become ruler, he was fearful of what might happen and, pleading illness, declined to attend to affairs of state. Instead he plotted with a eunuch named Han Tan and his son to kill Zhao Gao. When Zhao Gao came to visit the ruler and inquire about his illness, Ziyang called him in and then had Han Tan stab and kill him. All of Zhao Gao's three sets of relatives were executed.

Three months after Ziyang became ruler, the forces of the governor of Pei entered the Wu Pass and made their way to Xianyang. All of the hundred officials deserted the Qin and none offered any resistance. Ziyang came with his wife and children, tying a rope around his neck and surrendering by the side of Zhi Road. The governor of Pei handed him over to the officials. When Xiang Yu arrived, he had Ziyang executed, and so Qin in the end lost the empire.

The Grand Historian remarks: Li Si, a man of the lanes and alleys, after visiting the various feudal rulers, entered the service of Qin, and because of a fortunate opening in circumstances was able to act as aide to the First Emperor, helping him to become emperor and himself occupying one of the three highest ministerial posts. He may be said to have been highly honoured for his services. Li Si understood the principles underlying the Six Classics, yet he did not strive for enlightened government as a means of repairing the ruler's defects. Instead, while clinging to his substantial title and stipend, he flattered and complied, whatever the demand, making government authority ever stricter and penalties harsher, heeding Zhao Gao's evil advice and casting aside the rightful heir to set up a younger son by a concubine. After the feudal lords had already revolted, he finally made an effort to admonish and correct, but by then it was far too late.

People all claim that Li Si exerted the utmost loyalty and in spite of that suffered death by the five penalties. But if we examine the root of the affair, we find it was very different from this popular appraisal. If he had truly been such a man, then his accomplishments would have been worthy to rank with those of the Duke of Zhou and the Duke of Shao.¹⁹³

SHI JI 88: THE BIOGRAPHY OF MENG TIAN

For the Qin he opened up new lands and increased the population. In the north he subdued the Xiongnu, established the frontier along the Yellow River, used the mountains as a defence, and created the region of Yuzhong. Thus I made “The Biography of Meng Tian”.

Meng Tian's ancestors were natives of the state of Qi. Meng Tian's grandfather, Meng Ao, came from Qi to enter the service of King Zhaoxiang of Qin, advancing to the position of a chief minister.

In the first year of the reign of King Zhuangxiang of Qin (250 BC) Meng Ao, acting as a general for Qin, attacked Hann and seized Chenggao and Xingyang, making them into the province of Sanchuan or Three Rivers. In the second year Meng Ao attacked Zhao and seized thirty-seven cities.

In the third year of the reign of the First Emperor (244 BC) Meng Ao attacked Hann and seized thirteen cities. In the fifth year (242 BC) he attacked Wei and seized twenty cities, making them into Dong Province. In the seventh year (240 BC) Meng Ao died.

Meng Ao's son was named Wu, and Wu's son was named Tian. Tian at one time served as a law official and handled legal documents.

In the twenty-third year of the First Emperor (224 BC) Meng Wu, acting as an assistant general of Qin, joined Wang Jian in an attack on Chu. They inflicted a major defeat and brought about the death of the Chu leader Xiang Yan. In the twenty-fourth year, Meng Wu attacked Chu and captured the king of Chu.

Meng Tian's younger brother was Meng Yi. In the twenty-sixth year of the First Emperor (221 BC), because of the distinguished service rendered by his family for succeeding generations, Meng Tian was appointed a Qin general. He attacked Qi, inflicting a major defeat, and was honoured with the post of prefect of the capital.

Qin, having completed its unification of the empire, dispatched Meng Tian to lead a force of 300,000 men and advance north, expelling the Rong and Di barbarians and taking control of the region south of the bend of the Yellow River. He set about constructing the Great Wall, following the contours of the land and utilizing the narrow defiles to set up frontier posts. The wall began at Lintao and ran east to Liaodong, extending for a distance of over 10,000 *li*.¹⁹⁴ Crossing the Yellow River, it followed the Yang Mountains, twisting and turning as it proceeded north. Meng Tian remained in the field for over ten years, residing in Shang Province.

At this time Meng Tian's might had struck terror into the Xiongnu people. The First Emperor treated the members of the Meng family with extreme

favour, trusting them and assigning them to office because of their worth. He was particularly close to Meng Yi, who advanced to the position of a chief minister. Outside the palace, Meng Yi rode in the same carriage as the emperor; at court he stood in the imperial presence. Meng Tian was entrusted with affairs on the foreign front, while Meng Yi constantly took part in the planning of internal affairs, and both enjoyed a reputation for loyalty and good faith. As a result, none of the other generals or high ministers dared to compete with them.

Zhao Gao belonged to a distant branch of the various families of the Zhao surname. He had several younger brothers, all of whom were born in prison, his mother having been condemned to punishment. His family had thus for generations been lowly and humble. The First Emperor, having heard that Zhao Gao was diligent and well versed in legal matters, appointed him as chief of the office of palace carriages. Zhao Gao then entered the private service of Prince Huhai, the emperor's youngest son, instructing the prince in legal decisions.

When Zhao Gao was accused of a major crime, the emperor ordered Meng Yi to settle the case in accordance with the law. Meng Yi, not daring to make an exception in Zhao Gao's case, recommended that he be condemned to death and removed his name from the roster of officials. But because Zhao Gao was so knowledgeable in the handling of affairs, the emperor pardoned him and restored him to office.¹⁹⁵

The First Emperor was about to set out on a tour of the empire, proceeding through Jiuyuan and going directly to Sweet Springs. He accordingly ordered Meng Tian to construct a road that would run directly from Jiuyuan to Sweet Springs, cutting through mountains and filling in valleys for a distance of 1,800 *li*. The road had not yet been completed when, in the winter of the thirty-seventh year of his reign (210 BC), the First Emperor journeyed to Kuaiji and then, following the seacoast, turned north toward Langya. He fell ill along the way and ordered Meng Yi to return to the capital and carry out sacrifices to the mountains and rivers.

Before Meng Yi had reached the capital, the First Emperor, who had proceeded as far as Shaqiu, passed away. The fact was kept secret, so that none of the host of officials were aware of his death.

At this time the emperor was constantly attended by the chancellor Li Si, the emperor's youngest son, Prince Huhai, and Zhao Gao, chief of the office of palace carriage. Zhao Gao had always enjoyed great favour with Huhai and wanted to see him made successor to the throne. In addition, he hated Meng Yi because, when the latter investigated the criminal charges against him, he had refused to make an exception in his case. Hence he harboured murderous feelings toward him.

For these reasons Zhao Gao joined the chancellor Li Si and Prince Huhai in a secret plot to set up Huhai as heir apparent. When Huhai had been so designated, they dispatched an envoy to Prince Fusu and Meng Tian

accusing them of crimes and granting them the privilege of taking their own lives. Fusu did so at once, but Meng Tian, suspicious of the order, asked to have it confirmed. The envoy handed Meng Tian over to the law officials, replacing him with one of Li Si's retainers whom he appointed as military protector.¹⁹⁶ Then the envoy returned and reported on his mission.

When Huhai heard that Fusu had already killed himself, he wanted to pardon Meng Tian. But Zhao Gao was afraid that the Meng family might regain its prominence and once again have a say in government, and would bear a grudge against him. So when Meng Yi returned to the capital from his mission, Zhao Gao, pretending to be acting solely out of loyalty to Huhai, set about to wipe out the Meng family.

"I have heard that the former emperor had long wanted to promote a man of worth by setting you up as heir apparent," Zhao Gao said to Huhai. "But Meng Yi remonstrated with him, insisting that it would not do. If Meng Yi knew you were a worthy man but persisted in opposing your appointment, then he acted disloyally and was deliberately misleading the ruler. In my humble opinion, he had best be punished for it!"

Huhai, heeding this advice, had Meng Yi seized and put in bonds in Dai. Earlier he had had Meng Tian imprisoned in Yangzhou.

By this time the body of the First Emperor had arrived in Xianyang. After the interment, the heir apparent ascended the throne and is known as the Second Emperor. Zhao Gao was constantly by his side, day and night speaking ill of the Meng family, ferreting out their crimes and errors and promoting their impeachment.

Ziying¹⁹⁷ came forward to remonstrate with the Second Emperor, saying, "I have heard that in past times King Qian of Zhao put to death his loyal minister Li Mu and employed Yan Ju instead, that King Xi of Yan secretly heeded the advice of Jing Ke and broke his promise to the state of Qin, and that King Jian of Qi killed the ministers who had served him loyally for generations and adopted the advice of Hou Sheng. These three rulers, because they changed old ways, all lost their states and brought calamity upon themselves. Now the members of the Meng family are high officials and ministers of planning in Qin. As ruler, you may wish to rid yourself of them all in one morning, but I venture to think such a course is not right.

"I have heard that one who is reckless in planning can never govern a nation, and one who considers himself the sole possessor of wisdom can never preserve his ruler. If you put to death loyal ministers and in their place promote men who have done no exemplary deeds, then at home you will create distrust among your officials, and abroad will encourage disaffection in your fighting men. I venture to think that such a course is not right!"

Huhai did not listen to this advice, but dispatched the imperial secretary Qu Gong to go by relay carriage to Dai and confront Meng Yi with this order: "The former ruler wanted to appoint me as heir apparent, but you,

sir, opposed the move. Now the chancellor considers that you have acted disloyally, and that punishment should extend to the members of your family. As sovereign, I cannot bear to inflict such a penalty, and so I grant you the privilege of taking your own life. This is a mark of extreme favour and I trust you will act accordingly."

Meng Yi replied, "Am I accused of having failed to understand the intentions of the former ruler? But I served him from the time I was young, and continued to enjoy his favour until he passed away, so I had ample opportunity to know his thoughts. Or is it said that I failed to recognize the abilities of the heir apparent? But the heir apparent, alone among all the princes, always accompanied the ruler in his travels about the empire. I therefore had no reason to doubt that he was far superior in ability to the other princes. The former ruler's plan to raise him to the position of heir apparent must have been one that the ruler had contemplated for a number of years. With what words could I have dared to remonstrate with him, with what proposal of my own could I have ventured to question his plan?

"I do not dare employ fine phrases in hopes of avoiding death. It is just that I am ashamed to bring dishonour upon the former ruler's name. Therefore I ask Your Lordship to consider the matter with care, so that I may be condemned to death on charges that have true substance!

"Obedient service that insures long life — this is what the Way prizes; but punishing and killing — this is the end of the Way! In past times Duke Mu of Qin put to death three good ministers and accused Baili Xi of a crime worthy of execution, though the latter was guiltless. Therefore he was given the posthumous title Mu or 'Mistaken'.¹⁹⁸ King Zhaoxiang of Qin put to death Bai Qi, Lord Wuan; King Ping of Chu put to death Wu She; and King Fuchai of Wu put to death Wu Zixu. These four rulers all committed grave errors, and the world condemned them for it. As rulers they were thought to lack understanding, and the other feudal lords noted this in their records. Therefore it is said: 'One who governs by the Way does not put to death the guiltless or inflict punishment on those without blame.' I hope Your Lordship will give thought to the matter!"

The imperial secretary, however, knew what Huhai wanted and so, without heeding these words of Meng Yi, he had him put to death.

The Second Emperor also sent an envoy to Yangzhou with an order to Meng Tian that read: "Your errors are many, and your younger brother Yi has committed serious crimes. Under the law, you are implicated as well."

Meng Tian replied, "From my grandfather down to his sons and grandsons, my family has accumulated merit and enjoyed trust with Qin for three generations. I have been put in command of over 300,000 troops, and though I am bound and imprisoned, I have power enough to carry out a revolt. But, although I know it means death, I have abided by the principles of righteousness because I would not dare to disgrace the teachings of my forbears, and because I cannot forget my debt to the former emperor.

"In ancient times, when King Cheng of the Zhou dynasty was first made ruler, he was still a babe in swaddling clothes. His uncle, Dan, the Duke of Zhou, carried the infant king on his back when he attended court, and so peace was brought to the empire. Later, King Cheng fell gravely ill and his life was in danger. The Duke of Zhou pared his fingernails and threw the parings into the Yellow River, saying, 'The king as yet has no understanding of state affairs; I alone am handling them. If there is some fault, I alone should suffer the ill effects.' Then he made a record of what he had done and stored it away in the archives. He acted, one may say, in complete good faith.

"Later, when the king grew old enough to govern the nation, evil ministers asserted that the Duke of Zhou had long been plotting revolt. If the king did not take precautions, they warned, the results would surely be calamitous.

"The king was enraged at these words, and the Duke of Zhou fled from the kingdom and took refuge in Chu. But when King Cheng examined the archives, he found the document recording the words the Duke of Zhou spoke when he threw the parings into the river. Tears streaming from his eyes, he said, 'Who tells me that the Duke of Zhou is plotting revolt!' He put to death those who had spoken so and recalled the Duke of Zhou. Therefore the *Book of Zhou* says: 'One must know the threes and fives.'¹⁹⁹

"My family has served without duplicity for generations. If affairs have come to this, it must be because nefarious ministers are plotting treason and attempting to usurp power from within. King Cheng committed an error, but he remedied it and hence in the end was able to flourish. But Emperor Jie killed Guan Longfeng and Emperor Zhou killed Prince Bi Gan and neither ever repented; so they brought death on themselves and the downfall of their kingdom.²⁰⁰ Therefore I say, 'Faults can be remedied, remonstrance can bring understanding.' To examine the threes and fives is the method employed by the sages of antiquity. I say all these things not because I hope to escape censure, but because I wish my death to be a remonstrance. I beg that Your Majesty will give thought for the 10,000 people and abide by the Way."

But the envoy said, "I have received an imperial decree to carry out the law, General. I cannot presume to relay your words to the sovereign."

Meng Tian gave a deep sigh and said, "What crime have I committed before Heaven that I should die an innocent death?" Then after a long while he said in a grave manner, "In fact I deserve to die for the crime I have committed. From Lintao east to Liaodong I built a wall extending for 10,000 *li* and more. In the course of it, I could not help but cut through the arteries of the earth. That must be my crime!"

Then he swallowed the poison and died.

The Grand Historian remarks: I have travelled to the northern border and returned by the Direct Road. As I went along I saw the outposts of the Great

Wall which Meng Tian constructed for the Qin. He cut through the mountains and filled up the valleys, opening up a direct road. Truly he made free with the strength of the common people!

Qin had only recently destroyed the feudal states; the hearts of the people of the world were not yet at rest and the wounded were not yet healed. Meng Tian was a renowned general, yet he did not take this opportunity to remonstrate forcefully, to relieve the ills of the common people, to care for the old and rescue the orphaned. He did not strive to bring about the well-being of the mass of people. Instead he toadied to the will of the emperor in undertaking these constructions. Was it not right that for this he and his brother met with punishment? What is this "crime of cutting through the arteries of the earth"?

SHI JI 126: THE BIOGRAPHIES OF WITS AND HUMORISTS (EXCERPT)²⁰¹

ACTOR ZHAN

Actor Zhan was a dwarf entertainer of Qin. He was clever at making pronouncements that were amusing and at the same time in complete accord with the Way.

One time the First Emperor of the Qin was holding a banquet when it started to rain. All the guards stationed with their shields on the palace steps were drenched and freezing. Actor Zhan noticed them and, feeling sorry for them, said, "Would you like a rest?"

"We certainly would!" the guards on the steps all replied.

Actor Zhan said, "When you hear me call you, you answer 'Yes sir!' as quick as you can."

After a while in the upper part of the hall the toasts and cries of "Long Life!" began. Actor Zhan leaned over the railing and called out in a loud voice, "Guardsmen!"

The guardsmen answered, "Yes sir!"

Actor Zhan said, "Tall as you are, it's no good — you get to stand in the rain. But short as I am, I get to take things easy in here!"

With this the First Emperor gave orders for half of the guards to be relieved, and then to take their turn relieving the other half.

The First Emperor once called for discussions on a plan to enlarge his hunting park so it would extend east to the Hangu Pass and west as far as Yong and Chen Granary.²⁰²

Actor Zhan said, "Splendid! Then we can turn a lot of wild birds and beasts loose in here, and if any rebels try to come in from the east, we'll get the deer and elk to butt them. That'll stop 'em!"

The First Emperor decided to drop the idea.

When the Second Emperor came to the throne, he wanted to have the city walls lacquered.

"Splendid!" said Actor Zhan. "Even if Your Majesty hadn't mentioned it, I fully intended to make such a proposal. True, lacquering the walls may be some worry and expense for the people, but how nice they'll look!"

Lacquer walls all slick and shining —
when the rebels come, they'll never climb 'em!

"But now about the work. The lacquering is easy enough. Only rigging a drying shed might be something of a problem."

The Second Emperor burst out laughing and the idea was accordingly

dropped. Not long after, the Second Emperor was killed and Actor Zhan went over to the side of Han. He died a few years later.

Appendix One

SHI JI 48: THE HEREDITARY HOUSE OF CHEN SHE

When Jie and Zhou sank into evil, Tang and Wu rose to replace them. When the way of Zhou faltered, the *Spring and Autumn Annals* were made. When Qin's rule failed, Chen She marched forth. The lords sprang to revolt like a great wind rising, like clouds that cover the sky, until the house of Qin at last crumbled. All the world took its cue from Chen She's rebellion. Thus I made "The Hereditary House of Chen She."

Chen Sheng, whose polite name was Chen She, was a native of Yangcheng; Wu Guang, or Wu Shu, was from Yangxia. When Chen She was young, he was working one day in the fields with the other hired men. Suddenly he stopped his ploughing and went and stood on a hillock, wearing a look of profound discontent. After a long while he announced, "If I become rich and famous, I will not forget the rest of you!"

The other farm hands laughed and answered, "You are nothing but a hired labourer. How could you ever become rich and famous?"

Chen She gave a great sigh. "Oh, well," he said, "how could you little sparrows be expected to understand the ambitions of a swan?"

During the first year of the Second Emperor of Qin [209 BC], in the seventh month, an order came for a force of 900 men from the poor side of the town to be sent to garrison Yuyang. Chen She and Wu Guang were among those whose turn it was to go, and they were appointed heads of the levy of men.²⁰³ When the group had gone as far as Daze County, they encountered such heavy rain that the road became impassable. It was apparent that the men would be unable to reach the appointed place on time, an offence punishable by death. Chen She and Wu Guang accordingly began to plot together. "As things stand, we face death whether we stay or run away," they said, "while if we were to start a revolt we would likewise face death. Since we must die in any case, would it not be better to die fighting for our country?"²⁰⁴

"The world has long suffered under Qin," said Chen She. "From what I have heard, the Second Emperor was a younger son and ought never to have succeeded to the throne. The one who should have been made ruler was Prince Fusu. But because Fusu several times remonstrated with the former emperor, he was sent to lead the armies in the field. Someone has told me that, though Fusu was guilty of no crime, he has been murdered by

the Second Emperor. The common people have heard much of Fusu's worth, but they do not know that he is dead. Xiang Yan was a general of Chu who many times distinguished himself in battle. He took good care of his troops and the people of Chu thought fondly of him. Some say that he is dead, but others say that he is only in hiding. Now with the group we have, if we could deceive people into thinking that I am Fusu and you are Xiang Yan, we could lead the world in our own tune, and there are sure to be many who will join in the chorus!"

Wu Guang approved of this idea, and they went to consult a diviner. The diviner guessed what the two were planning, and replied, "Your undertakings will all meet with success. But might you not seek your fortune with the spirits?"²⁰⁵

Chen She and Wu Guang were delighted with the idea of enlisting supernatural aid in their scheme. "It must mean that we should first do something to overawe the men in our group!" they declared, and proceeded to write with cinnabar on a piece of silk: "Chen She shall be a king." They stuffed the silk into the belly of a fish someone had caught in a net. When one of the soldiers bought the fish and boiled it for his dinner, he discovered the message in the fish's belly and was greatly astonished. Also Chen She secretly sent Wu Guang to a grove of trees surrounding a shrine which was close to where the men were making camp. When night fell, Wu Guang lit a torch and, partly concealing it under a basket, began to wail like a fox and cry, "Great Chu shall rise again! Chen She shall be a king!"

The soldiers were filled with alarm, and when dawn came they talked here and there among themselves, pointing and staring at Chen She.

Wu Guang had always been kind to others and many of the soldiers would do anything for him. When the officer in command of the group was drunk, Wu Guang made a point of openly announcing several times that he was going to run away. In this way Wu Guang hoped to arouse the commander's anger, get him to punish him, and so stir up the men's ire and resentment. As Wu Guang had expected, the commander began to beat him, when the commander's sword slipped out of its scabbard. Wu Guang sprang up, seized the sword, and killed the commander. Chen She rushed to his assistance, and they proceeded to kill the other two commanding officers as well. Then they called together all the men of the group and announced: "Because of the rain we encountered, we cannot reach our rendezvous on time. And anyone who misses a rendezvous has his head cut off! Even if you should somehow escape with your heads, six or seven out of every ten of you are bound to die in the course of garrison duty. Now, my brave fellows, if you are unwilling to die, we have nothing more to say. But if you would risk death, then let us risk it for the sake of fame and glory! Kings and nobles, generals and ministers — such men are made, not born!"

The men of the garrison all replied, "We'll do whatever you say!" Then, in order to win the loyalty of the people, Chen She and Wu Guang falsely

proclaimed themselves to be Prince Fusu and Xiang Yan. Baring their right shoulders, they raised the cry of "Great Chu!" and built an altar and swore an oath before it, offering as a sacrifice the heads of the commanding officers. Chen She set himself up as commander of the army, with Wu Guang as his colonel, and together they attacked Daze County. After capturing Daze County, they proceeded to attack and capture Qi. They dispatched Ge Ying, a man of Fuli, with a force to seize control of the area east of Qi, while they themselves attacked Zhi, Zan, Ku, Zhe, and Qiao, all of which submitted. Recruiting soldiers as they went along, they were able by the time they reached the city of Chen to build up a force of 600 or 700 chariots, over 1,000 horsemen, and 20,000 or 30,000 infantry.

When they attacked Chen, neither the governor of the province nor any of the magistrates of the districts under him were in the city. Only one of the governor's aides was present, who engaged them in battle at the Qiao Gate but was defeated and killed. They entered the city and quartered there for several days, sending out an order summoning all the village heads and important men of the region to meet with them and plan a course of action. To this the village heads and distinguished men replied, "The general has buckled on armor and taken up his weapons to attack the unrighteous and punish the violence of Qin, that he may restore once more the sacred altars of the state of Chu. Because of the glory he has won, he deserves to be made a king."

Chen She accordingly was made king and given the title "Magnifier of Chu," whereupon men in many of the other provinces and districts who had suffered under the Qin officials overpowered and murdered their governors and magistrates and allied themselves with Chen She.

Chen She made Wu Guang an acting king with supervision over the other leaders of their band, and sent him west to attack Xingyang.²⁰⁶ Chen She ordered Zhang Er, Chen Yu, and Wu Chen, a man of Chen, to seize the region of Zhao, while he sent Deng Zong, a native of Ruyin, to seize the province of Jiujiang. By this time a countless number of bands consisting of several thousand men each had been formed throughout Chu.

When Ge Ying, who had been sent by Chen She to seize the land east of Chi, reached Dongcheng, he set up Xiang Qiang as king of Chu. Later, hearing that Chen She had already become king himself, he murdered Xiang Qiang and returned to report what he had done to Chen She. Chen She executed him and dispatched Zhou Shi, a native of Wei, to march north and seize the region of Wei.

Meanwhile Wu Guang surrounded the city of Xingyang, but Li You, the governor of Sanchuan, held the city, and Wu Guang was unable to conquer it.

Chen She summoned the distinguished men of the state of Chu to meet with him and plan the next move. He appointed Cai Ci, the lord of Fang, a man of Shangcai, as his chief minister. Zhou Wen, a man of some distinction

in Chen, had formerly been diviner of auspicious days in the army of Xiang Yan and had also served under the lord of Chunshen. When he declared himself adept in military affairs, Chen She presented him with the seals of a general and sent him west to attack Qin. Gathering troops as he went along, he entered the Pass²⁰⁷ with a force of 1,000 chariots and 20,000 or 30,000 infantry and camped at Xi. Qin ordered its privy treasurer, Zhang Han, to free all conscript labourers at Mt. Li,²⁰⁸ and the children of household slaves, and lead them forth in an attack upon the army of Chu. They succeeded in routing it, whereupon Zhou Wen fled back through the Pass in defeat, halting and camping at Caoyang for several months. Zhang Han pursued him and defeated him again, and Zhou Wen once more fled, camping at Mianchi for ten days or more. Here Zhang Han inflicted a final defeat. Zhou Wen cut his throat, and his army ceased all further resistance.

When Wu Chen reached Handan in Zhao, he set himself up as king of Zhao, making Chen Yu his commanding general and Zhang Er and Shao Sao his prime ministers of the left and right. Chen She was enraged at this and seized and bound the members of their families, preparing to execute them. But the chief minister, Cai Ci, interceded, saying, "Qin, our great enemy, has not yet been destroyed. Now if you execute the families of the king of Zhao and his ministers, you will only create a second Qin to plague us. It would be better to comply with what Wu Chen and the others have done and confirm their positions."

Chen She accordingly dispatched an envoy to congratulate Wu Chen on his new position as king of Zhao, but the families of Wu Chen and the others he had transferred to his own palace and kept under guard. Zhang Er's son, Zhang Ao, he enfeoffed as lord of Chengdu.

Chen She urged the troops of Zhao to proceed with all haste to the area within the Pass, but Zhao's generals and ministers plotted with their king, saying, "It was not Chen She's intention that you should become king of Zhao. When he has finished conquering Qin, he will assuredly turn his forces against us. The best plan, therefore, would be for us not to dispatch troops west, but instead to send a force north to seize the region of Yan and broaden the territory under your command. With the Yellow River to protect Zhao in the south, and Yan and Dai to the north in our possession, Chen She in Chu will not dare try to impose his will upon us, even if he is victorious over Qin. And if Chen She should fail to conquer Qin, he will be forced to rely more heavily than ever upon us. At that point we can take advantage of the damage already inflicted upon Qin by Chen She and have our way with the whole empire!"

The king of Zhao approved their suggestion and sent no troops west, but instead dispatched Han Guang, a former troop commander of the province of Shanggu, to lead an army north and seize the region of Yan.

The former nobles and leaders of Yan addressed Han Guang, saying, "Chu has already set up a king, and so has Zhao. Although Yan is rather small, it

still deserves to be called, as the old phrase has it, 'a kingdom of ten thousand chariots.' We would like therefore to make you king of Yan."

Han Guang, however, objected. "My mother is still in Zhao," he said. "I am afraid it would not do!" But the men of Yan replied, "Zhao at the present time has all it can do to worry about Qin in the west and Chu to the south. It has no strength left to interfere with what we do. Chen She, in spite of all his power, did not dare to harm the families of the king and ministers of Zhao. How should Zhao dare to do any harm to your family?"

Han Guang, considering that what they said was true, declared himself king of Yan. After a few months Zhao with all due respect sent his mother and the rest of his family to him in Yan.

By this time there were any number of leaders of the revolt attempting to win control of different regions of the empire. Zhou Shi raided the north as far as Di in Qi. Tian Dan, a native of Di, murdered the magistrate of the district of Di and declared himself king of Qi. He then proceeded to lead the forces of Qi in an attack on Zhou Shi. Zhou Shi's army scattered before him, turned back, and retreated to the region of Wei. Zhou Shi wanted to set up Wei Jiu, the former lord of Ningling, who was a descendant of the royal family of Wei, as king of Wei, but Jiu was at the time with Chen She and so was not able to come to Wei. After Zhou Shi's men had conquered the region of Wei, they wanted to join the people of Wei in setting up Zhou Shi himself as king, but Zhou Shi refused to consent. Five times envoys were sent back and forth between Wei and Chen She in an attempt to reach a solution, until finally Chen She agreed to make Jiu the king of Wei, and sent him to his new kingdom. Zhou Shi in the end became his prime minister.

Tian Zang, one of Chen She's generals, plotted with his fellow officers, saying, "Since Zhou Wen's army has been defeated, Qin's soldiers may be on us at any moment. Now we have encircled the city of Xingyang, but we have been unable to take it. When the armies of Qin reach us we are sure to suffer a great defeat. It would be better to leave a small number of troops behind, sufficient to keep watch on Xingyang, and lead our best men west to meet the Qin armies. Our leader, Wu Guang, who has been made an acting king, is too arrogant and knows nothing of military tactics. He is not worth consulting with on matters of strategy. If we do not do away with him our whole undertaking will be in danger of collapse!" Accordingly they joined in forging orders from Chen She and proceeded to execute Wu Guang and send his head to Chen She. Chen She in turn sent an envoy to reward Tian Zang with the official seals of prime minister of Chu, making him commanding general.

Tian Zang then ordered Li Gui and some of his other generals to guard the city of Xingyang, while he himself led his best troops west to meet the army of Qin at the Ao Granary and join in battle. Tian Zang was killed and his army defeated. The Qin commander Zhang Han advanced with his troops and attacked Li Gui and the others before the walls of Xingyang, defeating and killing them.

A man of Yangcheng named Deng Yue was at this time in charge of a force of men in Tan. Zhang Han dispatched an expeditionary force to attack and crush him, whereupon Deng Yue's army scattered and fled to Chen. Wu Xu, a man of Zhi, held command of a force at Xu, but when attacked by Zhang Han his army, too, scattered and fled to Chen. Chen She executed Deng Yue.

At the time when Chen She first set himself up as a king a group of men, including Qin Jia of Ling, Dong Xie of Zhi, Zhu Jishi of Fuli, Zheng Bu of Qulü, and Ding Ji of Xu, started an uprising of their own, leading a band of troops to surround Qing, the governor of Donghai, at Tan. When Chen She received word of this he dispatched Pan, the lord of Wuping, to act as their commander and take charge of their forces, which were camped outside the walls of Tan. Qin Jia, however, declined to accept these orders, but instead declared himself a grand marshal and refused to put himself under the lord of Wuping's command. "The lord of Wuping is too young and knows nothing of military affairs," he advised his officers. "Do not listen to what he says!" Accordingly they forged an order from Chen She and executed the lord of Wuping.

After Zhang Han had defeated Wu Xu he marched to attack the city of Chen, killing Cai Ci, the chief minister. He then advanced and attacked the army of Zhang Jia west of Chen. Chen She came out to observe the battle, but the army was defeated and Zhang Jia killed. In the twelfth month, at the time of the winter sacrifice, Chen She journeyed to Ruyin and from there withdrew to Xiachengfu, where he was murdered by his carriage driver, Zhuang Jia, who declared Chen loyal to the Qin government. Chen She was buried at Dang with the posthumous title of "The Melancholy King."

General Lü Chen, former master of purification under Chen She, formed a band of men known as the Blue Heads and started an uprising in Xinyang. They attacked and conquered the city of Chen, killed Zhuang Jia, and declared Chen loyal to Chu once more.

When Chen She first marched on Chen he dispatched Song Liu, a man of Zhi, with orders to lead a force of troops west to conquer the region of Nanyang and enter the Wu Pass. Song Liu had already gained control of Nanyang, but when news of Chen She's death spread abroad, Nanyang declared itself loyal again to Qin. Song Liu was therefore unable to enter the Wu Pass, but instead marched back east as far as Xincai, where he encountered the Qin army and surrendered to it. The Qin government had him brought back to the capital by relay carriage, where he was tied to two carts and torn apart to serve as a warning to the populace.

When Qin Jia and his band heard that Chen She's army had been defeated and was in flight they set up Jing Ju as king of Chu and led their troops to Fangyu, planning to attack the Qin army outside the walls of Dingtao. In the meantime they dispatched Gongsun Qing as their envoy to Tian Dan, the king of Qi, requesting that Qi join with them in the attack.

"Though word has come that Chen She has been defeated, no one knows

whether he is still alive or not," said the king of Qi. "What do you mean by setting up a new king of Chu without consulting me?"

"You did not consult Chu when you set yourself up as king of Qi," responded Gongsun Qing. "Why should Chu consult Qi when it sets up its own king? Chu is the leader of the uprising. It is only proper that she should give orders to the rest of the empire!" The king of Qi executed Gongsun Qing.

Qin's colonels of the left and right again attacked Chen and recaptured it. Lü Chen's army fled, but soon recruited more men and reformed. Qing Bu, the lord of Dangyang, a bandit leader of Po, recruited a force of men and joined Lü Chen in another attack on the colonels of Qin, defeating them at Qingbo. With this, the city of Chen once more became an ally of Chu. It was at this time that Xiang Liang set up Xin, the grandson of the former King Huai, as the new king of Chu.

All in all, Chen She was a king for six months. When he had become king and was ruling the region of Chen, one of his old friends who had once worked as a hired hand with him in the fields heard of his success and went and knocked upon the palace gate of Chen, saying, "I want to see She!" The gatekeeper was about to order him arrested, but he managed to convince the keeper that he was an old friend of Chen She. The gatekeeper let him go, but refused to allow him to enter the palace.

When the king emerged from the palace, the man stood by the roadside and shouted "She!" Hearing his voice, Chen She ordered that he be brought forward and, inviting him to ride in his carriage, returned with him to the palace. When the man entered the palace and saw all its great halls with their curtains and trappings he said, "Oh, a heap of stuff you have, She, now you're a king! Such a big place!" (The people of Chu say "a heap" when they mean a lot.) Eventually the story spread all over the empire, so that from this incident with Chen She originated the saying "Even 'heap-of-She' got to be king."

After this the old friend came often to visit Chen She, making himself more and more at home in the palace and telling people about Chen She's life in the old days. Someone warned Chen She about this, saying, "This guest of yours is ignorant and ill-bred, and his idle chatter serves only to degrade your dignity!" Chen She had his old friend's head cut off. Thereafter all of Chen She's former acquaintances withdrew of their own accord, and no one attempted to be on intimate terms with him.

Chen She appointed Zhu Fang as rectifier and Hu Wu as director of faults, putting them in charge of his other ministers and officials. When any of the various generals returned from expeditions to seize territory, if it appeared that they had not carried out their orders exactly, these two officials believed it their duty to bind them like criminals and subject them to the severest examination. If any fault was found in their behaviour, their case was not submitted to the lesser officials for trial, but was settled summarily by Zhu Fang and Hu Wu themselves. Chen She entrusted everything to

these two men with the fullest confidence, and for this reason his generals felt no personal attachment to him. This is why he failed.

Although Chen himself died very early, the various rulers and commanders whom he set up and dispatched on expeditions eventually succeeded in overthrowing the Qin. Thus it was he who actually began the uprising. In the time of Emperor Gaozu of the Han, thirty families were established to take care of Chen She's grave at Dang, so that down to the present day he has continued to enjoy the blood and flesh of sacrifices.[209](#)

Appendix Two

SIMA QIAN'S LETTER TO REN AN

The text of the following famous letter is preserved in the "Biography of Sima Qian," which constitutes chapter 62 of the *Han shu, or History of the Former Han*, by Ban Gu (AD 32 — 92). Sima Qian's friend, the government official Ren An or Ren Shaoqing, had earlier written to him urging him to work for the advancement of men of worth. Qian in his reply first apologizes for his delay in answering and then describes the affair that led to his being sentenced to the punishment of castration. He explains that although any real man of honor would have committed suicide rather than submit to such disgrace, he chose to endure humiliation so that he could complete the writing of his history. In the course of his letter, he mentions that Ren An himself was at the time of writing under accusation for some grave offense and in danger of execution. One theory is that Qian's letter was written late in 91 BC, when Ren An was in prison on charges of aiding the heir apparent, Prince Li, in his attempted rebellion in the seventh month of 91 BC, charges that led to Ren An's execution. Another theory is that Qian's letter was written late in 93 BC, when Ren An, it is presumed, was accused of some offense for which he was later pardoned. This dating fits better with Qian's description of his own activities prior to the writing of the letter and seems to me more plausible. Another text of the letter, with slight textual differences, is preserved in chapter 41 of the *Wen xuan*.

Shaoqing, honored sir:

In the past I had the honor of receiving a letter from you in which you advised me to be cautious in my dealings with others and instructed me in my duty to recommend those of ability and work for the advancement of worthy gentlemen. Your concern is most kind and heartfelt. Perhaps you are angry that I have not marked your words and think I am following the counsel of unprincipled men. I assure you I would not dare do so. Worthless old creature that I am, I have yet heard something of the teachings handed down from the great men of old. But I remember that I am no more than a mutilated being who dwells in degradation. Anything I might attempt to do would simply meet with censure. If I tried to help others I would only succeed in doing them injury. Therefore I am "in sadness and despair with no one to speak to."[210](#)

The old saying has it: Who do you do it for, who can you make listen? After Zhong Ziqi died, his friend Bo Ya never again played the lute. Why?

Because it is for a friend who understands him that a man will act, and for a lover who delights in her that a woman will make herself beautiful. But one like myself, whose very substance is mutilated — though I might possess the worth of the jewels of Sui and He, though my conduct might be as pure as that of Xu You and Bo Yi, in the end I could never achieve glory, but on the contrary would only succeed in inciting laughter and bringing shame on myself.

I should have answered your letter, but at the time I had to accompany the emperor on a trip to the east and was pressed by petty affairs of my own. The time we had together was short indeed, and I was so busy that I could not find a moment of leisure to tell you all that I really feel. Now, Shaoqing, you are accused of this terrible crime, and the days and months have slipped by till we are in the last month of winter.²¹¹ I am forced to go in attendance upon the emperor to Yong. If you should suddenly meet with that which cannot be disguised by euphemism, it would mean that I would have no chance to tell you of my bitterness and sorrow. Then in the long journey hereafter your spirit would forever bear me secret resentment. So I beg you to let me explain in brief my unworthy feelings, and I hope you will not blame me too severely for having been so long in answering.

I have heard it said that to devote oneself to moral training is the sign of wisdom; to delight in giving to others is the beginning of humanity; that proper giving and taking are the marks of a person's sense of duty; that times of shame and disgrace determine one's courage; and that making a name for oneself is the end of all action. Only when one has shown that he possesses these five qualities may he take a place in the world and rank among the company of superior men.

Therefore no more severe misfortune can come to a man than to be driven by covetous desires; no sadness is so painful as the grief of the heart, no deed more hideous than bringing shame to one's ancestors, and no disgrace greater than the "palace punishment," castration. That a man who has undergone such punishment is no longer fit to be associated with is not the opinion of one age alone but has been held since ancient times. When Duke Ling of Wei rode in the same carriage with the eunuch Yong Qu, Confucius departed for Chen. Because Shang Yang obtained audience with the king through the eunuch Jing Jian, Zhao Liang's heart turned cold. When the eunuch Zhao Tan rode in the emperor's carriage, Yuan Si was fired with anger. So from old times men have been ashamed to associate with eunuchs. If even ordinary men are loath to have dealings with them, how much more so in the case of gentlemen of virtue and feeling? Although our court today may be in need of good men, what business would I, a mere "remnant of the knife and saw," have in trying to recommend the finest and most worthy men of the world?

Because of the undertakings of my father, which have passed on to me, I have been allowed for some twenty years to wait upon the royal carriage. I

am fully aware that first of all I have not been able to pay due fidelity or inspire real confidence in serving our enlightened sovereign, nor have I gained a name for cleverness in planning or for superior ability. Second, I have been unable to perform any service in repairing deficiencies or supplying what was lacking in the imperial rule or in promoting and advancing men of virtue and talent, nor have I brought to light any gentlemen who were in seclusion. In foreign affairs I have commanded no ranks of men, captured no walled towns, fought on no field; no glories of generals slain or enemy pennants seized are mine. At the least I have not, by piling up the days and sticking to my labors, achieved any high position or large salary, or brought favor to my family and friends. I have not succeeded in a single one of these four endeavors. From this it is obvious that I am a worthless person who by mere chance has been tolerated at court.

Once in former times I too took my place among the lower officials and participated in the lesser deliberations of the outer court. If I could not at that time introduce any great precepts or present any of my ideas, now when I am no more than a lackey who sweeps the paths, mutilated and ranked among the base and insignificant — now if I should try to lift up my head and look lordly by discoursing on right and wrong, would I not show contempt for the court and bring shame to the gentlemen of my time? Alas, alas! A man like myself — what can he say? What can he say?

It is not easy to know the beginning and end of things. When I was young I had a spirit that would not be bridled, and as I grew older I won no praises in my village and district. But because of my father, our ruler graciously allowed me to offer my poor talents and to come and go in the inner parts of the palace. I considered then that a man who has a bowl over his head cannot hope to see the sky. So I cut off my personal acquaintances, neglected private family affairs, and instead day and night thought solely of how to use to the fullest my poor talents and ability. I went about the duties of my office with a single mind, seeking only the favor and love of our ruler. But, quite contrary to my hopes, things came to a terrible misunderstanding.

Li Ling and I held office at the same time, though basically we were never very close. Our likes and dislikes lay in different directions; we never so much as drank a cup of wine together or shared the joys of intimate friendship. But I observed that he was clearly a man of superior ability. He was filial to his parents and trustworthy with his associates, honest in money matters and just in all his giving and taking. In questions of precedence he would always yield; he was respectful and modest and gave way to others. His constant care was to sacrifice himself for his country, hastening in time of need without thought for his own safety. This was always in his mind, and I believed him to be truly one of the finest men of the nation. A subject who will go forth to face ten thousand deaths, giving not the slightest thought for his own life but hurrying only to the rescue of

his lord — such a man is rare indeed! Now he has committed one act that was not right, and the officials who think only of saving themselves and protecting their wives and children vie with each other in magnifying his shortcomings. Truly it makes me sick at heart!

The infantry that Li Ling commanded numbered less than five thousand. They marched deep into barbarian territory, strode up to the ruler's court, and dangled the bait right before the tiger's jaws. In fearless ranks they shouted a challenge to the powerful barbarians, gazing up at their numberless hosts. For over ten days they continued in combat with the *Shanyu*. The enemy fell in disproportionate numbers; those who tried to rescue their dead and wounded could not even save themselves. The barbarian lords in their felts and furs trembled with terror. They summoned their Wise Kings of the Left and Right and called out all the men who could use a bow.²¹² The whole nation descended together on our men and surrounded them. They fought their way along for a thousand miles until their arrows were all gone and the road was blocked. The relief forces did not come, and our dead and injured lay heaped up. But Li Ling with one cry gave courage to his army, so that every man raised himself up and wept. Washed in blood and choked with tears, they stretched out their empty bows and warded off the bare blades of the foe. Facing north again, they fought to the death with the enemy.

Before Li Ling fell into the hands of the enemy, a messenger came with the report [of his attack] and the lords and ministers of the Han all raised their cups in joyous toast to the emperor. But after a few days came word of his defeat, and because of it the emperor could find no flavor in his food and no delight in the deliberations of the court. The great officials were in anxiety and fear and did not know what to do. Observing His Majesty's grief and distress, I dared to forget my mean and lowly position, sincerely desiring to do what I could in my fervent ignorance. I considered that Li Ling had always shared with his officers and men their hardships and want, and could command the loyalty of his troops in the face of death. In this he was unsurpassed even by the famous generals of old. And although he had fallen into captivity, I perceived that his intention was to try to seek some future opportunity to repay his debt to the Han. Though in the end he found himself in an impossible situation, yet the merit he had achieved in defeating and destroying so many of the enemy was still worthy to be proclaimed throughout the world. This is what I had in mind to say, but I could find no opportunity to express it. Then it happened that I was summoned into council, and I used the chance to speak of Li Ling's merits in this way, hoping to broaden His Majesty's view and put a stop to the angry words of the other officials.

But I could not make myself fully understood. Our enlightened ruler did not wholly perceive my meaning, but supposed that I was trying to disparage the Ershi General and plead a special case for Li Ling.²¹³ So I

was put into prison and was never able to make clear my fervent loyalty. Because it was believed that I had tried to deceive the emperor, I was finally forced to submit to the judgment of the law officials.

My family was poor and lacked sufficient funds to buy commutation of the sentence. Of my friends and associates, not one would save me; among those near the emperor no one said so much as a word for me. My body is not made of wood or stone, yet alone I had to face the officials of the law. Hidden in the depths of prison, to whom could I plead my case? This, Shaoqing, is something you have experienced yourself, and was I not in the same predicament? Li Ling had already surrendered alive and destroyed the fine reputation of his family. And then I was thrown into the "silkworm chamber" [where castrations are performed]. Together we became a sight for all the world to laugh at. Alas, alas!

My father had no great deeds that entitled him to receive the tokens of privilege or enfeoffment. He dealt with affairs of astronomy and the calendar, which are close to divination and worship of the spirits. He was kept for the sport and amusement of the emperor, treated the same as the musicians and jesters and made light of by the vulgar men of his day. If I fell before the law and was executed, it would make no more difference to most people than one hair off nine oxen, for I was a mere ant to them. The world would not rank me among those who were able to die for their ideals, but would believe simply that my wisdom was exhausted and my crime great, that I had been unable to escape penalty and in the end had gone to my death. Why? Because all my past actions had brought this on me, they would say.

A man has only one death. That death may be as weighty as Mount Tai, or it may be as light as a goose feather. It all depends upon the way he uses it. Above all, a man must bring no shame to his forebears. Next he must not shame his person, or be shameful in his countenance, or in his words. Below such a one is he who suffers the shame of being bound, and next he who bears the shame of prison clothing. Next is the man bound and fettered who knows the shame of rods and staves, and the man who bears the shame of the shaved head and the binding manacle. Below again is the shame of mutilated flesh and severed limbs. Lowest of all is the dire penalty of castration, the "punishment of rottenness"!

The Commentary says: "Punishments shall not extend to the high officials."²¹⁴ This means that a gentleman must be ever careful of proper conduct.

When the fierce tiger dwells in the deep hills, all the other beasts quake with fear. But when he is in the trap or cage, he wags his tail and begs for food, for he has been gradually overawed and broken. Therefore there are cases when, even though one were merely to draw a circle on the ground and call it a prison, a gentleman could not be made to enter it, or though one merely carved a wooden image and set it up as judge, a gentleman

could not be made to contend with it, but would settle the affair for himself in accordance with what is right. But when a man has been bound hand and foot with stocks and ropes, has been stripped naked, flogged with rods, and plunged into the depths of encircling walls, at that time when he sees the judge he strikes his head on the ground, and when he looks at the jailers his heart gasps with fear. Why? Because he has been gradually overawed and broken by force. A man must be thick-skinned indeed if he comes to this and yet says, "I am not ashamed!" What respect could people have for such a person?

Xibo was an earl, and yet he was imprisoned at Youli. Li Si was chancellor, yet he suffered all the five punishments. Han Xin was a king, but he was put into fetters at Chen. Peng Yue and Zhang Ao faced south and called themselves rulers, but both were dragged to prison and punished. Zhou Bo, the marquis of Jiang, overthrew and punished the Lü family; his power exceeded that of the Five Hegemons of old, yet he was imprisoned in the Inquiry Room. Dou Ying, the marquis of Weiqi, was a great general, yet he wore red convict's clothing and was bound with three sets of fetters. Ji Bu was a manacled slave for Zhu Jia and Guan Fu suffered shame in the prison of Jushi. All these men achieved the position of feudal lord, general, or high minister, and their fame reached to neighboring lands. But when they were accused of crimes and sentence was passed on them, there was not one who could settle the matter with his own hands by committing suicide. In the dust and filth of bondage, it has ever been the same, past and present. How in such circumstances can a man avoid shame?

From this you can see that "bravery and cowardice are only a matter of circumstance; strength and weakness are only a matter of the conditions."²¹⁵ This is certain. Is there any reason to wonder at it? Furthermore, if a man does not quickly make his decision to settle things for himself outside the law, but waits till he has sunk lower and lower, till he lies beneath the whip and lash, and then decides to save his honor by suicide, is it not too late? This is probably the reason why the ancients hesitated to administer punishment to officials.

It is the nature of every man to love life and hate death, to think of his parents and look after his wife and children. Only when he is moved by higher principles is this not so. Then there are things that he must do. Now I have been most unfortunate, for I lost my parents very early. With no brothers or sisters, I have been left alone and orphaned. And you yourself, Shaoqing, have seen me with my wife and child and know I would not let thoughts of them deter me. Yet the brave man does not necessarily die for honor, while even the coward may fulfill his duty. Each takes a different way to exert himself. Though I might be weak and cowardly and seek shamelessly to prolong my life, I know full well the difference between what ought to be followed and what rejected. How could I bring myself to sink into the shame of ropes and bonds? If even the lowest slave and scullion

maid can bear to commit suicide, why shouldn't one like myself be able to do what has to be done? But the reason I have not refused to bear these ills and have continued to live, dwelling in vileness and disgrace without taking leave, is that I grieve that I have things in my heart that I have not been able to express fully, and I am shamed to think that after I am gone my writings will not be known to posterity.

Too numerous to record are the men of ancient times who were rich and noble and whose names have yet vanished away. It is only those who were masterful and sure, the truly extraordinary ones, who are still remembered. When Xibo, the Earl of the West, was imprisoned at Youli, he expanded the *Book of Changes*. Confucius was in distress and he made the *Spring and Autumn Annals*. Qu Yuan was banished and he composed his poem "Encountering Sorrow." After Zuo Qiu lost his sight, he wrote the *Conversations from the States*. When Sun Wu had had his feet amputated in punishment, he set forth the *Art of War*. Lü Buwei was banished to Shu but his *Spring and Autumn of Mr. Lü* has been handed down through the ages. While Han Fei Zi was held prisoner in Qin he wrote "The Difficulties of Disputation" and "The Sorrow of Standing Alone." Most of the three hundred poems of the *Book of Odes* were written when the sages poured out their anger and dissatisfaction. All these men had a rankling in their hearts, for they were not able to accomplish what they wished. Therefore they wrote about past affairs in order to pass on their thoughts to future generations. Those like Zuo Qiu, who was blind, or Sun Wu, who had no feet, could never hold office, so they retired to compose books in order to set forth their thoughts and indignation, handing down their writings so they could show posterity who they were.

I too have ventured not to be modest but have entrusted myself to my useless writings. I have gathered up and brought together all the old traditions of the world that were scattered and lost. I have examined the events of the past and investigated the principles behind their success and failure, their rise and decay, in 130 chapters. I wished to examine into all that concerns heaven and humankind, to penetrate the changes of the past and present, putting forth my views as one school of interpretation. But before I had finished my rough manuscript, I met with this calamity. It is because I regretted that it had not been completed that I submitted to the extreme penalty without rancor. When I have truly completed this work, I will deposit it in the Famous Mountain archives. If it may be handed down to those who will appreciate it and penetrate to the villages and great cities, then though I should suffer a thousand mutilations, what regret would I have? Such matters as these may be discussed with a wise man, but it is difficult to explain them to ordinary people.

It is not easy to live in poverty and lowliness while base men multiply their slanderous counsels. I met this misfortune because of the words I spoke. I have brought upon myself the scorn and mockery even of my native village and I have soiled and shamed my father's name. With what face can I stand

again before the grave mound of my father and mother? Though a hundred generations pass, my defilement will only become greater. This is the thought that wrenches my bowels nine times each day. Sitting at home, I am befuddled as though I had lost something; I go out and then realize that I do not know where I am going. Each time I think of this shame, the sweat pours from my back and soaks my robe. I am now no more than a servant in the women's quarters. How could I leave of my own accord and hide far away in some mountain cave? Therefore I follow along with the vulgar, floating and sinking, bobbing up and down with the times, sharing their delusion and madness.

Now, Shaoqing, you have advised me to recommend worthy men and promote scholars. But would not such a course be at odds with my own view of things? Now although I might try to add glory and fame to myself, or with fine words seek to excuse my error, it would have no effect on the vulgar. I would not be believed, but would only take upon myself further shame. Only after the day of death will right and wrong at last be determined.

I cannot convey my full meaning in a letter, but I have ventured to set forth in brief my unworthy opinion.

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[1](#)

Our understanding of the Qin legal system has been unexpectedly enriched by the discovery in 1975 of a large number of legal and administrative texts written on bamboo in the grave of a Qin local official who died in 217 BC. These suggest that the Qin laws may have been somewhat less severe than traditional accounts would lead us to believe. The texts have been translated in A. F. P. Hulsewé, *Remnants of Ch'in Law* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1985).

[2](#)

See appendix 2: Interpolations in the *Shih-chi*, *The Cambridge History of China*, vol. 1, pp. 94-98.

[3](#)

For a discussion of twentieth-century attempts to re-evaluate the role of the First Emperor in Chinese history, see Li Yu-ning, ed., *The First Emperor of China* (White Plains, N.Y.: International Arts and Sciences Press, 1975), Introduction.

[4](#)

This and the summaries that head the other chapters of the translation are taken from Sima Qian's table of contents in *Shi ji* 130. The meaning of these cryptic statements will become clear in the course of the chapter.

[5](#)

The second of the Five Emperors, mythical rulers of high antiquity who are described in *Shi ji* 1, "The Basic Annals of the Five Emperors".

[6](#)

According to *Shi ji* 1, Shao Dian was the father of the Yellow Emperor, the first of the Five Emperors and the great-grandfather of Zhuan Xu. This whole opening section on the legendary descent of the Qin ruling family is fraught with problems and inconsistencies.

[7](#)

Note how often bird and animal raising and skill in carriage driving are mentioned. This may be because the Qin people, living on the far western border of China, were closely associated with the nomadic Rong and Di people of that area.

[8](#)

Chufu was said to be another name for Feilian.

[9](#)

Legends concerning King Mu of Zhou and his fabulous journey to the west are recorded in many early works. The traditional dates for his reign are 1001-947 BC. One *li* is equal to about one-third of a mile, though here the phrase "a thousand *li* in one day" is not to be taken literally.

[10](#)

A minister to Duke Wen of Jin and famous ancestor of the ruling family of the state of Zhao.

[11](#)

King Li was noted for his stem and violent ways and his refusal to heed

admonition. He was finally driven out of his capital and died in exile, according to traditional dating, in 828 BC.

[12](#)

One theory is that “King Feng” here is a mistake for King You of the Zhou dynasty, who is mentioned below, and that Muying was made a concubine of King You. Another theory is that King Feng is the title of some Rong chieftain in the area.

[13](#)

This move took place in 770 BC and marks the close of the Western Zhou period (1122-771 BC) and the beginning of the Eastern Zhou (770-256 BC).

[14](#)

One *lao* or set of sacrificial animals usually consisted of an ox, a sheep, and a pig.

[15](#)

Changed from barbarian to Chinese ways? The statement is vague in meaning.

[16](#)

The Zhou people in ancient times were said to have lived in the area of Mt. Qi. If Duke Wen presented the area east of Qi to the Zhou dynasty, the offer must have been refused or the territory subsequently returned to Qin, as it is obvious that Qin in later times included the region east of Mt. Qi.

[17](#)

Stone-like objects that were enshrined and worshipped by Duke Wen. Their worship is described in *Shi ji* 28, “The Treatise on the Feng and Shan Sacrifices”.

[18](#)

The three sets of relatives are usually defined as the parents, brothers, and wife and children of the criminal, though some say it refers to the families of the criminals’ father, mother, and wife.

[19](#)

This event took place in 712 and is recorded in the *Spring and Autumn Annals*. Sima Qian from time to time mentions such events that occurred in other states in order to keep the reader cued in as to the overall chronology of his narrative.

[20](#)

Dang may refer to an individual rather than a family. These persons whom the Qin rulers attacked such as Hao, Dang, and Pengxi later in the text, were apparently local chieftains of the Rong people living in the area.

[21](#)

According to the *Spring and Autumn Annals*, these events took place in 686, which would correspond to the twelfth year of Duke Wu’s rule. The murder of Wuzhi and setting up of Duke Huan took place the following year. Duke Huan of Qi became the first of the so-called *ba*, overlords or hegemonies who exercised power over the other feudal rulers of the time while ostensibly acting in the name of the Zhou king.

[22](#)

Officials or attendants of a deceased ruler were often buried with him so that they might “accompany him in death”. Sometimes the persons committed suicide voluntarily, in other cases they were forcibly put to death. The custom was actually quite old in Chinese society, as evidenced by excavations of Shang period burial sites, but Han writers such as Sima Qian often blame its origin on the state of Qin.

[23](#)

The *fu* is the hottest part of the year; here according to commentators the word indicates a summer sacrifice in which dogs were offered at the gates on the four sides of the capital in order to prevent pestilential influences brought on by the hot weather.

[24](#)

This is the old *Ji* clan state in the lower Yellow River valley. I have romanized the name “Wey” in order to distinguish it from the state of Wei that was created in 403 BC by the partition of the state of Jin.

[25](#)

Lady Li was a concubine of Duke Xian of Jin who tried to manoeuvre her son Xiqi into a favourable position by casting suspicion on his older half-brothers Shensheng, Chonger, and Yiwu. Chonger or “Double Ears”, who in time became Duke Wen of Jin, is one of the outstanding heroes of this period.

[26](#)

Lü Sheng’s name is sometimes given as Xialü Yisheng. In my translations of the passages in the *Zuo zhuan* (*Tso chuan*) that deal with the events, I have used the name Xialü Yisheng (Hsia-lü I-sheng).

[27](#)

Elsewhere in the *Shi ji* the death of these men is dated to the fifteenth year of Duke Mu’s rule, 645 BC. Guan Zhong is the famous statesman who assisted Duke Huan of Qi to become an overlord.

[28](#)

The rulers of Jin belonged to the same Ji clan as the Zhou kings.

[29](#)

According to the fuller account in the *Zuo zhuan*, Duke Xi 33rd year (627 BC), the Qin forces failed to show proper respect for the Zhou king when they passed the gate of his capital at Luoyang. *See my Tso chuan*, p. 69.

[30](#)

This is a highly abbreviated version of the “Oath of Qin” section of the *Book of Documents*. In the *Documents* version, there is no mention of Baili Xi and Jian Shu by name. The preface to the *Documents* version places the oath earlier in Duke Mu’s career, when his armies first returned to Qin from their defeat at Yao.

[31](#)

“Airs of Qin” Mao no. 131. The *Book of Odes* gives their family name as Ziju.

[32](#)

The *mengzhu* or “leader of the alliance” was the leader of most powerful state among a group of feudal lords entering into an alliance. As indicated here, the term implies not only political power but moral superiority as well.

[33](#)

This passage summarizes the judgment found in the *Zuo zhuan*, Duke Wen 6th year, which begins with the words “The gentleman remarks”. The judgment is somewhat ironical, since, as we can see later, Qin did in fact “march east in conquest” in the centuries that followed.

[34](#)

Also known as Shi Hui. In my *Zuo zhuan* translations I have referred to him by the latter name.

[35](#)

By “asking about the cauldrons”, the ritual vessels of the Zhou dynasty, he hinted that he was contemplating overthrowing and replacing the Zhou ruler. This famous incident is described in the *Zuo zhuan* under Duke Xuan 3rd year or 606 BC. See my *Tso chuan*, p. 82.

[36](#)

The Zhi, Fan, Zhonghang, Hann, Wei, and Zhao families. The last three emerged victorious from the power struggle and in 403 BC divided up the Jin territory to create the states of Hann, Wei, and Zhao. The name of the state of Hann has been spelled with two n’s to distinguish it from the later Han dynasty.

[37](#)

According to the *Zuo zhuan*, Duke Ding 10th year (500 BC), Confucius acted as *xiang* or chief of ceremonies at a meeting between the rulers of Lu and Qi, but he was never chief minister of the state, as Sima Qian implies. Sima Qian’s wording probably reflects the Han period tendency to magnify Confucius’s political importance.

[38](#)

Shu is the Sichuan area southwest of Qin, which at this time was just beginning to be integrated into the Chinese cultural sphere.

[39](#)

The same prophecy is recorded in *Shi ji* 4, “The Basic Annals of Zhou”, and *Shi ji* 28, “The Treatise on the Feng and Shan Sacrifices”, where the text reads “seventeen years”, which is probably correct. The prophecy no doubt is intended to refer to the First Emperor of Qin.

[40](#)

Hann, Wei, and Zhao, the three states created out of the former state of Jin.

[41](#)

Wei Yang is the Legalist philosopher Gongsun Yang or Lord Shang, whose life is described in *Shi ji* 68; see pp. 89-95 below.

[42](#)

Eleventh highest in the Qin ranks of nobility, of which there were probably seventeen or eighteen at this time. The order of the ranks is counted from the bottom up because later, higher ranks were added at the top.

[43](#)

The sixteenth rank.

[44](#)

The main or south gate of the palace. Xianyang remained the Qin capital until the final overthrow of the state.

[45](#)

The capping rite that took place when young men reached the age of twenty.

[46](#)

Xishou, which means “rhinoceros head”, is identified by commentators as an official title; his personal name was said to have been Gongsun Yan.

[47](#)

No person named Gongzi Ang is known to have served the state of Qin at this time; commentators suggest that the text should read “Gongsun Yan”, referring to the *xishou* mentioned above.

[48](#)

A winter festival celebrated in the twelfth lunar month of the year.

[49](#)

Commentators say he did this because he assumed the title of king in the thirteenth year of his rule, 325 BC. The carefully dated entry in the preceding paragraph should perhaps refer to the ruler of Qin rather than the ruler of Wei.

[50](#)

Commentators throw doubt on many details of this passage, including the assertion that the Xiongnu, a nomadic people living north of China, took part in the attack. In any event, the figures for enemy dead seem extremely high for all these military actions, even given the fact that the scale of warfare had greatly increased over what it had been in earlier periods.

[51](#)

Liang here refers to the state of Wei, which had its capital at Daliang. Sima Qian often refers to Wei as Liang.

[52](#)

The text should read King Xiang of Wei.

[53](#)

The office of *chengxiang* or chancellor replaced that of *xiang* or prime minister. But in the narrative that follows, Sima Qian seems to use the two terms interchangeably.

[54](#)

The three rivers are the Yi, the Luo, and the Yellow River. This sinister pronouncement by King Wu presages Qin’s eventual overthrow of the Zhou dynasty in 256 BC.

[55](#)

The text appears to be faulty and the meaning is uncertain.

[56](#)

Zuogeng is the ninth highest of the Qin noble ranks. Bai Qi’s biography is

translated on pp. 119-124 below.

[57](#)

He was a military leader of Qin. He left to avoid punishment for some offence and fled eventually to Qi. See *Shi ji* 72 (p. 115 below).

[58](#)

They realized that as long as there were two of them, the title of *di* or “emperor” was meaningless.

[59](#)

A *keqing* or “guest minister” is an official who came originally from another state.

[60](#)

Zhonggeng is the eighth highest of the Qin noble ranks.

[61](#)

The text appears to be faulty and the meaning is doubtful.

[62](#)

In *Shi ji* 28, “The Treatise on the Feng and Shan Sacrifices”, Sima Qian mentions that according to some reports the cauldrons had been sunk in the Si River at Pengcheng many years earlier. The cauldrons were supposed to have been made by Emperor Yu, a sage ruler of high antiquity.

[63](#)

That is, Qin set up another Zhou ruler to carry on the sacrifices. It was considered highly inauspicious to put an end to the sacrifices of a family that had once been rulers.

[64](#)

Wuji, the lord of Xinling, was a prince of the Wei ruling family. This attack by the combined forces of Yan, Zhao, Wei, Hann, and Chu was the last major effort by the other states to combat the Qin encroachments.

[65](#)

It was customary for the ruling families of the various states to exchange sons as hostages so as to insure compliance with diplomatic and military alliances. On Lü Buwei, see chapter 85 below.

[66](#)

He was probably named Zheng because he was born in the first (*zheng*) month of the year. He may have used the surname Zhao because he was born in the state of Zhao, though there are other explanations; the traditional surname of the Qin ruling family was Ying.

[67](#)

The name can also be pronounced Yingyang; it is in Henan.

[68](#)

The text is very unclear and the meaning doubtful.

[69](#)

On Lao Ai, the paramour of the queen dowager, see p. 163.

[70](#)

A period of three years of hard labor for the government. Originally, such persons were assigned to gather firewood for use in the sacrifices to the

ancestral spirits, but later the term came simply to designate hard labour.

[71](#)

Any suggestion that the king was treating his mother in an unfilial manner would be highly damaging to his reputation.

[72](#)

See the biography of Li Si, p. 179.

[73](#)

Sima Qian quotes the order directly. The last phrase means that this order shall serve as a precedent in future cases.

[74](#)

This is the famous Legalist philosopher, author of the *Han Fei Zi*, who committed suicide at his place of confinement at Yunyang.

[75](#)

Because the personal name of the First Emperor's father, King Zhuangxiang, was Zichu, the character *chu*, the name of the Chu state in the Yangtze valley, was taboo at this time. Hence the state was referred to by its archaic name, Jing.

[76](#)

According to the theory of the Five Elements, here called the Five Powers, each successive dynasty rules by the power of one of the five traditional elements or agents, water, fire, wood, metal, and earth. There were different interpretations of the theory, but the First Emperor evidently subscribed to that by which the elements proceed in the order in which they "overcome" each other, i.e., the element water follows fire because water has the power to overcome fire. In Five Elements lore, the element water is associated with the colour black, the number six, winter, darkness, harshness and death.

[77](#)

According to some reports, these colossal figures, which each weighed the equivalent of nearly twenty-nine English tons, represented twelve giants wearing "barbarian" garb who appeared at Lintao in Gansu in this year. The statues were said to have survived until the close of the Eastern Han, when the warlord Dong Zhuo (d. AD 192) destroyed ten of them; the rest were melted down in the fourth century AD.

[78](#)

The name of the first star mentioned in *Shi ji* 5, "The Treatise on the Heavenly Offices".

[79](#)

The "fast roads" (*chidao*) were broad, tree-lined highways reaching to outlying parts of the empire.

[80](#)

On the Feng and Shan sacrifices, see the treatise of that name in *Han Dynasty* vol. II. The inscription is in four-character phrases with a rhyme at the end of each third phrase. Subsequent inscriptions employ rhyme at the end of each second phrase.

[81](#)

On the cauldrons of Zhou, see note 59 on p. 32 above.

[82](#)

Shi ji 55, the biography of the early Han statesman Zhang Liang, reveals that the “bandits” were Zhang Liang and an assistant, who attempted to assassinate the emperor in revenge for his overthrow of the ruling house of the state of Hann. Their plan was to attack the emperor with an iron bludgeon, but they mistakenly struck the carriage in which his attendants were riding. See Han Dynasty vol. I, p. 101.

[83](#)

On the *la* festival, see note 45 on p. 26 above.

[84](#)

Jieshi is on the Gulf of Bohai. The seven characters that occur in the text after the word “gate” appear to be a contamination from the text of the inscription and have been omitted in translation.

[85](#)

The true meaning of the prophecy does not become evident until p. 63 below.

[86](#)

Absconders were those who had run away to avoid taxes or conscription. The second category of persons are men who had sold themselves as bond servants to another family and, unable to buy back their freedom, had become adopted son-in-laws of the family.

[87](#)

Tian Chang was a high minister of the state of Qi who in 481 BC overthrew the Qi ruling family. The ruling family of Jin was similarly overthrown in 403 BC by the leaders of six of the most powerful ministerial families.

[88](#)

The term *chengdau* or “wall dawn” is defined rather unconvincingly to mean that the convict had to build walls and stand guard from dawn. It probably simply meant some form of convict labour.

[89](#)

These figures seem to indicate a throne room measuring approximately 675 by 112 metres, which is incredibly large. See *The Cambridge History of China*, vol. 1, p. 102.

[90](#)

Where the emperor was building his mausoleum.

[91](#)

Yunyang was the site of the Palace of Sweet Springs, the Qin summer palace.

[92](#)

Keng, the word translated here as “executed”, can also mean to bury alive. Commentators anxious to emphasize the satanic nature of the First Emperor usually take it in the latter meaning.

[93](#)

Commentators can only guess at the meaning of the terms “lord of Hao Lake” and “primal dragon”. The First Emperor is clearly disturbed that they may apply to him.

[94](#)

The text must be in error, as no such cyclical date is possible for the seventh month.

[95](#)

The *renyu* or “man-fish” appears to be a type of aquatic mammal; some kind of seal or whale have been suggested as possibilities.

[96](#)

Following the suggestion of commentators, I reverse the order of these two phrases.

[97](#)

Duke Xiang reigned 777-766 BC and the Qin state had apparently maintained ancestral temples for him and all the succeeding rulers of Qin. The temples of these early rulers are now to be dismantled and only seven, those of the First Emperor’s seven immediate predecessors, retained.

[98](#)

In early times *zhen* was a common first person pronoun for persons of various social ranks, but it had evidently gone out of ordinary use and the Qin accordingly reserved it for the sovereign alone. In Taoist literature the word also means “sign” or “trace”, and commentators think Zhao Gao may be playing on this meaning here, though in just what way is not clear. See also the parallel passage in the biography of Li Si, p. 195 below.

[99](#)

The Second Emperor is quoting from and paraphrasing the section on “The Five Vermin” from the works of the Legalist philosopher Han Fei Zi (d. 233 BC).

[100](#)

In order to insure that Yan Yue did not betray him.

[101](#)

The Biography of Li Si, p. 205, describes Ziying as a younger brother of the First Emperor, but “younger brother” there may simply be a mistake for “grandson”.

[102](#)

The rope indicated total submission; white is the colour of mourning.

[103](#)

The discussion that follows is the famous essay entitled “The Faults of Qin” by the Han Confucian scholar Jia Yi (201-169 BC).

[104](#)

Jia Yi is referring to the efforts to weaken or destroy Qin in the late Warring States period.

[105](#)

Jia Yi is thinking of late Zhou times when the Zhou kings had become powerless, but were able to maintain their position as nominal rulers

because of the support and protection of the powerful feudal states.

[106](#)

The material just quoted is usually treated as the third section of Jia Yi's essay on "The Faults of Qin". What follows are the first and second sections. The first section is also quoted at the end of *Shi ji* 48.

[107](#)

This concludes Jia Yi's essay. There follows a brief chronological outline of the reigns of Qin rulers and their place of burial, probably one of the sources that Sima Qian used for his account of the Qin which someone has appended to the end of the chapter, plus some remarks by the Han historian Ban Gu (AD 32-92) that were written in response to Jia Yi's essay. Both have been omitted in the translation.

[108](#)

Li ji, Qu li, part 2. Sima Qian is pointing out that Duke Xiang of Qin, by performing sacrifices to the Lord on High, another name for Heaven, was usurping privileges reserved for the Zhou ruler.

[109](#)

In 403 BC three powerful ministerial families divided up the state of Jin, creating the states of Hann, Zhao, and Wei, also known as the "Three Jin". In 386 BC Tian He made himself ruler of Qi. The Six States are Hann, Zhao, Wei, Qi, Yan, and Chu.

[110](#)

Sima Qian regards the actual founding of the dynasty as the "reaping of rewards." The location of Bo is uncertain, but the other places mentioned are all in northwestern China.

[111](#)

A reference to the writings of the Confucian philosopher Xun Zi, particularly *Xun Zi*, sec. 5, *Fei Xing*.

[112](#)

The old Ji clan state situated in the lower Yellow River valley. I have romanized it "Wey" to distinguish it from the Wei farther to the west that was created out of the former state of Jin.

[113](#)

The term designates the branch of the Legalist philosophy of government that deals with bureaucratic control of the population, particularly through the use of harsh penalties.

[114](#)

Duke Mu (r. 659 BC) greatly strengthened the power of the state and in time became recognized as a *ba* or hegemon who was able to exercise power over the other feudal states of the time. Gongsun Yang's journey to Qin took place in 361 BC.

[115](#)

There are said to have been five feudal rulers in the Spring and Autumn period who merited the title of *ba* or hegemon. Lists differ, but all include Duke Huan of Qi (r. 685 BC-643 BC) and Duke Wen of Jin (r. 636 BC-628

BC), and usually Duke Mu of Qin mentioned in note 3 above.

[116](#)

Tang and Wu are the founders of the Yin and Zhou dynasties respectively.

[117](#)

Zuoshuzhang was the eleventh highest in the Qin ranks of nobility, of which there were probably seventeen or eighteen at this time. In the debate just concluded, we are never told who Gan Long and Du Zhi are, though presumably they were officials at the court of Duke Xiao.

[118](#)

Daliangzao was the sixteenth rank in the Qin ranks of nobility.

[119](#)

There is considerable debate concerning the exact meaning of this laconic statement, though it seems to refer to some reform in the land system. The traditional interpretation is that it indicates the abandonment of the old well-field system.

[120](#)

Lord Five Ram Skins, so called because at one point he was ransomed for the price of five ram skins, was Baili Xi, a famous statesman who served under Duke Mu of Qin.

[121](#)

The three rulers of Jin were dukes Hui (r. 651 BC-637 BC), Huai (r. 637 BC-636 BC) and Wen (r. 636 BC-628 BC). The reference to a “misfortune” in the state of Jing or Chu is unclear.

[122](#)

You Yu’s ancestors were from the state of Jin but he was born among the Rong barbarians of the north. He was sent to the court of Duke Mu of Qin by the chief of the Rong and later became Duke Mu’s adviser on barbarian affairs. The “Pass” is the Hangu Pass, one of the passes leading to Qin, the “land within the passes”.

[123](#)

From the “Airs of Yong”, Mao no. 52. The two quotations that follow, from the *Odes* and *Documents* respectively, are not found in the present texts of those works.

[124](#)

Midway in his reign, Duke Hui, Duke Xiao’s successor, assumed the title of king, as did many of the other feudal rulers of the time; hence he is referred to here as King Hui.

[125](#)

“Opening up Barriers” and “Agriculture and Warfare” are the titles of two sections in the *Shangjun shu* or *The Book of Lord Shang*, the work that purports to embody Lord Shang’s political theories. The present text of the work is in 26 sections.

[126](#)

Fourteenth highest in the Qin ranks of nobility.

[127](#)

King Wu is hinting at the overthrow of the Zhou ruler. In “The Basic Annals of Qin”, the pronouncement appears in slightly different form; see p. 27 above.

[128](#)

I.e., you will be demonstrating an admirable impartiality, not allowing personal enmities to interfere with your judgment in matters of state.

[129](#)

Wusui, a city of Hann, had earlier been seized by Qin. Yiyang likewise had been seized from Hann and its inhabitants expelled.

[130](#)

The text reads “Devil Valley”, which seems to be a contamination from the passage above; I have followed commentators in emending to “Acacia Valley”. Guigu or Devil Valley is in Yangcheng in the state of Hann; Huaigu or Acacia Valley is near the Qin capital.

[131](#)

Apparently the king of Chu felt he was on sufficiently close terms with Qin to be able to select someone for the office of prime minister of Qin.

[132](#)

Reading *ke lian* instead of *bu lian*.

[133](#)

The assertion that the seven-year-old Xiang Tuo acted as teacher to Confucius would appear to be one of numerous Taoist inspired legends designed to make fun of the Sage.

[134](#)

The famous Qin military leader Bai Qi, whose biography appears below.

[135](#)

The marquis of Ying is the Qin statesman Fan Ju.

[136](#)

The Bazi of Lady Mi’s name is a court title indicating that she was a concubine of the middle rank. The statement that Queen Huiwen died before her son is contradicted by *The Basic Annals of Qin*, p. 28, where we are told that she died in the revolt that followed the death of King Wu.

[137](#)

The revolt referred to in the note above.

[138](#)

Book of Documents, “The Announcement to the Prince of Kang”.

[139](#)

The Three Jin are the states of Zhao, Hann and Wei created in 403 BC out of the old state of Jin.

[140](#)

The text of this letter, like the parallel passage in *Zhanguo ce*, “Strategies of Qin”, presents numerous problems of interpretation and the translation is frequently tentative.

[141](#)

Zhao Bao and Zhao Sheng, members of the Zhao ruling family. Zhao Sheng

or Lord Pingyuan has his own biography in *Shi ji* 76.

[142](#)

Lord Mafu was Zhao Kuo's father Zhao She, a military leader noted for his command of strategy.

[143](#)

Assuming that the text is not faulty, this entry for the forty-eighth year, which begins with the tenth month, then mentions the first month, and finally the ninth month, is proof that at this time the state of Qin began its calendar year with the tenth month. This practice continued through the Qin dynasty and into the early Han; see *Han Dynasty* vol. I, p. 1 note 2.

[144](#)

Jing is an old name for the state of Chu in the Yangtze valley.

[145](#)

There is some disagreement as to the proper character for Fan Ju's personal name. Gladys and Hsien-yi Yang in their translation of the chapter call him Fan Sui (*Records of the Historian*; Hong Kong, Commercial Press, 1974, pp. 94-117). I follow the reading used by Crump in his translation of the *Zhanguo ce*, J.I. Crump, Jr., *Chan-kuo ts'e* (Oxford, 1970).

[146](#)

According to Qin law, Wang Ji, the one who recommended Fan Ju, would be held responsible for any shortcomings in the person he recommended.

[147](#)

According to *Shi ji* 110, "The Account of the Xiongnu", Queen Dowager Xuan, King Zhao's mother, had had relations with the ruler of the Yiqu, a non-Chinese people living west of Qin. She bore him two sons, but later deceived and murdered him at the Palace of Sweet Springs, an act that led to hostilities between Qin and the Yiqu people.

[148](#)

Painting the body with lacquer to induce leprosy sores is a reference to the actions of Yu Rang, who did so in order to disguise his identity and avenge the death of his lord. Loosing the hair like a madman refers to Ji Zi; see note 6 below.

[149](#)

Wu Zixu was a native of the state of Chu. When King Ping of Chu killed his father and elder brother, he escaped south through the Zhao pass to Wu. He became adviser to King Helü of Wu and eventually rose to high position. His biography is in *Shi ji* 66. See my *Records of the Historian* (Columbia University Press, 1969), pp. 16-29.

[150](#)

Ji Zi was a nobleman under the evil last ruler of the Shang dynasty. When his admonitions were unheeded, he feigned madness. Jieyu, the madman of Chu, was a recluse of Chu and contemporary of Confucius. There is no mention of these men having painted their bodies with lacquer.

[151](#)

I.e., to the right and left of the ruler as he sits on his throne facing south.

[152](#)

This place name may also be read Yingyang.

[153](#)

No such lines are found in the present text of the *Book of Odes*.

[154](#)

Cui Shu was minister to Duke Zhuang of Qi, Nao Chi minister to King Min. Li Dui served under King Wuling of Zhao.

[155](#)

Xu Jia addresses Fan Ju by his polite name.

[156](#)

Reading *lao* in the place of *ru*, as in the parallel passage in *Shi ji* 41, "The Hereditary House of Yue".

[157](#)

The first quotation is from the *Book of Changes*, the explanation for the first hexagram, *qian*. The second is from *Analects* VII, 15.

[158](#)

Duke Huan of Qi (r. 685-643 BC) was the first of the five *ba* or hegemonies who imposed their will on the other feudal rulers during the Spring and Autumn period. The meeting at Kuqiu or Sunflower Hill took place in 651 BC.

[159](#)

Xia Yu appears to have been a person of great strength and daring. Nothing is known of the story of the grand historian Jiao.

[160](#)

Fan Li and Dafu Zhong helped King Goujian (r. 496-465 BC) of Yue to defeat his rival, the state of Wu, and attain a position of power. But Fan Li, unlike Dafu Zhong, had the good sense to withdraw from Yue, go elsewhere, and embark on a second career under the name Lord Zhu of Tao.

[161](#)

No such passage is found in the present text of the *Book of Documents*.

[162](#)

Explanation for the first hexagram.

[163](#)

Han Fei Zi, sec. 49, "The Five Vermin".

[164](#)

In these last remarks, Sima Qian is no doubt hinting at his own difficulties with Emperor Wu.

[165](#)

Younger sons of rulers were often sent to reside at the courts of allied states where they acted as hostages to encourage the continuance of peaceful relations between the states.

[166](#)

In such cases the tally was broken in two, the pieces to be held by the two parties to the agreement. Since Lord Anguo was himself only crown prince, he could not at this time make public his decision.

[167](#)

The famous Confucian philosopher Xun Zi (fl. 250 BC), author of a work in 32 sections.

[168](#)

The work is still extant and provides invaluable information on Qin period thought and language.

[169](#)

Because it would involve his whole family in the punishment.

[170](#)

Confucius, contrasting the true man of distinction with one who merely enjoys a good reputation, said, "The man of fame may be one who puts on the appearance of virtue but in practice acts quite differently." (*Analects* XII, 20)

[171](#)

The biography of Jing Ke is the last of five biographies that make up *Shi ji* 86, "The Biographies of the Assassin-retainers". The *cike* or "assassin-retainers" are men who undertake an assassination or threat of assassination in order to avenge some wrong done to their lord or to right a political wrong. The account of Jing Ke is the only one of the five biographies that concerns the history of the state of Qin. The whole chapter is translated in my *Records of the Historian: Chapters from the Shih Chi of Ssu-ma Ch'ien* (N.Y.: Columbia University Press, 1969), pp. 45-67.

[172](#)

The boundaries of the state of Yan.

[173](#)

The deadly scales that protrude from the throat of a dragon.

[174](#)

Cao Mei or Cao Mo, a general of the state of Lu, had several times been defeated by the forces of the neighbouring state of Qi and forced to concede lands to Qi. When the rulers of Lu and Qi came together for a meeting, Cao Mei, brandishing a dagger, threatened the Qi ruler, Duke Huan (r. 685-643 BC), and forced him to return the lands to Lu. Cao Mei's is the first of the five biographies that make up "The Biographies of the Assassin-Retainers".

[175](#)

An anonymous fictionalized version of the Jing Ke story, which contains this detail, has been handed down, in somewhat battered state, under the title "Prince Dan of Yan". It is translated in Wolfgang Bauer and Herbert Franke, eds., *The Golden Casket* (Harcourt, Brace & World, Inc., 1964), pp. 30-41.

[176](#)

The Confucian philosopher Xun Zi.

[177](#)

King Zhuangxiang died in 247 BC and was succeeded by his son Zheng, who in time became First Emperor.

[178](#)

The reigns of Duke Xiao and kings Huiwen, Wu, Zhao, Xiaowen, and

Zhuangxiang, or from 361 to 247 BC.

[179](#)

According to *Shi ji* 29, “The Treatise on the Yellow River and Canals”, Hann had sent Zheng Guo to Qin to talk Qin into undertaking construction of an irrigation canal so as to deplete Qin’s funds and manpower. When Zheng Guo’s true purpose came to light, the king of Qin was about to put him to death, but he persuaded the king to let him complete the project, which in fact proved to be highly beneficial to Qin. See my *Records of the Grand Historian, Han Dynasty* vol. II, pp. 53-54.

[180](#)

Zhang Yi (d. 309 BC) was a native of the state of Wei, who entered the service of Qin and aided it in the acquisition of territory.

[181](#)

See the parallel text in “The Basic Annals of the First Emperor of the Qin”, p. 54 above.

[182](#)

Kings Tang and Wu overthrew the last rulers of the Xia and Shang dynasties respectively. It is not certain what event in the state of Wey Zhao Gao is alluding to.

[183](#)

The last refers to the forces under the rebel leader Zhou Wen, also called Zhou Zhang, which advanced as far as Xi or Hongmen, just east of the Qin capital, before being repulsed. See *Han Dynasty* vol. I, p. 4.

[184](#)

As noted earlier in the parallel passage in “The Basic Annals of the First Emperor” on p. 69 above, the Second Emperor is quoting and paraphrasing section 49, “The Five Vermin”, from the works of the Legalist philosopher Han Fei Zi.

[185](#)

Master Shen is the Legalist philosopher Shen Buhai (d. 337 BC). Only fragments of his writings remain.

[186](#)

Han Fei Zi, sec. 50, “Eminence in Learning.”

[187](#)

Here and in the next paragraph Li Si is once again drawing on “The Five Vermin” section of *Han Fei Zi*.

[188](#)

A reference to the Mohists and Confucians.

[189](#)

The assassination of Duke Jian of Qi by Tian Chang took place in 481 BC. The usurpations of Zihan are mentioned in *Han Fei Zi*, sec. 7, “The Two Handles”, but the incident is otherwise unknown, as is the incident of Han Yi and King An (r. 238-230) of Hann; this last was presumably an event familiar to both Li Si and the Second Emperor.

[190](#)

The five penalties are tatooing of the face, amputation of the ears, nose, fingers and feet, flogging and exposure of the head at the execution.

[191](#)

From this it appears that Zhao Gao had a child or children before becoming a eunuch.

[192](#)

The text describes Ziyi as a “younger brother” of the First Emperor, but “younger brother” must be a mistake for “grandson”.

[193](#)

Model statesmen of the early Zhou period.

[194](#)

Lintao is in Gansu Province south of the present day city of Lanzhou. Liaodong is on the Gulf of Bohai.

[195](#)

Since Sima Qian has not devoted a separate chapter to Zhao Gao, he is obliged to insert this brief account of his background into the biography of one of the many men whose downfall Zhao Gao engineered.

[196](#)

Omitting the name Huhai, which does not appear to belong in the sentence.

[197](#)

The brother or nephew of the Second Emperor who in time succeeded him as ruler of Qin.

[198](#)

On these charges against Duke Mu, see “Basic Annals of Qin”, p. 17 above. It is very doubtful that the posthumous name Mu was intended to mean “mistaken,” though one way of writing the character can yield that meaning.

[199](#)

No such quotation is found in the present text of the Zhou section of the *Book of Documents*. To know “the threes and fives” means to know the true situation. A slightly different version of this story is found in the “Metal-bound Casket” section of the *Book of Documents*.

[200](#)

Jie is the evil last ruler of the Xia dynasty, who refused to heed the admonitions of his minister Guan Longfeng. Zhou is the evil last ruler of the succeeding Shang dynasty.

[201](#)

Sima Qian’s brief chapter on “Wits and Humorists” (*hua ji*) deals with court entertainers and actors who, like the king’s jester in Western literature, deftly correct their erring or unenlightened lords through their use of a ready quip. Translated here is the only section of the chapter that deals with the Qin.

[202](#)

Le., to make the whole capital area into one big hunting park.

[203](#)

I.e., they were chosen from among the men of the group to be its leaders; the group as a whole was in turn commanded by officers of the Qin government.

[204](#)

I.e., die fighting for the restoration of the former state of Chu. Another interpretation would have it mean “die fighting to win a kingdom.”

[205](#)

Like all good diviners, this one is careful to answer ambiguously. His remark may be interpreted to mean, “Though your plan may succeed, will you not find yourselves among the spirits of the dead?” But Chen She and Wu Guang prefer to interpret him differently.

[206](#)

This placename may also be read Yingyang.

[207](#)

The heartland of Qin, with its capital, Xianyang, lay in the northwest, surrounded by rivers and mountains, the so-called land within the Passes. The two principal approaches to it were through the Wu Pass in the south and the Hangu Pass in the east. Unless otherwise stated, “the Pass” refers to the latter.

[208](#)

Where they had been assembled to work on the great mausoleum of the First Emperor of Qin.

[209](#)

This chapter lacks the customary closing remarks of the Grand Historian.

[210](#)

A paraphrase of the words of the poet Qu Yuan (3rd cen. BC) in his poem “Encountering Sorrow.”

[211](#)

Since it was considered inauspicious to carry out the death sentence in spring, executions were sometimes hastily conducted in the last days of the winter season.

[212](#)

The Wise Kings of the Left and Right were subordinates of the *Shanyu*, or khan, hereditary commanders of the eastern and western sections of the Xiongnu nation respectively.

[213](#)

The Ershi, or Sutrishna, General was Li Guangli, overall commander of the expedition and eldest brother of the emperor’s favorite, Madam Li.

[214](#)

Li ji, or *Book of Rites*, sec. 1. The meaning is not that officials are outside the law but that anyone who has the moral qualifications to hold high office will not commit an offense, or if he does so, will take his own life without waiting for punishment to be applied.

[215](#)

A quotation from the *Bing fa*, or *Art of War*, by Sun Wu.

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